THE FREEDMAN'S CHILDREN

Rome at the Summit — Book One

A Novel

Mature content: adult themes, sex, violence, strong language. Not for readers under 18.

This is a work of fiction. Historical persons appear within the record; all else is invented.

1

The News Ship

Puteoli, February, in the first year of Trajan

The first she knew of the emperor's death was that a man did not pay.

He had come down the stairs at the sign of the Dolphin at the hour when the lamps were being trimmed, a factor from Ostia with a Syrian's beard and an Italian's boots, and he had stood in the doorway buckling his cloak and looking at the harbour as if it had done him a personal injury. Her mother had said the sum. The man had said, "Nerva is dead," as though that settled it, and gone out into the dark with the price of two nights and a girl still owing.

Her mother had looked at the door for the space of a breath. Then she had said, "Fausta. Get the shutters."

She, Fausta, was ten that winter, and she had got the shutters, because that was the order of things in the house: you did the thing in front of you and you thought about the emperor later, when the lamps were out and there was nothing to do with your hands. She remembered the wood cold and swollen with the sea-damp, the bar that would not drop into its bracket until she leaned her whole weight on it, and the sound behind her of her mother counting what was in the box and not saying the number aloud.

That was the second of February, or the third. Afterwards she could never fix the day, because in Puteoli the days of that month ran together like the sulphur-smoke that came over the hill from the burning fields and lay in the streets until noon. What she fixed instead was the man's hand on the cloak-pin, and the way her mother had not called after him. Hilara called after everyone. Hilara had once followed a Cretan wine-merchant to the mole and taken his purse off him in front of the harbour guard, and been applauded. But she did

not follow the Syrian. She let him go, two nights and a girl, and she said to the room — to Antiope, who was sitting on the bottom stair in her shift with her knees drawn up, to the two sailors from Alexandria who had stopped eating, to the lamp and the smoke and the cold — "Well. Now we'll see."

◆

In the morning the whole town knew, and knew it in the way the town knew things, which was from the harbour inward. The couriers of the Rome road had come through in the night and gone on to Neapolis and the fleet at Misenum, and nobody of consequence had been awake to receive them except the duty officer of the harbour watch, and he had told the bakers. So by the time the sun was over Vesuvius and the fog was lifting off the water in rags, the bakers had told the fishwives, and the fishwives had told the porters, and the porters had told everyone, and the news had been improved in each telling, so that Nerva was by turns dead of a fever, dead of a fall, dead of fury at a senator, and dead of the oldest cause of all, which was that he had been old. He had reigned sixteen months. He had adopted a soldier in Germany to come after him. That was the part that mattered, and it was the part nobody could tell her anything useful about, because none of them had ever seen the soldier and most of them could not say his name twice the same way.

"Traianus," said Antiope, who could. She had it from a man who had it from a letter. "He's Spanish."

"He's not Spanish. He's Roman. He was born in Spain."

"That's what I said."

They were in the yard behind the house, where the Isis shrine was, and where the slops went out, and where Antiope liked to sit in the first sun with her hair loose, because it was the only hour she had to herself and she chose to spend it being looked at by nobody. She was seventeen and had been at the Dolphin two winters. In summer she went up to Baiae and worked the villas, and came back in October

with silver in her hem and a tiredness that took until the Saturnalia to leave her face. Fausta had decided when she was eight that she loved her, and had not revised it.

"Spanish or Roman," Antiope said, "he's in Germany, and he's got the army, and that's the end of it. Your mother's worried about the wrong thing."

"She's not worried."

"She let that man go."

Fausta had no answer to this. She picked at the moss between the yard-stones with her thumbnail. The shrine was a niche in the wall with a painted goddess in it, the paint gone to a pink ghost, and a saucer of something in front of her that the cats had been at.

"She's thinking," Antiope said, "that when an emperor dies, the people who had his ear lose it, and the people who had their ear lose theirs, and so on down, until you get to a lodging-house in Puteoli, where a man who was going to pay decides he had better keep his money until he knows who his friends are. It'll be the same in a month. It's always the same in a month." She stretched. Her shift had slipped off one shoulder and she did not fix it. "I was in Rome when Domitian went. I was six. My mother says the price of bread didn't move."

"Your mother was a slave."

"So was yours, duck." Antiope smiled at her, not unkindly. "That's why we're having this conversation in a yard."

◆

Her mother sent her up the hill at the third hour with a message for the house of Laecanius Hermes, and that was how the day acquired its shape, and, as it turned out, the years.

The message was about oil. The Dolphin took its lamp-oil from Hermes's warehouse on the emporium, as it took its wine and its fish-sauce and, in a sense, its existence, since the house and the warehouse and the woman who ran one and the man who owned the

other all carried the same name, and the name was not theirs. They were Laecanii. The whole of the lower town, it sometimes seemed to Fausta, was Laecanii: the oil-man and the ship's-chandler and the woman who sold hot sausages by the baths, and the man who dug graves, and the two brothers who had a monopoly on the hire of mules for the Cumae road, and her mother, and herself. Every one of them had been owned once by the family in the big villa above Baiae, or was the child of someone who had, and every one of them wore the name like a brand that had healed over and could still be read in the right light. Some of them were rich. Hermes was rich. It did not matter. When Lucius Laecanius Bassus came down to the coast in April to open his villa, they all went up the hill to stand in his atrium and be looked at, the rich ones at the front and her mother at the back, and he called them *my people*, and they called him *patron*, and he was, and they were.

She did not think about any of this, at ten. It was the water she swam in. She thought about the hill, which was steep, and the message, which was that the last amphora had been short and her mother would pay for what she got and not for what was written, and about whether she would be allowed through to the back of Hermes's house, where the tutor had his room, or sent round to the kitchen door.

Hermes's house stood on the slope above the macellum where the streets began to straighten and the drains ran under the paving instead of down the middle of it. It was not a large house, by the standard of the villas on the point, but it was large for a man whose father had been a Greek bought in a lot of twelve at the slave-market in Delos, and Hermes had made sure that it looked larger than it was. He had put a porch on it with two columns, and the columns had capitals, and the capitals were, if you did not look closely, marble. On the lintel he had had cut, in letters that could be read from the street, *C. LAECANIUS C. L. HERMES AUGUSTALIS*, and the *L.* in the

middle of that, which meant *freedman of Gaius*, he had had cut smaller than the rest. Not much smaller. Enough.

The doorkeeper let her through. She was known. Nicias had said once, in her hearing, that the girl from the Dolphin had a better memory than the boy, and the doorkeeper had decided on the strength of it that she was a person, in the limited sense in which a doorkeeper decides such things, and did not make her go round. So she came through the atrium with its little pool and its painted walls — a seascape, ships and dolphins, the paint fresh enough that the blue still smelled — and through the passage past the room where Hermes sat with his tablets when he was at home, which he was not, and into the back court where the tutor had his room, and where Celer was sitting on the step with a wax tablet on his knees, scowling at it as though it owed him money.

He looked up. He was eleven, and he had his father's face already, the long Greek face with the heavy brows, and nothing else of his father's, not yet. He had the look he always had when she arrived: that she was late, and that he had expected her, and that he was not going to say either.

"Nerva's dead," he said.

"I know."

"The new one's called Trajan. He's in Germany. He's got the whole army. My father says he'll come to Rome in the spring and there'll be games and the price of everything will go up." He turned the tablet so she could see it. On it, in his square careful hand, he had written out the emperor's names, all of them, *Imperator Caesar Nerva Traianus Augustus Germanicus*, and under them a list of figures. "That's what a modius of wheat cost when Vespasian came in. And Titus. And Domitian. Nicias had it in a book. It goes up every time."

"Why?"

"Because of the games."

"Why do the games make wheat dearer?"

He thought about that. It was the thing she liked in him, that he would stop and think when he did not know, instead of saying the first thing; it was what made him different from every other boy in the lower town and most of the men. “I don’t know,” he said. “I’ll ask him.”

“I’ve got a message for your father.”

“He’s at the warehouse. Give it to Daphnis.” Daphnis was the doorkeeper. “Or tell me.”

She told him. He listened with his head on one side and then said, “It wasn’t short. The amphorae from that batch are all the small size; it’s the Baetican measure, not ours. She’s paying the same for less oil but it’s not short, it’s a different jar.” He said this without malice, as a matter of fact, and she felt her face heat, because it meant her mother had been wrong, and it meant the boy on the step knew more about her mother’s house than she did.

“She’ll want to pay for the oil, not the jar.”

“Then she should say that. Not that it was short.” He made a mark on his tablet. “I’ll tell him.”

“Tell him she said *short*.”

He looked at her. Then — and this was the other thing she liked in him, which she did not have a word for yet, and would spend twenty years finding words for, none of them adequate — he nodded, and rubbed out the mark, and wrote something else.

“All right,” he said. “Short.”

◆

Nicias was asleep in his room with a book over his face. He was a man of perhaps fifty, thin as a lath, with the pale indoor skin of someone who had spent his life in the back courts of other men’s houses, and he belonged, as it happened, not to Hermes but to the patron: he was one of Bassus’s Greeks, lent down the hill at a rent that Hermes paid quarterly and complained about monthly. He had taught Bassus’s son his letters and Bassus’s daughter hers, and now he was teaching the

freedman's boy, which he regarded as a demotion, and he had let the freedwoman's girl sit at the back because she was quiet and because it amused him, as he once told Hermes, to see what a mind would do with an alphabet when nobody had told it the alphabet was not for it.

He woke when Celer kicked the doorframe. He lifted the book off his face, and looked at the two of them, and said in Greek, "Well. The old man's dead."

"We know."

"Everyone knows. Even you. Sit." They sat. "Tell me who the new one is."

"Trajan. He's in Germany with the army."

"He is in Germany with *an* army. Two legions on the upper Rhine and the goodwill of the rest. It is not the same thing. If it were the same thing, Nerva would not have needed him." Nicias swung his feet to the floor and reached for the cup beside the bed. There was always a cup beside the bed. "Why did Nerva need him?"

Celer said, "Because the Guard didn't like Nerva."

"Why not?"

"Because he was a senator and he'd been put in by senators after Domitian was killed, and the Guard liked Domitian."

"Good. And so a year ago the Guard surrounded the palace and made the old man hand over the men who'd killed Domitian, and the old man, who was eighty and had no sons and no soldiers, did it, and then went up to the Capitol and announced that he had adopted the governor of Upper Germany as his son and heir, because the governor of Upper Germany had soldiers. And now the old man is dead, and the governor of Upper Germany is emperor of the world, and he has not seen Rome in three years and may not hurry to." Nicias drank. "What does that tell you?"

Celer frowned. Fausta said, before she had decided to, "That he doesn't need Rome. Rome needs him."

Nicias looked at her over the cup. It was a long look, and she could not read it. She was ten and she had been told her whole life that she was quick, by people whose idea of quickness was being able to add up a wine-bill, and she did not yet know that there were other kinds of quickness and that this man had spent his life watching for them in the children of the rich and had found it, as a rule, where it was no use to anyone.

"That's right," he said. "Rome needs him. Remember that, both of you. It's the only fact about an emperor that is always true." He put the cup down. "Now. Celer. The Baetican measure. Your father's warehouse. What is the ratio?"

They did ratios for an hour. She was better at them than he was and she had learned not to show it, mostly.

◆

They went down to the mole in the afternoon because the Alexandrian fleet was expected, and because it was the thing you did in Puteoli, in those years, when anything happened: you went down to the water and looked east.

It was not the season for the grain fleet. That came in May, when the sea opened, two hundred ships together under sail off Capri, and the whole town went out on the mole and the roofs and the hill to see them come in, and the magistrates in their best togas went down to the harbour steps to receive the first master, and there was a holiday. February was the dead month. But there were always ships, even in the dead month — the fast couriers that ran the winter passage for the imperial post and whoever could pay to go with it, the Rhodian merchantmen that took the risk for the prices — and the harbour watch had said that one of these was in the offing, and had been since dawn, beating up from the south against a wind that would not let her in.

The mole ran out into the bay on its great arches, farther than you could throw a stone and then farther again, and from the end of it you

could see the whole curve of the coast: Misenum with the fleet in its basin. The point of Baiae with the villas climbing it, and the headland where the patron's house was, white among its cypresses, and beyond that the Cumae hills, and behind everything the smoke from the burning fields, going up straight into the cold. There were fishermen on the mole, and porters waiting, and the usual boys. She and Celer sat on the end with their legs over the edge and the sea moving green under their feet and watched the ship not come in.

"My father says," Celer said, "the new emperor will build a harbour at Ostia."

"There's a harbour at Ostia."

"A proper one. A basin, with a mole like this one, so the grain ships can go straight up to Rome instead of coming here and unloading and sending it on by barge. Claudius started one and it silted. My father says Trajan will finish it, because he's a soldier and soldiers like roads and harbours. And then —" He stopped.

"And then what?"

"And then nobody will come here." He said it with great flatness, looking at the sea. "That's what he says. He says he's got ten years to get his money out of ships and into land, and then it won't matter."

She did not know, then, what to do with this. She looked at the town behind them, the stacked white houses going up the hill, the baths, the temples on the forum terrace, the amphitheatre like a great cup set down on the ridge. It was the biggest place she had ever seen. It was the biggest place she could imagine, because she had not seen Rome and did not, at ten, believe in it except as a kind of weather that came from the north and changed the price of things. The idea that a soldier in Germany could decide, in a room, to make all of it not matter was so large that it went straight through her and out the other side and left nothing but the cold of the stone under her legs.

"Then we'll go to Rome," she said.

He turned and looked at her. The wind had put colour in his face and taken the scowl off it; he looked for a moment like what he was, a boy on a wall.

"Who's *we*?"

"Us. Your father. My mother. The whole name. If the patron goes up to Rome more, he'll want his people there. That's how it works. He takes you where he needs you."

"How do you know how it works?"

"Antiope."

"Antiope's a whore."

"Antiope's been to Rome," she said, "and you haven't," and that was the end of that, for the moment, because the ship had come about and the wind had gone round a point and she was coming in at last, low and black, with the spray going over her bows.

They stood up to watch her. Everyone on the mole stood up. There was no reason to; she was one ship, in February, with a dozen passengers and a cargo of whatever had paid the winter rate. But the town had had its news by road, which was no way for a port to have anything, and it wanted the sea to confirm it. So the fishermen and the porters and the boys and the two children of the Laecanii stood on the end of the mole and watched her come down the last half-mile under a scrap of sail, and when she was close enough that you could see the faces along her rail, somebody on board, a man in a cloak at the bow, cupped his hands and shouted across the water: "*Nerva's dead. Trajan's emperor. Rome's quiet.*"

And the mole let out its breath. That was the sound she remembered afterwards, more than the shout: thirty men letting their breath go, and one of them laughing, and the harbour watch starting to shout for the lines.

Celer said, beside her, so low she almost did not hear him over it: "He said *Rome's quiet*. That's the part my father will want." He had his tablet out again. He was writing it down.

◆

They walked back along the mole behind the porters, who were already quarrelling over who would carry what, and at the harbour steps, where the mole met the land and the customs-house stood with its brazier going in the doorway, they found the patron's steward waiting for the ship.

She saw him before Celer did, because she had been taught to. Thallus was a man you learned to see early. He was Bassus's freedman — had been Bassus's slave, and his father's before him, born in the house — and he ran the villa at Baiae in the eight months of the year when the family was in Rome and ran the family's business on the coast in the four months when it was not. He had, over thirty years of this, acquired the particular stillness of a man who has watched a great many people come and go and has outlasted all of them. He was not large. He was not, to look at, anything: a man of fifty in a good plain cloak, bald, clean-shaven, with small hands that he kept folded in front of him and a face that had been arranged a long time ago to show nothing and had set that way. He had a boy with him to carry things. He always had a boy with him; it was never the same boy.

He had come down, she understood, for the letters. A courier-ship in February meant the imperial post and whoever had paid to ride with it, and the patron's house in Rome would have sent down by the first vessel after the old man died, because the patron's house in Rome would need its steward on the coast to know certain things before the coast knew them. That was what Thallus was. He was where the family's knowledge went when it went south.

"Celer," he said, as they came up the steps. Not *boy*. He used names; it was one of the things about him. "And the Dolphin's girl." He did not use hers. "You've been out to see the ship."

"Yes, sir."

"And what did the ship say?"

Celer told him. The names, the order of them, *Rome's quiet*. Thallus listened with his hands folded and his eyes on the boy's face, and when it was done he nodded, once, the nod of a man ticking an item on a list he had already made.

"Good," he said. "Your father will want that. Tell him I'll be down to the warehouse tomorrow about the spring consignment, and tell him the master wants the villa opened early this year. The Ides of March, not April. He'll want to be on the coast when the new man comes south, if the new man comes south." He reached into his cloak and brought out a coin and put it in Celer's hand, and closed the boy's fingers over it with his own small dry ones. "For the news."

Then he looked at Fausta. He looked at her the way the men on the stairs looked at her in the mornings, except that the men on the stairs were doing a sum and Thallus was checking one he had done years ago. It did not take long. It never did.

"Tell your mother," he said, "that I'll be down on the day after the Nones. The usual hour."

"Yes, sir."

"And tell her the Syrian's gone to Rome on a horse he hired in my name, and I'll be adding what he owes her to what he owes me, and she'll have it by Saturnalia, less my trouble." He turned away, toward the ship, where the harbour watch had the gangway down and a man in a courier's cloak was already coming along it with a satchel held in both arms. "Go on, the pair of you. You're in the way."

They went. They went up the harbour street with the fish-stalls shutting and the porters coming behind them under their loads, and neither of them said anything until the macellum, where their ways divided, and then Celer opened his hand and looked at the coin in it.

"A denarius," he said. "For telling him what the whole mole heard."

"He's not paying for the news."

"What's he paying for, then?"

"For you to remember he paid." She heard her mother in her own voice and did not mind it. "Now you owe him. That's a denarius' worth of owing. It's cheap, for him."

Celer looked at the coin a while longer and then put it in his belt. He did not throw it in the harbour, which a different boy might have done, and he did not offer her half, which a different boy might also have done. He put it away and he said, "He didn't give you anything."

"He gave my mother a message."

"That's not the same."

"No," she said. "It's not." And she went down the hill to the Dolphin with the message in her, the day after the Nones, the usual hour, and the other thing, *less my trouble*, which was the first time in her life she had heard it said aloud that her mother's house was a thing Thallus took a cut of, and which she carried the way you carry a cup too full, carefully, looking at it, so as not to spill any before she had worked out what it was.

◆

Her mother was in the kitchen when she got back, with her sleeves rolled and her hands in a basin, and she did not look round.

"The oil?"

"He says it wasn't short. He says it's the Baetican measure and the jars are smaller and you're paying the same for less but it's not short."

Hilara took her hands out of the basin and dried them on her apron, a long slow motion, and turned.

She was thirty-one that year, or thirty-two; she did not know her birth-year, having been bought at four, and had chosen one for the purposes of her manumission and stuck to it. She was small and very upright, with the broad cheekbones and the dark deep-set eyes that the Rhodians at the Dolphin said were Thracian and the Alexandrians said were Syrian and that Fausta had, looking in the bronze, decided were simply her mother's, because she had never seen them on anyone else. She had been handsome. She was still handsome, in the way of a

thing that has been handled a great deal and kept its shape. Men who came down the stairs in the morning looked at her a certain way, and then looked at the girl, and did the arithmetic, and some of them said something and most of them did not. Fausta had been watching them do it since before she understood what the sum was.

"*He* says. Hermes says, or the boy?"

"The boy. He's going to tell his father I said *short*."

"Is he." Hilara considered her daughter. "Why?"

"Because I asked him to."

Something moved in her mother's face and was put away. "Well," she said. "He's his father's son, that one, and his father never did anything for nothing in his life. You remember that. You remember it the next time he does what you ask." She turned back to the basin. "And he's right about the jars, damn him. I knew it when I sent you. I wanted to see if Hermes would admit it or send me a cheaper price and call it a favour." She lifted out a wet cloth, wrung it, slapped it over the edge. "The Syrian's not coming back. I asked at the watch. He went up the Rome road this morning on a hired horse. So that's that."

"Thallus was at the steps. He says the Syrian hired the horse in his name and he'll add what's owed here to what's owed there and you'll have it by Saturnalia. Less his trouble." She watched her mother's back. "And he's coming the day after the Nones. The usual hour."

Hilara did not turn round. Her hands went on with the cloth. But there was a pause in them, the length of a breath, and Fausta, who had been listening to this woman's silences since before she could walk, heard in it the same note she had heard the night before when the Syrian went out of the door: not fear, exactly. The sound of a thing being added to a column.

"Less his trouble," Hilara said. "Yes. There's always that." Then: "Antiope says what?"

"That it'll be the same in a month."

"Antiope's seventeen." Hilara wrung out another cloth. "Listen to me. I'm going to tell you something and you're going to put it where you keep things. When an emperor dies, nothing happens to people like us. Not for a year. Not for two. The price of bread doesn't move, the ships come in, the patron opens the villa in April, everything's the same. And then one day you look up and it's all different, and you can't say when it changed, and everybody who could have told you is dead or in Rome. That's what an emperor is. He's the weather that comes after the weather." She set the basin on the floor. "The old one was a friend to the senators. This one's a friend to the soldiers. Bassus is a senator. Work it out."

Fausta worked it out. It took her a moment, because she had to go round by way of the oil and the Syrian and the boy on the step, but she got there. "If the patron goes down," she said, "we go down."

"If the patron goes down," her mother said, "we go wherever he's standing when he falls, and we're underneath. That's what the name's for." She looked at the girl for a long moment, and then, unexpectedly, reached out and pushed the hair back off her forehead with a wet hand. "Go and help Antiope with the beds. The Alexandrians are staying another night and they want the room with the window."

◆

That night she lay in the little room under the stairs that was hers, that had been a cupboard, and listened to the house. It was a thing she did. A lodging-house at night was a kind of instrument, and if you lay still enough you could hear all of it: the Alexandrians arguing softly in the room with the window, and the creak of the stair when Antiope went up, and the different creak when she came down, and the sea on the mole, and under all of it the particular silence of her mother not sleeping, which had a quality to it that she could have picked out of a hundred silences.

She thought about the mole, and the shout across the water, and the thirty men letting out their breath. She thought about the boy writing it down. She thought, with the perfect selfishness of ten, not about the emperor, who was a name, nor the patron, who was a face she saw in April, but about the sentence *nobody will come here*, and about how he had said it looking at the sea, as if it had already happened and he had been there and come back.

She did not know that she would remember this night, and she would not have believed, if told, how much of what she was lay in it already: the shutter that would not bar until she leaned on it, the man who did not pay, her mother's hand in her hair, the boy's tablet. She thought she was waiting for her life to begin. She was wrong about that. It had begun on the second of February, or the third, and it had begun the way everything in her life would begin, with a man in a doorway deciding what he owed, and a woman letting him go, and saying *now we'll see*.

In the morning the price of bread was the same. In the morning the Alexandrians paid, in good coin, and went down to their ship. In the morning there was fog again off the water and smoke again off the hill, and a boy came down from the house above the macellum with a note in his square hand to say that his father would take back the Baetican jars at the price paid and send the Italian measure, *as a favour to the house of Hilara in consideration of long custom*. Her mother read it twice and laughed out loud, the first time in three days, and said, "Oh, he's *good*. He's good, that man. He's charged me for the favour and I haven't even seen the bill yet."

And then she said, "Give the boy a cake. No. Give him two. One for the tutor."

And Fausta gave him two, in the yard, by the shrine with the pink ghost in it, and he ate his on the spot and wrapped the other in a cloth with great seriousness, and said, "Nicias says to tell you the games make wheat dear because the emperor buys it to give away, and when

he buys it the price goes up for everyone who has to pay. He says it's the first thing anyone should know about Rome and nobody does."

"What's the second thing?"

"He didn't say. He went back to sleep."

They looked at each other across the yard. The sun had got over the wall and there was steam coming off the stones. She thought — it was a child's thought, and complete, and she would never have it again in that form — that she was happy, and that it was because of the cake and the sun and the boy, in that order, and that it would always be like this.

"Come down to the water later," he said. "The Rhodian's unloading. There might be something."

"I've got the beds."

"After the beds."

"After the beds," she said, and he went, and she stood in the yard a moment longer with the cloth he had left on the step, and then she folded it and took it in, because it was his, and because that was the order of things in the house, and because she had not yet learned that there was anything else.

2

The Tomb

Puteoli and Baiae, February–March 98

His father took him to see the tomb on the morning after the news, because that was what his father did with news: he went and stood in front of the thing he was building and measured it against what had changed.

The tomb was on the Capua road, a quarter-mile out past the amphitheatre, where the land levelled and the monuments of the town began — a street of the dead running out into the country with the living hurrying along it between them. Hermes had bought the plot in the year Domitian died. He had told his son the price, which was a thing he did with every price, so that the boy would carry the figures of the family's rise in his head like a second set of bones. He had bought it from a decayed decurion's heirs who had wanted ready money, and it was a good plot, on the right-hand side going out of town, where the morning sun struck, between the monument of a sea-captain and the enclosure of a family of dyers who had been in Puteoli since before the Greeks left and had, in consequence, the air of regarding the whole road as their yard.

They walked out. His father did not keep a litter, on principle; he said a man who had been carried as a slave — not literally; he had been a clerk — had no business being carried as a free one, and that the day he could not walk to his own tomb he would have earned the right to be laid in it. Celer walked at his left and a step behind, which was the place, and the boy Daphnis's son came behind with the tablets. They went up through the town in the early light with the shops opening and the smoke coming down the hill, and people said *Hermes* to his father as they passed, and some said *Augustalis*, and he gave them each

the precise degree of nod that their saying it had earned.

He, Celer, had learned the degrees by watching. There was the nod for a man who was Laecanius too, which was slight and lateral, a nod between equals who both knew they were not. There was the nod for a man who was free-born and poor, which was fuller, because that man had the one thing that could not be bought and it was polite to acknowledge it even in a man who had nothing else. There was the nod for the magistrates, which was not a nod but a lifting of the hand, as between men of business. And there was the nod he gave to the decurions' sons who sometimes came through the macellum in the mornings on their way to the baths, which was not visible at all, and which his father gave anyway, inside, where it cost nothing and could be collected on later.

"You saw the steward," his father said, when they were past the amphitheatre and the road had opened out.

"At the steps. He gave me a denarius."

"For what?"

"For telling him what the ship said."

"Which he knew."

"Yes."

"And you took it."

"Yes."

His father walked on a few paces. "Good," he said. "A man who refuses a coin from a steward is telling the steward he thinks he's above him, and the steward will remember that and so will the master when the steward tells him. A man who takes it is telling the steward he understands how the house works. You understood. That's worth more than the denarius. Keep the denarius too." He glanced sideways. "He say anything about the villa?"

"The Ides of March. He wants to be on the coast if the emperor comes south."

"*If.*" His father made the word into a small dry sound. "He won't come south. He's in Cologne with the legions and he'll go up the Danube first, to show the Pannonian army his face, because the Pannonian army is the one that could have made someone else. Then Rome. Autumn at the earliest. Next year more like. But Bassus will open the villa in March, because Bassus is a senator, and senators don't know how to wait. It's what's wrong with them." He said this as a man might remark on a defect in a breed of dog. "We'll be ready. I want the spring oil moved before the Ides and I want the big warehouse swept and whitened so that when the steward walks through it he sees a house that is doing well and has nothing to hide. Write that down."

Celer took the tablet from the boy behind and wrote it down.

◆

The tomb was not finished. It had been not finished for four years, and would be, Celer sometimes thought, not finished for ever, because his father went on changing what he wanted of it as the family's prospects changed, and the family's prospects had done nothing but rise since the day the plot was bought.

It had begun as a simple thing, a brick enclosure with an altar and a space for the urns. Then the shipping had gone well — the Alexandrian contract, the three hulls, the warehouse — and the enclosure had got a facing of stone. Then his father had been made one of the Augustales, which was the thing he had wanted for ten years and had paid, Celer knew because he had been shown the figure, the price of a hull to get; and the Augustales had rights, among them the right to have the fasces and the magistrate's chair shown on your monument, and so a mason had been hired to cut a relief. The relief had grown, and now the front of the tomb was a thing you could not walk past without looking at. There was Hermes, in his toga, seated in the curule chair he was entitled to sit in on two days of the year. There were the two lictors who attended him on those days. There was a

ship, below, under sail, and on the ship men at work, and if you knew the house you could see that the men had Greek faces and the ship had the lines of the *Isis*, which was the first of the three hulls and the one his father never named without touching something made of wood.

The inscription was not cut yet. His father had been composing it for four years and had got as far as the names and the offices. *C. LAECANIUS C. L. HERMES, AUGUSTALIS, SHIPOWNER OF THE ALEXANDRIAN TRADE.* The *L.* was there, because it had to be; a freedman who left it off his tomb was a freedman who could be prosecuted, and a man who had spent his life learning the law so as to stand exactly on the right side of it did not stumble at the end. But the mason had instructions. The *L.* was to be cut last, and smaller, and in a slightly different hand, so that it would look, to anyone who did not stop to count the letters, like the kind of abbreviation a stonecutter squeezes in when he has misjudged his line.

"And here," his father said, standing in front of the blank space under the ship, "is where you go."

He said it every time. It was not morbid; it was a kind of accounting.

"*C. LAECANIUS C. F. CELER.* Son of Gaius. *F*, not *L*. Nobody will ever cut an *L* after your name, not on this stone, not on any stone. That's what the whole of this is for." He gestured at the tomb, the relief, the lictors, the ship, the thirty years. "I'm a freedman. I'll be a freedman when I'm ash. You're the son of a Roman citizen, born in his house, in his marriage, to his wife —" he did not say *first* wife; he never said it — "and the law doesn't know the difference between you and the son of a consul. The law is the only thing in this world that doesn't know the difference. Men do. Men always will. So you have to make it so that men have to go through the law to get at you. You understand?"

"Yes, Father."

"You don't. Not yet. But you've a good memory and one day it'll come back to you, and that'll do." He put his hand briefly on the back of his son's neck. It was not a caress. It was the way he put his hand on a hull he was inspecting, to feel whether it was sound. "There's an emperor dead and a soldier in his place and Bassus is going to be scared for a year and spend money to show he isn't. Scared senators do two things. They borrow, and they look for men to stand in front of them. We'll lend. And when the time comes, you'll stand."

"When the time comes for what?"

But his father was already turning away, toward the road, and the boy with the tablets, and the warehouse that wanted whitening, and the morning that was getting on. "Rome," he said over his shoulder, as if it were a place one could simply walk to, as one walked to one's tomb. "When the time comes."

◆

His stepmother was at her loom when they came in, which was where she always was at that hour and which, he had come to understand, was where she arranged to be seen to be. Vibia Procula was freeborn. It was the first thing anyone said about her and it was, very nearly, the last; she had been the daughter of a man with a small farm and a large name near Nola, a man whose family had had the citizenship since the Social War and nothing else since, and when his father had come looking for a second wife — a *mother for the boy*, he had said, though the boy had been nine and in no want of one — he had gone looking in exactly that stratum, among the free and the poor, and had paid for her what she was worth to him, which was a good deal.

She was thin. She had a long upper lip and pale eyes and a way of holding herself very straight at the loom as though someone might at any moment come in to draw her. She was pious in the old way, the way of the farm, and kept the household gods with a care that his father found restful and the slaves found exacting, and she had given his father, two years since, a second son, whom his father had named

Lucius after no one, so that the boy would have a name with no history in it at all. Celer did not dislike her. He had tried, in the first year, and failed, because she had never once given him cause; she treated him with the exact, measured courtesy of a woman who has been brought into a house to perform a function and intends to perform it perfectly, and who understands that the elder son is part of the function.

"You went to the tomb," she said, not looking up from the loom.

"Yes, Mother."

"He's worried, then."

He was silent. She looked up. She had a trick of looking up that was almost like a question and not quite.

"He goes to the tomb when he's worried," she said. "He thinks I don't know. Men always think the thing they do most often is the thing nobody notices." The shuttle went across. "The new emperor is a Spaniard and a soldier and nobody knows him, and your father has three ships and a contract with the grain office that was signed under Nerva by a freedman who will not be at the grain office by summer. That's the worry. He won't say it to you because he doesn't want you to carry it. I'm saying it to you because you'll carry it anyway, and you may as well know what it weighs."

He had not known she knew about the contract. He had not known she knew about anything. He stood by the loom and felt, as he sometimes felt with Nicias, that he had been living in a house with more rooms than he had been shown.

"What should I do?" he said.

"Nothing. You're eleven." The shuttle went across. "But when he tells you to do something, do it quickly and do it well, and don't ask why in front of anyone. He'll tell you why when it's safe to. He always does." She looked up again. "And stay away from the lodging-house for a while."

Something in him went still, the way the harbour went still before the wind changed.

"Why?"

"Because Thallus will be in the town for a month, opening the villa, and Thallus goes to the lodging-house, and your father doesn't want Thallus seeing his son come out of it. " She said it very evenly, looking at the thread. "It's not about the girl. It's about the steward. Everything in this house is about the steward until the master comes, and then it's about the master. You'll learn."

◆

The villa at Baiae opened on the Ides, as the steward had said it would, and on the morning after, the freedmen of the house of Laecanius went up to pay their respects.

They went up together, because that was the custom, in a body from the lower town — Hermes at the front in the toga he wore four times a year, with his son beside him, and behind them the oil-man and the chandler and the mule-brothers and the sausage-woman and the gravedigger and the rest, perhaps forty people, the men in whatever white they owned and the women in their best, walking the coast road in the early sun with the bay on their left hand going blue. It was five miles. Nobody rode. You did not ride to your patron's door; you arrived on your feet, warm and a little dusty, so that he could see you had made the effort.

Celer looked for the Dolphin's people and found them near the back, where they always were. Hilara in a dark-red gown he had not seen before, walking very straight, with her hair up under a scarf. The girl beside her in something blue that had been let down at the hem. Antiope was not there; Antiope was not Laecania, she belonged to nobody in particular, which was a thing he had thought of, when he was younger, as a kind of freedom, and had come to think of as the opposite. He caught the girl's eye once, over the shoulders of the mule-brothers, and she looked at him and then away, and he

understood from the way she did it that she had been told, too, to keep her distance while the steward was on the coast, and that she had worked out why faster than he had.

The villa was built on the headland above the hot springs in the way of all the villas on that coast, which was to say that it climbed; it went up the slope in terraces, each with its colonnade and its view, so that from the sea the whole hill looked like a staircase for giants with white pillars at every step. Bassus's grandfather had built the lowest terrace. Bassus's father had built the middle. Bassus had built nothing, and had let the roof of the upper bath-house go, and it was this, more than anything his father said, that told Celer where the family stood; because he had walked in through the great door with his father and looked up the terraces and seen, between the second and the third, a stretch of tile that had slipped and not been replaced. He knew what a slipped tile cost to fix, because his father had told him.

They were received in the atrium. It was a very large atrium, with a pool in the floor that had real fish in it and a skylight above through which the sun came down in a square, and around the walls the masks of the family's ancestors in their cupboards, wax faces, a dozen of them, going back to a consul under Nero whose name was on the base of the household shrine in letters as tall as a hand. The freedmen filed in and arranged themselves, the rich at the front, by instinct, as water finds its level. Hermes stood where the square of sun would strike him when the master came. Celer stood at his shoulder and looked at the masks.

He had seen them before. He saw them every year. But he looked at them that morning with the tomb in his head, and his father's blank stone, and he thought: that is what a name is. It is a wax face in a cupboard that your great-grandson takes out at funerals. And he thought: we have one face. It is my father's and it is not finished and it is on the Capua road with a ship under it. And he thought, with the cold clarity that came to him sometimes and that he had not yet

learned to be afraid of: *the fish in that pool cost more to keep than the Dolphin makes in a month, and the tile on the third terrace has been down since last summer.*

Then the master came in and he stopped thinking.

◆

Lucius Laecanius Bassus was sixty that year. He had been praetor under Vespasian and consul — a suffect consul, for two months, in a year nobody remembered — under Domitian, and he had held, since, a succession of the offices that are given to men who are owed something and cannot be given anything that matters: a curatorship of roads, a priesthood of the deified Titus, a seat on a commission about the Tiber banks. He had been in Rome for the killing of Domitian and had not been in the room; he had been in Rome for the mutiny of the Guard and had kept his doors shut; and he had, in sixteen months of Nerva, borrowed, as far as Celer's father could learn, about eight hundred thousand sesterces against the Baian estate at a rate that assumed the old man would live and the senate would rule. He was a tall man run to softness, with a fine head of white hair that he was known to be proud of and a face that had been handsome and was now only large. He had a way of standing with one hand on his hip under the fold of the toga and the other raised, slightly, as if about to bless or to beckon, and he had been standing that way, Celer thought, since before anyone in the room was born, and had never once been told it looked like anything.

He came in through the tablinum with his steward a pace behind and his son a pace behind that, and he stopped in the square of sun, and he said, "My people."

And they said, "Patron."

It went as it always went. He spoke. He said that an emperor had died and that the gods had given Rome another, and that he had every confidence in the senate's choice — *the senate's* — and that he had come down early this year because a man's place in uncertain times

was among his own. He looked round the atrium as he said this as if to count them, and Celer saw his eye go over the rich at the front and slow, very slightly, at the dark-red gown at the back, and move on. Then he said that the steward would see them each in turn about the year's business, and that he hoped they would all dine, in the garden, at his expense, and that he was glad — here the raised hand came down, and rested, for a moment, on Hermes's shoulder — glad to see the house of Laecanius doing so well in his absence. The hand was on his father's shoulder for perhaps the time it took to breathe twice. His father did not move. But Celer, standing at his elbow, saw the colour come up the back of his father's neck above the toga, slowly, like a tide coming in over flat sand, and understood that he had just watched his father receive the one thing in the world he could not buy, and that it had cost the giver nothing, and that both of them knew it.

Then the master went out, and the steward took his place, and the real business of the morning began.

◆

He met the son in the garden, over the dinner, which was bread and cold meats and a thin wine served at trestles under the fig trees on the second terrace, with the sea below and the slipped tile, if you looked, above.

Laecanius Rufus was twenty-eight. He had been quaestor two years since, which had cost his father a sum Celer's father had been unable to discover and had therefore estimated high, and he was now at the stage of a senatorial career where a man waited, and attached himself to people, and hoped. He had come down from Rome with the news and was going back with the spring, and in between he was doing what the sons of patrons did in the country, which was to walk about among his father's freedmen being gracious and finding it tiring. He was a well-made young man with his father's height and none of his softness, a boxer's shoulders under a plain tunic, a short beard in the new style that had come in with the Spanish soldier, and a

face that Celer could not read and did not, for the moment, try to; he had only the sense, watching him move among the trestles, that here was a man who had been told what he was worth and had believed it, and was now discovering that the market disagreed.

Rufus found him by the wall where he had gone to look at the sea.

"You're Hermes's boy."

"Yes, sir."

"The one Nicias teaches. He writes to me about you. Did you know that? He writes to me about everything, the old fraud, he thinks I'm still eight." Rufus leaned on the wall beside him. He smelled of the baths and of a scent Celer could not name and later learned was Syrian and cost more an ounce than the Dolphin paid for oil in a month. "He says you've a head for figures and no Greek style at all."

"He says that to me too, sir."

"Does he? Good. He's right, probably. He usually is about the things that don't matter." Rufus looked at the sea. He had the look, Celer thought, of a man who had been looking at seas from villa terraces all his life and had stopped expecting them to do anything. "You know what's going to happen, I suppose. Your father will have told you."

Celer said nothing, because he did not know, and because saying nothing was what you did with the sons of patrons until you did.

"Trajan will come to Rome," Rufus said. "Next year. He'll settle the Guard and give the people a show and the senate a speech about liberty, and then he'll do what all of them do, which is look round for a war. There's one waiting. The Dacians have been taking Domitian's money for ten years and laughing at us across the Danube, and a soldier can't have that; he'll want to go up there and make it stop. And when he goes, every man in the senate under forty who wants to be anything will go with him, and I am under forty, and I want to be something." He said it without heat, as a man recites a sum. "I'll need a staff. A man on a staff needs people who can count, and write, and

keep their mouths shut, and don't cost anything because they belong to him already. Your father has offered me you."

The sea went on doing what it did.

"When?" Celer said. His voice came out steady, which he noted with a kind of distant interest, as if it were someone else's.

"When it happens. Two years. Three. You'll be fourteen, fifteen. Old enough to hold a tablet." Rufus turned and looked at him properly for the first time, and there was something in the look that was not unkind and was not kind either; it was the look of a man pricing a horse he has been given and would not have chosen. "I'm telling you now because your father asked me to, and I'm telling you here because he didn't want it said in his house. He thinks you'll take it better from me. I think he's wrong, but it's his son." He straightened from the wall. "Think about Rome, boy. It's the only place anything happens. Everything else is just where people wait for news of it."

And he went back along the terrace toward his father's guests, and Celer stood by the wall with his hands on the warm stone and looked at the bay, and at the point beyond it, and at the town beyond that, white on its hill, with the mole going out into the water like a finger pointing east; and he found that he was looking for the Dolphin. That he could not pick it out from here, and that he had known he could not before he looked.

◆

He told her on the shore below the town, three days later, in the evening, where the fishing boats were drawn up and the nets were spread on the stones and nobody from either house would think to look.

He had meant to tell it well. He had rehearsed it, walking down, the way he rehearsed Greek: *the patron's son is going to the war when it comes, and he'll need a staff, and my father has offered me, and I'll go.* He had meant to say it plainly, as a fact, so that she would see it was a

fact and not a thing he had chosen or could un-choose. He had meant, if he was honest, to be a little grand about it.

She was sitting on the keel of an upturned boat with her feet in the shingle. She listened to the whole of it without moving. Then she said, "I know."

"You — how?"

"Antiope. A man from the villa was at the house on Tuesday. One of the Rome slaves, the ones who came down with the son. He told her in the morning. He said the young master had a freedman's boy for a secretary now and would be dragging him up to Rome to carry his tablets, and wasn't that a thing." She looked at him. "He said it before the son said it to you. So the whole villa knew first. And then the Dolphin. And then you."

He stood there in the shingle with his rehearsed sentence in his mouth, useless, and felt, for the first time in his life and not the last, the specific humiliation of discovering that a thing he had thought was his own had been passed from hand to hand before it reached him.

"Why didn't you say?"

"We weren't supposed to speak. The steward's in town." She said it without reproach, as a fact of weather. "Besides. It was yours to tell."

He sat down on the shingle beside the boat, because his legs had decided it for him. The stones were still warm from the day. Out on the bay the lamps of the fishing fleet were coming on one by one, and the smell of the sulphur was coming down off the hill the way it did in the evenings when the wind dropped.

"I'm not going to carry his tablets," he said. "I'm going to do his accounts. There's a difference."

"Is there?"

"Yes." He said it with more force than he meant. "His father's borrowed eight hundred thousand against the villa and the tile's off

the roof. A man like that goes to war to get rich, and a man who goes to war to get rich needs someone to count it. That's not a slave's job. That's —" He stopped, because he did not have the word.

"That's your father's job," she said. "With a sword behind it."

He looked at her. She had the last of the light on the side of her face and she was not smiling and she was not sorry for him; she had simply said the thing, as she did, as Nicias did, and left it there for him to pick up. He picked it up. He turned it over. It was true.

"Yes," he said.

She was quiet a while. Then: "When?"

"When the war comes. Two years. Three."

"And you'll come back."

"Of course I'll come back. Everyone comes back from Rome. Antiope came back."

He said it lightly, and heard it land wrong even as it left him, and watched her hear it. She did not say anything. She looked at the fleet. And he understood — slowly, and then all at once, in the way he would come to understand most of the important things in his life, too late to do anything but watch — that he had just told the first lie of his life that mattered. Not *I'll come back*. He might. But *of course*, and *everyone*, and the lightness, which said that he had already begun to think of here as a place one came back to, and not as a place one was.

"I'll write," he said. It sounded, in his own ears, like something the Syrian might have said on the stairs.

"You'll be fourteen," she said. "You'll be in Rome with a senator's son. You'll be busy." And then, before he could answer, she slid down off the keel onto the shingle beside him, close enough that their shoulders touched, and said in a different voice, the one from the yard and the tutor's room and the mole: "Tell me about the villa. Did you see the fish? Antiope says there's a fish in the pool that's older than the master. She says it's got a ring in its lip that his grandfather put there."

So he told her about the fish, and the masks, and the slipped tile, and the hand on his father's shoulder and the colour coming up his father's neck, and she listened, and asked the right questions, and once laughed; and the lamps came on across the bay, and the stones cooled, and neither of them mentioned Rome again that evening, or the steward, or the two years, or three. He felt the lie sitting between them the whole time like a third person on the shingle, and he thought that she must feel it too, and he could not tell, from her face in the dusk, whether she had decided to forgive it or simply to put it where she kept things.

When he got home his stepmother was at the loom with a lamp, and she looked up, and looked at the shingle-dust on his tunic, and said nothing at all, and went back to the thread. And the next morning his father said, at breakfast, not looking up from the tablets: "Rufus spoke to you."

"Yes, Father."

"Good." And then, after a moment, as if it were the same subject, which it was: "The steward will be at the lodging-house tonight. The usual hour. Stay in."

He stayed in. He sat in the tutor's room with the lamp and the wax and did the Baetican ratios again, all of them, until they came out the same three times, and he did not think about the usual hour, or what it meant that his father knew it, or what it meant that the girl had known it before him and had not said that either. He thought about numbers. It was, he was discovering, a thing he could always do, and he put that knowledge away too, with the denarius, in the place where he was beginning to keep the things he owed.

3

The Ship of Isis

Puteoli, March 98

The day after the Nones, at the usual hour, her mother sent her to bed early, and she went, and did not sleep, and that was the first time she counted.

She had heard the steward come. She had heard him from the cupboard under the stairs with the curtain drawn: the door, and the particular pause of her mother's feet in the passage, and his voice, low, saying something that had her mother's name in it, and then the two sets of feet going up. She had heard the stair creak in the place where it creaked. She had heard the door of the room with the window, which was the best room, and which her mother had told the Rhodian in it at noon that he would be changing for the one at the back, with no reason given and the price not altered. And then she had heard nothing, which was what she had been listening for, and she had lain in the dark and counted it.

She did not know why she counted. It was not for anything. It was that the silence had a shape, and she wanted to know the size of it, so that if it came again she would recognise it. She got to four hundred and something and lost the thread and began again, and the second time she got to six hundred before the door, and the feet, and the stair, and his voice in the passage again, not low now, ordinary, the voice he had used on the harbour steps — *the Ides, then, as agreed* — and the outer door, and the bar going down.

Then her mother's feet, going not up but into the kitchen, and water being poured.

She lay with her eyes open and looked at the underside of the stairs. There was a knot in the fourth tread that she had looked at

every night of her life and had decided, at six, was the face of a dog. It was still the face of a dog. She thought: *six hundred, and he said the Ides, and the Rhodian's in the back room, and the price wasn't altered.* She did not put these things together into anything. She was ten. But she put them side by side, carefully, the way you set out counters before a game, and she left them there, and in the morning she got up and did the shutters, and her mother was at the hearth with her hair done and her face ordinary, and said, "The Rhodian wants eggs. Go and see if the Greek woman has any," and she went.

◆

The feast of the Ship came on the fifth day of March, and the whole town went down to the water for it, as it did every year, in its best, with flowers.

It was the goddess's feast, Isis of the Sea, who had opened the sailing-season since before there were Romans to sail in it, and in Puteoli, which had an Alexandrian for every third man on the emporium and a temple to her above the harbour with a roof of gilded bronze, it was the greatest day of the spring. The priests came down from the temple in white linen with their heads shaved, with the sistra going and the long trumpets and the image of the goddess on her litter under a canopy, and behind them the whole of the town's Egypt — the grain-factors and the ship-masters and the women in their fringed shawls and the children with painted faces — and behind them everyone else, because a goddess who opened the sea was nobody's property in a port. They went along the harbour street to the steps where the steward had waited for the courier, and there on the water was the Ship: a little boat, painted and gilded, with a sail of embroidered linen and no crew, filled to the gunwales with flowers and spices and the written prayers of everyone who could write or pay to have it done. The high priest said the words and the ship was pushed out, and the wind took her, and she went out past the end of the mole into the open bay with the sun on her sail, and when she was

small enough that you could cover her with your thumb the whole harbour cheered and the season was open.

She had put a prayer in. She had written it herself, on a scrap of papyrus the Greek woman had given her, in the square letters Nicias had taught her, and she had not shown it to anyone, and she had folded it small and pushed it down among the lilies when the priests' backs were turned. It said: *Let the house stand.* It did not say which house. She had thought about that for two days and decided the goddess would know.

Antiope had put one in too. Antiope had let her read it. It said: *A rich man who is not cruel,* and Antiope had laughed when she wrote it and said, "She's never managed it yet, but she's the only one I've asked who hasn't told me it was my own fault."

Celer had not come. She had looked for him, among the Augustales who walked in the procession behind the priests with their own little image of the Emperor's Genius on a pole, and she had found Hermes, in his toga, with the band of office across his chest, and behind him the stepmother very straight with the baby, and no boy. She had not expected him. The steward had been in the town for ten days and the boy's house had its rules and so, she supposed, did hers. But she had looked, and had seen herself look, and had put that beside the counters too.

◆

So she went out to Baiae in the fishing boat with Antiope instead, in the afternoon, when the feast was done and the town was drunk, and that was when she saw the great.

The boat belonged to a man called Scorpus who fished the bay and was, in the loose way of the lower town, Antiope's friend; he took them because Antiope asked, and because he was going that way anyway to set his pots off the hot-spring shore, where the fish came for the warmth. He had a boy with him and the boy rowed and Scorpus sat in the stern with the tiller under his arm and said nothing,

and Fausta sat in the bows with the water going by close enough to touch and the whole of the coast opening in front of her the way it never did from the land.

She had been to Baiae. She had walked the coast road behind her mother every April of her life to stand in the patron's atrium. But the coast road ran behind the villas, along the hill, and from it you saw gates and walls and the tops of cypresses, and the sea only in pieces. From the water you saw the front. You saw what the villas were for.

They were for being looked at from the water. She understood that within a quarter-mile. Every one of them had been built by a man standing in a boat, saying *there*, and then going ashore to make the hill agree with him; and the hill had agreed, over a hundred years and more, until the whole curve of the shore from the point to the springs was one long staircase of white columns and painted walls and terraces coming down to the sea, with fishponds cut in the rock at the foot of them and boat-houses with their mouths open and gardens on the roofs, and you could not, from the water, tell where one man's property stopped and the next began, because none of them had wanted you to.

And on the terraces, that afternoon, with the season open and the sun warm and the feast of the goddess going on across the bay, were the people the villas were for, and they were naked.

Not all of them. But enough. It was the thing about Baiae that Antiope had told her and that she had not, until that moment, quite believed: that the great, who in Rome went about in more cloth than a sail, came down to this coast in the spring and took it off. There was a terrace with a pool cut in it and three women in the pool and a fourth on the edge with her feet in the water and nothing on at all, laughing at something, with her hair down her back in a rope, and a slave standing behind her holding a cloth she had not asked for. There was a man on a couch under a vine, brown as a nut and bald, with his belly resting on his thighs and a book held up against the sun. There

was a boat-house with its doors open and in the shadow of it a young man with his tunic round his waist and a girl on her knees in front of him, and the young man's face turned to the sea with an expression on it of complete blank patience, like a man waiting for a slow clerk. There were two boys of perhaps her own age racing along a parapet with nothing on and a dog after them. There was a litter being carried along the shore-path by six Nubians in matched tunics with a woman inside it whose arm hung over the side, and on the arm, from the wrist to the elbow, gold.

Nobody looked at the boat. Scorpus set his pots fifty feet from the woman on the pool's edge and she did not turn her head. The man with the book did not lower it. The young man in the boat-house did not change his expression, though the girl, once, looked up and out over the water and met Fausta's eye, and looked back down. They were a fishing boat. They were a fact of the water, like a gull. The great had built their houses to be looked at from the sea and then had forgotten, or had never needed to know, that there would be anything on the sea but their own reflection.

"That's him," Antiope said quietly. "There. Second terrace from the top, with the striped awning."

It was the patron's villa; she knew it by the slipped tile. Under the awning there were couches, and on the couches people, and one of them, large and white-haired and lying on his side with one hand raised as if to beckon a servant, was Bassus. He had a wine-cup. There was a girl pouring. He was, from this distance, exactly the man who had stood in his atrium and said *my people*, except that his toga was on a chair, and the girl who was pouring was Antiope's age, and he was looking at the girl, not the sea, and his hand had come down from its beckoning and rested, lightly, where the girl's tunic ended.

"That's the one from Nola," Antiope said. "The new one. He bought her in the autumn. She'll be at the Dolphin by Saturnalia, you watch; he never keeps them past the winter." She said it without any

particular feeling, as Scorpus might have said the fish were running. "Your mother was his for seven years. Did you know that? Seven. That's the longest anyone remembers. He must have liked her."

Fausta watched the hand.

"He let her go," she said. It came out as a question and she had not meant it to.

"He let her *out*. There's a difference. He put her in the lodging-house with a lease and a name and a baby, and he put it in his will that she's free, and she's been free ever since in every way that matters except one." Antiope leaned back against the thwart and shut her eyes to the sun. "And the one that matters is the one Thallus comes about."

Scorpus, in the stern, cleared his throat. Not a warning; a comment. Antiope opened one eye at him and said, "She's ten, not deaf. Row on."

They rowed on. The villa went behind them. The woman with the gold on her arm was set down at a landing-stage and helped out by the Nubians and went up a flight of marble steps into a house with its whole front open to the sea. The awning of the patron's terrace flapped once in a breath of wind off the land and was still; and Fausta sat in the bows with her hands between her knees and put it all side by side with the rest. The hand on the tunic. Seven years. *In every way that matters except one.* She felt the counters grow in number until they were almost a shape, and then she stopped, deliberately, the way you stop before the end of a sum you do not want to come out, and looked instead at the water going by, which was green, and clear, and had fish in it, and asked nothing of anyone.

◆

The knock came at the second hour of the night, three raps and a fourth after a pause, which was the steward's, and she was in the kitchen with her hands in the bread-trough and did not go to bed.

She had not planned it. She had meant to go up with the Rhodian's water and come down and draw the curtain and count, as before. But her mother was in the yard when the steward's knock came, filling the lamps, and Fausta was in the kitchen, and the knock came a second time before her mother could get the oil-jar down, and so it was Fausta who went to the door and drew the bar and let him in.

He stood in the passage with his hands folded and looked at her. He had a boy with him, a different boy, who stayed outside. The lamp over the door made the top of his bald head shine.

"The Dolphin's girl," he said.

"My mother's in the yard, sir. She's coming."

"I'm in no hurry." He went past her into the common room, where the two tables were, and the bench, and sat down on the bench with his back to the wall, which was where men sat who liked to see the door. "Bring me wine. Not the Rhodian's. Hers."

She brought it. He drank a little and set the cup down and looked at it, and then he looked at her again with the pricing look, and said, "You read, I'm told."

"Yes, sir."

"Who told you that you could?"

She did not understand the question, and then did. "Nicias, sir. In Hermes's house. He lets me sit."

"Nicias." Thallus turned the cup a quarter-turn on the table. "Nicias is my master's slave, lent to Hermes at a rent that Hermes is three months behind on, and if Nicias is teaching a lodging-house girl to read on my master's time I should like to know who is paying for it." He said this without the smallest heat, as one notes a discrepancy in a column. "Not that I object. A girl who can read is worth more than a girl who can't, in the right place. I only like to know where the money's going." He drank. "What do you read?"

"Whatever he has. He's got Homer. He's got a book about Egypt."

"And figures?"

"Yes, sir."

"Give me the sum of the Rhodian's bill. He's been here nine nights at four asses and he's had wine every night at two and the girl twice." He said *the girl* as though Antiope were an item on the slate, which, she realised, to him she was. "What does he owe?"

She did it in her head. Nine fours, thirty-six; nine twos, eighteen; and Antiope, who was eight an evening for a lodger — she knew this because she had heard her mother say it on the stairs — sixteen. "Seventy asses, sir. Four denarii and six."

"And what will he pay?"

She looked at him.

"He'll pay what he's charged," Thallus said patiently, "which will not be what he owes, because your mother will have rounded it to four denarii to keep his custom and will have forgotten, as she forgets every spring, to charge him for the water the girl carries up. So he'll pay sixty-four and your mother will say *seventy* to me when I ask, and the six in the middle is the kind of thing that a steward is paid to notice." He finished the wine. "Not that I'll mention it. It's not worth the mention. I'm telling you so that you understand what reading is for."

Her mother came in from the yard then with oil on her hands, and stopped in the door, and looked at the steward on the bench and the girl standing before him, and something went across her face that was there and gone before Fausta could name it.

"Thallus."

"Hilara." He stood. "I was examining your daughter in arithmetic. She has it. She'll be useful." He said it to Hilara and he kept his eyes on Fausta while he said it, and she felt the word *useful* go into her and lodge, the way a splinter goes in, too small to find and too deep to leave alone. "Shall we go up? I've the villa to get back to and the master wants his accounts by the lamp."

Her mother said, “Fausta. The Rhodian’s water.”

“The Rhodian,” said Thallus, “can wait. He’s not paying for it.” And he went up the stairs, and after a moment her mother wiped her hands on her gown and went after him, and Fausta stood in the common room with the empty cup in her hand and listened to the stair creak in the place it creaked, and did not count. She found she did not need to. She knew the size of it now.

◆

Her mother came down afterwards and found her still in the common room, on the bench where the steward had sat, with the cup in front of her and the slate.

She had not meant to be found. She had meant to be under the stairs with the curtain drawn. But the slate had been on its nail by the door and the stylus with it. She had taken them down without quite deciding to and had sat where he had sat, with her back to the wall and her eyes on the door, and had written out the Rhodian’s bill the way he would have written it — nine nights, the wine, the girl, the water nobody charged — and had been looking at the two numbers at the foot of it, the one that was owed and the one that would be paid, when the stair creaked and her mother was in the doorway in her shift with her hair down.

Hilara looked at the slate. She did not take it. She came and sat on the other side of the table, which she never did, since the other side of the table was where the lodgers sat and she had a rule about it, and she put her elbows on the board and her chin on her hands and looked at her daughter across the lamp.

“He asked you the Rhodian.”

“Yes.”

“And you gave him seventy.”

“Yes.”

“And then he told you I’d take sixty-four.” Her mother’s mouth moved; it was not a smile. “He does that. He asks a child a sum and

then tells the child where the mother's cheating, so the child goes to bed knowing something about the mother that the mother didn't tell her. It costs him nothing and it's a hook in you for life. Don't take it to heart. I'd have told you myself in a year; he's only moved the day." She reached out and turned the slate round and looked at the figures. "Your sevens are too like your ones. He'll have noticed that too. Make the tail longer."

Fausta made the tail longer.

"I'll tell you what he didn't tell you," Hilara said, "since he's started it. I take sixty-four from the Rhodian because the Rhodian comes four times a year and brings two others with him and tells the whole of his island that the Dolphin's honest, and the six asses I don't charge him buys me that. Thallus knows this. Thallus doesn't care. Thallus wants the six asses on his slate as a thing I owe him, because a woman who owes him six asses can be made to owe him anything, and a woman who owes him nothing can't. That's the whole of it. That's the whole of the man. He's not clever. He's only never once in his life forgotten a number." She pushed the slate back across. "You're cleverer than him already. Don't let him see it. Give him his seventy and let him catch you in the six and look ashamed, and you'll have him thinking he's got you, and a man who thinks he's got you leaves you alone. That's a thing I know."

The lamp guttered and she trimmed it without looking.

"Mama." It was a word Fausta used perhaps twice a year. "What does he come for?"

Her mother was still for a moment with the trimming-pin in her fingers. Then she set it down.

"He comes for the quarter," she said. "I pay the lease on this house to the patron through the steward, and the steward comes for it, and I give it him. That's one thing. And he comes to see the accounts, because the patron likes to know what his people are making, and I show him. That's another." She looked at the lamp, not at the girl.

"And he comes because there's a paper in a box in the patron's study in Rome, and in the paper it says that a woman called Hilara who was the patron's is to be free when he dies, and have this house, and a sum. And a paper like that can be taken out of a box and put in a fire by any man who holds the key to the room. Thallus holds the key to the room. That's the third thing." She was quiet. "You've worked out most of this already, I think. You've been counting on the stairs. I heard you the first night. You breathe different when you're counting."

Fausta looked at the table.

"Don't be ashamed of it. Count. It's what I'd do." Hilara reached across and put her hand, briefly, over the girl's hand on the slate, and took it away. "I'm not telling you this so you'll be frightened. I'm telling you so that when you hear men say your mother's a free woman you'll know what it costs to stay one, and so that when you're grown you'll know what to look for in a box. The paper's the thing. Not the man. Men come and go up the stairs; they always have; a lodging-house is a lodging-house. But the paper is the one thing in this world with my name on it that says I'm not a thing, and until the patron's dead and it's been read out in front of witnesses, it belongs to whoever's standing nearest the fire." She stood. "Now go to bed. And tomorrow you're to go to Nicias as usual, steward or no steward, by the kitchen door; I've thought about it and I'd rather you learned than hid. A girl who can read a paper is a girl who can tell when one's been changed."

"Thallus said he'd like to know who was paying for it."

"Did he." Her mother picked up the slate and hung it on its nail. "Then you can tell him, if he asks again, that I am. In the usual coin. At the usual hour." She said it flatly, to the wall. "He'll understand. He's never forgotten a number in his life."

And she went up, and Fausta went under the stairs and drew the curtain and lay a long time looking at the dog's face, and thought

about the box, and the key, and the fire, and found that she had stopped being ten at some point in the evening and had not noticed when.

◆

She went to the tutor's room the next day by the kitchen door with the oil-jar on her hip, as she had been told, having decided on the way up the hill that her mother was right and the rule about the steward was a rule about being seen, and that a girl with an oil-jar was not seen by anyone, and that if she was wrong about this she would find out.

She was not wrong. Daphnis looked at the jar and at her and let her through, and the stepmother was at the loom in the atrium and did not look up, and Nicias was in his room with the shutters half-closed against the morning and a cup beside the bed, awake for once, writing something on a tablet that he turned face-down when she came in. Celer was not there.

"He's at the warehouse," Nicias said. "With his father. There is a consignment of oil that his father wishes him to see counted, because the steward is coming to look at it tomorrow and his father wishes his son to know what a warehouse looks like when it has been prepared for a steward. It is an education in itself. Sit down." She sat. "You've missed a week."

"I had to."

"I know you had to. I didn't ask you why. I said you'd missed it." He picked up the cup. "You've been on the water, I hear. Out to the springs."

She stared at him.

"Scorpus's boy is my laundress's son," Nicias said. "This is a town of forty thousand souls and there are perhaps six who don't know by nightfall what the other thirty-nine thousand did in the afternoon, and I regret to say that I am not one of the six. Don't look like that. It's nothing. Everyone goes out to look at the villas once. It's how the villas are supposed to be looked at. The only people who think they're

private are the people in them." He drank. "What did you see?"

She thought about the hand on the tunic. She thought about the young man in the boat-house with his face turned to the sea. She said, "They didn't look at the boat."

Nicias set the cup down.

"No," he said. "No, they didn't. Good. That's the lesson, and you've had it, and most people go their whole lives without it." He leaned forward with his elbows on his knees, and for a moment the dry indoor face was something else, something that she would remember later and come to think of as the nearest the man ever got to anger. "Listen to me. I am a slave. I have been a slave for fifty-three years and I shall die one, because the master has no reason to free me and a great many reasons not to, and I have taught his son and his daughter and his freedman's son and I have had, in all that time, exactly one thing that was mine, and it was this: I could see them, and they could not see me. Not *would* not. *Could* not. I was the boat. You understand? A man who is being looked at and does not know it is a man who can be read, as you read a page, and he will turn his pages for you, one after another, and never once think to ask what you are writing down." He sat back. "That is what reading is for. Not accounts. Thallus told you accounts, I imagine; it's what Thallus thinks it's for, and for Thallus he's right. But Thallus is a steward, and a steward is a man who has read one book very carefully. There are others."

She sat with her hands in her lap and felt something in her chest that she did not have a name for and that she would later, when she had read more books, call *being seen*; and it was so unlike the pricing look of the men on the stairs that for a moment she did not recognise it as a kind of looking at all.

"He said I'd be useful," she said.

"You will. That's not in your gift. What's in your gift is to whom." Nicias reached for the tablet he had turned over, and turned

it back, and she saw it was a letter in Greek, half-written, with a name at the top she could not read upside-down. "Now. The boy will be back after noon and he'll want to tell you about the warehouse, and he'll tell it badly, because he's eleven and he thinks a warehouse is about oil. Let him. Then ask him how many jars the steward counted and how many his father said there were. It won't be the same number. It never is. And watch his face when he realises that his father lied to the steward in front of him and that he was meant to see it done." He bent to the letter. "That's his lesson. He'll have it today or next year, but he'll have it. Go and fill your jar; you're supposed to be fetching oil."

◆

Celer came back after noon with warehouse-dust on him and told her about the warehouse. He told it badly. She let him. He told her about the stacks and the tallies and the whitewash and how the steward would walk the aisles tomorrow with his hands folded and look at everything and say nothing, and how his father had had the men move the Baetican jars to the back where the light was bad. She said, "How many jars did your father say there were?" and he said, "Four hundred and twenty," and she said, "And how many did you count?" and he opened his mouth, and shut it, and she watched his face, as she had been told to, and saw it happen.

It was not a large thing. His eyes went to the side, to the wall, where there was nothing, and came back; and his mouth, which had been open to say a number, closed on it; and something behind his face that had been a boy's rearranged itself and was, for the space of a breath, not. Then it was a boy's again, and he said, "Four hundred and twenty," and looked at her steadily, and she understood that he had just chosen, in front of her, to carry his father's number instead of his own, and that he knew she had seen him choose it.

"All right," she said.

"It's the Baetican measure. They're smaller. If you count by the Italian —"

"I said all right."

He was quiet. Then he said, in a different voice: "You went out to Baiae. In Scorpus's boat."

"Everyone knows."

"I didn't. I had to hear it from Daphnis." He looked at the wax on his knee. "What was it like?"

She thought about how to tell him. She thought about the woman with her feet in the pool, and the boys racing on the parapet, and the gold from wrist to elbow, and the patron's hand. She thought about the boat-house, and about the girl's eyes coming up over the water and meeting hers and going down again, and about how she had felt, meeting them, a thing she had not felt before and had no name for yet, which was not pity, and was not fear, and had a heat in it she did not understand and did not like and had, since, lain awake with. She had seen a man's body before; she had grown up in a lodging-house. But she had not before seen one being *used*, in the open, in the sun, as a thing is used, and had not before felt herself, watching it, become for a moment a thing that could be used too, and known it, in her skin, the way you know cold.

She did not tell him any of that. She was ten. She said, "They didn't look at the boat."

And he, who was eleven, and had just chosen a number, and was looking at her across the tutor's room with warehouse-dust in his hair and something in his face that was new and that she would spend years learning the name of, said after a moment: "No. They wouldn't."

So they did ratios, because Nicias had gone out and left the tablets, and because it was the thing to do with hands. And when she went home at dusk with the oil-jar full, the house was quiet and her mother was at the hearth and the Rhodian had paid — sixty-four asses,

exactly, she saw it on the slate — and Antiope was on the stairs with her knees up, and said as she passed, "Well? Was the goddess kind?"

"She didn't say."

"She never does, duck. That's how you know it's her and not a man." Antiope yawned. "Thallus says the villa's full. Senators' sons up from Rome for the season, because it's safer here than there until the Spaniard's settled. He says I'm to go up from next week. Good money. He says the young master's asked for me particular." She stretched, and the shift went off her shoulder, and she did not fix it. "A rich man who's not cruel. We'll see. Maybe she was listening."

And she went up, and Fausta stood at the foot of the stairs and looked at the knot in the fourth tread that was a dog's face, and counted, this time without meaning to, and got nowhere, and went in to the hearth, and her mother, without turning, said: "Did Hermes's boy tell you his number?"

"Four hundred and twenty."

Hilara nodded slowly, at the fire. "Then he's his father's," she said. "That's settled, then. That's one thing we know." And she handed her daughter the ladle, and the day was over, and the season was open, and the little gilded ship was somewhere out past the point with its freight of flowers and prayers, going wherever the wind had decided, with nobody aboard to say otherwise.

4

The Books

Puteoli, summer 98

The grain fleet came in on the ninth day before the Kalends of June, two hundred and eleven sail, and his father made him count them.

He stood on the roof of the warehouse with a tablet and a stylus and the whole of the emporium below him roaring, and he counted. It was not easy. They came round the point of Misenum in no order, the big Alexandrian hulls with their artemon sails bellied out ahead of them like a second ship, and the smaller carriers tucked in among them, and the harbour boats going out to meet them in a swarm. The town on every roof and the mole black with people and the magistrates on the harbour steps in their purple-bordered best with the priests of Isis behind them and the trumpets; and from the warehouse roof, with the sun on the water and the whole bay full of canvas, they looked less like ships than like a thing that had happened to the sea. He counted anyway. He counted by masts, because masts did not move, and he made a mark for every ten and a cross for every fifty, and when the last of them was inside the mole and the roar had settled into the long rolling noise of a town that would be drunk by nightfall, he had two hundred and eleven. He went down the ladder and gave the tablet to his father.

His father looked at it. "The harbour-master will say two hundred and nine."

"I counted twice."

"I know you did. The harbour-master will say two hundred and nine because two of them are ours and they came in the night before last and anchored off the springs, and he's been paid not to have seen them." His father put the tablet in his belt. "You're right. Remember

that you're right. And remember that being right about a thing the harbour-master has been paid to be wrong about is worth exactly nothing until you know who paid him." He turned to go down to the quay, and stopped, and looked back at his son with an expression Celer could not read. "I paid him. In case you were going to ask. Now come and watch them unload the *Isis*."

◆

The summer went like that: a lesson in everything, from a man who gave lessons the way other men breathed, without appearing to notice he was doing it, and who had decided, that year, that the time for his son to learn the business by watching was over and the time to learn it by doing had come.

So Celer did. He went down to the warehouse at the first hour and stayed until the lamps. He learned the measures, Italian and Baetican and Alexandrian and the one the Rhodians used that was none of these. He learned the tallies, which were kept on wooden boards hung in the aisles and which he was made to reconcile every evening against the wax, and against the papyrus in the strong-room that was the record of record. He learned that the three never quite agreed and that his father could look at the discrepancy and say to within an amphora who had been careless and who had been thieving and which of the two was cheaper to tolerate. He learned the names of the masters of the three hulls and what each of them drank and what each of them was owed and what each of them owed back, and he learned the shape of the contract that was the whole of the house's fortune: so many thousand modii of Egyptian wheat carried from Alexandria to Puteoli each season on behalf of the prefecture of the grain-supply in Rome, at a rate per modius fixed under Nerva, with a bounty for early delivery and a penalty for short. The whole of it countersigned by a freedman of the prefect's office named Felix whose name his father never said without a small movement of the lips, as though tasting something.

"Felix," his father said, in the strong-room, with the lamp between them and the contract unrolled on the table, "is the kind of man who has a price and lets you know it. That's a good kind. It's the ones who don't that cost you. Felix is a freedman of Nerva's household, and Nerva is dead, and the new man will bring his own freedmen down from Germany, or he won't, and either way there'll be a season when Felix doesn't know whether he's Felix any more, and in that season he'll be expensive. I've put money by for it." He touched the papyrus. "Read me the penalty clause."

Celer read it. His Greek was bad, Nicias said, but his Latin was his father's, and the contract was in the Latin of the grain-office, which was a language of its own, with no verbs to speak of and every noun hedged about with others. He read it twice before he understood it, and then he said, "It's by weight. Not by measure. The penalty's by weight."

"Yes."

"But the tallies are by measure."

"Yes."

"So if the grain's wet —"

"If the grain's wet," his father said, "it weighs more, and the prefecture gets its weight and we get our bounty, and the baker in the Subura gets a loaf that's a tenth water, and nobody counts that, because the baker's a baker. And if the grain's dry it weighs less, and the prefecture docks us, and we go to Felix. And Felix, who is paid by the prefecture to weigh the grain, weighs it on a day when it's been under a wet sail." He rolled the contract. "You're going to ask me if that's honest. Don't. It's the measure. It's the Baetican jar again; it's smaller, and everyone knows it's smaller, and the price is set knowing. The man who'd lose by it is a man in Rome who's never seen a ship and never will. I'm not going to the lamp for him."

Celer did not ask if it was honest. He had learned, since the warehouse and the four hundred and twenty, not to ask that, or rather

to ask it somewhere else, in a place behind his face where the answer was always the same and never made any difference. He said instead: "Who else knows it's by weight?"

His father looked at him for a long moment across the lamp.

"Felix," he said. "The prefect, if he's ever read it, which he hasn't. Me. You. And the girl from the Dolphin, if she's read this table as often as I think she has when my back's turned, because she reads everything, that one, and remembers it, and I've never yet caught her doing it, which is the only reason I let it go on." He put the contract in its box and locked it. "I'm not angry. I'd rather she read my papers than Thallus's. Only remember, when you're grown and have papers of your own, that the people who can read them are the people who can hurt you, and that there are only ever two things to do about that. You can stop them reading, which you can't; or you can make it cost them more to tell than to keep. That's the whole of business. Everything else is jars."

◆

She was in the tutor's room that afternoon, with Nicias asleep and a book in her lap she was not reading, and she looked up when he came in and said, "You've been in the strong-room. You've got lamp-smoke in your hair."

He sat on the step. He did not say *my father knows you read his papers*. He had thought about it the whole way up the hill and had decided that it was his father's to say, and that his father would not say it, and that this meant something, though he did not yet know what. He said instead, "The contract's by weight."

"I know."

"How long have you known?"

"Since the winter. I read it when he was out and you were counting jars." She said it without any shame at all, as she said everything. "It's in the fourth line of the second column. *Pondere, non mensura*. He's had it there for two years and he reads it every month

and he's never once had the words cut out, because the day he does, Felix knows he's noticed." She turned a page she had not read. "Does he know I know?"

"Yes."

She was quiet. He watched her put it where she kept things; he had begun, that summer, to be able to see her do it, a small settling of the face, like a bird closing its wings. "And he's not angry."

"He says he'd rather you read his than Thallus's."

"That's not the same as not angry."

"No," Celer agreed. It was the thing about her, that she would not let a sentence by that was doing two jobs. "It's not."

They sat. Nicias snored once, softly, and turned over on his pallet with the book sliding off his face, and did not wake. Through the half-shutter the sound of the town came up, the long drunk roar of the fleet's second day, and the smell of fish frying in a hundred streets, and under it, faint, the sulphur.

"Show me the tallies," she said.

He looked at her.

"The boards. You said they never agree with the wax. Show me how you tell who's thieving and who's careless. I want to see if I can do it." She closed the book. "Not the papers in the box. I won't go in the box again, you can tell him. The boards. They're hung in the aisles for anyone to see; a boy with a broom sees them. That's not reading his papers. That's looking at his wall."

He thought about it. He thought about his father's face across the lamp, and *the only reason I let it go on*, and the thing he had not been able to read in it; and he thought about the girl in front of him who had read the contract in the winter and had not told him until he found out, which was either a betrayal or the opposite. He could not, at eleven, make up his mind which, and suspected — he was beginning to suspect this about a great many things — that it was both.

"Tomorrow," he said. "First hour. Before he's down. Come in by the quay door; the men know you."

"They know me as Hilara's girl."

"That'll do. Hilara's girl comes for fish-sauce. Bring a jar."

She smiled, then, which she did not often do, and never for long; it went across her face like light off water and was gone. "I always bring a jar," she said.

◆

So in the summer of the Spaniard's first year, while Rome waited for its emperor and the senate made speeches about liberty and the Guard sat in its camp and sulked, the son of Hermes and the daughter of Hilara stood in the aisles of a warehouse on the emporium of Puteoli at the first hour of the morning with a fish-sauce jar between them and read the walls.

He showed her the boards. He showed her how each aisle had its own, and each board its own hand, because each aisle had its own man, and how you learned the hands before you learned anything else: Pyrrhus in the first aisle made his fives like a gallows and never got a sum wrong and was, in consequence, never watched; Syrus in the third made beautiful figures and lost a jar a week and was watched always and never caught, because the jar was never a jar, it was a sixth of one, poured off the top of six. He showed her how to run a finger down a column and feel for the place where the hand changed — not the figures, the pressure, the way a man leaned on the stylus when he was writing what he had counted and the way he did not when he was writing what he wished he had. He showed her the wax, which was the aisle-men's boards copied each evening by the clerk, and the places where the clerk's copying improved on the boards without meaning to, because the clerk was a man who liked round numbers. And he showed her the thing his father had shown him, which was that the discrepancy between the board and the wax and the papyrus was not a problem to be solved but a fact to be read, like a face, and that a house

whose three records agreed was a house where somebody had gone to the trouble of making them.

She was faster than he was. He had known she would be. She had the memory, the thing Nicias had said about her in the doorkeeper's hearing years ago, and once she had seen a column she had it, and could set it beside another column from the day before and see where the two did not meet without going back to look. He did not have that. What he had, and found out that summer he had, by watching her not have it, was the other thing: he could see what the column was *for*. She would say, "Syrus is a sixth short on the Baetican again," and he would say, "Yes, and he's a sixth over on the Italian, because he's selling the Baetican oil in Italian jars to the sausage-woman's brother and splitting it," and she would look at him and say, "How do you know that?" and he would not be able to tell her, except that he knew Syrus and he knew the sausage-woman's brother and he knew what a sixth of a jar was worth and to whom. It had fitted together behind his face while she was still reading.

"You see the system," she said once, on the quay, with the jar full and the sun just over the warehouse roof. "I see the page. That's the difference."

"Nicias says you've got the better memory."

"Nicias is right. And he says you've got no Greek style and he's right about that too. It doesn't mean what you think it means." She hefted the jar. "A page is only a page. A system's a thing you can live in."

He thought about that, going back up the aisle. He thought about it so long that Pyrrhus asked him if he was ill.

◆

He took her into the strong-room once that summer, at the end of it, with the lid off, and read her a bill.

It was not against his father's word; his father had said *I'd rather she read mine than Thallus's* and had meant it as a figure, and Celer

had decided, at eleven, that a figure a man said was a figure he could be held to. So on an evening in September with the fleet gone and the town quiet and his father at the Augustales' dinner, he lit the lamp in the strong-room and took down from the shelf a pine box with his father's seal on the lid, and broke nothing, because the seal was on a thread that lifted, and set the lid beside it. She stood in the door and did not come in.

"You said you'd not go in the box again."

"I'm not. You are. I'm reading it to you. That's different, and he'd say so." He unrolled a sheet. "You've read the contract. *Pondere, non mensura*. You know what it says. You don't know what it's *for*. I'll show you what it's for, and then you'll know the thing he knows and I know and Thallus doesn't, and there'll be three of us, and he'd rather that than two of them."

She came in. She stood across the table from him with the lamp between and her hands at her sides and the shutter to. He read it to her, with his eyes on the sheet and not on her, because that was how he read: a sail-maker's bill, from the year the *Isis* was bought, for a mainsail of the heavy Egyptian canvas, so many pounds, so much the pound, and in the margin, in his father's small square hand, a second figure beside the first, and beside that a word.

"*Dry*," he read. "That's the first. That's what the sail weighs rolled on the quay. And this one, under it, he's written himself — it's not the sail-maker's, see, it's his ink — that's the sail *wet*. He had it weighed both ways the day it came. Four hundred pounds between them." He looked at the margin. "A spare mainsail's stowed over the forward hold. If it's been over the side in the night on a line and come up and been stowed again across the hatch-boards, and the forward hold's weighed with it on, by a man who's not a sailor, the hold's four hundred pounds over. And a hull that's over is a hull that's early and full, and nobody docks a hull that's over. They pay her the bounty." He set the sheet down. "That's what *by weight* is for. That's the whole

of it. He's written the sum in the margin of a sail-maker's bill because he's a man who writes the sum down, and he's never burned a sheet in his life, and the bill's in this box, and now you know."

She did not say anything for a long moment. She looked at the margin, and at the two figures, and at the word. He saw her put it where she kept things, the small settling, the bird closing its wings; and then she looked up, at him, across the lamp, which she did not often do when he was reading, and held it, so that he looked up from the sheet and found her already looking, and could not read her, and would remember that he could not.

"All right," she said.

That was all. *All right.* He put the lid back on and the seal back on its thread and the box on its shelf, and she went out by the quay door, and he stood in the strong-room with the lamp and understood that he had just shown her the one thing in his father's house that could be used against his father, because he had wanted her to see what he could see. That she had said *all right* and looked at him, and that he did not know what either of those meant, and that he had done it anyway, and that this was going to be true, he suspected, of a great many things.

◆

Nicias caught him at it in July — not the warehouse; the thinking.

"You've a face on you like a man doing long division in a temple," the tutor said. "Stop it. Sit. We're doing Demosthenes, and you'll hate it, and that's the point." He had the roll open on his knees, and the cup beside him, and the shutters half-closed, and the girl was not there; she had the fleet's accounts to help with at the Dolphin, where the masters lodged in the season and ran up bills that Hilara had begun, that summer, to let her daughter keep. "*On the Crown.* He's defending his whole life in front of a jury that's already decided. Read me the opening."

Celer read it. His Greek was what it was: correct, and flat, every word in its place and none of them alive. Nicias listened with his eyes shut, and when it was done he said, "Yes. Well. You've just killed a man who's been dead four hundred years and I didn't think it could be done twice." He opened his eyes. "Do you know why you've no style?"

"Because I don't care about it."

"No. Because you don't believe anyone is listening. You read as if the words were a tally-board — a thing that's true whether anyone looks at it or not. Demosthenes didn't believe that. He believed that nothing was true until he'd made five hundred Athenians feel it in their stomachs, and he was right, and it's the only thing worth knowing about Greek." Nicias reached for the cup. "Your father has the same fault, and it has made him rich, so I don't say it's a fault in a shipowner. But you're not going to be a shipowner. You're going to Rome on a senator's staff, and in Rome nothing is true until someone has said it well in the right room, and a man who can only count will spend his life counting for men who can talk."

"The girl talks."

"The girl listens, which is rarer, and she'll talk when she needs to, because she's listened to how it's done. You've never listened to anything in your life but a number." He drank. "I'm not scolding. I'm telling you where the gap is so you'll know what you're stepping over when you fall in it."

Celer looked at the roll. He said, after a while, "You write to Rufus about me."

"I write to Rufus about everything. He pays me to — not in coin; he lets me keep the books. It's the same thing." Nicias did not look away. "I wrote to him in the spring that you had a head for figures and no Greek style and that you would be useful to him in exactly the way your father intends and in no other, unless someone took the trouble. He wrote back asking whether I thought it worth the trouble. I said I

didn't know yet."

"And the girl? Do you write about her?"

The tutor was quiet for a moment. Then he said, "I wrote once. In the winter. I said there was a child at the back of my room who had a memory like a strong-room and no one had thought to lock it. He wrote back and asked whose child. I told him. He didn't write again about it." He set the cup down. "I shouldn't have said that to you. I've said it. Put it where you put things, and read me the next paragraph, and this time pretend that someone in the room wants you to lose."

Celer read the next paragraph. He pretended. It was no better, but Nicias said it was, slightly, and let him go; and he went down through the house with the roll's words still in his mouth and the other words under them, *whose child*, and *he didn't write again*. He thought that a man who did not write again about a thing was a man who had put it somewhere, and that he would like, very much, to know where.

◆

"You'll not go down to the Dolphin again," his father said, breaking bread, in August, with his eyes on the tablets.

It was not a scene. His father did not make scenes; a scene was a thing a man did when he had failed to arrange matters so that it was unnecessary. It was done at breakfast, in the ordinary voice, with the tablets open and the stepmother at the loom in the next room where she could hear and was meant to.

"The steward goes back to Rome with the family on the Kalends of September," his father said. "Until then, and after, you'll keep away from Hilara's house. Not the girl; the girl may come here, by the kitchen, as she does. The house." He turned a leaf of the tablet. "You've been seen going in. Twice in July. By the quay door, in the evening, when you'd told your mother you were at the baths."

Celer said nothing. There was nothing to say that was not either a lie or an admission, and he had learned that silence, with his father, was taken as the second and forgiven more readily than the first.

"I don't ask what you did there. I know what you did there; you sat in the yard with the girl and the other one and talked, because you're eleven and there's nothing else you'd know how to do. I'm not a fool and I wasn't born a Roman. But I'm telling you to stop, and I'm telling you why, which I don't have to. It's this." His father put the stylus down. "Thallus goes to that house. The master's son goes to that house, or sends for what's in it. Half the villa goes to that house in the season. It's a lodging-house with a woman upstairs; that's what it is, and that's what it's been since before you were born, and there's no shame in it for Hilara, who does what she can with what she was given, and none for the girl. But there's shame in it for *you*. Not now. In ten years. When you're in Rome on Rufus's staff and some clerk who's jealous of you finds out that Hermes's boy used to be at the Puteoli whorehouse every evening of his twelfth summer, and tells it at dinner, and makes it something it wasn't." He picked up the stylus again. "I've spent thirty years making sure there's nothing anyone can say about this house that's true. I'm not going to have you hand them something. Keep away."

"She's not —"

"I know what she's not. I said so. I'm not talking about what she is. I'm talking about what can be said." His father looked at him then, and there was something in the look that was almost — Celer would think about this for years and never settle it — almost an apology, or the place where an apology would have been in a different man. "You think I'm hard. I'm not hard. I'm *careful*. You'll be glad of it. Now go down to the warehouse; the *Isis* is loading for the return and I want the manifest in your hand, not the clerk's."

He went down to the warehouse. He held the manifest. He did not go to the Dolphin for eleven days, and on the twelfth he went, and that was the first time in his life he disobeyed his father in a thing that mattered, and he did it, as he would do most such things afterwards, without deciding to.

◆

He went in by the yard, over the wall from the alley behind, because the quay door was watched now — he had seen Daphnis's son loitering at the corner on the ninth day and had understood what that meant — and dropped down among the cats by the shrine with the pink ghost in it, and stood still, and listened.

The house was quiet. It was the dead hour after noon, when the lodgers were out or asleep and the women were in the kitchen or upstairs with the shutters closed against the heat, and the yard had the stillness of a place that has been used hard and is resting. Antiope was not there; Antiope was at the villa, had been since the spring, and came down only on the goddess's days with silver in her hem and a look in her face that he had seen and not understood and had, lately, begun to. The shrine's saucer had milk in it. Someone had put a flower by it, a single red one, and the cats had not touched that.

The girl came out of the kitchen with a basin and saw him and stopped.

She did not say *you're not supposed to be here*. She looked at him over the basin, and he watched her read him — the wall-dust on his knees, the sweat, the way he was standing — and put it away, and say, in the ordinary voice: "You've got nine days before the steward goes. If you're going to be stupid, be stupid in the house. The alley's watched from the baker's roof."

"Daphnis's boy."

"And one of the steward's. Since the Ides. He sits with the baker's girl and watches the yard wall. He's not very good at it." She set the basin down. "Come in. My mother's asleep. She sleeps now, in the afternoons; she didn't use to."

He went in. He had been in the common room many times, and the kitchen, and the yard; he had never been further, and she did not take him further now, but she took him to the foot of the stairs, where the light came down from the window on the landing, and sat on the

third step. He sat on the first, and they looked at each other with the whole of the quiet house around them like held breath.

"He's forbidden you."

"Yes."

"Because of what can be said."

"How did you —"

"It's what he'd say. It's what Thallus would say. It's what anyone would say who'd thought about it, and your father's never not thought about anything." She put her chin on her knees. "He's right."

"I know he's right."

"And you came anyway."

"Yes."

She was quiet. The light moved on the stairs. Somewhere above them a shutter ticked in the heat, and a lodger turned over, and the whole house settled a fraction on its timbers the way a ship did at anchor.

"Why?" she said.

He did not know. That was the truth and he knew it was the truth and he knew she would know it if he said anything else, so he sat on the bottom step and looked at her and tried to find it, the way you tried to find a sum that had gone wrong somewhere in the middle; and what he found, when he went looking, was not an answer but a number, and the number was eleven days, and under it another. The other was *two years, three*, and under that, very small, so that he could barely read it, the thing his father had said at breakfast about the twelfth summer and the clerk at dinner and *makes it something it wasn't*; and he understood, sitting there, that his father had been describing a thing that had not happened yet in order to prevent it, and that he, Celer, had climbed a wall in the heat of the afternoon to find out whether it was true.

"I don't know," he said.

She looked at him a long moment. Then she nodded, slowly, as if he had said something exact.

"All right," she said. "That'll do. It's better than a reason." And she got up off the step and went into the kitchen and came back with bread and a piece of the hard cheese the Rhodians liked, and gave him half, and sat down again on the third step, and said with her mouth full, "Tell me about the *Isis*. Is it true she's got a bronze eye on the bow that the master touches before he sails?"

So he told her about the *Isis*. And at the end of it he said, because it had been in him since the strong-room and had to come out somewhere, "He said you're the only one besides Felix and him who knows it's by weight. He said the people who can read your papers are the people who can hurt you, and there are only two things to do about it, and one of them's to make it cost them more to tell than to keep."

She stopped chewing.

"And which has he done with me?"

"I don't know. I don't think he's decided." He looked at the bread in his hand. "I don't think he knows what it would cost you to tell. I don't think anyone does. I think that's why he lets it go on."

"And you?" she said. "Do you know?"

He thought about it honestly, because she had asked honestly, and because the house was quiet and it was the dead hour and there was nobody to perform for. "No," he said. "I know what it'd cost him. I know what it'd cost me. I don't know what it'd cost you, because I don't know what you'd get. I don't know what you want." He looked up. "What do you want?"

It was the first time he had asked. He saw it land. He saw her face do the thing it did — the bird closing its wings — and then, unexpectedly, open again, so that for the length of a breath he was looking at a girl of ten on a stair with bread in her hand and nothing in front of her face at all.

"I want the house to stand," she said. "That's what I put in the Ship. I didn't say which house. I thought she'd know." She put the last of the bread in her mouth. "That's what you've got that I haven't. You know which house. Your father's told you every day of your life. It's on a stone on the Capua road with a ship under it." She stood up. "Go on. Over the wall, not the quay. The baker's girl goes in at the ninth hour and he goes with her, and he won't be back on the roof for a quarter. Count a hundred after you hear the baker's door."

He counted a hundred. He went over the wall. Nobody saw him, or if they did, nobody said; and he walked back up to the house above the macellum through the dead white heat with the taste of Rhodian cheese in his mouth and her question in him, *do you know*, and his own, *what do you want*, and the thing she had said about the stone, which was true, and which he had never once in his life thought of as a thing that could be envied.

His stepmother was at the loom. She looked at the wall-dust on his knees. She said, "Your father's at the warehouse till dark," and went back to the thread, and that was all; and he understood that he had been given something, and did not know whether it was a kindness or a debt, and put it with the others.

◆

On the Kalends of September the family went back to Rome, and the steward with them, and the villa was shut, and the slipped tile stayed where it was; and on the second day of the month a letter came down from Rufus to his father, by the ordinary post, which Celer was allowed to read because it concerned him.

It was short. The young master thanked Hermes for the summer's hospitality, by which he meant, Celer's father said drily, the loan. He reported that the emperor was still in the north and had gone from the Rhine to the Danube to review the Pannonian legions, as Hermes had predicted, and that Rome did not expect him before the next summer at the earliest. He mentioned that the Dacian king had sent an

embassy to the emperor's camp and that nobody knew what had been said, which was, in Rufus's phrase, *the kind of silence that is usually expensive for somebody.* And he closed by saying that he looked forward to seeing Hermes's boy in Rome when the emperor came, as his father had so kindly proposed, since the young man would want to see the city before he was asked to be useful in it.

"*When the emperor comes,*" his father said, and folded the letter. "Next summer, then. A year." He looked at his son across the table. "You'll go up with me for the entry. You'll see the thing. You'll see him."

"Yes, Father."

"And you'll stop going over the Dolphin's wall." It was said in exactly the same voice. "The baker's girl is Vibia's laundress's niece. I've known since the first time. I let it go because the steward was here and a boy who's forbidden a thing and does it anyway is a boy who'll be hard to break later, and I'd rather you were hard. But the steward's gone and so's the reason." He put the letter in the box. "Nine days. I counted too. It's a thing you'll find, in this house, that there's never only one of us counting."

Celer said nothing. He went down to the warehouse. He held the manifest. And in the strong-room, with the lamp, when the clerk had gone, he unrolled the contract and read the fourth line of the second column, *pondere, non mensura*, and he thought about the girl on the third step saying *a system's a thing you can live in*, and he thought that she was wrong about one thing, which was that he knew which house.

He had thought he did. He had been told every day of his life. But he sat in the strong-room of his father's warehouse with his father's contract under his hand and he found, when he looked, that the house he wanted to stand was not on the Capua road, and was not above the macellum, and was not anywhere he could have put his finger on a map; it was a stair with light coming down it, and two people on the steps, and a quiet that was not his father's quiet or

Thallus's or anyone's; and he did not have a word for it. He did not look for one, because a boy who has been raised to count knows better than anyone that there are things which, once you have put a figure to them, can be taken out of a box and put in a fire.

5

The Entry

Rome, autumn 99

The summons came as a tally of days, which was how a patron asked a freedwoman for anything: not *will you* but *you owe*.

Thallus brought it down himself in September, on the first of his autumn visits, and read it out in the common room with his hands folded on the paper, as though it were a thing that had happened to all three of them and not a thing he had written. The house of Laecanius in Rome required its people for the emperor's entry. The master would be receiving. There would be a dinner for sixty on the day and the house would be open to callers for the ten days after and the Roman household could not do it alone, and so the freedmen of the coast who owed days were called upon to give them, as was their duty and, the steward added without any change in his voice, their privilege. Hilara owed the house twelve days a year under the terms of her manumission, and had, by the steward's count, given none of them these four years, since the master had not asked. The master was asking. She would come up by the Kalends of October with whatever help she had and would be lodged in the house and fed and would work in the kitchens and at table and would be sent home when the callers stopped. Her own house she could shut, or leave with the girl upstairs, as she pleased; the lease would be excused for the month.

"Whatever help I have," her mother said.

"The girl. She's eleven. She can carry a dish." Thallus folded the paper. "I'd not have thought to name her, but the master's cousin is coming for the entry, a widow, the consular Tertullus's widow, and she keeps a great many women and has opinions about who serves her, and the Roman steward is short. A girl who can count and doesn't

gape will be useful. I said we had one."

"You said."

"I said. To the master's son, who asked." He stood. "You'll travel with the oil. Hermes is sending a cart up on the twenty-fifth for the entry, with his boy on it to see the city; you'll go with that. It's a kindness of his. He's not doing it for you."

"I know who he's doing it for," her mother said. "Tell him we'll be at the warehouse at dawn."

When the steward had gone she sat for a long time at the table with the lamp. Then she said, not to Fausta, who was at the hearth, but to the room: "Twelve days a year for four years is forty-eight. He's forgiven thirty-six and called it a month. He wants me to notice that." And then, to her daughter: "Get the good gown out, the red, and see if it can be let out again. And your blue. We're going to Rome."

Fausta had the gown out already. She had got it out while the steward was reading. She found that she was not surprised by any of it, and that she had, in some part of herself, been waiting since the day on the mole for Rome to come down the hill and ask for her, and that it had, and that it had asked by the usual messenger, in the usual coin, and had called it a kindness.

◆

The cart left the emporium in the dark, two mules and the oil-man's son driving, with twenty jars of the good Italian measure under a sail in the bed and three passengers on the board behind the driver: the boy, with a tablet in his belt and his father's letters in a satchel on his knees, and the freedwoman, and the girl. Hermes was going up separately, by the fast post, with Bassus's letters and his own; a man of the Augustales did not ride on an oil-cart. The boy, it appeared, did, when the alternative was that he should go up in his father's company and be seen arriving in it.

"He wants me to come in with the trade," Celer said, when the town was behind them and the Capua road had opened out white

between its tombs. “So that when Rufus sees me I’m already there. He says a man who’s seen arriving is a man people remember arriving.”

“And your tomb?”

“We passed it. You didn’t look.”

“I looked. The mason’s cut the ship’s eye.” She had looked; she had seen the bronze eye catch the first light, high on the stone, where the *Isis* was. “It’s got a pupil now. It didn’t in the spring.”

He was quiet. Then he said, “He had it done in August. After he forbade me the house. I don’t know why.”

“Because he’d won,” said her mother from the end of the board, with her eyes closed, “and a man who’s won likes to see something finished.” And she did not open her eyes, and the cart went on, and the mules’ bells and the jars talked to each other under the sail. The sun came up over the hills on the right hand and showed them Campania going by, the vines in their long rows and the villas and the cypresses and, once, far off, the sea again, and then no more sea.

It took four days. She would remember it as one long day with sleep in it. She would remember the Appian Way, when they came to it, which was not a road but a thing laid across the world — stone, flat and black and wide enough for two carts, going straight where the land went crooked, with the tombs on both sides thickening as the city came nearer until they were a street of the dead ten miles long, with the living going between them in a river of carts and litters and mules and soldiers and men on foot, all north, all for the entry. She would remember the aqueducts coming in from the hills on their arches like something walking. She would remember the smell, which began a day out and which she could not name until the boy said *that’s the city* and she understood that a city could be smelled, like a man, before it was seen. And she would remember the moment on the fourth morning when the road came over a rise and there it was, all of it, filling the whole of the plain in front of them from one edge of the sky to the other, red and white and brown and gold under a haze of its

own smoke, with the hills standing up out of it crowned with temples, and she had not known, she had not been able to know, that anything made by hands could be that size.

She did not say anything. The boy did not either. Her mother, who had seen it before, said, "Breathe. You've stopped."

◆

The house of Laecanius in Rome stood on the Caelian, on the slope above the old temple of the deified Claudius, in a street of houses like it: high walls and a door and nothing else to show, so that you could walk the length of the street and not know you had passed the homes of six men who had been consul. Inside, it went back and back. She had thought the villa at Baiae was large. The villa at Baiae was a holiday; this was the thing itself, the machine the villa paid for, and it had a hundred and forty slaves in it when the family was in residence and eleven freedmen who came in daily and a steward who was not Thallus and had never heard of her.

His name was Eutyches and he had been Bassus's father's and he ran the house the way the sea ran the harbour at Puteoli, by being everywhere and never seen. He looked at Hilara and the girl in the slaves' court behind the kitchens on the morning they arrived, with the cart being unloaded in the lane and the oil-man's son shouting at a doorkeeper, and he said, "The Puteoli woman. Twelve days. Kitchens for the dinner, table for the callers. And this is the one Thallus wrote about for the lady Cornelia." He looked at Fausta for perhaps the time it took to blink. "Too young. She'll do for the water. Give her a clean tunic and put her with Phaedrus's lot; he's bringing the lady's people over this afternoon and he can have the sorting of her. You —" to Hilara — "the kitchens know you're coming. Don't argue with the cook; he's Gaul and he bites."

That was the whole of her reception. The city had been in sight for two hours and she had not yet seen a single thing in it but walls and a lane and a slaves' court, and already she had been looked at,

priced, and put in a column. She found it steadying. It was the harbour again; it was the Dolphin with a hundred and forty rooms. The great were the great, but their stewards were stewards, and a steward was a man who had read one book very carefully, and she knew the book.

Celer she lost at the door. He had been taken off by a slave of Rufus's before the cart was unloaded, and had looked back once from the end of the lane with his satchel on his shoulder and his face doing the thing it did when it had been told to be a face, and then had gone; and she did not see him again for nine days, and when she did they were both in other people's clothes.

◆

Phaedrus came over in the afternoon with the lady Cornelia's people, and the lady Cornelia's people were a thing to see.

There were thirty of them. Fausta had not known that a woman went visiting with thirty people. There were the litter-bearers, eight Cappadocians in matched grey; there were two women whose only work, she gathered, was the lady's hair, and a third whose only work was the lady's face, and a fourth who carried the lady's cosmetics in a case that had its own slave; there were readers, two, a Greek and a Latin; there were the secretary and his boy; there was a dwarf, whom nobody explained; and there were a dozen girls of between twelve and twenty who did, as far as Fausta could ever afterwards make out, nothing at all except be present in sufficient numbers that the lady was never in a room with fewer than four of them, and who had the look, all of them, of expensive things kept in a drawer. Phaedrus was their steward, a tall Alexandrian with a shaved head and a Greek so pure it sounded like water, and he looked at the Puteoli girl in her clean borrowed tunic and said, "Can you pour without touching the rim?" and she said, "Yes," and he gave her a jug and watched her, and said, "Yes. You can. Who taught you?"

"Lodgers."

"Lodgers." He considered this. "Well, it doesn't show. You'll stand behind the lady at the dinner and keep her water full and say nothing whatever and look at no one. If she speaks to you, you say *domina* and whatever's true. She doesn't like a lie and she can hear one through a wall. Can you read?"

"Yes."

"Don't let her find it out. Not yet. She collects girls who can read the way some women collect emeralds and she's got eleven and they hate each other." He took the jug back. "I'm telling you that as a kindness. Nobody told me."

◆

She saw the emperor from a roof.

That was the whole household's arrangement; the family went down to the Forum in the dawn to stand with the senate. The house's people, those who were not needed to prepare the dinner, went up onto the roofs of the Caelian, where the whole slope was black with the slaves and freedmen and clients of forty great houses, and looked down over the valley and the Colosseum's great curve and the Sacred Way beyond it, and waited.

They waited from dawn until the fourth hour. She stood at a parapet between two of the lady Cornelia's girls, who talked across her about a man, and did not look at the city, because if she looked at the city she would gape, and Phaedrus had said. So she looked at the roof-tiles, and at the backs of her own hands, and at the girls' hands, which had never carried a water-jar up a stair and showed it, and she counted the hours by the shadow of the parapet, and she listened. The city made a sound she had not heard before. It was not the roar of the fleet-day; that had been forty thousand people being glad. This was ten times that, or twenty, a sound so large it had stopped being a sound and become a condition, like heat; and it was waiting. It moved, so that you could hear where the emperor was by where the roar was thickest, far off beyond the Caelian to the south where the

Appian came in through the gate, and then nearer, and nearer, along the valley, until it was below them and the girls stopped talking.

He was on foot.

That was the thing everyone said afterwards, and it was the thing she saw: a man walking. He came along the Sacred Way through the middle of the roar with the senate behind him in their white and the Guard behind that. He was not carried and he was not on a horse, he was walking, in a plain toga, with his head bare, a tall man with a soldier's shoulders and grey hair cut short, and as he came he stopped — she saw him stop — and a man came out of the crowd at the roadside, an old man in a senator's stripe, and the emperor took him by the arms and kissed him, and walked on, and stopped again, and did it again. The roar changed when he did it. It went up a note. She did not know what the note meant until one of the girls said, with something in her voice that was almost awe and almost contempt, "He's *embracing* them. He's letting them touch him. Domitian would have had you flogged for being on the same side of the street."

Fausta watched the man walk. She thought: he is doing it on purpose. She thought: he has a hundred thousand people on the roofs and he is making sure they see him stop. She thought, with the part of her that had learned in a yard and a tutor's room and a warehouse aisle to read the thing behind the thing: that is the Baetican jar. He is giving them less than an emperor and calling it a favour, and they are cheering him for the size of the jar.

And then she stopped thinking that, because behind him, a little way behind, with two women beside her and no litter and no canopy and no thirty people, there was another figure walking, and it was a woman. She was walking as the emperor was walking, on foot, in a plain dress, with her hair done simply and her head covered, and she was not stopping to embrace anyone and nobody was roaring for her; she was simply walking into Rome behind her husband like a woman going to market.

"That's the empress," the girl on Fausta's left said. "Plotina. She's from Nemausus. Nobody knows anything about her." And then, lower, because she had been told something and could not keep it: "She said a thing on the palace steps. My cousin's in the Palatine household. She stopped on the steps and turned round to the crowd and said, *I enter here the kind of woman I should wish to be when I leave.* In front of everyone. The senate didn't know where to look."

Fausta watched the woman walk. She was too far off to see a face. But she could see how the woman held herself, which was very straight, and very still in the middle of all that noise. She could see that the woman did not look up at the roofs, not once, though the roofs were black with people looking down; she looked at the road, and at the man in front of her, and at nothing else, as though the city were a thing that had been arranged for her to walk through and she had agreed to walk through it and that was the extent of the bargain.

They didn't look at the boat, Fausta thought. But it was not that. It was not the great not seeing. It was something else, that she did not have yet and would spend a long time acquiring: a woman who could see the boat perfectly well, and all the roofs, and every face on them, and had decided that the only answer to being looked at by a hundred thousand people was to give them a straight back and a covered head and a sentence they would be repeating in the slaves' courts by nightfall. It was not modesty. The girl beside her thought it was modesty. Fausta, who had grown up in a house where women arranged themselves to be seen for a living, knew the difference between modesty and work.

She watched the woman until the procession went round the end of the Palatine and out of sight. Then she looked down at her own hands on the parapet, which were a water-carrier's hands, and thought: *that one is the one to watch. Not the man. The man's a soldier and he's been told what the city wants and he's giving it. She's the one who told him.*

She did not know that this was true. She was eleven. But she put it where she kept things, in the front, where she could reach it.

◆

The dinner was for sixty and went until the third watch and she stood behind the lady Cornelia's couch for the whole of it with a silver jug and did not touch the rim.

She did not, that first night, see the lady's face; she saw the back of her head, which was done in a style four years out of fashion and kept there, Phaedrus had said, on purpose, because the lady had been a beauty under Domitian and did not propose to be anything else under anyone. She saw the shoulders, which were broad for a woman's and held square. She saw the hand that came back, without turning, for the cup, and the cup go to the lips she could not see and come back, and she filled it, and the hand came back again, and she understood after the fourth time that the lady was not drinking but using the cup as a thing to do with her hand while she listened, and that she was listening to everything. That the men on the couches round her — Bassus's guests, senators and their sons, a couple of the new Spanish faces that had come in with the emperor, Rufus, Hermes very far down the table in a place that was a great honour for a freedman and a precise insult to the freedman's hopes — were talking across her and past her and through her as men talked across a woman of fifty-five, and that she was letting them.

Bassus talked about liberty. The Spaniards talked about the Danube. Rufus talked about the Danube to the Spaniards and about liberty to his father, and did both well, and Fausta, filling the cup, thought that he was a man who had learned to pour without touching the rim and was pleased with himself for it. Hermes said nothing at all for two hours and then, when one of the Spaniards asked the table whether anyone knew what the Alexandrian fleet had carried this year, said the figure, to the modius, and the Spaniard looked down the table to see who had spoken, and looked away again, and Fausta saw

the back of Hermes's neck do what it had done in the atrium at Baiae when the hand had rested on his shoulder.

She saw Celer once. He was with Rufus's people, standing behind Rufus's couch with a tablet, which was not a servant's work and not a guest's and was therefore exactly what his father had wanted: a boy who was visibly *something*, in a room where that was the whole point. He had a clean tunic and his hair had been cut and he looked, across sixty couches and the lamps and the smoke, like a stranger she had known once. He did not see her. He was watching Rufus's hands, the way she was watching the lady's, and she thought that between them they had the two most important people at that end of the table under observation and that nobody in the room knew it, and the thought gave her a small cold pleasure that she recognised, without liking it, as the first thing in Rome that was hers.

At the third watch the lady Cornelia set down her cup and said, without turning her head, in a voice that was low and dry and carried exactly as far as she intended it to, "Girl. Your hand's steady. Whose are you?"

"Domina. The house's. From Puteoli. My mother's a freedwoman of the master's."

"Hilara's." The lady said the name as though it were a place she had once been to. "Yes. I'd heard there was a daughter." Still she did not turn. "You've been watching the Spaniard on the third couch for an hour. Why?"

Fausta had not known it showed. She said, because Phaedrus had said *whatever's true*: "Because he asked about the fleet and didn't listen to the answer, domina. He was looking at who'd given it."

A silence. Then the lady's shoulders moved, very slightly, in a way that Fausta would learn, over years, to recognise as the nearest she came to laughing.

"Yes," said Cornelia Tertulla. "He was. That's Licinius Sura. He's the one who made this emperor, and he counts everything, and he's

just counted your friend's father." The cup came back. "Fill that. And tomorrow when the callers come you'll stand behind me again, and you'll say nothing, as you have tonight, and afterwards you'll tell me who looked at whom. I shall know if you make it up." A pause. "Phaedrus said you couldn't read. Phaedrus lies to me about one thing a year to see if I notice. I always notice. Can you?"

"Yes, domina."

"Good. Don't do it in front of the others." The hand went away. "Go and find your mother and tell her the Gaul says the fish was adequate, which from him is love, and that she's to stay the month and not the twelve days, and that I've told Bassus so. He'll agree. He agrees with me about everything that doesn't cost him anything, and you don't cost him anything, you're already his."

◆

Her mother was in the slaves' court behind the kitchens with her sleeves rolled and her hair coming down, sitting on an upturned basket in the dark with a cup of the Gaul's wine, and she listened to all of it without speaking, and at the end she said, "The month."

"Yes."

"She asked for you by name. The widow."

"She asked whose I was. I said yours."

"And she said the month." Hilara drank. In the dark her face was a shape and nothing else. "Listen to me. A woman like that doesn't ask a water-girl whose she is. She asks the steward, and the steward tells her, and she's known for a week. She asked *you* so you'd hear yourself say it. She wanted to know what you'd say. You said *the house's*. That was right. If you'd said *my mother's* she'd have put you in the kitchen with me and that would have been the end of it. You said the house's, and now you're the house's, and she's the house's cousin, and that's a door." She set the cup down. "I don't know yet if it's a door I want you through. I don't know what's on the other side. But I know what's on this side, and it's the Dolphin and Thallus on the Ides, and

I'll tell you now, since we're in the dark and in Rome and nobody's listening: I didn't bring you up for the Dolphin. I brought you up to read a paper. If reading a paper takes you into a widow's house on the Caelian, then that's where it takes you, and I'll go back to the coast with my twelve days paid and my lease excused and say my daughter's in Rome, and see what Thallus makes of that."

"Mama —"

"Don't. Not here." Her mother stood up and shook out her gown. "Go to bed. You've callers at the second hour and the widow wants to know who looked at whom, and you'd better have it right, because she's a woman who's spent fifty years being looked at and she can tell a lie through a wall. That's not Phaedrus's phrase, by the way. It's Thallus's. He said it about her in the spring. He's been in this house too; everyone's been in this house. It's a small world, the house of Laecanius. It only looks big from the lane."

Fausta went to bed. The bed was a pallet in a room with eleven of the lady Cornelia's girls, who had been given the slaves' dormitory over the bakehouse and resented it, and who looked at the Puteoli girl coming in late with the lady's word in her and did the arithmetic, and some of them said something and most of them did not. She lay down among them. She could not sleep. She lay and listened to the house, which was a thing she did, and found that she could not; it was too large; it did not come to her as an instrument came but as the city had come over the rise, all at once, without edges, a hundred and forty people breathing and the Gaul swearing in the kitchen and a cart in the lane and the roar, still, very faint, from somewhere down in the valley where the city had not yet stopped being glad.

So she thought instead about the woman walking. The straight back, the covered head, the eyes on the road. *The kind of woman I should wish to be when I leave.* She thought about the lady's hand coming back for the cup, and about Sura's eyes going down the table to find who had said the figure, and about Celer behind Rufus's

couch watching Rufus's hands, and about her mother in the dark saying *that's a door*. And she thought, before she slept, the first thought she ever had in Rome that was neither fear nor wonder nor arithmetic, and it was this: that everyone in this city was watching someone, all the time, and that the whole of the roar she could hear from the valley was only the sound of a million people trying to work out who was watching them.

It was, she would come to think, not a bad first thought. It was wrong in only one particular, and she would find out the particular from the lady Cornelia, in due course, and at a price.

◆

The callers came for ten days, from the second hour until noon, and she stood behind the lady's chair in Bassus's atrium with the jug and watched them, and every noon in the small room off the peristyle that Phaedrus had made the lady's own, she said who had looked at whom.

She was wrong at first. Not in the seeing; in the telling. She said, the first noon, that the senator with the limp had watched the door the whole hour, and the lady said, "Yes, and why," and she did not know why, and the lady said, "Because his wife's brother was due and didn't come, and he's lent the brother money, and the brother's gone over to Sura's people and won't be seen in this house again. You saw a man watching a door. I need to know what the door is. Find out. Phaedrus knows everything and lies about one thing a year; ask him, and work out which thing." So she asked Phaedrus, and worked it out, and the second noon she said who had looked at whom and why, and was right four times in six, and the lady said nothing, which Phaedrus told her afterwards was the lady's highest praise and that he had had it twice in nine years.

By the fifth day she had the shape of it. The atrium at the second hour was the harbour at the first: everyone who came in had a cargo and a port and a price, and the whole of the business was to read the manifest off the face before the man had opened his mouth. The

Spaniards came, and were given the front. The old senators came, Bassus's friends, Nerva's friends, men who had kept their doors shut on the night of the Guard, and were given the middle, and knew it, and smiled. The freedmen came last and stood at the back where her mother had stood at Baiae, and Hermes among them, every morning, in his toga, saying nothing, being seen. And through it all the lady sat at her cousin's left hand with her cup and her four-years-old hair and let the room talk across her, and once a day, perhaps, said a sentence, and the room stopped.

On the ninth day Celer came into the small room with a tablet for the lady from Rufus, and found her there.

He stopped in the door. She was standing at the lady's shoulder with the jug, as she stood; he was in a tunic of good undyed wool that was not his, with a clerk's case at his belt that was not his either, and his hair cut to the Roman length, and they looked at each other across the lady Cornelia's head for the length of a breath, two children from the same street in other people's clothes, and neither of them moved a muscle of the face, because they had both, in nine days, learned where they were.

"Rufus's boy," the lady said, without turning. "Give it to the girl. She'll read it to me; I've a headache and your master's hand is a crime against the alphabet."

He gave it to her. Their fingers did not touch; he saw to that, or she did. She read it. It was nothing — a note about the seating for the tenth day, who was to be moved up and who was to be allowed to notice. She read it in the voice Phaedrus had taught her, which was no voice, and the lady listened with her eyes shut, and when it was done said, "Tell him yes to the first and no to the second and that I don't care about the third. And boy —" Celer, at the door, stopped. "Your father stood at the back of my cousin's atrium for nine mornings saying nothing, and on the sixth morning Sura's secretary asked Eutyches his name. That's what he came for. He has it. Tell him he

can go home."

Celer said, "Yes, domina," and went, and did not look at Fausta, and she did not look at him, and the lady Cornelia opened her eyes and looked at neither of them but at the wall opposite, where there was a painting of a garden, and said after a moment in the dry low voice:

"You grew up with that one."

"Yes, domina."

"He didn't look at you. You didn't look at him. That was well done, both of you, and it was a mistake, and I'll tell you why, once, because nobody told me. Two people who don't look at each other in a room are the only two people in it that everyone else can see." She reached for the cup. "Next time, look. Look the way you look at the Spaniards. It costs nothing and it's invisible. The thing that shows is the effort." She drank. "Your mother goes home on the Kalends. You'll go with her. I'm not ready for you and you're not ready for me, and I've eleven girls who can read already and they'd have you in the Tiber by the Saturnalia. But I'll write to Bassus. In a year. Two. When you've bled and can be put in a room without a man thinking about it, or at any rate not thinking first." She set the cup down. "Don't thank me. I'm not doing it for you either. Nobody in this city does anything for anyone; it's the one thing about it that's restful. Go and tell the Gaul I'll have the eggs."

She went and told the Gaul. And in the lane behind the kitchens, where the oil-cart had stood nine days before and stood again now, empty, waiting for the Kalends, she found Celer sitting on the tail of it with the clerk's case on his knees, looking at nothing, and she sat down beside him without asking, and they looked at nothing together for a while.

"She said to look," Fausta said. "Next time."

"I heard. The door's thin." He turned the case over in his hands. "My father's got his name on Sura's list. He's going home tomorrow.

He's — I've never seen him like it. He walked into Rufus's rooms and didn't say anything and sat down. He sat *down*. In Rufus's rooms." A pause. "He's leaving me. For the winter. With Rufus. To see the city, he says. To be seen in it."

She had known. Phaedrus knew everything. She said, "And you?"

"I don't know what I am yet. Something between a clerk and a nephew. Rufus hasn't decided and I don't think he will till the war." He looked at her, then, properly, for the first time in nine days, the way the lady had said: the way you looked at a Spaniard. "You're going home."

"On the Kalends. She's not ready for me." She heard how it sounded and let it stand. "A year. Two."

"Then we'll both be here."

"We're both here now."

"No," he said. "We're not. You're the house's and I'm Rufus's and we're sitting on an oil-cart in a lane. That's not here. That's where people wait for news of it." And he said it without bitterness, as a fact, in the voice that she had heard him use about the Baetican jars and the harbour at Ostia, and she understood that he was telling her, as exactly as he could, where he had got to, so that she would know where to look for him; and she thought that it was, in its way, the most honest thing anyone had said to her in Rome, and that it was a thing a man said who had already begun to count the lane as somewhere he would not be coming back to.

"Look at me," she said. "The way she said."

He looked. It cost nothing. It was invisible. The effort, she thought, was the thing that showed, and neither of them let it; and a slave came out of the kitchen door with a basket of eggs for the Gaul and walked between them and saw two children on a cart and nothing else, and went in.

6

The Betrothal

Rome and Baiae, winter 99 to summer 100

Rufus's rooms were on the second floor of his father's house, over the garden, and from the window of the one he gave Celer you could see the whole of the Palatine across the valley, and Celer spent the winter learning that this was not an accident.

Nothing in Rome was an accident. That was the first thing the city taught him, and it taught it the way his father taught, by letting him find out. The rooms were on the garden side because the garden side was quiet and the street side was for clients and the family did not sleep where it received. The window faced the Palatine because the house had been built by a man who wanted to see the emperor's lamps from his bed, and had put the bed accordingly, and every man who had slept in it since had woken to the same view and had taken it, as Celer took it that first grey morning in December with the rain coming down on the valley and the palace standing up out of the murk like a ship, as a kind of instruction.

Rufus was not often in them. Rufus was out. That was what a man of twenty-nine did in Rome in the winter of a new reign when he wanted to be something: he went out at dawn to stand in other men's atria, and he came back at noon to let other men stand in his. He went out again in the afternoon to the baths, where the real business was done, and dined out, and came home at the third watch smelling of Syrian scent and somebody's wine and slept four hours and did it again. He took Celer to all of it. Not as a companion; as a thing that was carried. The boy went behind him with the tablet and the case and stood against walls and was not spoken to, and Rufus, who had said on the terrace at Baiae that a man on a staff needed people who

could keep their mouths shut, found out that winter that he had been given one who could also keep his eyes open, and did not, Celer thought, entirely like it.

"You were watching Sura's man," Rufus said once, in the litter, coming back from a morning at the house of a consular on the Quirinal where the whole of the senate's younger half had stood in the rain for two hours to be nodded at. "The secretary. The Greek with the ring."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because he was the only man in the room who wasn't watching Sura."

Rufus was silent for the length of a street. Then he said, "Nicias said you'd no Greek style. He didn't say you'd that." And after another street: "Don't do it where Sura's man can see you doing it. He notices who notices. It's his whole use."

So Celer learned not to be seen noticing, which was a different skill from not noticing and a harder one, and he practised it on the city as his father had made him practise the Baetican ratios, until it came out the same three times. He learned the hills and what lived on each. He learned that the Caelian was old money that had kept its doors shut and the Quirinal was old money that had opened them a crack and the Esquiline was new money and the Aventine was nobody's and the Palatine was the thing all the others were facing. He learned how a letter moved: from the hand that wrote it to the secretary who sealed it to the slave who carried it to the doorkeeper who took it to the steward who read it, because every steward read everything, to the master who was told what was in it by the steward and then read it himself to see what the steward had left out. He learned that Rufus owed, by his own count made in a strong-room that was not his with a lamp that was, three hundred and twelve thousand sesterces to nine men, and that two of the nine were Hermes, under different names.

That Rufus knew this, and that Rufus did not know that Celer knew it, and that this was the first thing he had ever held in his hand that could hurt a senator's son, and that he would have given a good deal not to be holding it.

He did not write to the girl. He had said he would and he did not, and he knew every day that he did not, and he told himself that it was because the post went by the house's slaves and the house's slaves were Eutyches's and Eutyches read everything; and this was true; and it was not the reason. The reason was that he did not know what he would say. *I am being carried about Rome behind a man who owes my father money and I am learning to see without being seen and this morning I stood against a wall for two hours and was not spoken to and it was the most important thing that has ever happened to me* — he could not write that. He could not write anything that was true without writing that, and he had learned, from Nicias, that a letter which was not true was a tally-board, and from his father, that the people who could read your papers were the people who could hurt you; and so he wrote nothing. The winter went by, and the rain came down on the Palatine, and he woke every morning to the instruction in the window and took it.

◆

The family went down to the coast on the Ides of April, and the villa was opened, and the slipped tile was still there; and in June, when the roses were out on the second terrace and the senators' sons had come down for the season and the Dolphin, he supposed, was full, Laecania Paulla was betrothed.

She was seventeen. He had seen her perhaps four times in his life, at the back of rooms: a tall girl with her father's height and her brother's shoulders and a face that had been told from birth it was the family's and had, in consequence, never been asked what it was itself. She was being given to a Spaniard. That was how everyone said it, on the terrace and in the kitchens and in the lower town — *the Spaniard*

— though the man had a name, which was Fabius Catullinus, and a family, which was from Baetica and had been in the senate for a generation and was, by every measure that could be made in a strong-room, poorer than the Laecanii and younger and of less account; and had one thing, which was that Fabius Catullinus's mother's brother had served under the emperor on the Rhine and dined with him in the palace twice a month. That in the summer of the second year of Trajan this was worth more than a consul under Nero and eight hundred thousand sesterces of debt.

"It's a good match," Rufus said, on the terrace, the morning the Spaniard's people arrived, with the same flatness he used for sums. "She'll be unhappy and he'll be rich and in ten years my nephew will have an uncle who was consul under Trajan and a grandfather who was consul under Nero and nobody will remember which of them paid for which. That's what a sister's for." He looked at Celer. "Write that down. No. Don't. I said it; that's enough."

The betrothal was done in the atrium with the fish and the masks, before witnesses, with the Spaniard's uncle standing in for the emperor's goodwill the way the masks stood in for the dead, and the girl between her father and her future husband with her eyes on the floor, and the whole of the family's people — the Roman household, the coast freedmen, the Augustales, Hermes at the front in his toga and the Dolphin's woman at the back in her red — ranged round the walls to see it done. The words were said. The ring was put on. The Spaniard kissed the girl on the forehead and she did not move, and Bassus raised his hand in the blessing-or-beckoning and said something about the gods and the house and the future that Celer, standing behind Rufus with the tablet, did not write down because he had stopped listening to Bassus in the winter and had not found a reason to start.

He was listening to Thallus. Thallus was at Bassus's shoulder, where he always was, with his hands folded, and Thallus was not

watching the girl or the Spaniard or the masks; Thallus was watching the back of the room, the way a steward did at a sale, counting the house. And Celer, following the steward's eyes because he had learned that winter that the man who was not looking at the thing was the man to look at, saw them go across the freedmen and stop, as the master's had stopped in the atrium two Aprils ago, at the red gown; and then move, a hand's breadth to the left, and stop again.

The girl was there. He had known she would be. He had not looked for her, because he had learned not to be seen looking, and because he had not written, and because it had been eight months. She was standing at her mother's shoulder in the blue that had been let down again and would not let down any further, and she had grown, and her hair was up, and she was looking — not at the ring, not at the girl, not at Bassus. She was looking at Thallus looking at her. Steadily, the way the lady Cornelia had told her, the way you looked at a Spaniard. And Thallus, who noticed who noticed, had noticed, and his face did nothing at all, and his eyes moved on; and Celer, with the tablet against his chest and his heart going in a way he did not care for, thought: *she has got better at it than I have. She has been practising on the stairs.*

◆

He found her on the stair between the second terrace and the third, in the hour after the ceremony when the house's people were being fed in the garden and the family and the Spaniards were being fed inside and the two feasts had, between them, emptied the staircases; she was sitting on the fourth step with a dish of something she had been sent for and had not taken back, looking out at the bay. She did not turn when he came down, though he had made no noise.

"You've grown," she said.

"So have you."

"I'm twelve. I'm supposed to." She moved the dish so he could sit. He sat, two steps above, so that they were not side by side and so that

anyone coming up from the garden would see a clerk resting and a kitchen-girl resting and nothing else; it was the kind of arithmetic they both did now without noticing. “You didn’t write.”

“No.”

“I know why. Eutyches reads everything. The post goes through his hands.” She said it evenly, offering it to him, and he understood that she was giving him the reason the way the lady Cornelia had given her the month: as a door he could go through if he chose.

He did not go through it. He found that he could not, with her; he had spent a winter learning to be a face and the thing would not work on her, had never worked on her, and he was tired, suddenly, in a way that had nothing to do with the hour. “That’s not why.”

“No,” she agreed. “It’s not.” She looked at the bay. “You didn’t know what to say.”

“I didn’t know what was true.”

She was quiet. Then she said, “That’s better. That’s a reason.” And she picked a fig off the dish and ate it, and gave him one, and they sat on the stair in the warm shade with the slipped tile above them and the roses below and the two feasts going on out of sight, and he told her — because the thing would not work on her and he had stopped trying — about the window that faced the Palatine, and the atria, and standing against walls, and Sura’s man with the ring, and the litter and *don’t do it where he can see you*, and she listened as she had always listened, with the whole of her face, and asked once, “Did Rufus mind?” and he said, “Yes,” and she nodded as though that were the point.

He did not tell her about the three hundred and twelve thousand. He noticed himself not telling her, and noticed that it was the first thing he had ever kept from her on purpose, and that it was not his to tell, and that this was true, and that it was not, entirely, the reason.

“Thallus looked at you,” he said instead. “In the atrium. You looked back.”

"I always look back now. The widow said." She finished the fig. "He comes to the Dolphin twice a month. He didn't use to. He says it's the lease, since Rome; he says the master's cousin has taken an interest in the house and he needs to know what the house is worth. He sits in the common room and asks me sums. My mother goes up and comes down and doesn't sleep after, and in the mornings she's slow, and she was never slow." She said all of this to the bay, flatly, as a manifest. "She's not well, I think. She says she is. Antiope says it's nothing, it's the summer, it's what happens to women who were pretty, and Antiope's not been down from the villa since the Ides so I don't know what Antiope thinks any more." A pause. "I'm not asking you for anything. I'm telling you what's in the house, because you asked once what I wanted and I said the house, and you should know what it's made of."

He sat with it. The bay went on being blue. Below them somebody in the garden laughed, a high senator's-son laugh, and was shushed.

"My father's going to buy me a place tonight," he said. "In the room off the peristyle. Secretary, with the name, when the war comes. The equestrian roll before I'm twenty-five. Against money he's been holding since January for the purpose. He's going to let Bassus think it's a dowry matter." He heard himself say it and did not know why he had, except that she had given him the house and he had nothing else of equal weight. "I'll be in the room. He wants me to see it done."

She turned, then, and looked at him; the proper look, the one that cost nothing.

"Then you'll have been sold in front of witnesses," she said, "and I'll have been priced in a common room by a steward, and we'll both know our number." Her mouth did the thing it did that was not quite a smile. "That's more than most people get. Most people have to guess." She stood, and took up the dish. "Don't look for me after. I'll have gone down with my mother; she doesn't walk the coast road in

the dark any more, we go at dusk. And Celer —" He looked up. "Write or don't. But don't do the thing where you decide what's true first. You'll be at it till you're forty." And she went down the stair toward the garden with the dish, and did not look back, and he sat on the fourth step with the taste of fig in his mouth and found that he was shaking, very slightly, in the hands, and could not have said whether it was the stair or the room he was about to go into or the other thing, the thing she had said about the house being made of a woman who had stopped sleeping, which he had not asked to be given and now held, and could not put down, and would be carrying, he understood, into the room off the peristyle, and north, and for a long time after.

◆

The business was done afterwards in the room off the peristyle, with the lamp, and he was in the room, because his father wanted him to see it done.

There were four of them. Bassus on the couch, with wine. Rufus standing at the window with his back to it. Hermes on a chair, which was a thing a freedman was not given in that room and had been given, and sat on very straight. And Thallus by the door, with the box.

"The Spaniard's people want the dowry in coin," Bassus said. He said it to the wine. "Not land. Coin. Six hundred thousand, by the Kalends of August, and the rest in Falernian and furniture, which God knows we have. Six hundred thousand in coin." He drank. "I have told them they shall have it."

Nobody said anything. The lamp hissed.

"Hermes," said Rufus, from the window.

"Patron." Celer's father did not move on his chair. "The house of Laecanius has my name on its lintel and my ships at its service and such coin as a shipowner has, which is less than people think, because a shipowner's coin is on the water nine months of the year. I can find two hundred thousand by the Kalends. Not six. Not without selling a

hull, and the man who sells a hull in June to pay in August is a man who has no hull in September when the fleet goes home."

"Two hundred," said Bassus, to the wine.

"And a further two in the spring, when the *Isis* is paid for the return carry. Against the Baian oil-rights, which are nothing to the house and something to me." His father said it as if he had just thought of it. He had been thinking of it, Celer knew, since December, when the first rumour of the Spaniard had come down the coast; he had had the figure in the strong-room under the lamp in January, and the oil-rights beside it, and had said to his son, *when he asks, and he'll ask, I'll give him a third and ask for a thing he doesn't value, and he'll think he's won.* "The remaining two hundred the patron will find among his other friends. He has many."

"Fewer than in Nerva's time," Rufus said drily.

"Then the patron has fewer friends and one of them is sitting in his study offering him four hundred thousand sesterces against a hillside of olives." Hermes looked at Bassus for the first time. "I don't ask for the olives, patron. I ask for what I asked for in the spring of the Spaniard's first year, on the terrace, when you were kind enough to put your hand on my shoulder before the house. The boy."

Bassus looked up.

"He's on Rufus's staff," he said. "He's been in Rome all winter. What more —"

"He's carried a tablet behind Rufus all winter, patron, with respect, and been very useful, and Rufus will say so. That's not a place. That's a favour, and a favour can be withdrawn." His father's voice did not change. "I want the place. I want it written. When the war comes — and it comes, the whole coast knows it comes, there were Dacian envoys at the emperor's camp last autumn and nothing came of it but a silence that's cost somebody already — when it comes, my son goes north on your son's staff as his *secretary*, with the name, and the pay, which I'll remit, and the standing in the camp,

which I can't buy anywhere else. And when it's over and your son is praetor, which he'll be, because a man who's been on the Danube with this emperor will be praetor if he can write his name — when he's praetor, my son is on the roll of the equestrian order before he's twenty-five. With your son's sponsorship. In writing. Witnessed." A pause. "Four hundred thousand, patron. In coin. By the Kalends and the spring. And the olives, which nobody in this house has walked through since your father died."

The lamp hissed. Rufus, at the window, had turned round. Thallus, by the door, had not moved at all, and his face was doing the thing it did, which was nothing, and Celer, watching it, saw the nothing go very slightly tight at the corners, the way a sail did when the wind came on it from a point it had not expected, and understood that the steward had not been told, and that his father had made sure of it.

Bassus looked at the freedman on the chair for a long time.

"You've thought about this," he said at last.

"Every day for thirty years, patron."

"Yes. I suppose you have." The old man set his cup down. He looked, for a moment, very tired, and very large, and not at all like the man who had stood in the square of sun and said *my people*; he looked like a man who had just been shown the bill for a dinner he had thought was a gift. "Rufus."

"Father."

"Is the boy any use?"

Rufus looked at Celer. It was the pricing look from the terrace, two years older and with a winter in it, and it went on for longer than was comfortable, and then it stopped.

"He's the only person in my household who knows what I owe," Rufus said, "to the sestertius. He worked it out in December from the strong-room and he's never once let me see that he knows it. Yes. He's some use." He turned back to the window. "Write it, Thallus.

Secretary, with the name. The roll before twenty-five, with my sponsorship, on my praetorship. Against four hundred thousand and the olives. Witness it yourself and have the Spaniard's uncle put his seal to it tomorrow; he'll do it, he thinks it's a dowry matter. Then nobody in this room can ever say it didn't happen."

Thallus wrote it. He wrote it standing, on the box, in the small quick hand that Celer had seen on a hundred tallies, and he did not look at Hermes while he wrote. He did not look at Celer; he looked at the paper, and when it was done he sanded it and brought it to the couch for Bassus's seal, and to the chair for Hermes's, and to the window for Rufus's, and then, last, with the ink still wet, he held it out to the boy by the wall.

"Read it," he said. "You're the subject of it. You should know what you've been sold for."

Celer read it. It was four lines. It was his life. He read it twice, as he read everything, and gave it back, and said, "Yes," because there was nothing else to say and because his father's eyes were on him and had in them a thing he had never seen there before and would see only twice again in his life. It was not pride, exactly; it was the look of a man watching a hull he has built go down the ways and into the water, and finding that it floats.

◆

That night his father took him down to the lower town and gave him a woman.

It was done, as everything his father did was done, without a scene. They walked down from the villa in the dusk along the coast road with the bay going dark on their right hand, the two of them, no slave, which was itself a signal. His father talked about the Spaniard's uncle and the price of Falernian and the olive-rights, which were worth, he said, about a quarter what the house thought and twice what he had let Bassus believe; and then, where the road came down into the town by the baths and divided, he turned not toward the

house above the macellum but the other way, toward the harbour, and said in the same voice: "There's a thing a man of our name does for his son at thirteen, and I'm doing it tonight, because you're going north inside the year and I'd rather it was done here by someone I've paid than there by someone who hasn't washed."

Celer said nothing. He had known. He had known, in the way one knew things in that house, since the spring, when his father had bought a girl at the Puteoli market from a dealer who did the Baian trade and had not put her in the kitchen, and the stepmother had looked at the loom and said nothing for a week.

"Her name is Chione. She's Bithynian, nineteen, cost me the price of a mule and she's cleaner than most of what's at the villa. She's in the room over the chandler's, which I've taken for the month. She knows what's wanted and she's been told to be kind about it, and if she isn't you'll tell me and I'll know why." His father walked on. "You'll not be ashamed. There's nothing in it to be ashamed of. Every man in this town has done it or had it done, and the ones who say otherwise are lying to a wife. You'll go up, and you'll come down, and tomorrow you'll be the same boy with one thing fewer to think about, and that's all it is. It's a jar. It's the measure. It's what's done."

They had come to the chandler's. There was a stair at the side, outside, going up to a door with a lamp over it. His father stopped at the foot of it.

"I'll be at the warehouse," he said. "Don't hurry. Don't go to the Dolphin after, you'll want to and you'll not; it's the wrong house for tonight and the woman there would know by your face." He put his hand on the back of Celer's neck, the hull-inspecting hand, and took it away. "Go on."

Celer went up.

◆

He came down an hour later, or less, and the lamp over the door had gone out and the street was dark, and he stood at the foot of the stair

for a long time.

He would not, afterwards, be able to say much about the room. He would be able to say that it was small, and clean, as his father had said, and had a bed and a lamp and a window on the harbour. That the girl had been sitting on the bed when he came in, and had stood up, and had been — this he would remember — exactly as tall as he was, so that when she came to him their eyes were level, and hers were brown, and had in them a thing he had seen in Antiope's on the stairs and in the girl's in the boat-house at Baiae and had not, until that moment, been on the receiving end of: a complete, practised, almost gentle attention that was looking at him and seeing a task. She had been kind. His father had paid for kind, and had got it. She had said his name, which she had been told, and had asked him nothing, and had taken his hands and put them where they went, and had been, throughout, the one in the room who knew what was happening; and he had been thirteen, and a body, and then not; and it had been over. She had got up and brought him water and said, in a Greek with the sea in it, *there, now, that's done, you'll find it's easier than counting*, which meant that his father had told her what he was, or she had read it off him, and he had not been able to tell which was worse.

He stood at the foot of the stair. The harbour was in front of him with its lamps. Up the hill the Dolphin would have its shutters barred, and the woman at the hearth, and the girl in the room under the stairs with the curtain drawn, listening to the house; and he found that his father had been right, that he wanted to go there, and that he would not, and that the not going was the first thing he had done since he came down the stair that he had chosen.

He did not feel ashamed. His father had said he would not and he found, examining it, that he did not; it was a jar, it was the measure, it was what was done. What he felt was something else, something that had no name in his father's strong-room and that he turned over now in the dark the way he had turned over the denarius on the harbour

steps. It was this. The girl in the room had cost the price of a mule. She was nineteen. She had been told to be kind and had been kind, as a slave in a warehouse aisle was told to count and counted; and she had done it well, and had said *that's done*, and he had come down the stair with one thing fewer to think about and she was still in the room, with the lamp. The window on the harbour, and would be in it tomorrow, and the day after, for the month his father had taken it, for whoever his father sent up; and he had not asked her anything. Not where in Bithynia. Not how long she had been in Italy. Not whether the window was a kindness or a cruelty, to a girl from the sea. He had been in a room with a person and had treated her, exactly as he had been told to, as a thing that was done, and she had let him, because that was what she was for; and the thought that went through him at the foot of the stair, cold and exact and unwelcome, was that he had just learned, in an hour, over a chandler's, the whole of what his father had spent thirty years trying to teach him about the house of Laecanius, which was what it felt like from the inside to be the master.

And he had liked it. That was the thing he would not say to anyone, then or ever. Not the act, which had been brief and strange and mostly her. The other thing. The being, for an hour, the one in the room who was not a task.

He went up to the house above the macellum by the long way, past the baths, so as not to pass the Dolphin's lane. His stepmother was at the loom with a lamp. She looked up when he came in, and looked at his face, and he saw her read it, all of it, the room and the stair and the thing at the foot of it; and she did not say anything, and she did not look away either, and after a moment she said, in her even farm voice:

"There's bread on the table. He said you'd not have eaten." And then, as he went past her to the table: "Her name's Chione. He'll have told you. He'll not have told you she asked me for a needle and thread in the spring, to mend her own tunic, because the kitchen wouldn't

give her one. I gave it her. You might remember that she sews."

He remembered it. He remembered it for forty years. And he went north inside the twelvemonth with it among the things he carried, and it was, of all of them, the only one that had been given to him by a woman, and the only one he never once took out and counted, because he knew already what it was worth and did not want to know to whom.

7

The Burning Fields

Puteoli, summer and autumn 100

They walked the coast road at dusk because her mother would not walk it in the dark any more, and it was on the coast road, with the bay going from blue to pewter on their left and the villas lighting their lamps behind them one terrace at a time, that Hilara told her about the seven years.

She had not asked. She had decided a long time ago, on the stairs, that she would not ask, that the counters could be laid side by side for as long as it took and she would not be the one to push them into a shape. But her mother had been slow all day, slow in the kitchen court at the villa where the coast women did the washing-up for sixty, slow on the stair with the dishes, slow now on the road, with a hand that went to her side when she thought the girl was not looking; and when they were past the last of the villas and the road ran empty between the hill and the water, she stopped, and sat down on the low wall where the road turned, and said, "Sit. I want to say a thing while I've the breath, and I'd rather say it here than in the house, where the walls have been listening for thirteen years."

Fausta sat.

"You saw him today. In the atrium. With his hand up."

"Yes."

"You've seen him every April of your life and you've never once asked me, and I've watched you not ask, and I've thought, she's her mother's, that one, she'll wait till the paper's in front of her. Well. There isn't a paper for this. There's only me." Hilara looked at the water. "I was bought at four. I told you that. Delos, in a lot, with a woman who said she was my mother and wasn't, and died on the ship.

I was in his father's house in Rome till I was twelve and then in his, because his father died and the household was split and I went with the young master's share. I did hair. I was good at hair. And when I was fifteen he came into the room where the women slept, one night, with a lamp, the way they do, and looked at the row of us, and stopped at me." She said it as she might have said *the Rhodian wants eggs*. "That's all that was. There's no more to it than that. He looked along a row and stopped. He could have stopped anywhere."

Fausta said nothing. The bay went on going grey.

"Seven years. Antiope's told you that; she tells you everything, she thinks it's a kindness. It's true. Seven years, in Rome and here, and I was the one, in that time, and I'll say this for him, he wasn't cruel. He wasn't anything. He was a man who'd stopped at me and kept stopping because it was easier than looking along the row again. He gave me things. He gave me a room. And when I was twenty-two and he'd been married three years and his wife had worked out where the room was, he put me on a ship for Puteoli with a lease on a house by the harbour and a sum in a bag and a letter to his steward saying I was to be free at his death and have the house. He said, *you'll want for nothing, Hilara*, and he was right, I've wanted for nothing, I've had the Dolphin and the Rhodians and the goddess in the yard and I've never once in thirteen years wanted for a single thing that could be bought." She stopped. Her hand had gone to her side again and she let it stay. "And I was three months gone when he put me on the ship, and he knew it, and that was why the ship."

The road was quiet. Somewhere up the hill a dog barked and stopped.

"I'm not telling you he's your father," her mother said. "I'm telling you I was his for seven years and I was three months gone when I left and you were born in the house by the harbour six months after, and you've got his nose, God help you, and the widow saw it across a dining-room in the lamplight in one look, and so did Thallus the day

you were born, and so would anyone who'd ever stood in that atrium and looked up instead of down. I'm telling you because you're twelve and you'll bleed this year and when you do the widow will write, and you'll go to Rome, and somebody there will say it to you in a corridor to see what your face does. I want your face to do nothing. I want you to have had it from me, on a wall, in the dusk, with nobody listening, so that when they say it you can look at them the way you looked at Thallus today and think, *yes, and?*" She turned, finally, and looked at her daughter. "That's the seven years. It's not a story. I've made it sound like one because I've had thirteen years to shape it, but it wasn't one at the time. It was a man with a lamp."

Fausta looked at her mother's face in the last of the light. She looked at the broad cheekbones and the deep eyes that the Rhodians said were Thracian and the Alexandrians said were Syrian, and she thought about the bronze in the room under the stairs and the face in it that she had decided at six was simply hers, and she did the sum she had been not doing for two years, and it came out. She had known it would. She had known the answer since the fishing boat, since the hand on the tunic and *seven years, he must have liked her*, and she had left the sum undone the way you left a door shut, not because you did not know what was in the room but because you did.

"Yes," she said. "And?"

Her mother looked at her for a long moment. Then she laughed — the real laugh, the one from the morning of the Baetican jars — and it turned into a cough, and she bent over it with her hand on her side until it passed, and straightened, and wiped her eyes, and said: "That's my girl. That's it exactly. Now help me up; the Rhodian's in and he'll want his eggs, and I'll not have him saying the Dolphin's gone soft because the woman sat on a wall."

◆

There was a scarf round Antiope's throat when she came in by the yard, in August, a good one, Tarentine wool, blue, and it had been

tied by someone who did not usually wear a scarf, because the knot was at the front, and it did not cover the mark.

She came in the evening, by the yard, and sat on the bottom stair in her travelling-cloak with her knees up, as she had always sat, and Fausta, who had been at the hearth, looked at her once and went and barred the door and came back and sat on the floor in front of her, and did not say anything, because she had learned from her mother that there were things you waited for.

"Well," Antiope said eventually. "He's rich."

"Rufus."

"Rufus." She pulled the scarf off and dropped it on the step. The mark was a hand. It was yellow at the edges now and blue in the middle and you could see, if you looked, where the thumb had been. "He asked for me particular. That's true. He's a man who likes to have a thing that's his for the season, and he's careful with it, mostly, and he pays. He paid. I've more in this hem than I made in three winters." She touched the mark, lightly, with two fingers, the way you touched a bruise to see if it was still yours. "He's not cruel. I want to say that, because I asked the goddess for it and I'm not going to say she didn't deliver. He's not. He's a man who's been told what he's worth and has started to think the market's wrong, and when he's had wine he needs to find out, and the nearest thing to hand is whatever's in the room. It was me in the room. It would have been a slave if it hadn't been. It was a slave twice, in June, when I had the flux. He was sorry after. He's always sorry after; it's one of the things he's good at." She looked at Fausta. "Don't do that with your face. I'm telling you because you're going to Rome, not because I want you to hold my hand. You're going to that widow's house and the widow's got a son, and all these houses have sons, and sons are all the same thing in different tunics. I want you to know what the thing looks like before it's in front of you."

"What does it look like?"

Antiope thought about it. “Like a man who’s just realised he’s allowed,” she said. “That’s all. That’s the whole of it. You’ll see it come into the face. It’s like watching a lamp lit. And once you’ve seen it you can’t not see it, and that’s the only protection there is, duck, seeing it a breath before he does.” She picked up the scarf and wound it back round her throat with practised fingers. “Your mother knows. Don’t tell her I told you. She’d want to have done it herself and she’s not got the breath for it this summer.”

“What’s wrong with her?”

“I don’t know. Nobody knows what’s wrong with women; there’s no money in it.” Antiope stood. “She’s tired and she’s thirty-four and she’s been upstairs with Thallus twice a month since the spring, and that’d tire a mule. She’ll mend when he’s gone to Rome. They always mend in the autumn.” She looked down at the girl on the floor. “You’ve not bled yet.”

“No.”

“You will. You’ve the look. And when you do, tell her, and then tell nobody, and when the widow writes, go. Don’t wait for me to say goodbye; I’ll be at the villa till the Kalends and I don’t say goodbye, it’s bad luck in the trade.” And she bent and kissed the top of Fausta’s head, quickly, as though it were a thing she had decided against and done anyway, and went up the stairs with her hem clinking, and the stair creaked in the place it creaked, and the house settled.

◆

There was blood on the pallet under the stairs when she woke, on the sixth day of September, a brown mark the size of her palm on the sacking, and she lay looking at it for a long time in the grey light with the dog’s face above her.

She did not feel anything. That was the thing she would remember: that she had expected to feel something — she had been told she would, by Antiope, by the Greek woman, by the lady Cornelia’s eleven girls in the dormitory over the bakehouse in Rome,

who had talked of nothing else for ten nights — and there was nothing, only the dark stain on the linen and a dull pulling low in her belly that she had taken, half-asleep, for hunger. She thought: *that's done, then.* She thought: *now the widow will write.* She thought, because she was her mother's daughter and had been told it on a wall, *now a man can be put in a room with me and think about it first*. She found that this thought, which should have frightened her, did not; it went into her and settled, cold and useful, beside the other things she kept, and she got up, and folded the linen, and went to find her mother.

Hilara was at the hearth. She looked at the folded linen and at the girl's face and did not say anything for a moment, and then she put down the ladle and came and took her daughter's face between her two hands, which she had not done since Fausta was small enough to be lifted, and looked at it — the nose, the eyes, all of it — as if she were reading a paper she had been waiting a long time to see.

"Well," she said. "There's the house, then. That's what it's made of now." And she let go. "Antiope's told you what to do with the linen. Do it. And then come back and we'll write to the widow before Thallus can; I want it in my hand that went to her, not in his."

So they wrote. Her mother dictated and Fausta wrote, in the square letters, on a sheet of the good papyrus that the Rhodian had left in payment once and that had been in the box under the hearth-stone for four years waiting for something worth it. The letter said that the freedwoman Hilara sent her duty to the lady Cornelia Tertulla and begged to inform her that the girl she had been kind enough to notice at the master's house last autumn was now of an age to be of use in a lady's household, and that if the lady's kindness still held, the girl was at her disposal, at the lady's convenience, and the master's. It did not say *please*. It did not say anything about the Dolphin, or the steward, or the summer, or the hand on the side. It was eleven lines, and when it was done her mother read it over twice

and said, "Good. Now put at the bottom, in your own hand, so she sees the hand: *The girl can read, and knows not to.*"

Fausta put it. Her mother sealed it with the Dolphin's seal, which was a dolphin, and which Bassus had given her with the lease, and which she used perhaps once a year.

"It'll go by the Rhodian," Hilara said. "He's sailing for Ostia on the ninth. He'll put it in at the widow's door himself; he owes me six asses and he knows it." She looked at the sealed letter on the table between them. "She'll not answer till the spring. They never do anything in the winter, the great; they go in and shut the door and come out in April like the rest of us. But she'll answer. She saw your nose."

"Mama."

"What."

"You said *there's the house*. When you looked at me."

Her mother was quiet. Then she picked up the letter and put it in the breast of her gown, and said, not looking at the girl: "I said it. I meant it. The Dolphin was never the house; the Dolphin's a lease and a man with a key. You're the house. You've been the house since I was three months gone on a ship and worked out that the one thing he'd given me that he couldn't take back through a steward was the thing I was carrying. That's what a child is, to a woman like me. It's the paper you can't burn." She turned back to the hearth. "Now go and do the linen, and then go up to Nicias; you've missed a week, and the boy goes back to Rome in a month, and after that you'll have the room to yourself."

◆

She did not have the room to herself. Nicias was recalled to the villa in the third week of September, to write the Spaniard's letters, and the last lesson was the last lesson. He knew it and she knew it and Celer, who was at the warehouse counting the return cargo and had been told to be there, did not, and so it was the two of them, in the room

with the half-shutter and the cup, with the roll of Demosthenes that nobody had got to the end of lying between them on the step like something that had died.

He did not teach. He sat on the edge of his pallet with his thin hands hanging between his knees and looked at her, and she sat on the step where the boy sat, and after a while he said, "You've bled."

She did not ask how he knew. He was one of the six.

"Good. That's the end of me, then. A tutor's a thing for children and you've stopped being one, officially. The widow will have her own Greeks who'll teach you to say *Homer* with the right vowels and despise you for having learned it in a room over a warehouse." He reached under the pallet and brought out a roll, a small one, old, with the ends frayed and the wooden boss cracked and mended with a bit of wire. "Take this. Don't open it here."

She took it. It was heavy for its size, the way old papyrus was.

"It's Strabo. The fifth book. It's got the bay in it — this town, the villas, the lake, the burning fields, all of it, as a Greek saw it eighty years ago when it was the greatest port in the world and Rome was a place you sent the grain. He got some of it wrong. He got the mole wrong; he says it's built on sand and it's built on the ash that the mountain threw, which is why it stands. Read it, and find where he's wrong, and then you'll know something about this town that nobody in Rome does, and that's a thing to carry into a widow's house: one true thing about a place they think they own." He sat back. "I stole it from the master's library in Rome in the year Titus died. He's never missed it. He's never read it. That's what a library's for, in a house like that; it's a tomb with better light."

"Nicias —"

"Don't. I've been a slave fifty-five years and I've no use for being thanked; it embarrasses the both of us and changes nothing." He picked up the cup, found it empty, set it down. "You asked me once, the first week, what the second thing was. About Rome. The boy

brought you the first — the games and the wheat — and said I'd gone back to sleep before the second. You remember."

"Yes."

"I hadn't gone back to sleep. I'd thought better of it. You were ten." He looked at the shutter. "The second thing is this. Everyone in Rome belongs to someone. The slave belongs to the master and the freedman belongs to the patron and the client belongs to the great man and the great man belongs to the greater and the greatest belongs to the emperor, and the emperor —" He stopped. "The emperor belongs to the city. That's the one they don't tell you. He's the most owned man in the world. He can't eat, or marry, or die, or walk down a street, without it being a thing the city has decided about him. You saw him walk. You told me. On foot, embracing old men. Did you think he wanted to?"

"No. I thought he'd been told what the city wanted."

"Yes. And so he gave it. Because he's owned, and he knows it, and a man who knows it can be reasonable about it. The dangerous ones are the ones who think they own the city. Domitian thought that. It killed him." Nicias turned the empty cup a quarter-turn, the way Thallus did, and she wondered if he knew he had the habit from the same house. "So. Second thing. When you're in that house on the Caelian and they're all looking at each other to see who's watching whom, as you said — you had that right, by the way, at eleven, in a slaves' dormitory; I was proud of that for a week — remember that every one of them is owned, from the widow to the dwarf, and that the only question that matters about any of them is *by whom*. Find that out and you've found the whole of them. It's the same as the tally-boards. It's the same as the hand on the stylus. Who's leaning, and on what." He stood up, slowly, with a hand on the wall, the way her mother stood up now. "That's the lesson. Go on; the boy will be back from the hulls and I'll not have him see me give a girl a book I didn't give him. He's had enough of being second to you in this room;

it's done him good, but there's a limit."

She stood with the roll against her chest. She looked at the thin indoor face and the hanging hands and the cup, and she thought that she would not see him again — she was right; he died at the villa two winters later of a chest, and Bassus, told of it at dinner, said *the Greek? pity, he had a good hand* — and she did not know how to leave a room with a man she would not see again and had not been taught, so she did the thing she had been taught, which was to look at him, at no cost, the way you looked at a Spaniard, and say the true thing.

"You could see them," she said. "And they couldn't see you. You said. You were the boat."

"Yes."

"I saw you."

He was still for a moment. Then the dry face did something she had not seen it do in six years, which was nothing, exactly, but a different nothing; and he said, in Greek, very quietly, the vowels right: "Yes. You did. It's been — go on. Go on, girl. The hulls."

She went. She went down through the house with the roll under her gown, past the loom where the stepmother looked up and looked at the shape under the cloth and looked down again, and out by the kitchen door and down the hill with the smoke coming off the fields behind her, and she did not open it until she was under the stairs with the curtain drawn and the dog's face above her; and then she did. It was the bay, as a Greek had seen it when it was the greatest port in the world, and he had got the mole wrong, and she found the place, and read it three times, and lay with it against her face in the dark the way other girls, she supposed, lay with other things.

◆

Celer took her to the burning fields on the last day of September, because he was going north to Rome on the Kalends and had, he said, never been, and could not go to the Danube having lived his whole life a mile from the mouth of the underworld and not looked in.

It was not the Danube yet. It was Rome again, for the winter, with Rufus, and then — nobody knew. The whole coast had been saying *the war* for two years and the war had not come, and had not come, and in September the news came down the road that the new consul, a lawyer called Plinius who had a villa on the Laurentine shore and more money than anyone could account for, had stood up in the senate and made a speech to the emperor that went on for three hours and said, among a great many other things, that the emperor was not a man who sought war but that if war sought him the Danube would learn what it had forgotten under Domitian; and Hermes, reading the summary that Rufus had sent down, had said *that's the war, then, that's the speech they make before they've decided to tell you*, and had gone to the strong-room and stayed there till the lamps.

So they went up the hill. It was an hour's walk from the town, up through the olive terraces and over the ridge behind the amphitheatre and down into the bowl where nothing grew; and she had been, once, with Antiope, years ago, and had not forgotten it and had not wanted to go back, and went, because he had asked, and because he was going.

The ground was warm. That was the first thing, always; you came over the lip of the bowl and the earth under your feet went from the ordinary autumn cool of the hill to something else, a heat that came up through your sandals like the floor of a bath-house, and the air thickened, and the smell that lay in the streets of the town every morning until noon was here not a smell but a presence, yellow, that got into your mouth. The bowl was white. Not white like marble; white like bone, like something that had been alive and had been in the fire; and across it, here and there, the earth cracked and steamed, and in the cracks the yellow crusted thick as candle-wax, and in the middle, where the guides took the Romans who came up from Baiae to be frightened for a fee, there was the mouth.

They stood at the edge of it. It was a pit the size of the Dolphin's yard, grey mud, and the mud moved — slowly, as if something

underneath it were breathing — and burst, and the burst was a smell and a sound like a pot on the boil and a gout of steam that went up and hung; and the Greeks had said it was Hephaestus's forge. The Romans said it was a door, and the guides said whatever you were paying for, and she, looking into it, thought that it was none of those things: it was simply the ground not pretending.

"Nicias says Strabo says the whole bay's like this underneath," Celer said. "That there's fire under all of it, under the town and the villas and the fleet, and this is only where it comes up. He says the hot springs at Baiae are the same fire with the lid on."

"Then the great are lying in it."

"Yes. For their health." He crouched and put his hand flat on the white ground, and took it away, and looked at his palm. "My father says Strabo's a Greek and Greeks say that sort of thing. He says the ground's the ground and the fire's the fire and a man who thinks about what's under his warehouse will never fill it."

"And you?"

He stood up. "I think the tile's still off the roof at the villa," he said, "and the dowry's in coin, and the Spaniard's uncle put his seal to a thing about me that he thought was about olives, and Rufus owes more than the house is worth and I'm the only one who knows it and I'm thirteen." He said it looking at the mouth. "I think everything's like this underneath. I think my father knows it and has decided not to think about it, and that's what being my father is. I don't know yet if I can do that. I'd like to. It'd be easier."

The mud breathed and burst. The steam went up.

"My mother told me about Bassus," she said.

He did not turn. He had known; she had seen him know on the stair in June, had seen him not say it, had put that beside the rest. "On the road?"

"On the wall where it turns. In June. She said I'd got his nose and the widow saw it in one look and so would anyone who'd ever stood

in that atrium and looked up instead of down." She heard her own voice saying it, level, into the yellow air, and thought that her mother would have been pleased. "She said someone in Rome would say it in a corridor to see what my face did, and she wanted it to do nothing. So I'm saying it to you first. In a place where it can go straight down." She nodded at the mouth. "Say it. Say what they'll say. I want to practise."

He turned then. He looked at her for a long moment with the steam going up between them and the whole white bowl around them and the smell in both their mouths. She saw him decide — she could see him do it now, the small settling behind the face that was the sum coming out — and he said, in a voice that was not his, that was a corridor voice, light and curious and pleased with itself: "They say you're Bassus's get. They say the old man's freedwoman down on the coast threw a bastard and he put her in a whorehouse to keep it quiet. Is it true? You've his nose."

Her face did nothing. She felt it do nothing; she felt it from the inside, like a shutter going to. She looked at him the way she had looked at Thallus in the atrium, the way the lady had said, steadily and at no cost, and she said, "Yes. And?"

And he laughed. It was not a thing he did often and it came out of him sideways, surprised, and he put his hand over his mouth as if to catch it and failed, and stood in the burning fields with his shoulders shaking. She stood and watched him and felt the shutter come open again, slowly, the way the ground did, and found that she was laughing too, which she had not expected and did not entirely understand, and that it hurt, low down, where the pulling had been since the sixth of September, and that she did not mind.

"That's it," he said, when he could. "That's exactly it. God. You'll do. You'll have them in the Tiber."

"The widow said her girls would have *me* in the Tiber."

"The widow's never heard you say *and*." He wiped his eyes. "Do it to Thallus. Next time he asks you a sum. Give him the sum and then look at him like that and say *and?* and see what his face does. I'd give the denarius to see it."

"You've still got it?"

"I've still got it. I'm not spending it till I know what it bought." He looked down at the mouth again, and the laughter went out of his face the way it had come, sideways, and left it older. "I'm going on the Kalends. Rufus wants me in Rome before the senate sits; there's a thing about the Danube supply that he's been given to look at and he can't read a manifest. Then — I don't know. If it's this year, it's this year. If it's next, it's next. Either way I'll not be at the Dolphin again before it, because my father's forbidden it and this time he's right, and there's no tutor's room to be at, now Nicias is gone up to write the Spaniard's letters. So this is —" He stopped.

"This is the mouth of the underworld," she said, "and you've looked in it. That's what you came for."

"Yes."

"Then let's go down. The ground's hot and the Rhodian's in and you've got a hull to count." She turned from the pit. And then, because they were in a place where things could go straight down and because she had practised one thing that afternoon and might as well practise another, she said over her shoulder, not looking at him: "Write. From the Danube. Not what's true. What you saw. I'll work out the true part."

He was quiet behind her for the length of three steps on the hot white ground. Then he said, "All right. What I saw." And then, lower, in his own voice, not the corridor one: "I saw you laugh. I'll put that first. I've not seen it since the cake."

She did not turn round. She walked up out of the bowl with her face doing nothing and the yellow air in her mouth and the heat coming up through her sandals, and when she got to the lip where the

ordinary hill began and the ground went cool she stopped, and waited for him, and when he came up beside her she took his hand — the first time; she had never, in six years, done it; they had sat on steps and keels and the ends of moles and had never once touched on purpose — and held it, hard, for the length of a breath, and let go, and said, "There. That's the true part. Now you've got it. Don't write it down," and went on down the hill ahead of him toward the town and the smoke and the Dolphin and the Rhodian's eggs, and he came after, and neither of them said anything more about it, then or in the letters, or for a very long time.

◆

He went on the Kalends. She did not see him go; she was at the hearth, because the Rhodian wanted eggs, and because her mother was slow that morning, and because a girl who went down to the Capua road to watch a boy on a cart was a girl who would be talked about in a town where six people did not know by nightfall what the other thirty-nine thousand had done. But she heard the cart. She heard the mules' bells go by at the end of the lane, and the jars talking under the sail. She stood with the ladle in her hand and counted, and got to a hundred and ten before the sound went under the sound of the harbour, and then she put the ladle down and went out into the yard, where the goddess was in her niche with the pink ghost of a face and a saucer the cats had been at, and she stood in front of her for a while and did not ask for anything.

Her mother came out and found her there.

"He's gone?"

"Yes."

"Good. One of you's out of it, then." Hilara put her hand on the wall, which she did now, in the yard, where there was nothing to hold. "The Rhodian says the widow's door had a new knocker on it, bronze, in the shape of a hand. He says he put the letter in the hand. He says her steward came out and looked at the seal and looked at him

and said *Puteoli?* like a man who'd been expecting the word." She looked at the goddess. "So that's two of you out of it, by the spring. And then it's me and the Dolphin and the man with the key, the way it was before either of you, and I'll tell you a thing, Fausta, since we're in the yard: I find I don't mind. I've had thirteen years of being a house, and I'm tired, and I'd like to be a woman at a hearth for a while with nobody's paper in me. Let the widow have you. Let the Danube have him. I'll keep the goddess fed." She pushed off from the wall. "Eggs. The man's waiting."

And Fausta went in and did the eggs, and the season went on, and the fleet went home, and the smoke came down the hill every morning and lay in the streets till noon, the same as it always had, the same as it would when all of them were ash; and on the far side of the world, on a river she could not picture, a soldier who had been told what the city wanted was looking across the water at a kingdom and deciding, in a room, that it did not matter. She did not know this, and it did not yet know her, and the ground under all of them went on not pretending.

8

The Mole

Rome and Puteoli, winter and spring 101

The war came as a manifest, which was how Celer would always afterwards think of wars: not as a trumpet but as a list.

It came to Rufus's rooms in January, in a leather case with Sura's seal on it, carried by the Greek with the ring, and it was forty sheets of papyrus in the hand of the grain-office setting out what the Danube legions would need between the spring and the autumn if the emperor were to go north with four of them and the Guard and the auxiliaries of three provinces: so many thousand modii of wheat, so many of barley for the horses, so much oil, so much wine of the kind soldiers drank, so many hides, so much iron. The ports it would come through and the roads it would go up and the depots on the river where it would wait. Rufus was to read it and report to Sura whether the figures from Puteoli and Ostia were sound, because Rufus had a shipowner among his father's people and was understood, in Sura's office, to know about ships.

Rufus did not know about ships. Rufus gave it to Celer, in the room with the window on the Palatine, and said, "Tell me what it says and whether it's true and what I should say about it that will make me look as though I'd thought of it," and went to the baths.

Celer read it. He read it the way he read everything, twice, and then a third time with the tablet; and on the third reading he began to see what it was, which was not a list of what the army needed but a list of who would be paid to supply it, written by men who already knew the answer and were arranging the question to fit. The Puteoli figures were his father's figures. He knew them; he had carried them in his head since the strong-room, and here they were, the *Isis* and her sisters

down to the modius, with the rate per carry that had been fixed under Nerva and that Felix had countersigned, and a note in the margin in another hand that said *confirmed, L.S.* — and he sat with that for a long moment, in Rufus's room, with the rain on the window, and understood that his father had been at the back of Bassus's atrium for nine mornings in the autumn of the entry for exactly this. That Sura's secretary asking Eutyches his name had been the whole of the transaction, and that the four hundred thousand and the olives had been, in his father's accounting, the price of being in the margin of a list in Sura's hand before the war was declared.

He did not write that down. He wrote, for Rufus, three things that were true and would make Rufus look as though he had thought of them: that the barley figure assumed the horses would be fed through the winter on the river and not sent south, which meant the staff expected to hold the far bank; that the wine was costed at the Campanian rate but routed through Aquileia, which was a thing someone would make money on and Rufus might wish to know who; and that the Puteoli carry was sound to the modius but that the depot at Viminacium was listed with a capacity it had not had since Domitian's war, when the Dacians had burned it, and somebody in the grain-office was working from an old map.

Rufus took the three things to Sura. He came back in the evening with a look on him that Celer had not seen before, which was the look of a man who has been praised by someone whose praise he had not expected to want.

"He asked who'd found the depot," Rufus said. He stood in the door of the room with his cloak still on and the rain on it. "I said my secretary. He asked your name. I told him. He said, *Hermes's boy; yes, the Puteoli figures*, and wrote something, and then he said —" Rufus stopped, and took the cloak off, and threw it at the bed, and said to the window, in his sum-reciting voice: "He said I'm to have the Seventh Claudia. Tribune of the broad stripe. Viminacium. We go

with the emperor on the twenty-fifth of March." He turned. "That's eleven weeks. You'll go down to the coast tomorrow and tell your father and bring back what he's promised, in coin, because a tribune's kit costs what a dowry costs and I've no sister left to sell. And you'll come back by the Kalends of March with it and whatever else he thinks I'll need, and then we'll go north, you and I, and find out what you're for."

Celer said, "Yes, sir." He had not said *sir* to Rufus before; it had not seemed to be wanted. It was wanted now. He could see it go into the man and settle, and he thought, watching it, that he had just learned the first thing about war, which was that it made men need to be called things.

◆

He went down on the fast post because Rufus paid for it, and came into Puteoli on the fourth day in a sleet that had followed him from the Alban hills and turned, as the road came down to the bay, into a thin cold rain that the sulphur-smoke could not get up through, so that the whole town lay under a lid of yellow and grey and the harbour was a blur and the mole was a line and the Dolphin, when he passed the end of its lane with his hood up and his face doing nothing, was a door with the bar down and a lamp behind the shutter.

His father was in the strong-room. He was always in the strong-room now; the stepmother said he slept there some nights, with the box for a pillow, and Celer had believed it as a figure of speech until he came in out of the rain and found his father at the table with the lamp and a blanket round his shoulders and the contract unrolled and his eyes shut.

They opened. They looked at the boy in the door with the road on him, and his father said, "The Seventh."

"How —"

"Thallus wrote. He's in Rome; he has a man in Sura's house who tells him what Sura's house has for dinner. He wrote the same day."

His father did not move. "I knew before Rufus did. I knew before you did, probably, unless Rufus told you in the litter. Sit down. You look like something the tide left."

Celer sat. The lamp hissed. His father looked at him for a long time across it with an expression he could not read and then, unexpectedly, reached across and put a hand flat on the boy's wet head, as a man might on a dog that had come back, and took it off, and said: "The twenty-fifth. Eleven weeks. You'll want coin for his kit, which I have, and a letter to the quartermaster at Viminacium, which I've written, because the quartermaster at Viminacium is a man called Lucilius who was a clerk at Ostia when I was a clerk at Ostia and who owes me a thing from thirty years ago that I've never asked for. You'll give him the letter and you'll not ask what the thing was. And you'll want what I'm going to tell you now, which is the only thing I've got that's worth more than the coin, so listen."

He listened.

"You're going to a camp. A camp is a town with one man in it. Everything else is clerks. The tribune's a clerk, the legate's a clerk, the quartermaster's a clerk, the centurions are clerks with sticks. The one man is the emperor, and you'll never see him, and nothing you do will ever reach him, and that's not the point. The point is that every one of the clerks between you and him wants something, and most of them want the same thing, which is to not be blamed. That's the whole of a camp. It's not courage and it's not iron. It's forty thousand men trying not to be the one whose name is on the tablet when the thing goes wrong." His father leaned forward. "You can count. You can write a manifest that's true. In a camp, that makes you the most dangerous man in the tent, because you're the one who knows whose name goes on the tablet. Use it. Not to hurt anyone — not yet; you're fourteen and you'll be killed for it. To be *needed*. Be the one who knows where the barley went. Be the one who can tell the legate on the day the depot's short that it was short in Domitian's war and

here's the old map. A boy like that doesn't get sent across the river with a shield. A boy like that gets kept in the tent, and the tent is where the war is decided, and the men who were in the tent are the men who come home with the land." He sat back. "That's it. That's thirty years. Rufus will be brave, probably; his sort are; it's the only thing they're taught. Let him. You be useful. One of you has to come back, and he's got a father who can buy another son."

Celer sat with his hands between his knees and the rain running off his hair onto the table. He said, after a while, "And Mother?"

His father looked at him blankly for a moment. Then he understood. "Vibia's at the loom. She'll say what she says. She's been saying it to the gods since Thallus's letter came and I've let her; it keeps her hands busy." A pause. "The other one's in the kitchen. Chione. I kept her; she's cheaper than a cook and the cook ran off at the Saturnalia. She asked after you. I didn't answer. You can go and see her or not. It's nothing to me either way and it should be nothing to you."

It was not nothing to him. He had carried it to Rome and back. He said, "Yes, Father," and went up out of the strong-room into the house, and found the stepmother at the loom, and stood by it. She did not look up, and said: "Eleven weeks," and he said, "Yes," and she said, "Then you'll have the lamb at the Ides, and the gods will have the rest of it, and you'll go to the tomb with him before you go and let him show you the stone, because he needs to and you can bear it." And then she did look up, with the long farm face and the pale eyes, and said: "And you'll go to the lodging-house. Once. Properly, by the door, in daylight, and I'll not tell him, and he'll know anyway and say nothing, because he's not a fool and you're going to a war. There's no point in being careful about a boy's name when the boy may not come back to use it. I've told him that. He didn't answer either. He's not answering anything this winter; it's how he's frightened." She went back to the thread. "Go on. Not tonight. Tomorrow, when it's

stopped raining. She'll want to see you dry."

◆

He did not go the next day, or the one after. He went to the warehouse with his father and counted what Rufus would need and put it in boxes and sealed the boxes. He went to the tomb and stood in the rain in front of the blank space under the ship where he would go, *F* not *L*, and let his father show it to him, and said what was wanted. He went to the harbour and arranged the carriage of the boxes to Rome by the house's cart. He went to the kitchen, once, at an hour when he knew it would be empty, and it was not; the Bithynian girl was there with her back to him at the hearth, and she turned, and they looked at each other across the room with the pots between them, and she said, in the Greek with the sea in it, *you've grown*. He said, *so have you*, which was not true and which she let pass, and then neither of them had anything, and he said, *my mother says you sew*, and she said, *your mother gave me the needle*, and he said, *yes*, and went out; and that was all, and it was enough, and he never spoke to her again in his life, and remembered it.

And on the ninth day, which was dry, with a wind off the land that had cleared the smoke and left the bay standing up blue and hard as a painted wall, he went down the hill to the Dolphin by the lane in daylight and knocked on the door with his face doing nothing, and the woman who opened it was not Hilara.

She was a Greek woman he knew by sight, the egg-seller's daughter, in an apron, and she looked at him and knew him and said, "She's upstairs. The mother. She's — she's lying down. The girl's in the yard." And stood back from the door, which was a thing nobody had ever done for him at that house, and he understood from the standing back more than from the words that something had changed in the Dolphin that the lane did not yet know about.

The girl was in the yard. She was sitting on the step by the shrine with a roll open on her knees, and she looked up, and her face did

nothing — he watched it do nothing, and was, in some small cold part of himself, proud of her — and then did something, briefly, that he did not have a word for, and then was still again.

"You came by the door," she said.

"My mother said to."

"Vibia." She closed the roll. "She's the only one in that house with any sense. Sit down. You'll want to know about my mother and I'll tell you once and then we'll not speak of it, because I've had three months of speaking of it and I'm done." He sat. "She's ill. Since the Saturnalia. It's her side; there's a hardness, Antiope's felt it, the Greek woman's mother's felt it, they look at each other over her and say nothing. She can't do the stairs. She can't do Thallus." Flat, a manifest. "I do the house. I do the slate and the lodgers and the Rhodian's eggs and I pay the Greek woman out of the box to do the beds. Thallus came at the Ides and I gave him the quarter and the accounts and he sat in the common room and looked at me and said *and the rest?* and I said *there's no rest, she's ill*, and he said *we'll see*, and went away. He'll be back on the Kalends. I don't know what he'll do. I don't think he knows. A man like that doesn't know what to do with a thing he can't price." She looked at the shrine. "The widow hasn't written. It's winter; they don't. The Rhodian put it in the bronze hand himself. So that's where we are. That's the house."

He sat on the step beside her in the hard blue light and found that he had nothing. He had come down the hill with eleven weeks and the Seventh Claudia and a letter to a quartermaster and the whole of his father's thirty years in a sentence about tents, and he sat beside her and it was all paper, it was all a manifest in another man's hand. The thing in front of him was a girl on a step with her mother dying above her and a steward coming on the Kalends, and he could not count it, and he could not make it come out the same three times, and he understood, for the first time, what his father had been doing in the strong-room with his eyes shut: not sleeping. Hiding from the thing

that would not add.

"I'm going on the Kalends," he said. "To Rome. And then north on the twenty-fifth. The Seventh, at Viminacium. Rufus has the broad stripe." He heard it come out of him in the corridor voice and hated it and could not find the other one.

"I know. Thallus told the whole common room. He was proud of it; he said it as if he'd arranged it." She turned her head and looked at him, the proper look. "You'll go. You should go. There's nothing here you can do and your father's right that one of you should come back and it had better be the one who can count." A pause. "Come to the mole tonight. After the lamps. I want to see the water and I'll not go alone and the Greek woman will sit with her. That's all I want. Don't bring anything. Don't say anything you've practised. Just come."

"Yes," he said. "All right."

"And Celer." He waited. "You said you'd write. From the Danube. What you saw."

"Yes."

"Write it to the widow's house. Not here. By the summer I'll be there or I'll be dead or the house will be Thallus's, and whichever it is, a letter to the Dolphin's a letter to him."

◆

The mole at night was a different thing. He had been on it a hundred times in the day with the porters and the boys and the fishermen and the whole town looking east, and he had never once been on it when it was empty. It was empty now: a road of stone going out into the dark on its arches with the sea moving under it, black, with the lamps of the fleet at Misenum far off on the left and the villa lamps on the right climbing their hill, and at the end of it, where they sat with their legs over the edge as they had sat to watch the news-ship, nothing but the bay and the stars and the sound.

They did not say anything for a long time. She had said not to and he found that he did not want to; the corridor voice had gone

somewhere on the walk out and he did not go looking for it. He sat with the stone cold through his tunic and the sea moving under his feet and her beside him, close, not touching, and listened to the water on the arches, which was a sound he had heard his whole life and had never once, until that moment, sat still long enough to hear all of.

"Strabo says it's built on ash," she said eventually. "Not sand. Nicias gave me the book. He says that's why it stands."

"My father says it stands because the Augustales pay for the repairs."

"Both." She leaned forward and looked down between her knees at the black water. "Everything's both. That's what I've worked out this winter, doing the slate. Every number's two numbers. The one that's owed and the one that's paid. The one on the board and the one in the wax. And you can't live in the gap, you have to pick one, and whichever you pick is a lie to someone." She sat back. "I'm going to pick the paid one. When I go to the widow's. I've decided. I'm going to be what's in the wax and let the board say what it likes."

"And if the widow doesn't write?"

"Then I'll pick it here. With Thallus. I've worked that out too." She said it without any weight at all, and he heard the weight in it anyway, the way you heard a hull's draught in how the water moved against it, and he turned and looked at her in the dark, and she was looking at the sea.

"Fausta."

"Don't. I said not to say anything you've practised."

"I haven't practised this. I don't know what it is." And he did not; he sat on the end of the mole with the whole of the sea in front of him and found that the thing in his chest had no number, had never had one, had been there since a yard and a cake and had been given no figure because a boy who was raised to count knew better, and that he was going to the Danube on the twenty-fifth and might not come back and that if he did not the thing would go into the river with him

uncounted, which was the only way he had ever been able to keep anything safe, and that it was not safe, it had never been safe, it had been on the mole the whole time where anyone could see it. "I don't know what it is," he said again. "I know it's not a jar."

She turned then.

He did not decide to. That was what he would say to himself, later, for years, in tents and strong-rooms and rooms with windows on palaces: that he had not decided, that it had happened the way the ship had come about on the news-day when the wind went round a point, all at once and with no one at the tiller. He put his hand on the side of her face, where the lamp from the villa hill caught it, and she did not move. He leaned in and kissed her, badly, with his eyes open, the way a boy of fourteen kissed who had been in a room over a chandler's and learned nothing there about this; and for the space of a breath, or two, or something that was not measured in breaths, she kissed him back, with her hand come up and closed in the front of his tunic, hard, the way she had held his hand at the lip of the burning fields, and he felt the whole of the sea stop.

Then she stopped it.

Not a push. She took her hand out of his tunic and put it flat on his chest and held him there, away, at the length of her arm, and her face in the villa-light was doing nothing, nothing at all, it was the shutter gone to, and she said, very low and very level, "No."

He sat back. He felt the cold come into the place where she had been.

"No," she said again, and it was not to him; it was to the sea, or the mole, or the stone under them. "Not that. Not like that. I'll not — I've seen where that goes. I've seen it every morning of my life coming down the stairs doing the sum. I'll not be a thing a man stopped at."

"I didn't — that's not —"

"I know it's not. I know what it is. I know better than you do; you've no idea what it is, you said so." Her voice did not rise. "That's

why. Because you don't know and you're going to a war and I'm going to a widow's house or a steward's bed, and whichever of those it is, I'll not go into it having been that, on a mole, in the dark, with the one person in the world who's never once looked at me as a thing. I'll not spend it. Not here. Not for nothing. Not when it's the only — " She stopped. She took her hand off his chest. "Not when it's the only paper I've got that nobody can burn."

He did not understand. That was the truth. He would know it as the truth for a long time before he knew what it meant: he sat on the mole with the cold in him and heard her say *no*, and *I'll not be a thing a man stopped at*, and heard it as a girl refusing a boy, as the market disagreeing, as the answer to a sum coming out wrong; and he did not hear, because he was fourteen and had spent the winter in a room with a window on a palace learning to be a face, the other thing under it, which was a girl whose mother was dying above a staircase that a steward climbed twice a month, who had done the sum on the wall and knew exactly what she was made of and what it had cost and who was holding the one thing she owned outright away from the only person she would have given it to, with her arm out straight, because she had seen what being given did to women.

He heard *no*. He was his father's son. He put it in the column.

"All right," he said. His voice came out steady, which he noted with the distant interest he always noted it with, as if it were someone else's. "All right. I'm sorry."

"Don't be sorry. Be — " She shook her head. "Just don't be sorry. Sorry's the thing Rufus is good at." And she stood up, on the end of the mole, with the sea behind her and the villa lamps on her face, and looked down at him, and he could not read her, and it was the first time since the yard with the cake that he could not, and he would remember that longer than the kiss. "Come on. The Greek woman's got to go home and I've the shutters. Walk me back. Don't say anything. We've both said it, whatever it was. Let it be both."

He walked her back. He did not say anything. At the end of the lane, where the Dolphin's lamp was behind its shutter, she stopped, and did not look at him, and said to the door: "Write what you saw. I'll work out the true part. I said I would." And went in, and the bar came down, and he stood in the lane with his hands at his sides for the length of a hundred counted, and then went up the hill the long way, past the baths, so as not to pass anything.

◆

The mason was at the tomb on the last day of February, and his father had sent him up to see the space.

It was on the road out of the town between the other tombs, on its own ground that his father had bought from the Augustales' college for more than it was worth so that the college would remember who had paid; and the plinth was up, in travertine, dressed square, and the stone was on it, and the mason was on a trestle in front of it with a chisel and a mallet and a boy holding the lamp against the grey, cutting letters. *C. LAECANIUS HERMES, FREEDMAN OF LUCIUS, AUGUSTALIS, SHIPOWNER.* The mason was at the second line. He was a Campanian with stone-dust in the creases of his face and he did not stop when the boy came up the road, because a man cutting a letter did not stop for anyone, and when the letter was done he sat back on the trestle and looked at the tall boy in the road and said, "You're the son."

"Yes."

"He's told me to leave a space. Here. After *son*. Two words' worth, in letters a hand taller than the rest, and I'm to leave it blank and go on with the freedmen and the descendants under, and when he sends me the two words I'm to cut them." The mason looked at the blank. "I've cut tombs thirty years. I've never been told to leave a hole in one. A hole in a stone's a thing people read. They'll walk past this every day to Capua and see a freedman's tomb with a gap in it a hand high and they'll say *what's that for* and somebody will tell them. He

knows that. He's a man who knows what a stone says before it's cut." He picked up the chisel. "I'm not asking what the two words are. I'd not cut them any better for knowing. I'm telling you the space is there and I'm leaving it, and that a space on a stone's heavier than a letter, because a letter's done and a space is waiting."

Celer stood in the road and looked at the blank. Two words' worth. A hand taller. He knew what they were; he had known since he could read; his father had never once said them to him and had never once not said them. He stood with his hands at his sides and looked at the place where they were not yet, and found that it was the first thing in his life he had looked at that had a figure he did not want to count. That he was counting it anyway, because he counted everything, and that the figure was *not yet*, and that he was going north in two days with a girl's *no* in his column and his father's two words in a space on a stone and both of them open.

"Tell him it's left," said the mason. "Tell him I've left it exactly the width he said, and that it looks like what it is, and that if he wants my advice, which he's not asked, he'll send me the words before he's dead, because I've cut a lot of spaces filled by sons and they never get the letters right."

◆

He went on the Kalends, in the house's cart, with the boxes, in a thin March rain.

His father walked beside the cart as far as the amphitheatre and did not speak and at the amphitheatre put his hand on the tail-board and stopped, so that the cart went on and the hand came off it. That was the goodbye; Celer looked back once and saw him standing in the road in his cloak with the rain on him, not waving, a man watching a hull go down the ways, and then the road bent and he was gone. The stepmother had said what she said at the door, and had given him a thing wrapped in cloth that was bread and a small bronze of the Lares from her father's farm, and had said, *the gods don't care which house,*

they only care that someone's feeding them, see that someone is, and he had put it in his satchel with the letter to the quartermaster and the denarius. The Bithynian girl had not come to the door. He had not expected her to and had looked anyway.

The Dolphin's lane he passed with his hood up. He did not look. He had decided on the mole that he would not, and he was a boy who, once a thing was decided, could carry it the way he carried a number; and so he looked at the mules' ears and the rain on the road and the tombs beginning, and he did not see the shutter on the upper window of the Dolphin open the width of a hand as the cart went by the end of the lane, and a face at it. The shutter close; and she did not see him not look, because she was not looking at him, she was looking at the cart, and the boxes, and the sail over them with the rain running off it, and counting, and she got to a hundred and forty before the sound went under the sound of the harbour, and then she closed the shutter and went down to her mother, who was awake, and wanted water.

He had the tomb on his right going out. The ship's eye caught what light there was. The blank space under it was still blank. He looked at that; he let himself look at that; and he thought, with the rain coming down on the Capua road and the Danube somewhere in front of him past a city and a mountain and a river he had seen only on a map that was out of date, that his father had been wrong about one thing in the strong-room. It was not that the clerks wanted not to be blamed. It was that everyone, down to the last mule, wanted to be the thing that was not spent. And he had spent nothing, on the mole, in the dark, because she had held him off at the length of her arm and said *no*, and he had put it in the column; and he sat in the cart with the boxes and found, when he went looking, that the column did not balance, that there was a figure in it he had not entered and could not find. That it was the first sum of his life that would not come out the same three times, and that he was going to a war with it open.

9

The Slate

Puteoli, spring 101 to spring 102

The first letter came in June by the hand of a woman who had never in her life set foot in the lower town, and the whole of the lane came to its doors to watch her do it.

Vibia Procula walked. That was the thing they would say about it afterwards, at the baker's and the baths: that Hermes's wife, the freeborn one, the one from Nola with the long lip, had come down from the house above the macellum on her own two feet with a single slave behind her and had walked the length of the Dolphin's lane in the ninth hour with her head covered and her eyes in front of her, and had stopped at the door, and knocked, and waited to be let in like anyone. Nobody could remember a freeborn woman of the Augustales' houses knocking at the Dolphin. Nobody could remember one knowing where it was.

Fausta let her in. She had been at the slate and had the stylus still in her hand and she stood in the doorway with it and looked at the woman on the step, and the woman looked back with the pale eyes and said, "You're the girl. I've seen you go through my atrium with an oil-jar for six years and never once looked at your face. I'm looking at it now. Yes. Well." And held out a folded packet with a seal that had been broken and pressed shut again. "This came to my husband inside his own letter from the north, with a note asking him to see it reached you. He read it, as he reads everything, and put it in the box and said nothing. I took it out of the box. He knows I took it. He hasn't said anything about that either. He's not saying anything this year; it's how he's frightened." She put the packet in Fausta's hand. "There'll be others. I'll bring them when I can. I'll not send a slave; a slave can

be asked. Is your mother receiving?"

"She's upstairs. She can't do the stairs."

"Then I'll go up." And she did; she went up the Dolphin's stair, which the stair had not had done to it by a woman of her kind in its existence, and the stair creaked in the place it creaked, and Fausta stood in the common room with the packet in her hand and heard, overhead, the door of the room with the window, and the stepmother's even farm voice saying *Hilara. I'm Vibia. We've not spoken. I've come to sit for an hour so the girl can read her letter in peace, and because I've a thing or two to say about the men in both our houses that I'd rather say to someone who already knows them*; and then the door closed.

She read it in the yard, by the shrine.

It was in his square hand on a sheet of army papyrus, the coarse kind, written small to get it all on. It did not begin with her name. It began: *What I saw.* And then it was a list.

The Danube, from the bank at Viminacium, in April. It is not a river. It is a thing the land does. Half a mile across and brown and moving faster than a horse walks, and on the far side nothing, trees, and above the trees the mountains where they are, and the men stand on the bank and look at it and do not talk. The bridge is boats. Forty boats, lashed, with planks across, and it moves under you, the whole length of it, like the mole in a swell, and the horses will not go on it until they are blindfolded and then they go, and the men go after the horses with their eyes open, which I think is the wrong way round.

The emperor, once, at a distance of three hundred paces, on foot, with his head bare, walking the line of the bridge-boats before the first cohort crossed, and stopping at every boat, and putting his hand on it. I asked the quartermaster why. He said: because the men will cross a bridge the emperor has touched. I said: and if it breaks? He said: then it broke under the emperor's hand and not theirs, and that is a different kind of drowning. He is a man called Lucilius who owes my father

something from thirty years ago. I gave him the letter. He read it and looked at me and said, your father has a long memory, and gave me a tent to myself, which a tribune's secretary does not get. I have not asked what the thing was.

Rufus, on a horse, in a cuirass that cost what the dowry cost, being brave at the men, who like him. I did not expect that. They like him. He talks to them the way he talked to the mule-brothers at the villa, as if they were people he had decided to be gracious to, and it turns out that in a camp that is rare enough to be mistaken for love.

The country beyond the river, which is called Banat by the people who were there before, and is flat and then is not, and has farms on it that are empty, with the fires still warm, and dogs that follow the column for a day and then go back. I saw a child's shoe in a doorway. I saw a loom with the cloth half-done. I thought of my mother. Not the dead one. The one at the loom.

A centurion of the Seventh called Crescens, a Spaniard, forty, with a nose that has been broken and a voice like a cart on gravel, who came to my tent on the second night across the river and said: you are the boy who found the depot. I said yes. He said: good; the depot is short, as you said, and the legate is going to ask whose name goes on the tablet, and I want it to be the grain-office's and not mine, and you are going to help me make that so. And I did. And he gave me a knife, afterwards, an ordinary one, a soldier's, and said: you will not need it, you are the kind that stays in the tent, but a man who has not got one is a man people notice. I have it in my belt. My father would say it was a denarius. It is heavier.

The mountains, on the fifth day, when the trees stopped. I do not have anything to say about the mountains. Nicias would have had Homer for them. I have only that they are there, and that the king is in them somewhere with everything he owns, and that we are going up.

That is what I saw. You said you would work out the true part. I have not put the true part in. I do not know what it is yet. I will send the

next when there is something.

Feed the goddess. — C.

She read it three times, as she read everything. Then she folded it along his folds and put it inside her gown against her skin, where the Strabo had been until she had found a better place for the Strabo, and she sat on the step by the shrine with her hands between her knees and did not cry, because she had decided on the mole that she would not, and she was a girl who, once a thing was decided, could carry it.

I thought of my mother. The one at the loom. She turned that over. She thought that it was the first thing he had ever written down that was not a number, and that he had put it in a list to make it one, and that this was exactly like him, and that it was the true part, and that she would not tell him so.

Upstairs, the door opened, and Vibia Procula came down the Dolphin's stair with her head covered and her face doing what it always did, and stopped at the foot of it, and said to the girl in the yard without raising her voice: "Your mother says the Greek woman's mother is to be sent for on the Kalends, not the Ides, and that she'll not argue about it. I agree with her. And I've said to her what I came to say, and she's said what she had to say back, and we understand each other, and that's enough for two women who've been in the same street for thirteen years and never once been in the same room." She drew her veil forward. "The next letter I'll bring in the evening. The lane talks less after dark."

◆

Antiope came down from the villa in April with nothing in her hem and something in her belly, and the Greek woman's mother was sent for a month early, and not for Hilara.

She told Fausta on the stair, the first night, with her knees up and her cloak still on, in the voice she used for the price of things. It was one of the winter men. The villa was shut from the Kalends of September to the Ides of April and Thallus left four slaves and a

freedman to keep it, and the freedman was a Gaul called Mettius who had the keys and the wine-cellar and nothing else to do for seven months. He had sent down to the Dolphin in January for company and Hilara had been too ill to go and too ill to say no, and so Antiope had gone up, and had stayed, because it was warm and the villa had food and the Dolphin that winter had had neither in any quantity. "And he was careful," she said. "He was careful every time but one. There's always one. You can be careful for seven years and it's the one that counts." She looked at her hands. "Three months. I felt it at the Ides. I thought: well, there it is, duck, the goddess has a sense of humour after all."

"Does he know?"

"Mettius? He knows. He said he'd speak to Thallus about a place in the villa kitchens when it came and I said I'd rather it didn't come, and he looked relieved and gave me four denarii, which is the going rate for relief." She pulled the cloak tighter. "Don't. I can see you doing the sum. Four denarii is what the Greek woman's mother charges and he knew it to the as; that's what *careful* means, in a man."

The Greek woman's mother came on the Kalends of May. She was a small woman, very old, from Rhodes, with a bag, and she had delivered half the lower town and undelivered a good part of the other half, and she looked at Antiope on the bed in the back room and at the girl standing in the door and said in Greek, "You. Water. Hot, and a lot of it. And cloths, and the strongest wine in the house, and then you'll stay, because I've only two hands and she'll want one to hold and I'll want the other for the work."

So she stayed. She would not afterwards describe it, to anyone, and did not need to, because it had gone into her in the way the warehouse boards had gone in and the Rhodian's bill and the dog's face in the stair, as a thing she had now and could not put down. She would remember the wine, which Antiope drank off in three swallows and asked for more of and was refused. She would remember

the old woman's hands, which were brown and spotted and perfectly steady and did not hurry. She would remember the smell of the herb that was burned in the brazier, which was bitter and green and which she would smell again in a palace twenty years on and have to leave the room. She would remember Antiope's hand in hers, which broke two of her fingers' worth of grip and left marks that lasted a week, and Antiope's face, which did not scream, because the lane would hear, but went white and then grey and then a colour she had no name for and made a sound through its teeth like the mud at the burning fields. She would remember the thing itself, in the basin, which she looked at because she had decided to look at everything, and which was nothing, a clot, a handful, a thing you could have thrown to the cats, and which the old woman wrapped in a cloth with great care and took away with her and did not say where. And she would remember the old woman at the door afterwards, with the bag, taking the four denarii and counting them and putting them away and looking up at the girl with eyes like black stones and saying: "You didn't look away. Good. Most do, the first time. You'll want to know how it's done, one day, for yourself or someone, and you've seen it now, and that's the start." And then, lower: "Your mother's the other thing. The hard thing in the side. I'll come for that too, when it's time, and it'll not be this; this is a thing you can do something about. That's a thing you can only sit with. You've a year, maybe. Feed her what she'll eat. Don't let the steward tire her."

She fed her mother what she would eat. She did not let the steward tire her, because Thallus, when he came on the Ides of May and found the woman upstairs grey and the girl in the common room with the slate and Antiope on the stair with her knees up and a look on her like a shutter, sat on the bench with his back to the wall and his hands folded and did not go up. He took the quarter. He took the accounts. He looked at the slate for a long time.

"You've improved your sevens," he said.

"Yes, sir."

"And you've charged the Rhodian for the water."

"Yes, sir. Sixty-eight. He paid it. He said he'd wondered when someone would."

Thallus turned the cup a quarter-turn on the table. He looked at her over it with the pricing look, and she looked back, at no cost, the way the widow had said, and he saw her do it, and she saw him see, and the look went on a moment longer than either of them had planned.

"Your mother," he said, "is not going to recover."

"No, sir."

"You know what the lease says."

"It says the house is hers for life and after that the master's. It says the master will provide for her at his death. It doesn't say what happens if she dies first." She had read it; her mother had got it out of the box under the hearth-stone in March and made her read it aloud twice and then read it again herself with her lips moving. "It doesn't say anything about me."

"No. It doesn't." He drank. "So you understand the position. When she goes, the house reverts. I can put anyone in it. I can put Antiope in it, if she'd take it, and she might; she's thirteen years older than you and she knows the trade. I can put the Greek woman in it. I can shut it and sell the lease to the chandler, who's asked. And you're a freeborn girl of thirteen with a slate and a nose, and no paper, and nowhere." He set the cup down. "I'm not saying this to frighten you. I've never in my life frightened anyone on purpose; it's a waste. I'm saying it because you can read and I'd rather deal with someone who can read. The widow has your mother's letter. I know that; I know what's in the bronze hand before the lady does. The widow hasn't answered. She may. She may not. She's a woman who takes a year to decide whether she wants an egg. And in the meantime there's a quarter due at midsummer and a woman upstairs who can't earn it

and a girl downstairs who could."

The common room was very quiet. Antiope, on the stair, had not moved.

Fausta looked at the steward. She looked at the small folded hands and the bald head shining under the lamp and the face that had been set, a long time ago, to show nothing, and she thought of the fishing boat. The hand on the tunic, and *in every way that matters except one*, and she thought of Antiope saying *like a man who's just realised he's allowed*, and she looked for it in Thallus's face, the lamp being lit, and it was not there. It was not there. He was not looking at her the way the men on the stairs did. He was looking at her the way he looked at the slate.

"You want the quarter," she said.

"I want the quarter."

"Then you'll have it. From the slate. Not from the stairs." She said it in the voice her mother used for the Rhodian's eggs. "I've raised the water and the wine and I've put the Alexandrians in the window room at a denarius and they pay it, because it's the only room in the lower town with a window on the mole and they're homesick. I've let the back room to the Greek woman's cousin by the month, which is less a night and more a quarter. I've stopped the Rhodian's six asses. I've got the Dolphin making what it made when she was well, and I've done it with a slate and a stair I don't go up, and if you'll look at the figures instead of at me you'll see it." She pushed the slate across the table. "The quarter's there. It'll be there at midsummer. And when she goes, if the widow hasn't written, you can put the Greek woman in and I'll go wherever the Greek woman wants a girl who can keep a slate, and you'll have lost nothing, because you never had anything to lose, because I'm not in the lease." She took a breath. "And?"

He did not move. For a moment nothing in his face moved. Then — she would remember this for a long time, and tell nobody, and when at last she did tell someone it was in a palace, to a woman with a

comb in her hand, who laughed — the corner of the steward's mouth went up, perhaps the width of a stylus, and came down again. He reached out and turned the slate round and looked at the figures, all of them, from the top, with his finger going down the column feeling for the place where the hand changed; and he did not find it, because there was not one, and he sat back.

"Sixty-eight," he said. "You charged him the water and lost him the custom of his island."

"I charged him the water and he laughed and said the Dolphin had grown up. He's bringing two more in July. He said so."

"Did he." Thallus folded his hands again. "Then you've found the thing your mother never found, which is that a man will pay for what he's charged if you look at him while you charge it." He stood. "The quarter at midsummer. From the slate. I'll not go up; tell her I asked after her, and that the lease stands while she does, and that I've no plans for the house that I've made yet, which is true, and which she'll know how to weigh." At the door he stopped, with his hand on the bar, and said without turning round: "The widow will write. I've seen the Rhodian's seal in her steward's hand and I've seen that steward keep things. He kept yours. He's an Alexandrian; they don't keep what they mean to throw away. It'll be the spring. They never do anything in the winter." And then, in exactly the same voice: "The boy's letters come through Hermes's house. I know that too. I've read none of them; it's not my house. But Hermes has read all of them, and the second one's been in his box a month, and his wife hasn't yet found the key. You might tell her where he keeps it. It's behind the Lares. It's always behind the Lares, with that sort; they think the gods are a lock."

And he went. And Antiope, on the stair, let out her breath, and said, "Well. Duck. You've either saved us or sold us, and I'll be damned if I can tell which," and Fausta sat down on the bench where he had sat, with her back to the wall and her eyes on the door, and

found that her hands were perfectly steady, and that this frightened her more than anything the steward had said.

◆

The egg-woman's girl brought the second letter up the lane in July, in the evening, between two fingers as if it were hot, because the same hand had sent it and the hand had found the key.

What I saw.

The pass at Tapae, in the last days of September, which is where Domitian's army was beaten and where the emperor had decided, I think before he left Rome, that this one would not be. I was not in it. I was in the tent with the tablets, two miles back, as my father said I would be, and I heard it, which is not the same, and is not nothing. It is a sound like the fleet-day, if the fleet-day went on for six hours and nobody was glad.

The wounded coming back past the tent. I did not know a man could be opened like that and still walk. One of them stopped and asked me for water and I gave it him and he drank it and said thank you, boy, in a Spanish Latin like Crescens's, and sat down against the tent-rope, and was dead when the orderlies came, with the cup in his hand. I took the cup back. I do not know why I am telling you that. It is a cup.

The emperor, afterwards, with the staff, in the rain, tearing his cloak into strips for the surgeons because the linen had run out. That is a thing that happened and that every man in the army knows happened and that I am told he has done before, at the Rhine, and that it was no less true for having been done before. Crescens says: the men would cross a bridge he had touched, and now they will die on a hill he has torn his cloak for, and that is what an emperor is, boy, it is a man who has worked out what cloth is worth. I think Crescens and Nicias would have liked each other. I think they would have agreed about everything and fought.

Rufus, who was in it, on the left, and whose horse was killed under him, and who came back on foot with his sword out and his face white and said to me in the tent, I did nothing, I stood there, they came at us and I stood there and the men went past me and did it and I stood there with this thing in my hand, and then he sat down and I gave him wine and he drank it and said, write to my father that the Seventh held the left, which is true, and that the tribune was in the line, which is also true, and that is all, and I wrote it. He is asleep as I write this. He has been asleep nine hours. The men say he held the left. They are not lying. He was there. I have decided that this is what holding means.

The prisoners, which there are a great many of, and which are put in a pen below the camp, and which I was sent to count, because somebody has to and the quartermaster is a man who uses what he has. I counted them. There are four hundred and six. I did not look at their faces because you do not look at the faces of a thing you are counting; my father taught me that in a warehouse and I did not know until this week what he meant. One of them spoke to me in Greek. He had been a merchant at Sarmizegetusa and traded down the river to the Black Sea and he said, boy, you are a Greek, you have the look, tell them I can be useful, I know the roads. I told Crescens. Crescens said: everyone knows the roads. I have not told the quartermaster. I do not know why. I have the number. The number is the thing I was sent for.

The king's men, dead, on the slope, in the morning, which I went up to see because the tent was two miles back and I had decided that I would look at everything. They wear a kind of cap, the nobles, a felt cap, and the rest do not, and you can tell the dead nobles from the dead rest by the caps, which is a thing I did not expect to be able to do and now can. They have a weapon like a scythe. The surgeons hate it. I saw what it does; I will not write what it does. I looked. I did not look away. You would have been proud of me, or Nicias would, or the old woman you wrote about; I do not know who I am being looked at by, up here. I only know I am.

That is what I saw. It is more than the last and I do not know what it adds to. You will. — C.

The goddess?

She wrote back. She had not, to the first. She had not known what to put, and had put it off, and had told herself it was the post and the house and her mother; and when the second came she sat down in the yard with the Rhodian's good papyrus and the stylus and wrote, that night, by the shrine, with the lamp:

What I saw.

My mother, in the window room, in June, when Vibia came up the stair and sat with her. I was in the yard. I did not hear what they said. I heard my mother laugh, once, the real one. She has not done it since.

Antiope, on the bed in the back room, on the Kalends of May, and the Greek woman's mother's hands. I will not write what they did. I looked. I did not look away. The old woman said that was the start of something. I think it was the start of knowing what a body is for, which is not what the men on the stairs think, and not what the goddess thinks either; it is a thing that can be opened, like your soldier, and go on walking, and ask for water.

Thallus, in the common room, on the Ides of May, not going up the stairs. I gave him the quarter from the slate and I said the thing I practised at the burning fields and his mouth moved. The width of a stylus. I have decided that this is what winning means, in this house. It is not much. It is not nothing.

The second letter, which was a month in Hermes's box before Vibia found the key, which is behind the Lares, which Thallus told me, which means Thallus has been in your father's house and knows where your father keeps the gods. I do not know what that adds to either. You will.

The goddess is fed. The cats have stopped taking it; I put the saucer higher. The flower by it is a thing the Greek woman does; she will not say for whom.

You asked who you are being looked at by. I can tell you. It is not me; I am two months behind you and reading the paid number off a sheet. It is you. You have started to be the boat. You said so, in the pen, with the four hundred and six: you did not look at the faces. That is the boat. You will have to decide whether to be it. Nicias was, for fifty-five years, and it was the only thing he had, and it was not enough, and he knew it, and he gave me a book.

Count the king's men by their caps if you must. But count the merchant too. He knows the roads. — F.

She gave it to Vibia to put in Hermes's packet north. Vibia read it, standing in the yard, with her head covered, all of it, as she read everything, and folded it, and said, "You've told him to count a Dacian. His father would say that was the first sentimental thing you've ever done." And then, putting it in her gown: "His father's wrong about a great many things. He's never once been wrong about a number and it's made him think the two are the same. Feed your mother. I'll bring the next."

◆

There was no next.

Not that winter. The war went up into the mountains and the snow came down out of them and the Danube froze, which it did, Hermes said, in a hard year, so that a man could walk across it, and in January the Dacian king and his Sarmatian horsemen did walk across it, in the dark, into Moesia, where the depots were, and burned what they found; and the news came down the Capua road in February as a list of towns, and one of them was Viminacium, and Hermes went into the strong-room and did not come out for three days, and Vibia did not come to the Dolphin. Fausta did the slate.

She did the slate. She did the Alexandrians in the window room and the Greek woman's cousin in the back and the Rhodian's two friends, who had come in July as promised and stayed into the autumn and paid the water without being asked. She did the quarter

at midsummer and the quarter at the Saturnalia and gave them to Thallus from the slate, and he took them, and did not go up, and did not say *and the rest*, and said each time at the door, with his hand on the bar, *the widow will write; it's the winter*, as if he were reminding himself of a tide. She did her mother. She did the broth and the cloths and the pot and the stair, forty times a day, up and down, until she could have done it blind and sometimes did, in the dark, when the lamp had gone out and her mother called. She did the Greek woman's mother, who came on the Ides of each month with her bag and her black-stone eyes and felt the hard thing in the side and said *not yet*, and then, in February, said nothing, and took no money, and at the door said: *the spring. If the widow writes, go. Don't wait to be let. She'll not know you've gone; by then she'll not know much. I'll see to the rest; I've done it for half this lane and I'll do it for her. She was good to my daughter when the Syrian wouldn't pay.*

And she did not cry, because she had decided; and she did not go to the mole, because she had decided that too; and she did not read the two letters again, because she had them, every word, in the place where she kept things, and reading them would only have been looking at a thing she already owned.

But she went to the yard, on the last night of March, when the house was quiet and her mother was asleep with the breathing that had changed in February and had not changed back. She stood in front of the goddess with the pink ghost of a face and the saucer she had moved higher and the Greek woman's flower, and she said — aloud; it was the first time she had ever spoken to her aloud — "The house is standing. You did that, or I did, or the slate did. I don't know who to thank and I don't think it matters to you. But she's going, and he's on a river that froze, and the widow hasn't written, and I've got one quarter left in me and then I don't know. So. If you were listening. If you've a sense of humour, the way Antiope says. This would be the time."

The goddess said nothing. She never did; that was how you knew it was her and not a man. But in the morning the Rhodian came up from the harbour at the first hour with his cap in his hand, which he never took off, and stood in the common room, and said: "There's a ship in from Ostia. Private. A lady's. The master says he's carrying a steward, an Alexandrian with a shaved head, and the steward asked on the quay for the lodging-house at the sign of the Dolphin, and when the quay told him, he said *Puteoli?* like a man who'd been saying the word to himself for a year." The Rhodian turned his cap round in his hands. "He's coming up the lane now. I thought you'd want your hair up."

She put her hair up. She put the Strabo in her gown and the two letters inside the Strabo and the slate on its nail, and she went to the door, and drew the bar, and opened it; and Phaedrus was standing in the Dolphin's lane in a grey travelling-cloak with the sulphur-smoke coming down the hill behind him and the whole lane at its doors. He looked at her — the hair, the gown that would not let down any further, the face doing nothing — and said in the Greek that sounded like water:

"She's decided she wants the egg. It took her a year and a half; it usually does. Can you be ready by the evening tide, or do you need to bury someone first?"

"I need to sit with someone," Fausta said. "Till the evening. Then I can go."

Phaedrus looked at her a moment longer. Then he nodded, once, the way the steward had on the harbour steps four years ago, ticking a thing on a list he had already made, and said: "Then sit. I'll wait at the harbour. I've waited a year and a half; I can manage till the tide," and turned, and went back down the lane with the whole of it watching, and she closed the door, and went up the stair, which creaked in the place it creaked, to the room with the window on the mole.

10

The Count

Moesia and the Danube, winter 101 to spring 102

Her letter reached him in October, in the mountains, in the rain, and it told him to count the merchant, and he did.

He went down to the pen the same evening. It was a thing he had not done since the counting; he had kept away from it as his father kept away from the Dolphin, by deciding to, and had found that a decision held in the mountains as well as it held on the coast, which was to say exactly until something arrived in a packet. The pen was below the camp in a fold of the hill with a ditch round it and a palisade and two cohorts' worth of guards who hated the duty, and in it were the four hundred and six less the thirty-one who had died of their wounds and the nineteen who had been sent down the river to be sold and the eleven whom nobody could account for and whom the quartermaster's tablets described as *escaped*, which Crescens said was a word that covered a great deal of ground in a camp. So, three hundred and forty-five. He counted them again from the gate, by habit, and got it, and then he did the thing he had not done the first time, which was look at the faces.

The merchant was by the palisade on the east side, where the smoke from the camp fires came down and there was a little warmth in it. He was perhaps fifty. He had a Greek face gone Dacian round the edges — the beard, the way he sat — and he was thinner than he had been in September and had lost the look of a man who expected to be useful; he had the other look now, the pen look, which was the look of a tally-board waiting to be reconciled. He saw the boy at the gate and did not get up.

"You're the one who counts," he said in Greek. "You came back."

"I was told to."

"By whom? Your centurion with the nose?"

"By someone on the coast of Italy who thinks you know the roads." Celer crouched by the palisade so that their eyes were level. He had not planned that; it was a thing he had learned over a chandler's and had not known he had learned. "Do you?"

The man looked at him for a long moment.

"My name is Apollonios," he said. "Of Tomis, on the Black Sea, where the Greeks have been since before your city had walls, and where I was born, and where I had a warehouse until I had one at Sarmizegetusa instead, because the king paid in gold and Tomis paid in fish. I have gone up and down the Olt and the Mureş and the passes between them for thirty years with mules. I know which fords hold in March and which do not. I know where the king's granaries are, the real ones, not the ones he lets you find. I know the names of the men who hold the passes and what each of them was promised and what each of them actually got. Yes. I know the roads." He turned his head and spat, neatly, into the mud. "I told your centurion that. He said everyone knows the roads. He is a soldier; soldiers think a road is a thing you walk on. A road is a thing you *pay* on, boy, every mile of it, to someone, and I know who. That is what I am worth. That is what you were sent to count."

Celer stayed crouched. The rain came down. Behind him the guards talked about a woman in Viminacium.

"If I take you to the quartermaster," he said, "and you're lying, it's my name on the tablet."

"Yes."

"And if I don't, you'll be sold at Viminacium in the spring with the rest for the price of a mule, and the roads go with you."

"Yes." Apollonios looked at him with something that was almost interest. "You've done this sum before."

"I've done every sum before. It's what I'm for." He stood up. His knees cracked; the rain had got into everything. "Tell me one thing I can check. One ford, one granary, one name. Something the quartermaster can send a rider to by tomorrow night. If it's there, I'll bring you up. If it's not, I never came."

The merchant thought. Then he said a name, and a place, and a number — a granary of the king's in a side-valley two days west that the maps did not show, with so many thousand modii in it and a garrison of forty under a man who had been promised land in the Banat and had got a felt cap — and Celer wrote it on his tablet in the rain with his back to the guards, and went up the hill, and gave it to Lucilius, and said nothing about where it had come from.

The rider went. The granary was there. The forty surrendered when they saw the standards, and the man with the felt cap asked, through an interpreter, whether the offer about the Banat was still open.

Lucilius sent for the boy. He was a heavy grey man with ink to the elbows who had been a clerk at Ostia with Hermes thirty years ago and owed him a thing, and he sat in his tent with the granary's figure on the table in front of him and looked at the freedman's son for a long time, and said: "Where?"

Celer told him.

"The Greek in the pen. The one who's been saying for a month that he knows the roads." Lucilius rubbed his face. "Crescens told me. I said everyone knows the roads. I say that about everyone; it's true of most of them." He looked at the figure again. "Bring him up. Put him in your tent; you've one to yourself, God knows why, and he's your find. Feed him. Get everything out of him you can before the snow, and write it down, in Latin, with the places spelled the way the maps spell them, because I'll not have the staff saying they couldn't read it. And boy." Celer waited. "If he runs, or lies, or turns out to have sent word to his king from your tent, I'll not remember whose find he was.

Your father's thing from thirty years ago covers a tent. It doesn't cover that. Understand me."

"Yes, sir."

"Good. Then go and get your Greek. And tell Crescens I said he was wrong about the roads. He'll enjoy that; he's not been wrong since Nerva."

◆

So Apollonios of Tomis lived in his tent for the winter, and taught him the roads.

It was the first thing Celer had ever learned that was not from a Laecanius. He would think about that, afterwards: that he had been taught his letters by his father's borrowed slave and his figures by his father and his Greek by a man who belonged to his patron and the city by the patron's son. That the first teacher of his life who was nobody's was a prisoner in a pen with a Greek face who owed him his life and knew it and did not, as far as Celer could ever tell, hold it against him.

The merchant talked. He talked the way a man talked who had been three months in a pen with nothing to do but rehearse what he was worth, and he talked in the Greek of the Black Sea, which had Scythian in it and Thracian and the slow vowels of the fishing towns, and Celer wrote it down in Latin with the places spelled as the maps spelled them, and the map of the kingdom in his head grew, over the winter, from a thing with mountains on it to a thing with people. The passes and who held them. The fords and when. The king's granaries, real and false, and the king's gold, which was not where anyone thought, Apollonios said, it was under a river, the king had had the river turned, and nobody who had worked on it was alive, and he knew this because he had sold the mules that carried the dead men's tools. The nobles with the felt caps, the *pileati*, and which of them had been promised what, and which were tired, and which had sons in the Roman pen, and which had sons who had been sent to Rome as hostages after Domitian's peace and had come back speaking Latin

and wanting things. And under all of it, in the way the man talked about it, a thing Celer had not expected and did not at first recognise, because he had never heard it from anyone about anywhere: the merchant loved the country. Not the king. The country. He talked about the Mureş in spring the way Crescens talked about a woman in Córdoba, and once, describing a valley above the king's city where there were apple trees that had been planted by somebody's grandfather and were still bearing, he stopped, and looked at the tent-wall, and said in the ordinary voice, *they'll cut those for the siege-works, your people, when they get there; they cut everything*, and went on with the ford.

Celer wrote it all down. He did not write that.

"You don't ask questions," Apollonios said once, in December, with the snow coming down outside and the brazier between them. "You write. I've had Romans ask me questions for three months and they ask like men hitting a wall to see if it's hollow. You just write. Why?"

"Because if I ask, you'll tell me what I asked. If I don't, you'll tell me what you know." Celer did not look up from the tablet. "It's how my father counts a warehouse. You don't ask the man in the aisle how many jars. You read his board and watch his hand."

"And what does my hand say?"

Celer looked up then. The merchant was holding out his hands to the brazier, both of them, with the fingers spread, and they were a merchant's hands, soft once, and the three months had taken the soft off them, and they shook, slightly, all the time now, which they had not in September.

"It says you're afraid of the snow," Celer said. "Not of us. Of the snow. You've started talking about the river freezing. You say it every day and you don't know you're saying it."

Apollonios took his hands back. He looked at the boy across the brazier for a long time, and then he said, quietly, in the Black Sea

Greek: "Yes. I'm afraid of the snow. Because when the river freezes the king will cross it. He's done it before. He did it under Domitian, when the Romans thought a river was a wall. He'll come across in the dark with the Roxolani, the horse-people, the ones with the scale coats, and he'll not come here, to the mountains, where the army is; he'll go where the army isn't. He'll go to the depots." He nodded toward the tent-wall, south, toward the river. "I've told your quartermaster. I told him in November. He said: the depots are garrisoned. I said: so was the granary with the forty men and the felt cap. He wrote it down. He writes everything down, your people; it's how you don't have to think." He put his hands between his knees to still them. "Write that, if you like. *The Greek says the king will cross on the ice.* Then when it happens there'll be a tablet with it on."

Celer wrote it. He put it at the top of the day's sheet, in the clear Latin, with the date; and he took the sheet to Lucilius, who read it, and sighed, and put it on a pile.

◆

The king crossed on the ice in the second week of January, in the dark, with the Roxolani, and went where the army was not.

Celer was not there. He would carry that for a long time in a particular pocket, next to the stair at the Dolphin: that the thing he had been warned of and had written down and had carried up a hill to the man whose job it was, happened eighty miles from where he was sitting with a brazier and a Greek, and that he heard of it, as he heard of everything, as a list. The news came up from the river on the fourth day by a rider who had killed two horses: the depots at the river were burned, three of them, and the fourth was holding, and the legate of the lower province was dead or taken. The Roxolani were across in strength and moving east along the bank toward the towns, and the emperor was to come down out of the mountains at once with whatever could march on ice, and Viminacium was —

"Standing," Lucilius said, when Celer got to the tent. The grey man was already in his cloak with the tablets being boxed around him. "Viminacium's standing. The new depot's gone, the one we built in the autumn on the far bank. The old one in the town's behind walls and it's holding; it was built for Domitian's war and they built it right, God rot them, it's the only thing they did." He shoved a box at a slave. "We go down tonight. All of it. The emperor's taking the Guard and the cavalry across the pass on foot in the dark, which is a thing nobody's done, and the Seventh goes behind with the baggage, and you go with the Seventh with every tablet in this tent, because when this is over the staff is going to want to know who knew what and when, and I want to be the man with the sheets." He stopped. He looked at the boy. "Your Greek."

"Sir."

"He said January. In November. It's on a sheet with the date." Lucilius's face did a thing that Celer had seen his father's do over a tally that would not reconcile. "And he's been in your tent since October with a brazier and all the roads in his head, and the king crossed exactly where the roads say the ice is thickest, and went straight to the new depot, which is not on any map the king could have had, because it was built in the autumn after the pen was full." He let that sit. "I'm not saying he did it. I'm saying that's what the sheet will look like to a man on the staff who wasn't here, and the man on the staff will want a name, and I've told you already whose name it won't be."

Celer stood in the tent with the slaves boxing the tablets round him and the snow coming in at the flap and the cold going through him that had nothing to do with the snow.

"He couldn't have," he said. "He's been in the tent. There's a guard. He's not had a word with anyone but me and the—"

"And the guards, who go into Viminacium on their days, and drink, and talk, and the women they talk to have brothers across the

river, and that's how a depot that's not on a map gets to be known on the ice." Lucilius pulled his cloak straight. "I don't say he did. I don't think he did; I think he's a frightened Greek who knows the roads and told us the truth and we were too busy writing it down to read it. But I've been a clerk forty years and I know what a sheet looks like when it wants a name on it, and that one wants his or it wants mine. Crescens is taking the pen down tonight. Ask him what he's doing with it. Then do what he says. He's a soldier; he knows what's done with a thing you can't carry."

◆

Crescens was at the pen with two centuries and torches and the snow coming down on all of it, and the three hundred and forty-five, less the winter, were being got into a column. The ones who could not walk were being got to one side, and Celer, coming down the hill with the quartermaster's words in him, saw what was being done with them before he was close enough to hear it, and stopped, and made himself go on.

"The boy who counts," Crescens said. He had a torch in one hand and nothing in the other, and the broken nose was red with cold, and his voice was the cart on gravel. "Good. Count them. The walking ones. I want a figure for the sheet and I want it from you, because the staff believes your figures and they don't believe mine." He did not look at the other side of the pen, where the ones who could not walk were, and where the sounds were. "Two hundred and ninety, I make it. Give me the real one."

Celer counted. He got two hundred and eighty-eight. He said so. Crescens nodded and said it to his optio, who wrote it, and then the centurion turned, with the torch, and looked at the boy, and said: "Your Greek."

"He's in my tent. He's — Lucilius says he's to be —"

"Lucilius says to ask me what's done with a thing you can't carry." Crescens's face did not move. "He's told you. He's told you the way

clerks tell things, by telling you where to go to be told. All right. I'll tell you straight, because I'm not a clerk and I've got two centuries in the snow. We're marching tonight across a pass on ice with the baggage and two hundred and eighty-eight prisoners who can walk and we're leaving the rest. Your Greek can walk. But your Greek's name is on a sheet that says he knew when the ice would hold, and in three weeks when the emperor's got the Roxolani back across the river and the staff sits down with the tablets, somebody is going to pick up that sheet, and the quartermaster who wrote *garrisoned* under it in November is going to need the Greek to be the reason, and the Greek will be. He'll be the reason whether he walks across the pass or not. And if he walks across it, he'll be the reason in front of the emperor, in a camp, with questions, and the questions will go to the tent he was kept in and the boy who kept him." He moved the torch. "Or he doesn't walk across it. And the sheet's got a name on it that's nobody's problem, and the quartermaster's covered and so are you, and there's one fewer Dacian who knows where the gold is. That's the sum. I've done it. Lucilius has done it. Now you do it, because he's yours, and in this army what's yours you see to."

The snow came down. Over on the other side of the pen the sounds had stopped.

"I brought him up," Celer said. His voice was steady. He noted it. "He told the truth. Every road he gave us was there. The granary was there."

"Yes."

"And you want me to—"

"I don't want anything. I want to get two centuries over a pass. I'm telling you what's done." Crescens reached into his belt and brought out a thing and held it out, and it was the knife, the ordinary one, the soldier's, that he had given the boy in April across the river and that Celer had worn ever since and had, he realised, left in the tent that morning on the table beside the brazier, next to the tablets, where

a Greek could have picked it up at any time in three months and had not. "You left this. I took it off your table when I went to look at him. He was asleep. He's still asleep, probably; he sleeps in the day now, he's frightened of the nights." The centurion put the knife in his hand and closed his fingers over it with his own, which were very cold, the way Thallus had closed them over the denarius. "You can give it to me and I'll do it and you'll have had it done for you, and you'll be a boy who had a thing done for him, and I'll know it and so will you. Or you can do it, and be a man who saw to what was his, and that'll be known too. Nobody will make you. Nobody in this army makes anyone do anything; that's not how it works, you've been here long enough to see that. They just tell you what's done. And then they watch what you do."

He stood in the snow with the knife in his hand.

He thought of his father saying *be useful; be the one in the tent*. He thought of Lucilius saying *whose name it won't be*. He thought of a girl on a step saying *count the merchant too*, and of the merchant's hands held out to the brazier, shaking, and *they'll cut those for the siege-works*, and *you don't ask questions, you write*. He thought, very clearly and from a long way off, that he was fourteen years old and that he had been sent to a war to hold a tablet and that there was a tablet, somewhere, in a box going down a hill in the snow, with a sheet in it in his own hand that said *the Greek says the king will cross on the ice*, dated. That he had written it to be safe and that it had made him the opposite, and that this was the thing his father had never told him about counting: that the figure you wrote down to cover yourself was the figure that, in the end, wanted a name.

"He's asleep," he said.

"He's asleep."

"Then he'll not—" He could not finish it. He did not need to. Crescens's face, in the torchlight, did a thing that was not kindness and was not its opposite, and the centurion said, quietly, for the first

time without the gravel in it: "No. He'll not. That's the one mercy there is in it, boy, and you'll be the one giving it, and you'll be the only one who knows you did. Go on. We march at the second watch. Be at the baggage with the tablets."

◆

"A road," said Apollonios of Tomis, by the brazier, on a night in December when the snow had stopped and the cold had come behind it and the tent-cloth was stiff as a board, "is a thing you pay on, boy. Write that down. No; don't; he's told you not to write what he hasn't said, and he's not said it, I have. Keep it in the place where you keep the rest."

Celer kept it.

"Every road the Romans have ever built, they've built so a legion can walk on it, and they tell you that, and it's true, and it's not the reason. The reason is that a road's a thing with two ends and a man at each, and everything that goes from one end to the other goes past a man in the middle with a tablet, and the man in the middle is the one who gets rich. The legion's the price of the road. The road's the price of the tablet." The Greek turned a hand over the coals. "I was born at the end of one. Tomis. Where the poet died, the one who wrote about love and was sent to the end of the world for it and wrote about that instead, and nobody read it, and he died, and the town put up a stone and spelled his name wrong. The road came to us from the south when I was a boy. Before it, we were Greeks on a beach with a wall and the Getae over it and the sea in front and we paid nobody. After it, we paid Rome. Not in blood; they didn't want our blood, we'd none to speak of. In grain, and salt, and the thing the man with the tablet called the *portorium*, which is a Latin word for *the road has two ends and you're at one*." He looked at the boy across the brazier. "Your king knows this. That's why he's a king and not a chieftain. Chieftains fight the legion. He's fighting the road. He's let them build it along the gorge and he's taken their engineers and their terms and their gold

for his army, and the whole time he's been looking at the man with the tablet in the middle, and thinking, *that's the one*. He's wrong. He'll lose. But he's wrong about the right thing, which is more than most men who lose can say."

"Who's the man with the tablet, sir? Here?"

Apollonios smiled, which he did not do often and which did not improve his face.

"Here? A Spaniard called Sura who's at the emperor's elbow and reads everything and burns nothing. And at his elbow, within the year, if I'm any judge of a boy who counts jars, you." He put his hands back toward the coals. "That's not a kindness. It's a figure. The man in the middle of the road gets rich and he gets *read*; everything that goes past him he sees, and so everything that goes past him knows he's seen it, and one night a thing goes past that would rather not have been seen, and it turns round. I'm telling you this in a tent on the Danube in December because I'm a Greek from a town that spelled a poet's name wrong and I've been the man in the middle of three roads and I've been turned round on by two of them and I'm forty-nine and I've a cough. You've the hand for it and the head and you've a thing in your column that won't balance, your face says so, and a man with a thing that won't balance is a man who'll sit in the middle of a road for forty years to avoid doing the sum. Don't. Pay the road. It's cheaper."

◆

He went up the hill. He went into the tent. The brazier was down to a glow and the Greek was asleep on the pallet by it on his side with his hands between his knees and his mouth a little open and the beard gone grey at the edges in a way it had not been in September, and he did not wake when the flap moved, because he slept in the day now; he was frightened of the nights.

Celer stood over him for a time that he did not measure, with the knife.

He would not afterwards be able to say what he thought. He would be able to say what he saw, because he had decided to look at everything and he looked: the pallet, the hands, the grey, the mouth, the sheet of the last day's roads still on the table with the Latin place-names spelled the way the maps spelled them. He would be able to say that it was not hard, in the way of the body — Crescens had shown him, once, in April, on a straw target, where, and the merchant did not wake, and it was quick, as the centurion had said, and the sound was less than he had thought and the rest was more. He would be able to say that he did not look away. He would be able to say that when it was done he stood for a moment longer and then did the thing that was in him deeper than anything, deeper than the lamp over the chandler's or the mole or the stair, which was that he went to the table and picked up the day's sheet and read it through, the last of the roads, and folded it, and put it in his tunic with the others, because it was true and had been paid for and would be wanted.

Then he wiped the knife on the pallet and put it in his belt and boxed the tablets and went down to the baggage.

He did not write to her. Not then; not in February, from Viminacium, behind the walls that had been built for Domitian's war, with the Roxolani being driven back across a river that was breaking up under them so that you could stand on the wall and watch men in scale armour go through the ice like coins into water and not come up; not in March, when the emperor came back from the eastern bank with the title of the river on him and the army cheered him in a voice that had the whole winter in it, and he tore no cloak, because there was linen now, and the men cheered that too. He did not write because she had said *count the merchant*, and he had, and she had said *I'll work out the true part*, and he had decided, on the hill in the snow with the knife, that she would not; that this was the first thing he had that would not go in a packet, not as a list and not as anything, that it would go where the thing on the mole had gone, into the column that

did not balance, and stay there. That he would carry it north and south and for the rest of his life as a man carried a knife he had been given and had not needed, which was to say every day and close to the skin and never once taken out to be looked at by anyone.

Lucilius sent for him in April, when the river was open again and the army was going back up into the mountains for the second year, and said, without preamble, holding a tablet: "The staff's read the sheets."

"Sir."

"All of them. The depot, the granary, the roads. The one from November about the ice, with the date." The grey man did not look up. "There's a note in the margin in Sura's hand. It says: *the Greek?* And under it, in the hand of the man who took the sheets up to him, who is that secretary with the ring: *died in the pen in the January withdrawal; see the centurion's count.* Two hundred and eighty-eight. Your figure." He turned the tablet over. "And under that, in Sura's hand again: *the boy who wrote the roads — send him up. L.S.*" He held it out. "You're wanted on the staff. Not Rufus's. Sura's. The man who made this emperor wants the freedman's son who counts, and I'm to send you with the sheets and a letter, and I've written the letter. It says you're honest and you're quick and you were nowhere near the pen in January, which is true, because I had you at the baggage; I made sure of it." He looked up then, finally, with the clerk's eyes that had been forty years at this. "Your father's thing from thirty years ago. You've never asked."

"No, sir."

"It was this. At Ostia, in the year Vespasian died, I made a mistake in a grain tally that would have cost a man his name, and your father, who was the junior clerk in the room and had nothing to gain, took the sheet off the pile and rewrote it in the night with the figure I should have put, and never spoke of it, and let me think for ten years he'd forgotten. That's the thing. That's what covered your tent."

Lucilius put the tablet in his hand. “I’m telling you because you’ve just done the same, in a way, for me, and I’d not have you think it was free. It wasn’t free for him and it’s not for you. He’s carried mine thirty years and I’ve carried knowing he has. Now you’ve got one of yours. Go up to Sura. Count his things. And boy—“ Celer waited. “Don’t ever write the date on a sheet you’d not want read back to you in front of the emperor. That’s the only lesson in this war, and you’ve had it, and it’s cost one Greek, which is cheap. I’ve known it cost whole cohorts.”

He went up to Sura with the sheets. The man with the ring took them from him at the door of the staff tent and looked at him, once, with the look of a man who noticed who noticed, and said, “Hermes’s boy. Yes. The roads. He’ll want you in the mornings, early; he reads before the emperor’s up. Don’t speak unless he does. Don’t write anything down that he hasn’t told you to. And don’t bring the knife into the tent; nobody carries iron near him, it’s not a rule, it’s just not done.”

Celer took the knife out of his belt and gave it to the man with the ring, who looked at it, and at him, and put it on a shelf by the door with a dozen others, and he never saw it again, and found that he did not need to. He had the weight of it. That was the thing about a denarius, his father had said, on the Capua road, in another life; you kept it, not for what it bought, but so that you would remember you had been paid.

11

The House on the Caelian

Puteoli, the sea, and the Caelian, spring and summer 102

Her mother was awake, and knew her, and that was the goddess's joke, if it was one: that the last day was a clear one.

She sat on the edge of the bed in the window room with the mole outside going out into the morning and the Alexandrians' things in the corner where they had left them, because she had not moved the Alexandrians, she had moved her mother, in March, into the best room, and had told Thallus it was so the woman could see the sea and had not told him that it was so the woman could be in the room where the steward had been, with the window, as its owner, at the end. Hilara was propped on the Alexandrians' cushions. The hard thing in her side had made the rest of her thin and the face was all cheekbone now, the Thracian ones or the Syrian ones or simply hers, and the eyes were very large in it and perfectly clear.

"The Alexandrian's come," she said.

"Phaedrus. He's at the harbour. He'll wait for the tide."

"He's a steward. They always wait. It's what they're for." Her mother's hand moved on the blanket and Fausta took it. It was hot and dry and weighed nothing. "You'll go."

"Yes."

"Good. I'd have been angry if you'd made me say it." The eyes went to the window. "The Greek woman's mother will do the rest. I've paid her. There's a thing in the box under the hearth-stone for the goddess — don't look like that, it's two asses and a bit of honey-cake, she's not expensive — and the lease and the seal and the copy of the letter I wrote the widow, and under them a thing I want you to take and not open till you're on the water." A breath. "It's not money.

There's no money. The quarters went to Thallus and the rest went to the old woman and I'm not sorry. It's a paper."

"Mama —"

"It's not *that* paper. That paper's in a box in Rome behind a lock and it'll be read out when he's dead, or burned the night before, and either way it's no use to me now and it never was. It's another one." Her mother's mouth moved; it was the not-quite-smile that Fausta had, that she had seen in the bronze and had thought was hers. "I'll tell you now, because I've the breath this morning and I'll not have it tonight. It's a thing I did the year you were born. I went to the magistrate at the basilica, the one who registers births, and I had him write you down. *Fausta, daughter of Hilara, freedwoman of Lucius Laecanius Bassus, born free in the house by the harbour on the fourth day before the Ides of May.* With witnesses. The Rhodian's father was one; he's dead. The egg-woman's husband was the other; he's not. And the magistrate sealed it, and I paid him what I'd been given in the bag for the purpose, half of it, and I've kept the copy under the hearth-stone for fourteen years and never once taken it out, because the day you take a thing like that out is the day someone asks why you thought you'd need it." The hand tightened, very slightly. "You'll need it. Not this year. One day someone in a room will say *the Puteoli woman's girl — was she born before or after?*, and they'll mean before or after I was free, and if it was before, I was a slave when I had you, and you're a slave's child, and a slave's child born in slavery is a slave, whatever the mother was after, and there are men who've made a living finding that out about freedmen's children twenty years on. I was free. I was free on the ship, by his word, the day he put me on it, in front of his steward. I wasn't free by paper till the lease. The paper under the hearth-stone says you were born to a freedwoman. It doesn't say when the freedwoman got free. It says what the magistrate was paid to say. It's the only lie I've ever put in writing and I'd do it again and you're to carry it and never once show it to anyone until the

day you have to, and on that day show it as if it were the truth, because it is, in every way that matters except one."

Fausta sat with her mother's hand in hers and the mole in the window and the lie in her, and said, after a while: "Does Thallus know?"

"Thallus knows there's a paper. He doesn't know what it says. He's never asked; he's never needed to; he's had the house and the stairs and the quarters and a woman who did what she was told, and a steward who has all that doesn't go looking for a paper that might make him have to do something about it." Hilara's eyes came back from the window. "But he'll go looking one day. Not for me. For you. When you're something, in Rome, and he's old, and wants a thing from you, and needs a hook. He'll remember there was a paper. That's when you'll need to have it where he can't put a hand on it." A breath. "Keep it in you. Not in a box. In you. Learn it by heart and then burn the copy if you must; a thing you've by heart they can't take out of a box."

"I'll not burn it."

"No. You're your mother's. You'll keep the paper and learn it too, both, and sleep with it against your skin like that Greek book you think I don't know about." The not-quite-smile. "Go on. Go down and do the slate once more so the Greek woman sees how it's kept, and then come up and sit with me till the tide, and don't talk; I've said it all and I'm tired and I'd like to look at the sea with my daughter in the room and nobody owing anybody anything. That's all I want. It's the first time I've wanted it and been able to have it. Let me."

She went down and did the slate. She came up and sat. They did not talk. The sun went across the window and the mole and the water, and the Alexandrians' things stood in the corner, and the stair creaked once, in the place it creaked, under nobody, the way old stairs do. Her mother's eyes closed and opened and closed and the breathing was the February breathing, and then the Greek woman was in the door

saying *the Alexandrian's sent up from the harbour, the tide's making*, and Fausta stood up, and bent, and put her mouth against her mother's forehead, which she had never done, and said, "Yes. And?" very low, into the hair, and Hilara's eyes opened and found her and the not-quite-smile came, the last one, and the hand on the blanket moved, toward the door, *go*, and she went.

She did not look back from the door. She had decided. She went down the stair, and out through the common room past the slate on its nail, and into the yard, where the goddess was in her niche with the saucer up high and the Greek woman's flower, and she took the two asses and the honey-cake out of the box under the hearth-stone and put them in the saucer, and the lease and the seal and the copy of the letter and the other thing in her gown with the Strabo. She stood in front of the pink ghost of a face for the time it took to breathe twice, and said nothing at all, and went out by the yard door into the lane with the whole of it watching, and down to the harbour, where a steward was waiting at the foot of a gangway in a grey cloak with the patience of a man who had been paid to have it.

Antiope was not there. Antiope did not say goodbye; it was bad luck in the trade. But at the harbour steps, where the mole met the land and the customs-house had its brazier going, there was a woman in a shawl sitting on the bollard with her back to the gangway, looking at the sea, and as Fausta went past her the woman said, without turning round, in the price-of-things voice: "A rich man who's not cruel. Ask her for me, when you get there. She's more likely to listen to you; you've the nose for it." And then: "Go on, duck. Don't make me look."

She went up the gangway. She did not make her look.

◆

Phaedrus lied to her once on the voyage, as he had said he would, and she caught it, and he was pleased.

The sea was not the sea she knew. She had known it from a mole and a stair and a window, a thing that came to the town and went away from it, and she had never once been on it, and the first morning, when the coaster cleared the mole with the whole of the Gulf opening to starboard and the hull began to do the thing a hull did, which was move in every direction a floor was not supposed to, she stood at the stern-rail with both hands on the wood and understood that the floor had gone, actually gone, and that there would not be one again for two days. She did not vomit. She had decided not to, on the mole, and it was a thing that could be decided, she found, if you kept your eyes on the one place that did not move, which was the line where the sky came down, and did not once look at the deck. The crew went by her bare-footed on the wet planks as if the planks were still. The smell was pitch and bilge and wet rope and the Gulf's own smell, which from a window had been clean and from the deck was not; and the sail above her made a noise when the wind came into it like a door slammed in a big house, every time, so that she flinched the first ten and had stopped by the twentieth. Off Misenum the swell came round the point from the open sea and the coaster put her shoulder down into it and the water came over the bow in a sheet and ran aft along the deck to her feet, cold, and went out through the ports, and the steersman beside her laughed at something, not at her, and leaned on the oar, and she looked at his forearms, which were doing a thing she could not have done, and thought: that is a skill, and I have none that would keep me alive out here for an hour.

The ship was the lady's own, a Tyrrhenian coaster with a cabin aft and a crew of eleven who had carried the lady's wine and the lady's furniture and the lady's girls up and down this coast for twenty years and were not curious about a fourteen-year-old from Puteoli in a gown that would not let down, and Phaedrus sat with her in the stern under an awning for the two days it took to raise Ostia, and talked. He talked the way Nicias had, as a man talks who has decided to teach and

does not propose to be thanked for it, and he talked about the house.

"The lady is fifty-eight. Her husband was Tertullus, who was consul under Domitian and Nerva's friend before it was safe and after, and died in the year of the Guard, in his bed, which was the only clever thing he ever did without her telling him to. She has been a widow six years. She will not marry again; she has said so, to the emperor, who asked, because the emperor likes to see women of her kind settled, and she said, *Caesar, I have been settled, and I did not care for it*, and he laughed, and nobody else did." The Alexandrian looked at the coast going by. "She goes to the Palatine twice a month. Not to the emperor; to the empress. Plotina receives perhaps a dozen women of Rome in her own rooms, and the lady is one, and has been since the entry, when she went up on the second day with a basket of figs from her Laurentine garden and said, *you'll want someone who knew the old court and isn't sorry it's gone*, and was kept. That is the whole of the lady's power and it is a great deal. There are consuls who would give a province to be in that room and they are not, and she is, with figs."

"And the son?"

Phaedrus was quiet for a moment.

"Cornelius Priscus is twenty-four," he said. "He is the lady's one failure and she knows it and it is not spoken of. He was to have been quaestor last year and was not, for reasons that cost the lady money to have forgotten. He lives in the house. He has his own wing, over the stables, and his own people, and he dines with his mother on the Kalends and the Ides and is charming on those days, because he can be, he has her gift for it and none of her use for it. The rest of the time he is in the city, or in his wing, with whatever he has brought back from the city." The steward's voice did not change. "He does not come into the lady's side of the house. That is the arrangement. It has held for three years. The girls know it. You will know it. If you see him in the lady's peristyle, which you will not, you will have seen a thing that is not supposed to happen, and you will tell me, and not the lady,

because the lady has decided not to know certain things about her son and it is my work to see that she need not."

Fausta looked at the coast. She thought about *like a man who's just realised he's allowed*. She said, "And the dwarf?"

"Momus. He's hers; he was her father's. He is sixty and the cleverest man in the house and he is treated as furniture by everyone but her, and it suits him, because furniture is not asked where it was." Phaedrus almost smiled. "Be kind to him. Not pitying. Kind. He will know the difference and so will she; it is one of the ways she tests."

"And the eleven."

"Twelve, now. She bought one in the winter, a Syrian, to annoy the others." He turned and looked at her, finally, with the Alexandrian's eyes that had been forty years in a house like that and had learned to see without appearing to. "I will tell you the truth about the girls, because nobody told me and I lost two years finding it out. They are not your rivals. They think they are. They will treat you as one, and you will let them, because a rival is a thing they know how to hate, and a thing they know how to hate is a thing they stop looking at. Your rival is not in the dormitory. Your rival is the lady's own idea of what you are for, which she has not yet formed, and which she will form from what you do in the first month. Do nothing in the first month. Pour. Read when told. Say *domina* and whatever's true. Let her form it. She forms slowly and she does not unform; once she has decided what you are, you will be it until one of you dies." He looked back at the sea. "That is the one piece of advice I have. The rest is furniture."

They were off the Circeian cape, with the mountain standing up out of the water on the left hand, when he lied.

"The lady," he said, "had your mother's letter the day the Rhodian put it in the hand. She read it, and said *the girl who watched Sura*, and put it in her box, and decided that night. The year and a half was the master. Bassus would not release you. He wrote three times that the

girl was needed on the coast, that the lodging-house could not spare her, that the mother was ill and the daughter her only support. The lady let him say it. Then in March she wrote to him that she had heard the mother was dying and that she, the lady, would be glad to take the daughter into her house as a kindness to his freedwoman's memory, and that she would mention his generosity to the empress. He wrote back the same day."

Fausta turned her head and looked at the steward, who was looking at the cape.

"No," she said.

"No?"

"She didn't decide that night. She decided in the autumn, when Thallus wrote to her that the Dolphin was making what it made when the mother was well and the girl was doing it from a slate. Thallus told me the widow would write. In May. He said he'd seen you keep the Rhodian's seal and that Alexandrians don't keep what they mean to throw away. He didn't say it like a man guessing. He said it like a man who'd been asked." She watched his face. "And Bassus didn't write three times that I was needed on the coast. Bassus has never once thought about whether I was needed anywhere. Thallus wrote, in Bassus's name, because Thallus wanted the quarters from the slate for one more year before he lost the girl who kept it. And the lady let him have the year because a girl who could keep a dying woman's house from a slate for a year was a girl worth having, and one who couldn't wasn't, and the year was the test." She looked back at the cape. "That's the one. That's your lie. You made it the master's doing to see if I'd believe a steward would do that for a master instead of for himself."

Phaedrus did not say anything for a while. The ship went on. Then he said, in the Greek like water, "Thallus wrote in October. He said: *the girl has the house in her hand and does not go up the stairs, and I have not asked her to, and I will not, and you may tell the lady that if she wants her she had better be quick, because I am a steward and not a*

saint and the quarter at the Saturnalia is a long way off." He folded his hands. "The lady read it to me. She said: *a steward who tells me he is not a saint is a steward who has thought about it. Write to him that I'll take her in the spring and that he's to keep thinking.*" He looked at her. "You've done well. Most of them get it on the second day, if at all, and they get it because I let the lie be clumsy. I didn't, with you. I was curious."

"Why?"

"Because the lady said *the girl who watched Sura*," said Phaedrus, "and the lady has said that about nobody else in nine years, and I wanted to know what she'd seen." He stood up, under the awning, and looked forward, to where the coast was flattening toward the river-mouth and the haze that was the city's. "Ostia by the evening. The Caelian by tomorrow noon. Sleep if you can. You'll not, the first month."

◆

She did not sleep the first month. She poured.

The house of Cornelia Tertulla stood on the Caelian two streets from Bassus's, in the same street of blind walls and single doors, and inside it went back and back the way they all did and was, in every particular that could be measured, the same: the atrium and the pool and the masks, the tablinum, the peristyle with its garden, the wings, the slaves' court, the kitchens, the hundred and sixty people. And it was not the same at all. She felt the difference the first hour and could not have said what it was until the third week, when she stood behind the lady's chair at the noon receiving with the jug and saw a senator — a consular, a man with a province behind him — come into the atrium and stop at the edge of the pool and wait, with his hands folded in front of him like a steward's, until the lady looked up from the letter she was reading and let him be seen; and she understood that the house of Laecanius was a house that faced the Palatine, and this one was a house that the Palatine, on two days a month, faced back.

The lady did not speak to her for nine days. On the tenth, at the noon receiving, with the atrium full and a Greek in it — a sophist from Smyrna with a voice like a lyre and a letter from the governor of Asia, who was holding forth to the lady's left on the subject of Homer's geography and getting the bay wrong — the lady reached back without turning for the cup, and Fausta filled it. The Greek said, in a Greek so beautiful it was almost unkind, *and of course Strabo tells us the mole at Dicaearchia is founded on sand, which is why the harbour has never been what the Alexandrians claim*, and the word *sand* went into her and found the place where the Strabo was and the thing she had read three times under the stairs the night a slave gave it her, and she said, in Greek, before she had decided to, quietly, to the jug: "Ash. It's founded on the ash the mountain threw. That's why it stands."

The atrium did not stop. A jug-girl had spoken; that was a thing that happened in houses, and was not heard, by anyone whose business it was not to hear. But the sophist heard, because it was his language and his error. He turned on the couch and looked at the girl behind the lady's chair with his lyre-voice stopped in his throat and an expression on his face that Fausta had seen once before, on a Spaniard, looking down a dinner-table to see who had given a figure; and the lady did not turn, and did not stop reading her letter, and said in the dry low voice that went exactly as far as she sent it: "She's right, Polemon. I've stood on it. Go on about Homer; you're better on things nobody can check."

And the sophist went on about Homer, and the receiving went on, and nothing had happened; and at noon, in the small room off the peristyle, with the door shut and Momus the dwarf on his stool in the corner being furniture, the lady Cornelia sat in her chair with her four-years-old hair and looked at the girl standing in front of her for a long time and said:

"Phaedrus told you not to let me find out you could read."

"Yes, domina."

"And not to speak. And not to do anything in the first month. He says that to all of them; it's his one virtue, he's consistent." The lady's hand moved on the arm of the chair. "You've been nine days in my house and you have poured and said nothing and looked at nobody, exactly as told, and I had begun to think the girl who watched Sura had been left on a quay in Puteoli. And then a Greek got a mole wrong and you corrected him in his own tongue in front of thirty people without raising your voice." The shoulders moved, the width of a stylus. "Well. Now I know what you are. You're a girl who can be silent for nine days and can't bear a false figure on the tenth. That's useful and it's dangerous and I shall have to decide which it's more of, and I'll take my time, because the last one I decided that about is over the stables with his own people." A pause. "Where did you read Strabo?"

"A slave gave it me, domina. A tutor. He'd stolen it from his master's library in the year Titus died."

"Bassus's Greek. Nicias. Yes; he had a good hand. He wrote to me once, you know, years ago, about a child at the back of his room. I didn't answer. I don't answer slaves; it unsettles them." The lady looked at her a moment longer. "You'll keep pouring. You'll keep silent. But on the days I go up to the Palatine — the Kalends and the Ides — you'll come, in the litter, behind, with the other two, and you'll stand in the empress's outer room with the jug and look at nobody, and when we come back you'll tell me who looked at whom, as you did in my cousin's house, except that this time if you're wrong it won't be about a senator's wife's brother; it'll be about the woman who made this emperor. She notices who notices, and she's kinder than Sura and much, much less forgiving." She reached for the cup that was not there and Fausta put it in her hand. "Go and tell Phaedrus he was right about you and I'm displeased with him for it. And Fausta." It was the first time the lady had said her name. "The

house of Laecanius had a letter this morning, from the wife of my cousin's freedman — the one from Nola, with the lip. It was for you. Phaedrus has it. I've read it. Everyone will have read it by the time it reaches you; that's a house. I'll tell you what's in it so you can have your face arranged before you open it, which is a kindness I was not shown, and it's this: your mother died on the fourth day after you sailed, in the window room, with the Rhodian's old midwife by her and the sea in the glass, and the midwife says she asked for nothing and said one thing at the end, which the woman from Nola has written down because she thought you'd want it, and it was *and?*" The lady looked at the garden on the wall. "I don't know what it means. The Nola woman didn't either. I expect you do."

Fausta stood in the small room with her face doing nothing. She felt it do nothing; she felt it from the inside, the shutter gone to, the thing her mother had wanted and had practised her in on a wall at dusk with nobody listening; and she thought that it was the second time in her life she had had a death told her as a sentence by a woman who had not turned round. That the first had been a Syrian in a doorway and *Nerva is dead*, and that she had got the shutters then, because that was the order of things, and she would get them now.

"Yes, domina," she said. "I know what it means."

"Then you'd better go and read it in private and come back for the second hour with the jug, because Zaidê is going to spill something on the Smyrna Greek before he leaves, I can see her planning it, and I want to watch her do it with someone behind me who'll not laugh." The lady did not look round. "Momus. Go with her. Sit in the door. Don't speak. She's not to be alone in a corridor in this house with a letter in her hand and that nose; there are people in it who'll want to see what her face does, and I'd rather it did it for you than them."

The dwarf got off his stool. He was a small square man with grey hair and a face like a walnut, and he came to the door and held it for her, which no one had ever done, and as she went past him he said,

very low, in a voice that had been sixty years learning to go no further than it was meant to: "I was in the room the day your mother was bought. In the old master's house, in the year Vespasian died. I was holding the lamp. She was four and she didn't cry. I thought: that one will do." He shut the door behind them. "I was right. Come on. I know a corridor nobody uses."

◆

She read the letter in the corridor nobody used, with Momus on the floor at the end of it with his back to the wall and his eyes on the other door, and it was what the lady had said, in Vibia's even hand. It had at the bottom, after *and?*, a line the lady had not mentioned, which was: *The steward came the day after and took the lease and the slate and put the Greek woman in, and stood in the yard a while before he went, in front of the shrine, and I am told he put something in the saucer, and I am told it was a coin, and I do not know what it adds to. You will.*

She folded the letter along Vibia's folds. She put it in her gown with the Strabo and the two letters and the lease and the seal and the other thing, the paper under the hearth-stone, which she had opened on the water, as told, off the Circeian cape, while Phaedrus looked at the coast, and had read once, and had by heart, and had not burned. She sat in the corridor nobody used with all of it against her skin and her face doing nothing and her hands perfectly steady in her lap, and the dwarf at the end of the corridor did not look at her, and did not speak, and after a while she said to the wall opposite, in the voice her mother used for the Rhodian's eggs:

"He put a coin in the saucer."

"Who?"

"Thallus. The steward. At the shrine in the yard. After he'd taken the lease." She looked at the wall. "I told you once — I told someone once — that he wasn't paying for the news. He was paying so you'd remember he'd paid. That's a denarius' worth of owing." Her hands did not move. "She's dead and he's put her goddess in his debt. That's

the man. That's the whole of the man."

Momus said nothing for a time. Then he said, from the floor, in the voice that went no further than it was meant to: "Or he's an old slave who held a key for thirty years and stood in a yard and didn't know what else to do with his hands. I've been that. It looks the same from a lane." He did not turn his head. "You'll find that out, in this house. That it looks the same. That's the hard part, girl. Not the ones who are cruel. The ones you can't tell."

She sat with that. The corridor was quiet. Somewhere beyond the other door the house went on being a house, a hundred and sixty people and a dwarf and a lady who faced the Palatine back, and over the stables a man with his own people who did not come into the peristyle, and she had been in it ten days, and had corrected a Greek, and had been told what she was, and had been given a corridor; and she thought about a girl of four who did not cry, and a lamp, and *that one will do*. She found that there was one thing in her that was not steady, and it was not her hands, and she let it be not steady for the time it took to breathe twice, in a corridor nobody used, with furniture at the door; and then she got the shutters.

"Second hour," she said. "The jug. The Syrian's going to spill something."

"She is. She's been planning it since the figs." Momus got up off the floor, which took him a moment. "Walk behind me. Nobody looks at what's behind a dwarf. It's the one use I've found for it, and it's taken sixty years, and I'll give it you for nothing, because the lamp was heavy that day and your mother didn't cry, and I've never forgotten either."

◆

Zaidê spilled it. A half-cup of the Chian down the Smyrna Greek's left sleeve as he rose to go, with a face of such flat Syrian stupidity that he could not even be angry at her, only at the house; and the lady watched it over her letter and did not move her mouth, and Fausta,

behind the chair, did not laugh, and that night in the dormitory over the bakehouse Zaidê came and stood over her pallet in the dark.

She was a year older than Fausta and a head shorter, with a wide flat face and black hair she wore in a plait as thick as a rope and hands that were always wet, from the jugs; she had been bought at six in Antioch and had been in the house nine years and had poured at the lady's left for the last two, and before the girl from Puteoli came she had been the one who went up the hill with the jug on the Kalends and the Ides. She did not sit. She stood with the plait over her shoulder and said, in a Latin that had come to her late and had never settled, "You spoke."

Fausta said nothing. Phaedrus had said not to, and she had done it once that day already.

"Nine days you were quiet. I thought, good, a quiet one, a nose and nothing behind it. And then you spoke, in Greek, in the atrium, to a *guest*, and she heard you, and now you'll go up the hill with the jug and I'll stay and pour for the women." The wet hands did not move. "I'm not clever. I know that. I've been in this house nine years and I've learned the one thing, which is where to stand, and you came off a boat and learned it in nine days. So." She bent, and Fausta felt the breath, which smelled of the kitchen's garlic. "I'll not touch you. I'm not a fool; they'd sell me. But everything you pour, I've carried, and everything you carry, I've washed, and you'll want to think about that before you drink from the house's cup. That's all I came to say."

She went back to her own pallet, at the far end, by the door, which was the best place because it was the coolest, and which she had had for two years because she had been the one who went up the hill.

In the morning, Fausta poured from a jug Zaidê had filled, and drank from the house's cup, in front of her, at the common table, without looking at it first, and set it down; and Zaidê watched her do it with the flat face and then went on eating, and nothing was said. But for a month after that the jug Fausta carried was always filled to

the brim so it slopped on the stairs, and the cloth she was given to wipe the lady's cup had always been used first on something, and the pallet she slept on was moved, twice, in the night, by nobody, from the wall to the draught by the hatch; and she did not go to Phaedrus, because Phaedrus had told her what a girl did who went to a steward in the first month, and she did not go to Momus, because the dwarf was the lady's and this was not. She carried the brimming jug without spilling it, which took a month of her wrists to learn, and found that by the end of the month she could carry a full cup across the atrium on a tray through thirty people without a ring of wet on the tray, which no one else in the house could do, and which the lady noticed, and said nothing about, and sent her up the hill with it.

She saw the son on the Kalends of June, at his mother's table, and he saw her see him, and that was the mistake.

He came in from the stable wing at the lamp-lighting in a dinner-tunic the colour of good wine with his hair oiled and his mother's gift for a room all over him like scent, and he kissed the lady's hand and said something that made her shoulders move the width of a stylus, which Fausta had not seen anyone but the Smyrna Greek's error do, and he took the couch at her right and was, for two hours, the most charming man Fausta had ever watched. It was a thing to see. He had Rufus's trick of being gracious to people as though he had decided to, and none of Rufus's tiredness in it; he remembered the names of the lady's girls, all twelve, and the Syrian's, who had been in the house five months, and asked Momus a question about the old master's library as though the dwarf were a man who might know, and listened to the answer. He talked to his mother about the war — Sura's staff had written; the king's granaries were being found one by one by someone who knew the roads; the emperor would have the mountains by autumn — and about the Smyrna Greek, whom he had met at the baths and thought a fraud, and about a horse. He drank very little. He looked at no one longer than was civil.

She stood behind the lady's chair with the jug and watched his hands, as she had watched Rufus's, and they were beautiful hands, long, with a ring on the left that had been his father's, and they did nothing, all evening, that a hand should not; and she thought, in the second hour, that Phaedrus had been wrong, or that the lady's one failure was a failure of some kind she had not been shown, and she began — she would remember this — to let the watching go slack, the way you let a rope go when the ship has stopped pulling.

And then the lady said, to the table, "The Puteoli girl corrected Polemon on Strabo. In front of the Asian's letter. I've not enjoyed anything so much since your father's funeral," and the son laughed, and turned his head, for the first time, to look at the girl behind his mother's chair who had done it; and she saw it.

It was exactly as Antiope had said. It was like watching a lamp lit. The face did not change — the charm was still on it, the smile, the mother's gift — but behind the face, in the eyes, which were brown and had been pleasant all evening and were pleasant now, something came on, the way the wick caught, and it was not desire, or not only; she had seen desire on the stairs every morning of her life and knew its sum. It was the other thing. It was a man looking at a thing in his mother's house and realising, pleasantly, with interest, that it was *in his mother's house*, and that his mother's house was the one place in the world where everything, in the end, was his, and that there was no one in the room who could say otherwise, and that the thing had a nose.

She saw it a breath before he did. That was the only protection there was, Antiope had said; seeing it a breath before he does. And she had it, the breath, she had the shutter half to —

— and he saw her see it. She watched him see. She watched the pleasant brown eyes register that the jug-girl behind his mother's chair had read him, in a breath, as nobody in that house had read him in three years, because nobody in that house looked at him, by

arrangement; and she watched the lamp, which had been lit with interest, go up, with something else, that she had no name for yet and would learn the name of in a corridor four years on, and that was, she thought afterwards, when it was too late to think anything else, simply this: he had never once been *seen* being what he was, and he had liked it.

He turned back to his mother. He said something about the horse. The dinner went on, and ended, and he kissed the lady's hand and went back to the stable wing with his own people, and did not look at the girl again, not once, not even the civil length; and the lady, in the small room afterwards, with Momus on his stool, said, "Well? Who looked at whom?" and Fausta said who had looked at whom, all of it, the Syrian at the son and the son at nobody and the lady at her own hands, and was right, and did not say the other thing, because the lady had decided not to know certain things about her son and it was Phaedrus's work to see that she need not; and she went and found Phaedrus, in the slaves' court, in the dark, and said it to him instead, all of it, the lamp and the breath and the seeing, in the voice her mother used for eggs.

Phaedrus listened. When it was done he was quiet for a long time, and then he said, in the Greek like water, very low: "You've been in this house a month and you've done the one thing I told you not to do, which is to make him look at you, and you did it by being good at the thing the lady keeps you for, which is the one way I couldn't have warned you against." He looked at the dark. "Three years the arrangement's held. He doesn't come into her side. He's never had a reason to. Now there's a girl on her side who's seen him, and he knows it, and he'll want to know what else she sees." A breath. "I'll not tell the lady. She'd send you back to the coast to keep the arrangement, and there's nothing on the coast now, and she'd lose the girl who watched Sura, and she'd not forgive either of us. So. You'll be on the Palatine side of every room he's in. You'll sleep in the dormitory with

the twelve and never in a corridor. You'll be behind Momus. And on the Kalends and the Ides you'll pour with your eyes on the jug and let him think the breath was luck." He turned to go, and stopped. "It wasn't luck, was it."

"No. A woman told me what to look for. On a stair. She'd had it from a man at the villa who was sorry after."

"Then she did you the one kindness there is," Phaedrus said, "and I'll do you the other, which is this. A man like that is slow. He'll want it to be his idea and he'll take years having it. You've years. Use them to become something the lady can't do without, and then when it comes — and it'll come; it always comes, with a house like this; the arrangement's a thing the lady made so she needn't watch, not a thing that stops anything — when it comes, you'll be a thing she has to choose between, and not a jug." He went into the dark. "Pour. Say nothing. You've till he's decided. It's more than most get."

12

The Terms

Dacia and Rome, summer 102 to spring 103

Sura read before the emperor was up, and Celer learned to be awake before Sura.

That was the whole of the first month on the staff: a tent at the top of the camp where the ground was driest, and a man in it at the first grey of the morning with a lamp and a pile, and a boy at the flap who was not to speak unless spoken to and was not to write anything down that he had not been told to, and who stood there, in the cold, with his hands behind his back, and watched a man who had made an emperor read.

Lucius Licinius Sura was fifty-five. He was a Spaniard from Tarraco with a face like a good knife, long and plain and kept sharp for use, and a way of sitting very still that Celer had seen before only in Thallus and in the lady Cornelia and had come to recognise as the posture of people who had arranged the world so that it came to them. He had been consul. He would be consul again; everyone knew it; he had been offered it this year and had said that the emperor needed him in the mountains and that the fasces would keep. He had, it was said in the camp, the whole of the emperor's correspondence in his head and most of the emperor's opinions, and had had them there since the Rhine, where he had, in a tent like this one, with a pile like this one, persuaded a governor of Upper Germany that an old man in Rome was about to adopt him and that he had better be the kind of man who deserved it. He did not shout. He did not, in a month, raise his voice once. He read, and set a sheet aside, or did not, and the sheets he set aside became the war.

"Hermes's boy," he said, on the eleventh morning. He did not look up. "The roads. Come here."

Celer went.

"This granary." A finger on a sheet. "The one in the side-valley, west, with the forty and the felt cap. Your Greek gave it you in October. You wrote: *the garrison was promised land in the Banat under Domitian's peace and has not received it.* Why did you write that?"

"Because he said it, sir."

"He said a great many things. You wrote this one. You didn't write that the commander was tall, or that he had a wife in the king's city, which your Greek also said, according to the centurion who went." Sura did not move. "You wrote the thing about the land. Why?"

Celer thought. He thought the way he had learned to in a warehouse aisle, which was not about the question but about what the question was for. "Because the forty surrendered when they saw the standards, sir. And asked if the offer was still open. A man who's been promised a thing and not had it is a man who's still waiting for someone to keep the promise. It doesn't matter who. I thought — I thought it was the kind of thing that would be true of more than forty."

Sura looked up then. It was the first time, and the eyes in the knife-face were not what Celer had expected; they were tired, and amused, and very old, in a way that had nothing to do with fifty-five.

"Yes," he said. "It's true of the whole kingdom. It's true of every man in a felt cap between here and the Black Sea; the king has promised them land and gold and the Roman tribute for ten years and he has given them a war, and they're tired, and they're waiting for someone to keep a promise, and it doesn't matter who." He set the sheet aside. "Lucilius said you were honest and quick and nowhere near the pen in January. He's a careful man. He didn't say you could

read. Not figures; anyone can read figures. The thing under the figures. The thing the man in the aisle leans on." He picked up the next sheet. "You'll stop standing at the flap. You'll sit there —" a stool, by the lamp — "and you'll read what I set aside, after me, and you'll tell me, each morning, one thing in it that's true of more than forty. One. If you tell me two I'll send you back to Rufus. Go on."

He sat. He read. He told Sura one thing each morning, and the war went up into the mountains for its second summer with the staff behind it, and by August the thing he had said about the felt caps was being said in the emperor's tent by the emperor. The king's nobles were coming in, one valley at a time, with their hands out, asking if the offer was still open; and nobody said *Hermes's boy* about any of it, because that was not how a staff worked, and he had not expected them to, and he found that it did not matter. He had been in the tent. That was the thing his father had said: the tent is where the war is decided. He had been in it, on a stool, with a lamp, and he had watched it be decided, and he had said one true thing a morning, and some of them had been used.

The tent he slept in was not Sura's. It was a four-man tent at the bottom of the staff's lines, by the mule-park, and there were two in it, because the staff was short that summer and the other two had gone down with the flux at Viminacium, and the other one was Aper.

Gaius Vettius Aper, of Ariminum, twenty, the second son of a man who owned the salt-pans north of the town and had bought a place on Sura's staff for him the way he would have bought a horse, by letter, through a friend of a friend of a consul, without seeing it. He had a round face and a broken nose he was proud of and hair the colour of wet straw, and the first night, when Celer came in at the fourth hour with the lamp and his hands blue and found him lying on the better pallet with his boots on, Aper looked up and said, "You're the shipowner's boy. The one Sura reads to. They say you add in your head," and before Celer had decided how a freedman's son answered

that, he had rolled over, pulled a wine-skin from under the pallet, and held it out across the tent with his arm straight. "Go on. I stole it from the tribunes' mess. It's better than it has any right to be."

Celer took it because the arm stayed out. It was the first thing anyone on the staff had held out to him. He drank, and it was good, and he handed it back, and Aper said, "Right. You take the far pallet; it's wetter but it's away from the mules, and I'd rather have the mules than the wet; I'm from a salt-pan, we don't mind stink. Tell me if I snore. I will. Hit me." And he turned over and was asleep.

That was the whole of it, and it did not stop. Aper talked. He talked in the tent at night about Ariminum and the salt and the girls of Ariminum and a horse he had lost at dice at Viminacium; he talked at the latrine; he talked across the clerks' table in the day with his stylus in the wrong hand and his tablets a disgrace, so that the senior freedman who kept the staff's day-book took the tablets away from him in the second week and gave them to Celer to copy fair, which Celer did, at night, by the lamp, while Aper lay with his boots on and told him what was in them in case he could not read the hand. Aper could not add. He said so, cheerfully, in front of the day-book man, as if it were a thing like being left-handed. He could ride, and he knew everyone's name in a week, the mule-drivers' and the tribunes' and the women who came up from the sutlers' lines. He knew which centurion's wine was drinkable and which optio would sell you a dry blanket, and by the end of the month Celer, who had never in his life had a thing he had not counted for, had a dry blanket and had not paid for it, and could not find out from Aper what it had cost.

"Nothing," Aper said. "He likes me."

"Men don't give a blanket for nothing."

"They do. You've just never had one." Aper lay back. "You think like a steward. It's not an insult; Sura thinks like a steward, it's why he's Sura. But it's a camp. People like people. It costs nothing and you get a blanket." He was quiet, for Aper, for the length of three breaths.

"My father says freedmen's sons are the best clerks in the empire and he'd not have one at his table. He says it as if it's the same sentence. I used to think it was." He yawned. "You can have my share of the wine tomorrow; I've lost it at dice already."

Celer lay on the wetter pallet away from the mules and did the sum on that and could not make it come out, and it was the first sum since the mole that had not, and he found, lying there with the lamp out and Aper snoring, that he did not mind.

He did not write to her. He told himself it was the staff: that Sura's post went through the man with the ring and the man with the ring noticed who noticed. This was true. It was not the reason, and he knew it was not, and he put the knowing in the column with the rest.

◆

The king came down out of his city in the first days of October with his nobles behind him and knelt in front of the emperor on a hillside, and Celer wrote the terms.

He had not expected to be there. He had expected to be in the tent with the pile, two miles back, where his father had said he would be, and had been content with it; it was Sura who said, the night before, without looking up, "You'll come up tomorrow. With the tablets. You'll stand behind the secretary and when the terms are read you'll write what's agreed, in your hand, as it's said. The secretary will write it in his, and afterwards we'll compare, and if they differ, yours is the one I'll read first, because you've no style and he has, and I want to know what was said before I know how it sounded." And so he had gone up, in the grey morning, with the staff, and stood on a hillside above a river with the whole of the army drawn up on the slopes below in its iron and its colours, which he had never seen all at once and had not known was so much, and watched a kingdom end.

It was cold. That was the first thing, and it stayed the whole morning under everything else: a cold off the mountains that had frost in it, the first of the year, so that the grass on the hillside was

white where the sun had not come and the breath of forty thousand men stood over the slopes like smoke off a town. They had been there since before light. He could see, from where the staff stood, the whole shape of it: the legions in their blocks down the slope to the river, the shields grounded, the standards up, the helmets making one surface that moved when the men shifted their feet against the cold, the way a field of barley moved; the auxiliaries on the flanks in their trousers and their long shields and their colours, Spaniards and Britons and Syrian archers with the bows unstrung in the cold; the cavalry out on the wings with the horses stamping and the steam coming off them; and behind, on the slope above, the engines, the catapults and the great bolt-throwers, drawn up in a line not because they would be used but because the king should see them when he came down and should count them, if he could count, and should know.

Nobody spoke. Forty thousand men and the only sound was the horses and the standards' cloth and, far down, the river, which went on about its business as a river did. A trumpet somewhere was tried and stopped. The emperor stood on the open ground in front of the staff in the plain cuirass with no cloak and his head bare and his hands at his sides, and did not move, and had not moved for an hour, and the cold did not seem to have reached him; and the staff behind him had the look of men who were trying to do the same and had less practice.

Then the gate. It was a mile away and above them, in the wall of the city on its mountain, and he saw it open before he heard the sound that went through the army, which was not a cheer and not a word but a thing the whole slope did at once, a drawing-in. Men came out of it. Small, at that distance; a line of them, on foot, coming down the road that zigzagged on the mountain's face, and it took them the whole of an hour to come, and the army watched them for the whole of the hour and the sound did not come again. They came nearer. He could see the caps, the felt caps of the nobles, and the long coats, and

the colours, which were not Roman colours, darker, the colours of a country that dyed with what grew; and then the faces, which were bearded and long and did not look at the army on either side of the road, because the road had been made to run between the legions' blocks and the king's people walked up it between two walls of iron with their eyes on the ground in front of their feet, as men walked past a thing they had decided not to see.

The king was in front. He was not tall. That was what Celer would keep, and tell nobody, because it was not a thing to tell: that the man who had beaten two Roman armies and held a mountain for twenty years and whose name had been a thing the whole empire said at dinner was a man of fifty with grey in his beard and a limp he was holding down, in a plain coat, with his cap in his hand, walking up a frosted hillside between forty thousand men who wanted him dead and had been told not to say so. He came to the open ground. He stopped. He looked, once, at the emperor, who had not moved, and the two of them stood there a moment, two men of an age, in the cold, with their breath going up; and then the king knelt, on both knees, on the white grass, and put his hands flat on the ground in front of him and his forehead down between them, and the army made the sound again, the drawing-in, and let it out, and it was the loudest thing Celer had ever heard, and it was not a word.

He had the tablet. He had the stylus. His hands were so cold he could not feel the stylus and he put it under his arm and worked his fingers against his palm until they would close, and looked up, because he had decided to look at everything, and saw the nobles behind the king, standing, with their caps in their hands, twenty of them, and counted them, because he could not help it, and saw that one of them, a young one at the end, was weeping without any sound and without moving his face at all, and looked away from that, because it was not his to see.

The emperor said a thing to the king, in Latin, short, and the interpreter said it in the other tongue, and the king answered without lifting his head. Celer did not hear it. He was too far, and the river was loud, and the breath of the army stood between. He saw the emperor's hand come up, once, palm down, and the king rise, slowly, with the limp, and stand with his cap still in his hand; and then the secretary stepped forward with the terms, and Celer put the stylus to the wax, and found that his hand was steady, which he had not expected, and that the cold had gone out of it.

The king was a big man. That was the first thing; Celer had expected, from the way the camp talked of him, something else, a creature. He was a big grey-bearded man of sixty in a felt cap and a cloak with a gold clasp, who walked up the hill between two lines of Roman iron with his nobles behind him in their caps and did not look to either side, and stopped at the distance that had been agreed, and looked at the emperor, who was standing, bare-headed, with Sura at his shoulder, and then did the thing that had been agreed, which was to go down on his knees on the wet grass and put his hands out, palm up, and lower his head, and stay there.

The army made a sound. It was not a cheer. It was the sound of forty thousand men seeing a thing they had been told they would see and finding it was true, and it went along the slopes like wind in barley and was gone.

The emperor let him kneel. Celer counted — he could not help it; it was what he was — and got to thirty before Trajan stepped forward and put a hand under the king's elbow and raised him, which had also been agreed, and said something that Celer could not hear and that the interpreter made into Dacian, and the king answered. The interpreter made it into Latin, and it was: *The king says he has been the enemy of Rome and is now its friend, and asks the emperor's clemency for his people, who have suffered.* And the emperor said — this Celer heard; the man had a voice made for hillsides — "Tell him his people

have my clemency. Tell him the terms are the terms. Tell him I'll not say it twice."

Then the secretary read the terms, and Celer wrote them.

He wrote: *The king to surrender his arms and engines of war and the makers of them. The king to raze his fortresses. The king to withdraw from all territory occupied since the peace of Domitian. The king to receive a Roman garrison in his capital. The king to surrender all Roman deserters and to receive none hereafter. The king to have the same friends and enemies as Rome. The king to send envoys to the Senate to have these terms confirmed.* He wrote it as it was said, in Latin, in the square hand, without style, and he looked up between the clauses, because he had decided to look at everything, and he saw the king's face while they were read to him in Dacian, and it did nothing. It did nothing at all. It was a face that had been arranged a long time ago to show nothing and had set that way, and Celer, watching it, thought of Thallus, and of a lodging-house, and of a man who had never frightened anyone on purpose because it was a waste, and thought: *he's not beaten. He's a steward. He's heard the terms and he's doing the sum, and the sum is how long.*

He did not write that. He wrote the terms. And when the thing was done and the king had gone back down the hill between the lines of iron with his nobles behind him and had not once looked to either side, and the army had made its sound again, and the staff had turned to go down to the tents, Sura stopped beside the boy with the tablet and said, low, in the voice he used for one true thing a morning: "Well?"

"He'll break them, sir."

"Which?"

"All of them. The arms first; he'll give up the engines and keep the makers. Then the fortresses; he'll raze the ones we can see. The deserters he'll send, because they're no use to him. The friends and enemies—" Celer stopped.

"Go on."

"He's already sent to the Parthians, sir. Apollonios said. In the winter. He said the king had a man at the Parthian court asking what Parthia would give for a war on the Danube that kept Rome's legions off the Euphrates. He said the man came back with a promise and no gold, which is what Parthians give." He kept his eyes on the tablet. "It's not in the sheets. I didn't write it. I didn't — the man was dead by the time I'd have had reason to, and it wasn't a road."

Sura was silent for a moment on the wet hillside with the army going down past them.

"No," he said. "It wasn't a road." And then: "You'll write it tonight. All of it. Everything your Greek said that wasn't a road. Every name, every promise, every man at every court. Date it the day he said it, not today, and bring it to me before the lamp's out, and I'll put it where it goes." He began to walk. "The emperor has clemency, boy. He has it for all of them, the king and the caps and the forty and the thousands; it's the thing he's best at and it's real, I've watched him have it on three frontiers and it's never once been a performance. And I have the other thing, which is what clemency needs standing behind it so that it can afford to be real. You've just told me the king will break the terms. I knew. I've known since the Rhine. What I didn't have was a dead Greek's account of the Parthian court with a date on it, and now I shall, and in three years when the king breaks the terms and the Senate asks why we were not warned, there will be a sheet." He glanced sideways. "That's what you're for. Not the roads. That. You read a man's face across a hillside and told me the sum. Keep doing it. Never do it where he can see."

◆

They came across the river in November in a line, on foot, in the rain, with their tools on their backs, the Roman engineers the king was giving up, and Celer stood on the near bank with a tablet and counted them, because the terms said a number and the terms were in his hand.

The king had agreed to give up the Roman deserters and the Roman engineers he had been paying for ten years to build him walls and engines in the Roman way. The number in the terms was the number the king's envoys had admitted to, and Celer had written it on the hillside in the square hand with the emperor's seal going on below it, and the number was one hundred and forty. They came over on the bridge of boats in a grey rain in a column with Dacian horsemen behind them who did not come onto the bridge, and a centurion of the Guard counted them off at the Roman end with a tally-stick, and Celer stood behind the centurion with the terms and counted them too, because Sura had said *you wrote the figure, see it kept*; and they were men. That was the thing he kept. He had written *one hundred and forty engineers and deserters* on a hillside as a figure, and they came over the river as men, in Dacian cloaks with Roman faces under them, some grey, some who had been boys when Domitian's war went wrong and had stayed because a king paid better than a legion and had been fifteen years building a thing they were now walking away from. They came off the bridge one by one past the centurion's stick and did not look at anyone, and one of them, near the end, old, with a mason's hands, looked at the tall boy with the terms and said in a Latin from somewhere south of Rome, "You the one who wrote it?"

"Yes."

"Then you'll know what the number was for." The old man did not stop walking. "It wasn't for us. He gave us up to buy the winter. A hundred and forty men for one winter. I built his south wall. It'll stand two years; I built it to. He knows that. He's bought the time to make it not matter." And he went past, into the Roman column, toward whatever was done with a man who had built a king's wall, which Celer did not ask and was not told.

The tally came to one hundred and thirty-eight. The centurion looked at his stick and at the boy and said, "Two short. They'll say

two died on the road. They always say that." And Celer wrote it under the terms, *one hundred and thirty-eight received, two reported dead on the road*, in the square hand, and took it to Sura, and Sura read it and said, "Good. That's a figure. Now tell me one thing." And he said, "He's bought a winter, sir. The old mason said so. The wall will stand two years and he's giving up the men who could make it stand longer because he's decided two years is all he needs." And Sura looked at him for a long moment and said, "Yes. That's what I told the emperor on the hillside and he said *I know, Lucius, I'm giving him the winter; I need it more than he does; I've a bridge to build*. You're a year behind the two of them and ten ahead of everyone else, which is the stool. Sit on it."

◆

They went down to Rome in December by the roads the army had built, and the city gave the emperor a triumph, and the name of the river, and Celer stood on the Palatine side of the Sacred Way among Sura's people in a toga that Sura's steward had found him and watched it go by, and thought about a roof on the Caelian.

He had been on the roof three years ago. He had not; she had. He had been behind Rufus with a tablet in a house on the Caelian watching Rufus's hands, and she had been on a roof watching a man walk; and now he stood at the foot of the Palatine among the staff with the whole of the city on its roofs above him, black with people, a hundred thousand faces. He looked up at them, which was a thing he had learned not to do and did anyway, and thought that somewhere in that was a face that had been on a roof three years ago, and that it was looking down, as it had looked down then, and that it could not pick him out, as he could not pick out the Dolphin from the villa wall, and that he had known this before he looked.

The triumph went by. The spoils went by on carts, the arms and the engines and the gold that had been found, which was not the king's gold, which was under a river, which the staff knew and the city

did not. The prisoners went by, in their caps, and he counted them, because he could not not, and lost the count at four hundred and did not pick it up again. The emperor went by, in the chariot, with his face painted red as the god's and a slave behind him holding the crown over his head and saying the thing the slave said, *remember you are a man*, which the city could not hear and knew was being said; and the staff cheered. Celer cheered, and found that he meant it, which surprised him, and put the surprise with the rest.

Afterwards, in Sura's house on the Aventine, which was large and plain and had no masks in its atrium because the Suras of Tarraco had not been anybody until this one, there was a letter waiting that had been waiting since May, from his father, and inside it another in his stepmother's hand, and he read them in the room he had been given, which had a window on nothing, a wall, which he took also as an instruction.

His father's said that the house was well, that the *Isis* had made the return carry at the bounty, that Felix at the grain-office had been expensive, as foreseen, and had been paid, and was no longer at the grain-office. That the man who had replaced him was a Spaniard who did not yet know what he was worth and was therefore cheap; that Bassus had been ill in the winter and was recovered; that the Spaniard son-in-law had been made quaestor; that Rufus's debts were being spoken of on the coast; and that Thallus had taken the lease of the lodging-house by the harbour on the death of the tenant and had put a Greek woman in it. *The girl went to Rome,* his father wrote, in a line by itself, *to the widow Tertulla's, on the Caelian, as her mother had arranged. I tell you so that you know, and so that you understand that she is in a consular's house two streets from the patron's and is, by that, a thing the patron's house will notice. You are on Sura's staff. I do not need to tell you what Sura's staff does not do on the Caelian. You have done well. Better than I planned. Do not spend it.*

Vibia's said that Hilara had died in the window room four days after the girl sailed, with the old Rhodian midwife by her, and had asked for nothing, and had said one thing at the end. That she, Vibia, had written it to the girl and would write it to him, because he had sat on her step and would want it, and it was *and?* And under that, in the even farm hand: *I do not know what it means. I expect you do. The Lares are fed. Chione sews. Your father goes to the tomb on the Kalends and stands, and comes back, and does not say. He has had the ship's eye gilded. I think he is proud of you in the only way he has, which is to add to a stone. Come home when you can. Not for him. For the gods, who like to see a face.*

He sat in the room with the window on the wall and the two letters on his knee and did not move for a long time.

And? He knew what it meant. He had stood in the burning fields and heard her say it to a corridor voice with the steam going up between them and had laughed until his eyes ran, and he had told her to say it to Thallus, and she had, and his mouth had moved the width of a stylus, and she had written him that. He had read it in a tent in the rain in another life with a Greek asleep by the brazier; and now the woman who had taught it her had said it to death, in a window, with the sea in the glass, and it had been written down by a farm-wife and sent north in a packet and had waited six months in a Spaniard's house for a boy who had killed a man in the snow and not written since.

He did not cry. He had not, since the chandler's stair, and had decided on the mole that he would not, and a decision held. But he sat with the letters until the lamp went down, and when it had gone down he got up and went to Sura's steward in the dark and asked whether the staff would be dining out in the spring, when the city opened again, and the steward, who was a Tarraco man and did not ask why boys wanted things, said that the staff dined where Sura dined and Sura dined where he was asked. That in the spring he was

asked everywhere, and that the Caelian was on the list, the widow Tertulla's among them, because the widow went up to the empress on the Kalends and the Ides and Sura liked to know what the empress had been told.

"Why?" the steward said then, because he was a Tarraco man but not a fool.

"My father's patron is her cousin," Celer said. "Two streets up. I'd not want to be in her house and not know the shape of it."

The steward looked at him in the dark for a moment. "You're the one who reads faces," he said. "Sura says. Read mine." And when Celer said nothing: "It says *that's not why and I don't care.* Go to bed. The spring's a long way off and the city's full of people who'd like to know what the staff wants and you've just told one of them. Learn not to."

◆

Sura dined at the widow Tertulla's on the third day before the Ides of April, with six of his people, and Celer was one, and she was in the room.

He had known she would be. He had known it the way he had known the four hundred and twenty jars and the three hundred and twelve thousand sesterces and the king's face on the hillside; he had done the sum and it came out the same three times, and he went up the Caelian in the litter behind Sura's with the sum done and his face arranged. He went in through the door with the bronze hand on it, and through the atrium with the masks, and into the dining-room with its three couches and its lamps and its painted garden, and took the place at the foot of the third couch that was a secretary's, and looked at nobody, as he had been taught; and she was behind the lady's chair with a jug, and he saw her the way you saw a thing you had been looking at for five years with your eyes shut.

She had grown. That was all, and it was not all. She was fifteen and she had the lady's house on her the way he had Sura's tent on him,

in the way of standing, the way of holding the jug, the way of being in a room and not in it; she had her hair up in the Roman way, plain, and a gown that fitted, which he had never seen her in, and her face was doing nothing, perfectly, the shutter to, and she was looking at the lady's cup. She did not look at him. He had expected that. The lady had told her once, in a small room, with the door thin, *next time, look*, and she was not looking, and he understood, in the first breath, that this was not disobedience; it was that the lady's lesson had been for a room where the two of them did not matter, and this was not that room.

The dinner began. Sura talked to the lady about the empress, and the lady talked to Sura about the Senate, and both of them told the other things that the other already knew and watched to see which things were new, and Celer, at the foot of the third couch, watched Sura's hands, as he was there to do, and did not watch the jug.

He watched the jug. He could not not. He watched it come forward to the lady's cup and go back, and come forward and go back. He watched the hand on it, which was steady, which had been a water-carrier's and was not now, and once, when the lady reached back without turning and the jug was there before the hand had finished reaching, he saw Sura's eyes go to it, for the width of a stylus, and come back; and he thought, cold, *he's counted her. He counts everything. He's counted the girl behind the widow's chair who knows where the cup will be, the way he counted my father down a table,* and he found that he did not know whether what went through him was fear for her or something else that he had no column for.

And then, in the second hour, the lady said — to Sura, in the dry low voice that went exactly as far as she sent it — "Your secretary is my cousin's freedman's boy. Hermes's. The one who found the depot. I had him in this house three years ago behind Rufus's couch with a tablet and he's come back behind yours with a better one. Puteoli breeds them, it seems. I have one of its daughters behind me now.

They were children together, in the same street. Did you know?"

Sura did not look at Celer. He looked at the lady, with the knife-face, and said, "I know what's in my own house, Tertulla. I'd not presume to know what's in yours."

"Then I'll tell you, since you've come up the hill to find out what the empress said and I'd rather give you something true than watch you guess. She's the girl who watched you. Three years ago, at the dinner for the entry, in Bassus's house, you asked who knew the fleet's figure and looked down the table to see who'd given it, and a water-girl of eleven behind my chair saw you do it and told me what you'd done and why, and I've kept her since, for that." The lady's shoulders moved. "And he's the boy who'd given it, or his father had, and you wrote his father's name in the margin of a list and he's been earning it since in a tent. So there you are. Two of Bassus's freedmen's children, in a room with the two of us, and neither of them has looked at the other once in two hours, and it's the only thing in this room anyone with eyes could see." A pause. "Boy. Look at her. Girl. Look at him. Do it now, in front of us, and get it done, so that the rest of us can eat."

He looked.

She looked.

It was across a room with lamps and three couches and the man who had made the emperor and the woman who faced the Palatine back and a dwarf on a stool and the lady's girls along the wall and a slave at his elbow with the wine; and it lasted the time it took to breathe twice. He had been told once, on a mole, in the dark, that he could not read her, and he could not read her now. Her face did nothing. It did it perfectly. It was the face she had practised on a stair and a steward and a corridor voice in a field of steam, and it had been made for exactly this, for a room full of people who noticed who noticed, and it was flawless, and he thought — in the second breath, with the whole room watching him think it — *she has become the*

thing she said on the mole she would be. The paid number. The wax. She's picked it, and she's it, and the board can say what it likes. And under that, where he kept the figure he could not find: *and she's looking at me the way she said she'd look at a Spaniard. At no cost. And it's costing her, I can see it costing her, and nobody else in this room can, and that's the only thing I've got.*

Then the lady said, "Good. That's done. Sura, the empress said this—" and the room let out its breath, and the jug went back to the cup, and he went back to the hands, and the dinner went on for another two hours and he could not afterwards have said one thing that was said in them.

In the atrium, going out, with the litters in the street and Sura already in his and the lady's people lining the walls, she was at the end of the line with the jug, by the door, because that was where the water-girl stood when the guests went. He went past her at the distance that was civil, and did not stop, and did not turn his head, and said, to the door, in a voice that went no further than it was meant to, in Greek: "Vibia wrote me."

And she said, to the jug, in the same Greek, in the voice her mother used for eggs: "Then you know what it means."

"Yes."

"Then don't write it down." And then, as he was through the door, so low he was not sure afterwards that he had heard it and not made it: "You stopped. In January. Two letters, and then you stopped. I worked out the true part. You didn't need to send it."

He went down the steps to the litter. He got in. Sura, in his, across the street, was looking at nothing, and as the bearers lifted he said, through the curtain, without turning his head, in the voice for one true thing a morning: "Well? You've looked. Tell me the sum."

Celer sat in the litter with his hands on his knees and the Caelian going by in the dark and the bronze hand on the door behind him, and he found that he had one, and that it was not the one he had done

on the way up.

"She's the widow's," he said. "All the way through. She's picked it. There's nothing in that house she doesn't see and nothing she'd tell, and the widow knows it, and that's why she's behind the chair and not in the kitchen." He looked at the curtain. "And the widow told you about her on purpose. In front of me. So that you'd count her. So that when the widow needs a thing from your office, you'll remember there's a girl on the Caelian who can read a room the way I can read a sheet, and that she's not yours."

A silence from the other litter. Then: "Yes. That's the sum." And, after a street: "She'll be on the Palatine within the year. Tertulla's grooming her for it; that's what the jug is, it's a girl learning where a cup will be before the hand that wants it knows. The empress likes that in a woman. She has it herself." The bearers' feet went on the stones. "You'll not go to that house again unless I send you. Not because of the girl. Because of the widow, who has just shown me she can make two of my people look at each other in front of me and call it a kindness, and I'd rather she did that to someone else's." A pause. "And boy. Whatever it was she said at the door, in Greek, that you think I didn't hear. Don't write it down."

"No, sir," Celer said. "I'd been told."

13

The Outer Room

The Palatine, summer and autumn 103

The empress's outer room was forty feet long and had one window and eleven women in it, and Fausta stood against the wall by the door with the jug for three hours on the Kalends of May and learned that none of the eleven was owned by the person she appeared to be owned by.

That was Marcia's sentence. She did not have it yet; she would have it in October, from a woman with a comb. But she had the thing itself by the end of the first hour, the way she had had the warehouse boards before Celer told her what they were for: she stood against the wall, and looked at the jug, and saw, at the edges of looking, the room arrange itself.

The lady Cornelia sat on a bench against the long wall with four other women of her kind, consulars' widows and wives, each with two girls behind her, and the five of them talked to each other in the dry carrying voices of women who had been in rooms like this under four emperors, and did not look at the door at the far end, which was the empress's, and had not opened. Across from them, on the other bench, sat three younger women who had not been in rooms like this under anyone, who had come up with the Spaniards — the wife of a legate, the sister of a man on Sura's staff, a Narbonese cousin of the empress's with a face like a pleasant horse — and they were quieter, and looked at the door, and their girls behind them looked at the lady's girls, and the lady's girls looked at the ceiling. In the corner by the window, alone, on a stool, with a book, sat a woman of perhaps thirty-five with a plain face and plain hair and a plain gown of very good wool, who was not talking to anyone and whom nobody was

talking to, and who turned a page every so often with a hand that had a ring on it; and Fausta had been in the room a quarter of an hour before she understood that every woman on both benches knew exactly where that woman was at every moment, the way the men on the stairs at the Dolphin had always known exactly where her mother was. That this was the empress's niece, Matidia, the emperor's sister's daughter, who had a daughter of her own married to the Spaniard with the accent and who held, by the arithmetic of the room, the whole of the future in a book.

And between the benches, moving, with a comb, was the freedwoman.

She was the only person in the room who moved. She went from woman to woman with a small ivory comb in her hand and a box at her belt and did their hair — not did it; touched it, a strand here, a pin there, the work of a breath, the kind of attention a woman gave another woman's hair when the hair was a reason to stand close and say a sentence. She was perhaps forty. She had been pretty and had decided, Fausta thought, at some point, to stop, in the way the lady had decided to keep her hair four years out of fashion; she had a round brown unremarkable face and quick hands and a way of being at a woman's shoulder before the woman had thought to want her. She was called Marcia, and she was the empress's, and had been since Nemausus, and when she came to the lady Cornelia's bench and put two fingers to a pin at the back of the lady's head, the lady said, without turning, in the voice that went exactly as far as it was sent, "Marcia. Is she well?" and the freedwoman said, "She slept, domina. She asked after your Laurentine figs," and the lady said, "She shall have them," and the fingers went away; and that, Fausta understood, had been the whole of the morning's business, and the three hours were what it cost to be in the room when it was done.

The door at the end did not open. The empress did not come out. At the third hour the freedwoman went through the door and came

back and said to the room, "The Augusta thanks you and is engaged," and the room stood, all of it, and bowed to the door, and went; and in the litter going down the hill the lady said, without preamble, "Well?"

"The Narbonese one is frightened of the legate's wife, domina. She sat where she couldn't be seen by her and looked at her the whole time. The legate's wife knows and likes it. The one from Sura's staff's family doesn't look at anyone; she's counting the room for her brother. Matidia turned nine pages in three hours and read none of them; she turned one every time the legate's wife laughed. And Marcia —"

"Yes."

"Marcia did everyone's hair except Matidia's and the Narbonese cousin's. The cousin because she's family and doesn't need it. Matidia because —" Fausta stopped.

"Go on."

"Because Matidia's hair's already done, domina. By someone else. It's done the way the empress's is in the painting in your atrium, the old way, plain. Somebody in that house does Matidia's hair the way the empress has hers, and it's not Marcia, and Marcia doesn't touch it, and I think the room knows that and I don't know what it means."

The lady was quiet for a street. Then she said, "It means that the empress has no children and her husband's niece has a daughter married to a Spaniard, and that in that house there are two women who are going to decide who sits in the chair after this man dies, and one of them does her own hair." The litter went on. "You saw that in three hours against a wall. It took me a year. I had to be told by Momus, who had it from a man who carried the empress's bath-water." The shoulders moved. "You'll go on the Ides. And every Kalends and Ides after. And you'll stand where you stood and you'll bring me the room, as you've brought it today, and in return I'll tell you a thing now that you'll want to know, and it's this: Marcia looked at you. Twice. Once when you came in and once when I asked after

the figs. She doesn't look at jug-girls. She's been forty years not looking at them; it's how she got from a hairdresser's stool in Nemausus to the only woman in Rome who goes through that door without knocking." A pause. "I don't know what she saw. I expect it was the nose. Everyone on that hill knew my cousin when he was handsome."

◆

"Sit," the lady said, in June, in the small room, which she had never said; and Fausta sat, on the stool by the window, and understood that the price was coming, and that it was not what she had expected, and that it was worse.

She had expected to be asked for the room. She had been asked for the room, and had given it, Kalends and Ides, the long wall and the short wall and the stool by the window and the comb, and the lady had taken it and said nothing, which was praise. What she had not expected was to be called into the small room off the peristyle on an ordinary afternoon with Momus on his stool and Phaedrus by the door, and to be handed a letter, folded, sealed with a seal she knew because she had grown up a street below it, and to be told: "Read that. Not aloud. Then tell me what it's for."

It was Hermes's seal. The letter was to the lady, in Hermes's clerk's Latin, and it was a letter of thanks, elaborately, for the lady's kindness to the daughter of his patron's freedwoman, and an assurance that the house of Laecanius Hermes would be glad to be of any service to the lady's house in the matter of oil, or wine, or carriage, at the lady's convenience; and folded inside it, on a separate sheet, in a different hand, a square hand, was a list, which was a copy of a manifest, the *Isis*'s, for the spring carry, with the figures to the modius.

She read it twice. She looked up.

"It's for you to know he can read me, domina," she said. "The manifest's in Celer's hand. From before the war; it's the old carry, the Nerva rate. Hermes has sent you a thing his son wrote so that you'll

know that his son is on Sura's staff and that his son's hand is a thing you can recognise. He's telling you the house has a man in Sura's tent. He's offering to be of service and showing you the kind of service he means." She put the letter down. "And he's sent it through me. Not to you. He's written *the daughter of my patron's freedwoman* so that when you want a thing from Sura's office you'll think of the girl behind your chair and the boy behind Sura's as a pair, and come to the pair through the one you own."

The lady looked at her for a long moment.

"Yes," she said. "That's what it's for. He's a clever man, your Hermes. He's never once been in a room with me and he's read me down a dinner-table across sixty couches and found the one thing I'd want from a Puteoli shipowner, which isn't oil." She reached for the cup and Fausta put it in her hand. "So. Here's the price, and I'll say it plainly, because you're the one girl in this house who can bear plainness and I'm tired of the other eleven. I'll want things from Sura's office. Not now; this year, next. Small things. Whether a letter's been read. Whether a name's on a list. The kind of thing a boy on a stool by a lamp sees and doesn't write down. And when I want them, you'll write to him — through the Nola woman, who's shown she can carry a packet past a husband — and ask, as a girl asks a boy she grew up with in a street, and he'll answer or he won't, and either way I'll know something." She drank. "That's what you're for, in the end. Not the room. The room I could get from Momus's bath-water man. You're for the hand on the other side of the city that's the same hand as yours."

Fausta stood very still.

"And if I won't, domina?"

"Then you'll pour, and go up the hill on the Kalends, and stand against the wall, and be a girl who watched Sura, and in five years you'll be one of the twelve and hate the Syrian, and that's not nothing; most of them would cut you for it." The lady's face did not change.

"But you'll not be anything else. Because the only thing you've got that the twelve haven't is a street in Puteoli, and I've just told you what it's worth, and a girl who won't spend the one thing she's got is a girl who'll be spent instead. Your mother knew that. She spent seven years of it and got a lease. You've a hand on Sura's staff. Spend it better."

The room was quiet. Momus, on his stool, was furniture. Phaedrus, by the door, was looking at the painted garden.

She thought of the mole. She thought of *I'll not spend it. Not here. Not for nothing.* She thought of a boy at the foot of the third couch who had looked at her because a woman had told him to, in front of the man who had made the emperor, and whose face had done nothing, perfectly, and under the nothing she had seen — she had seen it, she had been looking at that face since a yard and a cake — the thing that was not a sum, the figure he could not find, and she had said at the door *you didn't need to send it*, and had meant *I know what you did in January and I know you'll never tell me and I've worked out the true part and it's that you've started to be the boat*, and he had said *yes*. And now a widow was asking her to make him a thing she wrote to for lists.

"I'll write," she said. "When you want a thing. I'll ask. He'll answer or he won't." She heard her own voice, level. "But I'll tell him it's for you, domina. In the letter. Not as a girl who grew up in a street. As your girl, asking for your house. He'll know anyway. He's never once in his life not known what a letter was for. And if I pretend it's the street, he'll know that too, and he'll answer the pretending, and you'll get a tally-board. If I tell him it's you, he'll answer *you*, and you'll get a thing that's true, and he'll decide what it costs him, and that's his to decide, not mine." She took a breath. "That's the price I'll pay. The street's not for sale. The hand is."

The lady Cornelia looked at her across the small room with the four-years-old hair and the dry face, and something in the face moved

that Fausta had not seen move in a year, and could not name, and would, much later, in another room, decide had been the nearest the woman ever came to respect.

"Well," the lady said. "Well. The widow's girl has terms." She set the cup down. "Yes. All right. Tell him it's me. God knows he'll have a better opinion of us both for it." And then, as Fausta turned to go: "You've just done the thing your mother never learned. You've charged me for the water and looked at me while you did it. Don't do it again this year. Once is character. Twice is a habit, and I've a son with habits."

◆

"You. The jug. Come here and hold this." It was October, the Ides, the outer room, and the woman with the comb had not looked up, and was holding out a hairpin between two fingers toward the wall where Fausta stood.

She had not expected it. She had stood against the wall by the door for ten months of Kalends and Ides and had been looked at twice and had brought the lady the room and had not once been spoken to by anyone in it, which was correct; a jug-girl was not spoken to. But on the Ides of October the door at the end opened and did not close again — that was the first thing; the room went still — and the freedwoman came out of it with the comb and did not go to the benches. She came down the long wall to the door, where the jug-girls stood, three of them, the lady's two and the Narbonese cousin's one, and she stopped in front of the lady's second girl, who was Fausta, and lifted two fingers to a pin at the side of her head that was not loose, and said, in a low Nemausus Latin with the south in it, to the pin:

"The Augusta has a headache. She asks the lady Cornelia to go in, alone, for the length of a cup of water, and she asks that the girl who brings the water be the one who corrected the Smyrna Greek. She has heard about the mole. She was raised on a river and has opinions about what things stand on." The fingers moved the pin that was not

loose. “You’ll go in behind the lady. You’ll pour one cup. You’ll stand where I put you and look at the floor, and the Augusta will not speak to you and you will not exist, and afterwards the lady will ask you what you saw and you will tell her, as you do, everything, because the Augusta wishes the lady to know that she knows what the lady’s girl is for and does not mind.” The pin was done. “And then, next Kalends, you will stand where you stand, and I will come to you with the comb, and you will tell *me* what the lady said when you told her. Not everything. One thing. The thing that’s true of more than forty.” The round brown face did not change. “That’s the arrangement. I don’t ask whether you accept it. Nobody in this house is owned by the person they appear to be owned by, girl, and the sooner you stop appearing, the sooner you can start being.”

She went in behind the lady. She poured one cup. She stood where she was put, which was by the wall, three paces from a couch on which lay a woman of fifty in a plain gown with a cloth over her eyes and her hair done the old way, plain, by her own hand. She looked at the floor, and did not exist, and heard the lady say *Augusta* and the woman on the couch say *Tertulla, sit, don’t fuss, I’ve had this head since Nemausus and it’s never once killed me*, and heard, for the length of a cup of water, two women talk about figs and the Senate and a Spaniard’s accent and which of three men would be made consul and why, in the voices of women who had been in rooms like this together for four years and had stopped, somewhere in the second, pretending to each other; and she did not look up. She had been on a roof. She had seen the straight back and the covered head and the eyes on the road and had thought *that one is the one to watch*, and now she was three paces from her with a jug. She did not look up, because she had been told not to and because she had learned, in a corridor nobody used, that the ones you could see were the ones who could see you, and that this woman could see through a cloth.

But at the end, when the cup was empty and the lady was rising, the woman on the couch said, to the ceiling, not moving the cloth: "The girl."

"Augusta."

"Ash, or sand?"

"Ash, Augusta. The mountain's. It's why it stands."

"Yes. The Rhône's the same. Everyone thinks it's mud and it's stone underneath, from the old fires. Nemausus is built on it." The cloth did not move. "Tertulla, she's got Bassus's nose. Everyone will have told you. I'm telling you I don't care and neither should she. Half this hill has somebody's nose. It's the other thing that matters." A pause. "What's your name, girl?"

"Fausta, Augusta."

"*Lucky.*" The woman under the cloth made a sound that might, in a different woman, have been a laugh. "Your mother had a sense of humour. Or a hope. Go on. Marcia will say when I want water again."

◆

She told the lady everything, in the litter, as she did. She told Marcia one thing, on the next Kalends, with the comb at her ear, and it was that the lady had said *she'll want the figs on the Ides and she'll want to be told the Spaniard's been made praetor before Sura tells her, and I can do the first*; and Marcia's fingers moved the pin and the round face did nothing and the freedwoman said, "Good. That's true of more than forty," and went back up the long wall; and on the Ides the lady had the figs and the empress had the news before Sura, from somewhere, and nobody said anything, and it was done, and she was in it.

She was in it. She lay in the dormitory over the bakehouse with the twelve breathing round her and the Strabo and the letters and the paper under the hearth-stone against her skin and she thought about it, in the dark, with the house too big to hear. She was the lady's, all the way through; she had said so, at the door, to a boy, and had meant

it. And she was the freedwoman's, one thing a Kalends, and the freedwoman was the empress's, and the empress was the city's, and so on down, Nicias had said, and up. The only question that mattered about any of them was *by whom*; and she had been in Rome eighteen months and had three owners and a nose, and a widow's son over the stables who was slow and would want it to be his idea, and a hand on the other side of the city that was the same hand as hers and that she had agreed to write to for lists.

In August the house slept on the roofs.

Everyone did; the dormitory over the bakehouse was an oven and the lady's own rooms were not much better, and the twelve went up the ladder at the end of the slaves' court at dusk with their pallets and lay on the tiles under a sky with no colour in it, and the whole of the Caelian did the same, so that at night the hill was a thing of breathing, roof after roof, and a man talking in his sleep three houses away could be heard as if he were in the room. Fausta had the place by the parapet because she had come last to the roof the first night and it was the place nobody wanted, since the parapet was waist-high and a girl who rolled in her sleep was in the street. Zaidê had the place beside it because it was the second-worst, and because she had come second-last, having stayed below to wash the lady's cups, which was still her work, and would be.

They did not speak for a week. They lay a hand's breadth apart in the heat with the plait and the nose turned away from each other and the house breathing round them.

On the eighth night Zaidê said, to the sky, "There's figs."

Fausta said nothing.

"In the Greek's garden. The sophist's. Three houses down. They hang over his wall into the alley and his porter sleeps, and I've a boy who gets them." She did not turn her head. "You can have two. Not for anything. I've too many and they'll go."

Fausta put out her hand, in the dark, and a fig was put in it, warm from being under someone's shift, split a little on one side the way they split when they were ready, and she ate it, lying on her back on a roof on the Caelian. It was the first thing she had eaten in sixteen months that had not been given her by the house, and it tasted of the alley and of someone else's garden and of the sea-wall at Puteoli where the figs had been Antiope's.

"Who's the boy?"

"The one who stokes the baths. Syrian. From Emesa; it's not Antioch but it's near enough that we can insult each other properly." Zaidê's voice in the dark was not the voice she used in the court. It was lower and had a thing in it that was almost a laugh. "He's got arms like a mule's legs and nothing in his head and he thinks I'm beautiful. I'm not. I've a face like a dish. But he thinks it, and he's not clever enough to be lying, so." The plait moved on the tiles. "You've nobody."

"No."

"There's a boy you write to."

Fausta lay still. There was no sense in asking how; the house knew what it knew.

"Phaedrus's boy carries the sheets down the hill. He can't read. He can see a girl's face when she gives him a sheet, though; we all can." A fig was eaten, in the dark, with the sound figs made. "I don't care. I'm telling you I know so you'll know I've not told. The lady knows; she knows everything; but the others don't, the twelve, and they'd not have it from me." A pause. "Not for you. Because I'd want the same."

The house breathed. Three roofs away a child cried and was hushed. Down in the street a watchman went by with his lantern, and the light came up the wall and over the parapet and lay a moment on the two of them, the wide flat face and the nose, side by side on the tiles, and went on.

"I'll tell you one thing more and then I'll sleep," Zaidê said. "I don't go on the garden side after the fourth hour when the lady's at

the baths. Not the peristyle; not the corridor by it. I go round by the kitchens. It's longer." She turned over, with her back to the nose and the parapet. "That's not for you either. It's what I do. You can do what you like."

Fausta lay a long time looking up at the sky with no colour in it and the fig's taste in her mouth, and then she turned over too, with her back to the plait, so that they lay back to back a hand's breadth apart on a roof like two people who had agreed on something, and had not.

She had not written yet. The lady had not asked. But she had the Rhodian's papyrus, the last sheet of it, under the pallet, and she had begun, in October, after the cloth and the ash, a thing that was not a letter and that she did not intend to send and that began, in the square letters Nicias had taught her in a room over a warehouse: *What I saw. The outer room, which is forty feet long and has one window and eleven women in it and none of them owned by the one she appears to be. A woman under a cloth who asked me ash or sand and did not care about the nose. A comb.* And then, under that, after a space, because it was true and she had decided on a mole that she would not pretend about what was true, only about what it cost: *I have agreed to ask you for things. For the widow. I will tell you when it is her. When it is not her, I will not write at all, because I have nothing to say to you that is not a list, and you have nothing to say to me that is not a count, and we were both right on the mole and both wrong, and it is both. Feed the gods. Vibia says they like to see a face.*

She did not send it. She put it with the others. And in November, when the lady wanted her first thing from Sura's office — whether a letter from Bassus to the emperor about a priesthood had been read or set aside — she wrote a different sheet, four lines, without ornament, beginning *The lady Cornelia Tertulla asks*, and gave it to Phaedrus for the Nola woman, and it went; and nine days later a sheet came back by the same road, in the square hand, that said: *Set aside. Not read. Sura's*

note in the margin says: "Bassus wants a priesthood for his debts. Tell him the gods aren't lending." He has not been told. The lady may tell him or not. — C. And under that, in a smaller hand, as if added after the lamp had been trimmed: *I fed them. They liked it. Nothing else to say; you said so, and you were right, and it is both.*

She read it twice and gave the first part to the lady and kept the rest, which was hers, and was a list, and was not.

◆

The son came onto his mother's side of the house on the last day of November, in the afternoon, when the lady was at the baths with four of the twelve and the peristyle was empty, and Fausta was in it, and Momus was not.

She had been sent for a book. That was all; the lady wanted the Strabo — the lady's own, the house copy, which had never been opened — brought to the baths so that she could put the Smyrna Greek's error to a friend there with the page in front of her, and Phaedrus had sent the Puteoli girl because the Puteoli girl knew where in the fifth book the mole was, and the library was on the garden side, off the peristyle, and the peristyle was between the library and the door, and the dwarf was at the baths with the lady, holding the strigils, being furniture. It was eighteen months. She had been behind Momus for eighteen months, and on the Palatine side of every room, and had slept in the dormitory and never in a corridor, and the arrangement had held, as Phaedrus had said, because a man like that was slow and wanted it to be his idea; and she had let the rope go slack, a fraction, as you did, as she had at the dinner on the Kalends of June, and had come out of the library with the roll under her arm into the colonnade. He was standing at the far end of it by the fountain in a plain tunic with his hands behind his back looking at the water as though he had been there some time.

He had. She saw that. He had been there since the lady's litter went; he had known when it would go, and who went with it, and

who was left, and what the lady had sent for and who would be sent for it, because he was his mother's son and had her gift and had used it, this once, for the one thing in her house she had arranged not to see. He had taken eighteen months to make it his idea. He had made it, now. She could see it on him from forty feet, the way you could see a ship's draught from how she sat.

She stopped. She did not go back into the library, because a girl who went back into a room was a girl who could be followed into it, and the library had one door. She did not go forward. She stood in the colonnade with the Strabo under her arm and her face doing nothing and her hands steady, and he turned from the fountain and looked at her down the length of the peristyle and smiled, the charming one, his mother's, and said in a pleasant carrying voice: "The Puteoli girl. With a book. You're always with a book, I'm told. Come here; I want to ask you about the mole."

She thought — very fast, in the way she had learned on a stair with a slate — about what she had. She had a roll. She had a peristyle with four doors and a man between her and three of them. She had the paper under the hearth-stone against her skin, which was no use. She had eighteen months of Kalends and Ides, and a comb, and a woman under a cloth who had asked her ash or sand; and she had the lady's lesson from the small room, *two people who don't look at each other are the only two people everyone can see*, and she had, under that, the other thing, from the same room, the thing she had charged the lady for: *the street's not for sale. The hand is.*

She walked toward him. Not fast. The way a girl walked in a house she was owned in, which was as if the walk were an errand. She stopped at the distance that was civil, with the fountain between them, and looked at him — the proper look, at no cost, the Spaniard look — and said in the eggs voice:

"Domine. The lady wants the Strabo at the baths. I'm to take it. Phaedrus is waiting at the door with the boy." This last was a lie and

she said it as the magistrate had been paid to say a thing, as if it were the truth, because it was, in every way that mattered except one.

"Phaedrus can wait. He's good at it." The smile did not change. He came round the fountain. "I've a question about the mole. The real one. Not the sand. I'm told you were born under it."

"Behind it, domine. In a house by the harbour." She did not step back. A girl who stepped back was a girl who could be stepped toward. "The Augusta asked me the same, on the Ides. Ash or sand. She says the Rhône's the same; stone under mud, from the old fires. She says Nemausus is built on it." She let it sit, the name, the way you let a jar sit on a scale until the beam stopped. "Her freedwoman has asked for me on the Kalends. To do the Augusta's hair the old way, since I know how it's done on the coast. The lady's agreed. I'm to go up with the comb."

It was not true. Not yet. It was a thing Marcia had said with two fingers at a pin — *you might learn it; she likes it done by someone who was raised where it's done* — and she had put it where she kept things and had not taken it out, and she took it out now, in the colonnade, and laid it between them on the paving like the paper under the hearth-stone, and watched him read it.

He read it. She watched the lamp behind the pleasant eyes, which had been lit with interest and had gone up, on the Kalends of June, with the other thing; she watched it meet the word *Augusta* and the word *comb*, and she watched him do the sum, which was his mother's sum, which was that a jug-girl on his mother's side of the house was his mother's and his mother's was in the end his. That a girl who went through the door at the end of the outer room with a comb was *not*; she was a thing that stood three paces from a woman who could ask the emperor for a man's head with a cloth over her eyes and have it brought in by the Ides. She watched him understand that the thing in his mother's house with the nose had, in eighteen months, while he was making it his idea, made herself somebody else's; and she watched,

under the charm, which did not move, the lamp do what a lamp did when a hand was put over it.

It did not go out. That was the thing she would carry. It went down, and stayed lit, and the light that came round the edges of the hand was not interest any more, and not the other thing either, the being-seen; it was the thing a man had when he had been told the market disagreed, and had believed it, and had decided to be patient about it.

"The Augusta's hair," he said pleasantly. "Well. We're all going up in the world." He stepped aside from the fountain, and made her a small gesture toward the door, the gracious one, Rufus's. "Don't keep Phaedrus. He's old."

She went past him at the civil distance with the Strabo under her arm and did not hurry and did not look back, and at the door Phaedrus was not waiting, because she had lied, and she went out into the street with the roll and walked to the baths alone through the Caelian in the November light with her face doing nothing, and gave the lady the Strabo at the fifth book. The lady looked at her once and said nothing, and that night in the slaves' court, in the dark, she told Phaedrus, all of it, the fountain and the comb and the hand over the lamp, flat, as a manifest; and Phaedrus listened and was quiet a long time and then said:

"You told him you were the Augusta's."

"I told him Marcia had asked for me. She has. Not in those words."

"Then you'd better be, by the Kalends. Because he'll ask. Not his mother; he knows better than to ask her anything. He'll ask the Palatine, through whoever he drinks with, whether the widow Tertulla's Puteoli girl does the empress's hair, and if the answer's no, you've lied to him about the one person in Rome it's not safe to lie about, and he'll have you." The Alexandrian's voice was very low. "And if the answer's yes, you've made yourself the one thing in his

mother's house he can't put a hand on without the hand being seen from the hill. Which is the cleverest thing you could have done and the most dangerous, because a man like that doesn't forgive being made to be patient, and he's got years, and so have you, and now you're both spending them on each other."

"I know."

"Yes. You know. You always know; it's why the lady keeps you and it's why I'm afraid for you, and I've not been afraid for a girl in this house in nine years, and I don't like it." He turned to go in, and stopped. "Learn the hair. Properly. I'll find you someone from the coast in the kitchens who did it for her mother. Learn it by the Kalends, and go up with the comb, and make the lie true, because that's the only kind of lie that holds in a house like this, and your mother knew it, and so did the magistrate she paid."

She learned the hair. She went up on the Kalends with the comb. Marcia's fingers moved a pin that was not loose and the round face did nothing and the freedwoman said, "He asked. Through a man at the baths who drinks with a man of ours. I said yes. I'd have said yes anyway; you've the hands for it, and she likes the coast. But I said it a day before you'd touched her head, girl, and I'll want to know one day what that cost you, and you'll tell me, and it'll be true of more than forty." And she went through the door at the end with the comb behind the freedwoman, and stood three paces from a woman with a cloth over her eyes, and did her hair the old way, plain, as it was done on a coast built on ash, and the woman said, under the cloth, "That's it. That's how my mother had it. Tertulla's girl has found the one thing on this hill nobody else can do and it's a hairpin," and made the sound that might have been a laugh; and Fausta did not look up, and did not exist, and was, from that morning, hers.

14

How a Letter Moves

Rome, the Aventine, 104

In the year between the wars he learned how a letter moved, and it was not the way he had thought.

He had thought, in Rufus's room with the window on the Palatine, that he had learned it: hand to secretary to slave to doorkeeper to steward to master. That was how a letter moved in a house. In Sura's house it did not move at all; it arrived, and was read, and became something else, and the something else was what moved. A letter from a governor in Asia about a bridge became, by noon, a sentence in Sura's mouth at the emperor's table about the cost of stone in the East, and by the next morning a note in the emperor's hand to the treasury, and by the week's end a different governor's letter from a different province asking why his bridge had been refused; and the first letter was in a box on the Aventine with a mark in the margin in Sura's hand and nobody who was not in the room would ever know that the bridge in Bithynia had been built by a man in Asia complaining about a quarry.

"That's the whole of it," Sura said, on one of the mornings. "A letter's a thing a man sends to be read by one person. The art is to read it as the other eleven would. The governor writes to me about his quarry. I read him as the treasury would, which is as a man who wants money; as the Senate would, which is as a man who wants a province renewed; as the emperor would, which is as a man who is complaining and should be found something to do; and as his enemies would, which is as a man who has put in writing that his province cannot cut its own stone. Four readings. One letter. The governor thought he was telling me about a quarry." Sura's face did not move. "You read faces

across hillsides. Learn to read a sheet across a city. It's the same thing, slower, and nobody dies, mostly."

So he read sheets across the city. He sat on the stool by the lamp with the pile and read what Sura set aside, and told him one thing a morning, and in the afternoons he did the other work, the work that was not spoken of, which was to know where every sheet was. Sura's house held, by Celer's count in the second month, eleven thousand letters in boxes in four rooms, going back to the Rhine. The man with the ring, whose name was Philon and who had been Sura's since Tarraco, knew where every one of them was and was fifty-eight and had a cough; and Sura, who arranged the world so that it came to him, had looked at the boy who counted and the man who coughed and had said nothing, and had let Celer find his way into the four rooms, box by box, as his father had let the girl find her way into a strong-room, because he would rather the boy read his papers than anyone else's, and because a thing that was known by two men was a thing that would survive one of them.

Philon did not mind. That was the surprise. He was a small neat Greek with a ring that had been Sura's father's and he watched the freedman's son go through the boxes with the look of a man watching someone else carry a thing he had carried a long time, and in April, in the third room, with the Rhine boxes, he said, without being asked: "You'll want to know about the adoption."

Celer looked up.

"Nerva's. Of the emperor. You'll have heard it was done in Rome, on the Capitol, by an old man who'd been frightened by the Guard. It was. The sheets are here." He touched a box. "And you'll have heard that the emperor knew nothing of it till the letter came to Cologne, and wept, and said he was unworthy. The sheets for that are here too." Another box. "And in this one —" a third, smaller, with the wax on its cord unbroken in six years — "is what Sura wrote to the old man's friends in Rome in the September before, from Cologne, about what

the Guard would do in October and what the governor of Upper Germany would do about it if the old man had the sense to make it worth his while. Eleven letters. He let me seal the box. He's never opened it." The small neat face did nothing. "I'm telling you where it is because I'm fifty-eight and I cough, and because he's decided you're the one who'll know, and he'll never say so, and I'd not have you find it by accident and think it was a secret. It's not a secret. It's the thing the house is built on. Every house has one. Your father's has a stone with a small letter on it. This one has a box with the wax unbroken." He turned back to his own work. "Don't open it. Know it's there. That's what being in the tent is."

Celer did not open it. He knew it was there. He put it in the column with the depot and the Greek and the dated sheet about the ice, and he thought, that night, in the room with the window on the wall, that his father had been right about the tent and wrong about what was in it: it was not the war that was decided there. It was the question of what had happened, afterwards, when the boxes were opened, and who had sealed which.

◆

The man who came into Sura's outer room in May, in the morning, before the pile was done, had a beard, which senators did not, and an accent he was holding down with both hands, and Celer read him from the door, and did not like what the reading was for.

He was twenty-eight that year. He had been quaestor and had read the emperor's speeches to the Senate in a Baetican Latin that the Senate had laughed at, openly, in the house, and had gone away and practised, it was said, for a year, with a Greek, until the laugh stopped, and had come back and read them again; and he had been on the Danube in the first war with the Fifth Macedonica and had been given a decoration, and had been married, before the war, to the emperor's great-niece, the daughter of the woman who did her own hair, and was, by that, the only man in Rome who was in the family

and under forty, and knew it, and had the look. He was tall, and thick through the shoulder in the Spanish way, with a beard — the new beard, the one that had come in with the emperor and that he wore, Celer thought, a shade fuller than the emperor's, as if to show that his was his own — and a face that had been handsome and had decided to be interesting instead. He came into the room where Sura read without being announced, which nobody did, and sat on the end of the couch without being asked, which nobody did either, and said in Greek, "Lucius. You've got a boy on a stool. Is that the one who reads?"

Sura did not look up from the sheet. "That's the one who counts. The reading's incidental. Hadrian, this is Hermes's son, from Puteoli. He found the depot and wrote the roads and he's the reason you got your decoration, because the granary your cohort took in July was on his Greek's list. Boy, this is the emperor's great-nephew by marriage, who is going to be tribune of the plebs next year if he can stop sitting on my couch, and who reads Greek better than either of us and wants it known."

The Spaniard laughed. It was a real laugh, and a loud one, and it filled the room the way his shoulders did, and he turned on the couch and looked at the freedman's son on the stool with a pair of eyes that were grey and very quick and did not match the laugh at all. "The roads," he said. "I read the roads. In the tent at Tapae. Somebody'd written *the garrison was promised land under Domitian and has not received it* in the margin of a granary in a hand like a tally-board, and I thought: that's not a soldier, soldiers don't notice what people were promised. Was that you?"

"Yes, sir."

"How old are you?"

"Seventeen, sir."

"God. Lucius, he's seventeen. I was reading Ennius at seventeen and being laughed at." The grey eyes did not leave Celer's face. "What

was the Greek's name?"

Celer felt the room go very still around him, in the way the harbour went still before the wind changed, and he did not know why, and then he did: because the Spaniard had asked the one question that nobody on the staff had asked, in two years, about a man who was *the Greek* on every sheet and *died in the pen* in a margin, and had asked it the way Sura asked *why did you write that*, as a man hitting a wall to see if it was hollow.

"Apollonios, sir. Of Tomis."

"Of Tomis. On the Black Sea. Where Ovid was sent to die and wrote about the cold." Hadrian looked at him a moment longer with the grey eyes and the laugh gone out of his face entirely. "You remembered his name. Two years. Most of them wouldn't. Most of them would've said *the Greek* and been proud of the roads." He turned back to Sura. "Lucius, he reads. You can tell me he counts all you like. A boy who remembers the name of a dead Greek in a pen is a boy who reads, and I'd like him in my house when I'm tribune, and you'll say no, and I'll ask again when I'm praetor."

"I'll say no then too."

"Yes. You will." The Spaniard stood, which took the couch some time. At the door he stopped and said, to Celer, in a different voice, lower, in the Greek that he had practised for a year until the Senate stopped laughing: "The king's rebuilding. You'll know that; it's on the sheets. He's got the engines back from the men he was supposed to surrender and he's rebuilding the forts we razed and he's sent to the Iazyges and the Parthians and everyone else who'll take a letter, and the emperor knows, and is being clement about it, because he can afford to be, because somebody put a dated sheet in a box about the Parthian court two years ago. I read that one too." The grey eyes. "Next year, or the one after, we go back, and this time it's not terms, it's the end of it, and the staff will need a man who can write the inventory of a kingdom. Think about whose tent you want to be in

when that's written. Lucius will be in it. So will I. The emperor will be in it. And afterwards, the man who wrote the inventory will be the only one who knows what a kingdom weighed." He went out.

Sura set the sheet aside. He said, without looking up, "Well? One thing."

"He's going to be emperor, sir."

A silence. The lamp hissed.

"That's not one thing," said Sura. "That's a thing nobody in this city says aloud, and you've said it on a stool, at seventeen, to the one man who's spent six years making it possible without once writing it down." He turned the next sheet. "You're right. It's the only sum there is. The emperor has no son and a wife who likes the Spaniard and a niece who's given him her daughter and no other man under forty in the family, and the Senate hates him, and the army will take whoever's put in front of it by a man they've crossed a bridge behind. It'll be him. In ten years, in fifteen. Unless the emperor makes someone else, and he won't, because he's a soldier and he doesn't think about dying; he thinks about the Danube." The knife-face lifted, finally, and looked at the boy. "Now you know the thing the house is built on and the thing it's building. Philon told you about the box. I know he did; I told him to. So you've both ends of it. You're seventeen and you've got the adoption and the succession in your head and no stone to put either on, and that's the most dangerous thing a man can be in this city, and I've made you it on purpose, because I'd rather you were dangerous in my house than useful in his." A pause. "He'll ask for you again. He'll ask when he's praetor and when he's consul and when he's the thing he's going to be. Every time, you'll say what I say, until I'm dead, and then you'll do your own sum. That's the arrangement. It's not a kindness. It's the only way to keep a boy who reads alive long enough to be a man who knows."

◆

He struck his father in July, in a room on the Caelian, with the flat of his hand, once, and the sound it made was smaller than he had expected, and it was over a sentence.

Hermes came up on the fast post and lodged at Bassus's house on the Caelian, as a freedman of the house lodged, in the rooms by the slaves' court that were kept for the coast people, and sent to the Aventine the first evening to say that he would be at the Laecanius door at the second hour on the following day and that his son would come, if Sura could spare him, because there were things to say that were better said in the patron's house than in a Spaniard's. Sura could spare him. Sura could spare him, Celer had learned, for anything that would tell Sura something, and a shipowner from Puteoli who had put four hundred thousand sesterces into a senator's debts and his son into a tent was a thing worth sparing a morning for.

So he went up the Caelian at the second hour, past the door with the bronze hand — he did not look at it; he had decided — to the door two streets up with no hand on it, and in through the atrium with the fish and the masks, and found his father in the small room by the slaves' court where the coast people were kept, sitting on a stool with a tablet on his knee, in a tunic that was better than the ones he had worn on the coast and did not fit as well, as though he had bought it for Rome and Rome had not yet agreed to it.

They did not embrace. They had never. His father looked at him — up and down, the hull-inspecting look, the toga Sura's steward had found him and the hair and the way he stood — and said, "You've grown. Sit. You're eating; Vibia will want to know you're eating."

"I'm eating."

"Good." Hermes looked at the tablet. "Bassus is dying. Not this year. The Greek physician says two, perhaps three; it's the water, it's in his legs. He doesn't know I know; Thallus told me, because Thallus wants me to know what he knows, so that I'll know what he's worth. Rufus is praetor-designate for next year. That cost the Spaniard

son-in-law's uncle a word at the palace and me another hundred and fifty, which Rufus thinks was a loan and is not. So. The thing in the room off the peristyle, four years ago. The roll before twenty-five, on Rufus's praetorship, with his sponsorship, witnessed. He's praetor in January. You're eighteen in the autumn. I want it done by the time he's out of office. I want you on the roll, with the ring and the stripe, at nineteen, so that when the old man dies and the house goes to Rufus and Rufus's debts, you're already a thing the debts can't touch." He turned the tablet. "There's a problem. The census property qualification. Four hundred thousand, in land or its equivalent, in your name, not mine. I've the ships, but ships aren't land, and a freedman's ships in a freedman's name are a freedman's. I've been buying. In the Falernian hills, piece by piece, in your name, through a man at Capua who doesn't ask. I've three hundred and twenty. I'll have the rest by the spring if the *Isis* makes the bounty, which she will, because the new man at the grain-office is still cheap." He looked up. "That's where we are. That's thirty years. It's a year off, and I can see it from here, and I came to Rome to look at it with you in the room, because I've looked at it alone in a strong-room for long enough."

Celer sat on the other stool and looked at his father, and saw, for the first time, that the man was fifty-three, and that the hair had gone, and that the hand on the tablet had a thing in it that it had not had on the Capua road, a tremor, small, the kind the Greek's hands had had by the brazier in December.

"Yes, Father," he said.

"Don't *yes, Father* me. I'm not Bassus. Tell me what's wrong with it."

"Sura."

"Go on."

"Sura's kept me on his staff for two years on his own account. Not Rufus's. The arrangement was Rufus's staff and Rufus's sponsorship.

If Rufus sponsors me to the roll as his praetorship's gift, Sura will read it as the Laecanii buying back a man he's been paying for, and Sura reads everything four ways and one of them is as his enemies would." He kept his voice level. "He'll let it happen. He'll say nothing. And he'll put a mark in a margin, and the mark will say that Hermes's boy has two masters, and a boy with two masters is a boy who can be asked by either which one he'd choose, and I'll have been made that in front of him by my own father's census."

Hermes was quiet for a moment. Then — Celer would remember this — he smiled, the small dry one, and said: "Good. That's right. That's exactly right. Sura reads four ways and so do I, and I've read that one." He turned the tablet again. "So Rufus doesn't sponsor you. Rufus *recommends* you, as a praetor recommends a worthy young man from his father's client-house, in a letter, to the emperor's secretary for the equestrian rolls, who is a man called Titinius Capito, who was Domitian's and Nerva's and is now this man's and has survived all three by never once sponsoring anyone. And Sura, who is Capito's friend, hears of the letter from Capito, and says a word, or doesn't, and either way the roll's Sura's doing and not Rufus's, and you've one master and a ring." He set the tablet down. "I've had the letter drafted since March. I wanted to see if you'd find the hole. You did. You're your father's."

"Yes."

"And now the other thing." Hermes did not look at him. "The girl."

The room went still in the way Celer had learned.

"She's in the widow's house two streets down. She goes up the hill on the Kalends and the Ides and does the empress's hair. Thallus tells me. Thallus tells me a great many things about that girl; he's got a man in Tertulla's kitchens and he's never once in his life stopped counting a thing he's had in his hand." His father's voice was the strong-room voice, flat, a manifest. "And she writes to you. Through Vibia, who

thinks I don't know, and who I let think it, because she's a good woman and it costs me nothing. Four letters since the autumn. For the widow; she says so, at the top, *the lady Cornelia asks*, which is honest, and which Thallus's man in the kitchens has read, and which Thallus has therefore read, and which means that there's a steward on the coast who knows that Sura's secretary answers questions from the widow Tertulla through a freedwoman's bastard." He looked up. "I'm not angry. I'd have done it. I did do it; I sent the widow your manifest to show her what you were. I'm telling you that the thing's known, on the coast, and that the coast is Bassus's house, and that Bassus's house is going to be Rufus's house, and Rufus is going to be praetor, and a praetor's house that knows a thing about a man on Sura's staff is a thing Sura will one day read four ways." He paused. "Stop writing to her. Not for ever. For the year. Till the roll. A girl who does the empress's hair has gone up in the world, I grant you — she's done it the way her mother did, on her back, by a different name, and God knows I don't blame her, there's no other road for that sort — but she's a freedwoman's bastard in a widow's house and you're a year off the stripe and I'll not have the two of you on the same sheet in Thallus's hand when Capito reads the letter—"

Celer hit him.

He had not decided to. It was the ship coming about, the wind going round a point; he was on the stool and then he was standing and his open hand had gone across his father's face, hard, so that the sound of it went round the small room by the slaves' court and came back. His father's head went sideways, and the tablet went off his knee onto the floor and split, and there was a silence in which Celer heard, very clearly, a slave in the court outside stop walking.

His father put his hand to his face. He looked up at his son with the mark coming up red across the cheek and the thin hair disordered and the eyes — the eyes were the thing; they were not angry; they were doing the sum.

"Well," Hermes said. Quietly. "Well. There's that, then."

"She didn't." Celer's voice was not steady, and he noted it, and did not care. "She didn't go up on her back. She went up with a slate, in a house where her mother was dying over the stairs and a steward came twice a month, and she didn't go up the stairs, not once, Thallus will have told you that too if he told you anything. She kept the house from a slate for a year while I was in a tent writing lists, and she went to the widow's with a book under her gown and corrected a Greek on Strabo and got through the empress's door with a hairpin, and if you say *on her back* again in my hearing, Father, I'll — " He stopped. He did not know what he would. He stood in the small room with his hand stinging and his father's face marked and found that he had no end to the sentence, that he had never in his life said a sentence he did not know the end of, and that this was the first.

His father lowered the hand from his face. He bent, slowly, with the tremor, and picked up the two halves of the tablet, and looked at them, and put them together, and they did not fit, and he set them on his knee anyway.

"Sit down," he said.

Celer sat down.

"I said a thing I'd heard said. On the coast. By men who don't know her and never will, and I said it because it's what will be said in Capito's office when Thallus's sheet gets there, and I wanted you to hear it from me first, in a room, so that your face would do nothing when it was said by someone who meant it." Hermes looked at the broken tablet. "I didn't know you'd — well. I know now. That's a thing to know. A man should know what his son will hit him for." He was quiet. "I'll not say it again. Not because you struck me; because you're right, and I knew it when I said it, and said it anyway to see what you'd do, which is a thing I've done to you your whole life and will likely do till I'm ash, because it's the only way I've ever found of learning what a thing is made of. Now I know. Sit there. Breathe." A

pause. "And stop writing to her for the year. Not because of what she is. Because of what Thallus is, and what Rufus will be, and what Sura reads. You know I'm right about that. You knew it before you stood up."

Celer sat. He breathed. He knew his father was right about that, and had known it before he stood up, and he said, after a while, to the floor, "Yes, Father."

"Good." Hermes stood, with the tablet halves, with the mark on his face that would be there a week and that he would, Celer knew, explain to nobody, not Thallus, not Bassus, not Vibia, because a man who had been struck by his son in his patron's house was a man who had something, and his father never let anyone know what he had. At the door he stopped. "I'm sorry," he said, to the door, in the strong-room voice. "For the sentence. Not for the test. I'd do the test again. I'll not do the sentence." And then: "She wrote *and?* at the end of her mother. Vibia told me. I didn't understand it. Vibia said you would. I've thought about it since, in the strong-room. I think I've got it now." He went out.

◆

Philon taught him the dust in September, in the third room, with the lamp, because the archivist had decided that a boy who had seen the sealed box should know how to tell, without touching, which boxes had been opened since.

"Look. Don't touch. Never touch; a lid that's been touched is a lid that's been read, and a lid that's been read tells the next man who looks what the last man wanted." The old Greek held the lamp low along the shelf so that the light ran across the box-lids at a slant, and the dust on them stood up grey in it like frost on a field. "There. The fourth. The dust's whole. Nobody's had that lid off since Nerva's year; I'd not need the seal to tell me, the dust tells me. The seventh. See the edge, where it's thinner. Somebody's had a finger under the lid and not lifted it — tried the weight, wanted to know if it was full —

and put it down. That was Sura, in June, when the Spaniard was here, checking a thing he already knew. He does that. He thinks I don't see it. The ninth —" the lamp moved — "the ninth's been off and on and off again in a month, and the dust's been put *back*. Brushed on from the shelf with a sleeve. That's a man who knows what dust says and has tried to make it say something else, and it's the one thing in this room that frightens me, and it's why you're here."

Celer looked at the ninth. He looked at it a long time, with the lamp held where Philon held it, and saw what Philon saw, and said, "Who?"

"I don't know. That's the point. If I knew I'd have told Sura and Sura would have done the thing he does, which is nothing, with his eyes open, until the man did it again. I don't know, and so I've taught you, because you count everything and in a year you'll be able to walk down this shelf with no lamp and tell me which lids have moved, and then there'll be two of us, and a man who's brushing dust back onto a box in the third room will have to get past two pairs of eyes instead of one old Greek's." Philon straightened, with the cough, and the ring of Sura's father caught the lamp. "It's not a figure. It's a thing you'll know when you see it and can't say how, like your father with a hull. He reads a ship from the quay and knows what's in her by how she sits. You'll read a shelf. It's the same god; different altar."

He walked down the shelf that night after Philon had gone, with no lamp, by the light from the door, and did it, and got the seventh and the ninth, and missed one, the eleventh, which had been off that week by Sura's own hand for the Spaniard's letters, and knew in the morning that he had missed it because Philon told him so, with a face that was pleased, because a man who had missed one and been told was a man who would not miss it twice. He put it in the column with the rest. He did not know, that September, that the lid he would one day most need to read would be a pine box in his father's strong-room with the seal broken and the dust gone from it entirely, because a girl

of eleven had watched him lift it, and remembered.

◆

Aper came to Rome in August with the rest of the staff that had wintered on the river, and found him.

He did not send; he came up the Aventine on foot in the heat with his tunic stuck to him and his round face burnt the colour of a tile, and stood in the door of the room with the window on the wall, and looked at the room, and said, "Gods. It's a cupboard. You've been in Rome a year and a half and you're living in a cupboard in a Spaniard's house with a window on a *wall*," and then he came in and sat on the bed without asking, as he sat on everything, and said, "I need forty sesterces and I need you to come and eat something that isn't off a Spaniard's kitchen. Not in that order."

Celer gave him the forty. He had given him two hundred and ten over two years and been given back a hundred and ninety, in sums that did not match the loans, at times that did not match anything, and had stopped keeping the column in the third month because keeping it had begun to feel like a thing done against the man, and he did not want to do a thing against the man, which was itself a thing he had no column for.

They ate on the river side of the hill, in a cook-shop under the Emporium where the porters ate, standing, with the smell of the grain-barges coming in through the door, and Aper knew the woman who kept it by the end of the first cup. Her daughter by the second, and told them both that his friend here had written the terms of the king's surrender with his own hand and was being wasted on correspondence, and the woman looked at Celer with the look a woman gave a man who had been praised by another man and did not know where to put his hands, and gave them both more sausage than they had paid for.

"You see," said Aper, outside, in the dark, with his arm across Celer's shoulders because he had drunk the woman's wine as well as

his own. "That's a thing you can't add. She liked me so she liked you. Nobody did a sum."

"She'll have the forty back off you by the Kalends."

"She'll not. I'll have forgotten I owe it and she'll have forgotten she's owed and we'll both be happier." The arm tightened. "You're a hard man to be a friend to, Celer. You keep looking at me like I'm a bill you've not been given. I'm not a bill. I'm a second son from a salt-pan who'll be a tribune in a year because my father knows a man, and you'll be the best clerk Sura ever had and sit outside a door, and that's not fair and it's not my doing and I'll not pretend it isn't so, because you'd know." He stopped under the Aventine's wall and let go and stood swaying. "There. I've said the true thing. My father'd not have you at his table. I'd have you at mine. I've not got one. When I have, you'll be at it, and he can eat in the kitchen."

Celer walked him down to the lodging by the Circus where the staff's bachelors slept, and put him through the door, and stood a moment in the street afterward under a lamp that was somebody else's, and found that he was smiling, in the dark, at nothing, with nobody to see it, and went back up the hill to the cupboard, and did not put the evening in the column at all.

He did not write to her for the year.

He told himself, in the room with the window on the wall, that his father was right, which was true, and that Sura would read it four ways, which was true, and that a sheet in Thallus's hand in Capito's office with both their names on it was a thing that would cost her more than him, because he had a father buying Falernian hills in his name and she had a paper under a hearth-stone, which was true; and under all the true things, in the column that did not balance, was the other one, which was that he had struck his father for a sentence about her and had then done exactly what his father told him, in the same quarter of an hour. That this was what he was, and that he had known it since a warehouse and four hundred and twenty jars, and

that she had known it since a tutor's room, and had said *all right*, and had let him carry the number.

The widow asked for three more things that year, through Phaedrus, through Vibia, in four flat lines, *the lady Cornelia Tertulla asks*; and he answered the first two, because Sura said to — "let the widow have her small things; she's cheap at the price and one day I'll want to know what the empress said and I'll have it through her girl through you, and she'll have arranged it, and we'll both pretend otherwise" — and he answered them in four lines, in the square hand, with nothing under them, no smaller hand after the lamp was trimmed. The third he did not answer at all, because it came in September, the week his father's letter from Capua said *the last parcel's bought; it's four hundred and six, in your name, in the Falernian hills, and the vines are old and the house has a roof and I've never seen it and I'll not; it's yours*; and he sat with the widow's four lines and his father's one in his two hands on the stool by the lamp and found that he could not write anything to that house that was not either a list or the thing on the mole, and he had been told not to write the one and had decided not to spend the other, and so he wrote nothing, and put the widow's sheet in the box with the rest, and the next morning told Sura one thing that was true of more than forty, and it was about the Iazyges, and it was used.

Hadrian asked for him again in December, when the tribunate was his. Sura said no. The Spaniard laughed, and looked at the boy on the stool with the grey eyes, and said in Greek, going out, "Apollonios of Tomis. I've not forgotten either. We'll talk about him one day, you and I, when Lucius is dead and you've done your sum." And Celer sat on the stool with his face doing nothing and thought that he was eighteen, and on the roll by the spring, and had the adoption and the succession and a dead Greek and a king's gold under a river and a stone on the Capua road and a girl two streets from the bronze hand who did an empress's hair, all in him, all uncounted, and no column

that would hold any of it; and that his father had said *I think I've got it now*, about *and?*, in a doorway, and had gone out before Celer could ask him what he thought it was, and that this was the question he would most have liked to put to any man in Rome, and the one man he could put it to was the one he had struck, and he would not, and that was both.

15

The Witness

Rome, spring 105

She knew the patron was dead an hour before his cousin did, and spent the hour deciding what the hour was worth.

It was Marcia who told her, on the Kalends of February, in the outer room, with the comb. The door at the end was shut that morning; the Augusta had the head, and was not receiving, and the benches sat and talked across the room at each other in the dry voices and did not look at the door. Fausta stood by the wall with the jug and the box of pins that was hers now, and the freedwoman came down the long wall, as she did, and lifted two fingers to a pin, and said to it, in the Nemausus Latin: "Laecanius Bassus died in the night. In his bed, on the Caelian, of the water in his legs. The priests of the deified Titus were sent for at the third watch because he held their flamen's place and the place has to be filled before the Ides, and the priests' secretary sent up here at dawn because the Augusta likes to know when a priesthood's empty before the Senate starts wanting it. His own house hasn't sent to the widow yet. His son's in the house. His son's steward's in the house. They're reading the will." The fingers moved. "I'm telling you because you've his nose and you'll want your face arranged, and because the widow will have it from her own people within the hour, and I want to know what you'll do with the hour. Do what you like with it."

Fausta stood against the wall and looked at the jug.

She thought — fast, the slate way — about what the hour was. It was a thing the empress's freedwoman had given her that the empress's freedwoman had not needed to give, which meant it was a test, and the test was not whether she would tell the lady; it was *how*.

She could go to the bench now, with the box of pins, and touch a pin that was not loose at the back of the lady's four-years-old hair and say it to the pin, and the lady would have it before the room did and before her own house did. The room would see the Puteoli girl do it and would know, by the Ides, that the widow's hair-girl got things from the empress's hair-woman, which was true and which nobody yet said. Or she could stand against the wall for the hour and let the lady's man come up the hill with it and have the lady hear it in front of five women in a public voice, and the lady would have been the last on her own bench to know that her cousin was dead, and would know afterwards, from Momus, that the girl had known, and had stood.

She went to the bench. She did not hurry. She lifted two fingers to a pin and said to it, very low: "Domina. Your cousin died in the night. The priests have it; the Augusta has it; the house hasn't sent. They're reading the will. Rufus is there, and Thallus."

The lady did not move. The shoulders did not move. The dry carrying voice went on, to the consular's wife beside her, about a dinner, for the length of a sentence, and finished the sentence, and then the lady said in the same voice, not lower, so that the whole of the bench and half the other heard it: "My cousin Bassus is dead. Marcia's just had it from the priests and been kind enough to send it down the wall to me by my girl, which is more than my cousin's own son has thought to do. Fausta, you'll go down to the house with Momus and find out what's in the will before Thallus has finished improving it. I'll stay; the Augusta may want to know who she's giving the Titus priesthood to and I'd like to be in the room when she asks." A pause. "And child. You've just told the whole of this room where you get your news. On purpose, I think, since you could have whispered. Yes?"

"Yes, domina."

"Good. It's time they knew. Go on."

She went, with Momus. Going down the long wall past the door at the end, Marcia was standing by it with the comb, and did not look at her, and said to the comb as she passed: "You told her so the room would hear. That's not what I'd have done. It's what *she'd* have done, at your age, before she learned to whisper." A breath. "Which means you've read her better than I have, and I've had her since she was a bride. Go and read the will."

◆

The house of Laecanius had its door open, which it never did. The atrium had the pool covered and the masks out of their cupboards, all twelve of them, the wax faces set up on stands round the walls so that the consul under Nero and the praetor under Claudius and the rest looked down at the bier in the middle with the expression of people who had seen it done before; and on the bier, under a purple cloth, with his feet to the door and coins on his eyes and his fine white hair combed, was the man who had stood in a square of sun and said *my people*, and who had looked along a row of girls with a lamp once and stopped, and who was, by every arithmetic she had ever done on a stair or a wall or a fishing boat, her father, and whom she had never once in seventeen years spoken to.

She stood at the edge of the atrium behind Momus and looked at him. She looked at the nose. It was hers. It was more hers dead than it had been alive, because the softness had gone out of the face in the night and left the bone, and the bone was the bone she saw in the bronze; and she waited to feel the thing she had been told she would feel, by Antiope, by the eleven girls, by the poets the lady's Greek read aloud, and it was like the morning of the linen: there was nothing. There was a dead man on a bier who had put her mother on a ship. There was a face that had stopped at a row. She thought, *yes, and?*, and found that it was not defiance, this time; it was simply the sum, done, with nothing left over.

"Don't," Momus said, very low, at her elbow, not looking at her. "Don't go looking for it. I did, at my old master's. Stood by the bier for an hour waiting to feel something about the man who'd bought me at nine and I felt my feet. That's all there is for people like us. Feet." He nodded, barely, toward the tablinum. "They're in there. The son and the steward and a man from the praetor's office with the will. Walk behind me. Nobody looks at what's behind a dwarf."

They were in there. Rufus, on his father's chair, which he had never sat in and sat in now as though it had been waiting, in a dark tunic with his hair unoiled and the boxer's shoulders gone soft in four years of Rome and a look on his face that she had seen on Antiope coming down from the villa: *he's not cruel; he's a man who's been told what he's worth*. Thallus, standing, at his shoulder, where he always stood, with his hands folded and the bald head shining, reading over the praetor's man's arm. And the praetor's man, a freedman with a bad cough, unrolling, by the lamp, a thing that had been in a box behind a lock since before she was born.

She did not hear it read. She was behind a dwarf in a doorway; she heard the shape of it, the way she had heard the house at the Dolphin from under the stairs, by its silences. The estate to Rufus, entire, with the debts. The Baian villa to Rufus. The Falernian land — a bequest to the Spaniard son-in-law, which made Thallus's hands tighten on each other. A sum to the priests of Titus. Sums to the freedmen, by name, the Roman household first, in order of their usefulness, each with the degree of thanks their usefulness had earned, so that she could have told, standing in the doorway, which of them had been loved and which merely kept. The manumission of eleven slaves, by name, Eutyches at the head of them, who had been promised it for thirty years and now had it from a dead hand and would not, she thought, be grateful. And then the coast freedmen, briefly, as a list; and then —

"*To Hilara, my freedwoman, of Puteoli,*" the praetor's man read, in the cough-voice, "*the house by the harbour at the sign of the Dolphin, in which she lives, for her life, and twenty thousand sesterces, in gratitude for her long service. Should she have predeceased me, the house to revert to the estate and the sum to lapse.*" He coughed. "The steward informs me she has predeceased."

"She has," said Thallus. "Three years since."

"Then it lapses. Next: *to Nicias, my Greek*—"

And that was all. That was the paper in the box behind the lock that her mother had talked about on a wall at dusk and on the last clear morning with the sea in the glass; that was the thing that could be taken out and put in a fire by any man who held the key; and it had not been burned, it had been kept, and read out, in front of witnesses, with a praetor's man's cough, and it said *long service* and *twenty thousand* and *lapse*. Her mother had been three years in the ground with a coin in the goddess's saucer from the man who was standing at the dead man's son's shoulder with his hands folded, and the twenty thousand lapsed, and the house had a Greek woman in it, and the paper had been true all along, and it did not matter, because the one thing a paper could not do was arrive in time.

She stood in the doorway behind the dwarf and did not move. Her face did nothing. She felt her feet.

Then Thallus looked up.

He looked up from the praetor's man's arm, across the tablinum, past Rufus's chair, to the doorway, where there was a dwarf of the widow Tertulla's and, behind the dwarf, a girl with a box of pins at her belt; and his face did what it always did, which was nothing, and his eyes went still the way she had watched them go in a common room over a slate, which was go down a column feeling for the place where the hand changed; and he said, in the ordinary voice, to the room: "The widow's girl is here. The lady Cornelia will want to know what's in it. She may tell her it's what was expected." And then, to the

girl, directly, which he had never done in front of anyone of rank: "Your mother's remembered. You heard. It lapses. The master's generosity was real and his timing was his own, as it always was." The small hands did not move. "There's a thing I've never asked you, in all the years of sums. I'll ask it now, since the master's dead and the house is the young master's and I'm the young master's steward with the young master's debts to think of, and a steward with debts to think of has to count everything in the house, even the things that have gone to the Caelian. Your birth-year. Your mother gave one for the lease. Was it before the ship, or after?"

The room was quiet. Rufus, in the chair, looked up for the first time, at the girl in the doorway, with the pricing look. She watched him see the nose, and watched him do the arithmetic, which he had never had occasion to do, and watched him arrive, and watched something go across the soft handsome face that was not kindness and was not its opposite and was, she thought, simply a man discovering that his father's house had one more item in it than the will had listed.

"After, sir," she said. "By six months. It's registered at the basilica in Puteoli. With witnesses."

"Is it." Thallus inclined his head, the width of a stylus. "Good. Then there's nothing to count. I only like to know where the money's going." He turned back to the praetor's man. "Go on. The Greek. He's dead too, but the master would have wanted it read."

She went out behind the dwarf. In the atrium she passed the bier, and the nose, and the twelve wax faces, and she did not look at any of it, because she had decided, and because her feet were the only thing she could feel and she needed them for the street.

◆

Celer was in the street.

He was coming up it from the Aventine side with his toga on and Sura's steward's boy behind him, because Sura had sent a man of his house to stand at a consular's bier for the length of a cup of water,

which was the degree of attention a dead flamen of Titus with eight hundred thousand in debts earned from the man who made emperors; and the man Sura had sent was the dead man's freedman's son, because Sura read four ways and one of them was *let the Laecanii see what they sold*. He saw her come out of the door behind Momus. He stopped. She stopped. They were twenty feet apart in a street of blind walls on the Caelian in February with a dead man between them in a house and a dwarf and a steward's boy watching, and neither of them had looked at the other since a room with three couches two years ago and a door, and he had not answered the third letter.

She looked at him. The proper look. It cost nothing.

He had grown again. He had the ring — not yet; the roll was in the spring, Vibia had written; but he had the look of a man who had been told he would have it, which was a different thing from Rufus's look, because Rufus had been told what he was worth and this one had been told what he had bought — and he had something else on him that she could not name and that she would see again, years on, on other men, and would learn was what the Palatine did to a face when the face had been near it long enough: a stillness that was not Thallus's and not the lady's but was the thing both of them had been practising toward.

"The will's read," she said, across the twenty feet, in the eggs voice, so that the steward's boy would hear a servant reporting. "My mother's remembered. The house for her life and twenty thousand. It lapses."

He did not move. "Yes," he said. "It would."

"Thallus asked my birth-year. In front of Rufus."

A pause; the length of a breath. "What did you say?"

"The truth. After. Registered. With witnesses." She watched his face, which did nothing, perfectly, and she looked under the nothing, as she had at the foot of the third couch, and found — she was not sure. For the first time since a yard and a cake she looked under and

was not sure what was there; it was as if the column had been closed and the box sealed and she was looking at the wax. "You didn't answer the third."

"No."

"Your father?"

"Yes. And Sura. And the roll." He said it the way he had said *the contract's by weight*: a fact, laid between them, for her to pick up. "It's a year. He said a year."

"And after the year?"

He looked at her for a long moment, across the street, with the dead man's door open behind her and the dwarf and the steward's boy and the February light. And he said, in Greek, very low, so that it went no further than it was meant to: "After the year I'll have a ring and a stone with an *F* on it and four hundred thousand in Falernian vines I've never seen, and you'll have the Augusta's hair and the widow and the room, and Thallus will have Rufus and a question about a birth-year that he's asked once in front of a praetor's man so that it's on a sheet somewhere. That's after the year. I don't know what's after that. I've stopped — " He stopped. "I've stopped doing that sum. It doesn't come out."

She stood with the box of pins at her belt and the paper under the hearth-stone against her skin.

"No," she said. "It wouldn't." And then, because it was both, and because he had said *stopped* and she had heard what it cost: "Go and stand by the bier. Sura sent you. Stand for a cup of water and look at the nose and come away. It's all any of us can do for him." She turned to go, and turned back. "Celer. The witnesses. At the basilica. One's dead. The other's the egg-woman's husband, and he's sixty, and he drinks, and Thallus has the Dolphin. If you've a hand on the coast that's not Thallus's — "

"Vibia."

"Vibia. Tell her the egg-woman's husband is to be paid, by someone, something, every quarter, for nothing, so that when a steward comes to ask him a question he's a man with a reason to remember the answer." She heard her mother in it and let it stand. "That's not for the widow. That's for me. It's the first thing I've asked you for me since the mole. You can not answer it. You're good at that."

He did not say anything. He looked at her, and then he nodded, once, the way the steward had on the harbour steps when she was ten, ticking a thing on a list; and he went past her, at the civil distance, into the dead man's house to stand for a cup of water, and she went down the Caelian behind a dwarf, and at the bottom of the street Momus said, without turning his head, in the voice that went no further than it was meant to: "You asked him for the one thing that matters and made it sound like eggs. Your mother did that. She asked the old master for a lease and made it sound like oil." The dwarf's short legs went on. "He'll do it. He's the kind that does the thing you ask and not the thing you want, and you've just learned to ask for the right one. That's the whole of men, girl. Took me sixty years and a bath-water carrier."

◆

She needed a thing carried in April, and it was Zaidê who carried it, and Zaidê named the price.

Not to Sura's office; that went by Phaedrus's boy, under the lady's name, as it should. This was the other thing: two lines, in her own hand, to a Rhodian's shop by the Tiber wharves, which the lady did not know about and must not, and which Fausta could not take herself because the Augusta's hair-girl, which she was now on the Kalends and the Ides, did not go to the Tiber wharves. She stood in the slaves' court at the wash-trough where Zaidê had her arms in the lady's linen to the elbow and said it, low, and Zaidê did not stop wringing.

"The wharves."

"The Rhodian's. Under the sign of the ship. He'll know the hand."

"And I go on my half-day, which is tomorrow, which I was going to spend on my back with a man from Emesa, and I walk to the river and back, which is an hour each way, and I hand a paper to a Greek, and I don't ask what's in it." The linen went into the trough and came out. "What do I get."

Fausta had the figure ready. She had done it in the night. "Six sesterces."

"No."

"Eight."

"No." Zaidê wrung the shift and shook it out and hung it over the line and turned, with her wet arms, and the flat face had nothing on it at all, which was its strength. "You go up the hill now. You do the Augusta's hair. You come back down with your face shut and the twelve look at you the way they'd look at a priest. I don't want your sesterces; I can get sesterces off the stoker. I want the Ides."

"The Ides?"

"The next one you go up. I come. With the jug, behind, as I used to. I stand in the outer room with the women and I pour nothing and I look at nobody and I see it. Once." The arms folded. "I was two years going up that hill before you came and I never once got past the outer room and I'd like to stand in it once more as the girl who goes with the Augusta's hair and not as the girl who washes her cups. That's the price. It's not money. You'll understand that; you're the one who understands that."

Fausta looked at her. Nine years in the house, and the one thing learned, which was where to stand; and she had learned it well enough to know that this, too, was a place to stand, and to want it, for one morning, for nothing that could be sold afterward.

"The Ides," she said. "Behind. With the jug."

"Done." Zaidê turned back to the trough. "Give me the paper. Not here; the hatch, tonight. And girl." She did not look round. "If the Greek's not under the sign of the ship I'm not walking the wharves looking. I'll bring it back and you'll owe me the Ides anyway."

The Rhodian was under the sign of the ship. The two lines went where they were going. And on the Ides of May Zaidê went up the hill in the litter's dust with the jug on her hip, behind the Augusta's hair-girl, and stood in the outer room among the twenty women who waited and poured nothing and looked at nobody for two hours with the flat face doing what it did, and came down again, and said not one word about it, then or ever. That night at the common table she put the heel of the loaf on Fausta's side without looking, which was a thing she had never done, and did not do again.

Phaedrus taught her the hand in May, in the steward's room, at the table where he kept the house's book, because the lady had said *the child writes like a lodging-house and I'll not have a lodging-house writing to Sura's office under my name*.

"Not your mother's. Your mother's is a good hand for a slate; it's fast and it's true and it looks like a woman who's been owed money. That's not what a consul's widow's letters look like." The Alexandrian laid a sheet in front of her and a reed and sat on the other side of the table with his own, and wrote, slowly, so she could see the reed go, *the lady Cornelia Tertulla asks*, in a Latin that had no haste in it anywhere and no ornament either, the letters upright and even and spaced as if each had been paid for separately. "That. The lady's house has written like that since her father, because her father had a Greek who'd been a copyist in Pergamum and the Greek taught the lady and the lady taught me and I'm teaching you, and in thirty years you'll teach someone, and the hand will go on after all of us, which is what a hand's for." He turned the sheet. "Again. Slower. You're making the *a* as if it owed you a quarter's rent."

She made the *a* again. It took a month. She wrote the lady's Latin in the steward's room every afternoon the lady rested, until the reed went where the hand wanted without her watching it, and she found, somewhere in the third week, that the hand had changed the Latin as well; that a thing written slowly in letters that had each been paid for came out as a different sentence from the same thing on a slate, not because the words moved but because the hand would not let her hurry past what they cost. She wrote *the lady asks* and it meant *the lady asks*; and underneath, in the same hand, when the lady's request was done, she found that she could write a line of her own that said what the asking was for, in the lady's letters, and that the letters made the line a thing a man on a stool across the city would have to read slowly too.

"There," said Phaedrus, on the last day, looking at a sheet. "That's the house. That's thirty years of not declaring anything, in a hand. Nobody reading that will know a lodging-house girl wrote it." He put it down. "And Fausta. The line at the foot. The one that's yours. Keep it to one, two at most. A line in that hand under the lady's request is a thing a man will read twice, because it costs him something to read it at the pace the hand insists on, and a man who's read a line twice has been *told* something, whether or not you meant to tell him. You'll mean to. I can see it in the *a*. Mean it carefully."

◆

Marcia gave her the long game in June, on the Ides, through the door, with the empress on the couch and no cloth over her eyes.

It was the first time she had been in the room when the Augusta was not ill. She had gone through the door with the comb perhaps twenty times by then and the woman on the couch had always had the head, or had said she had, and Fausta had begun to understand, somewhere in the spring, that the head was a thing the Augusta had when she wished to receive someone without receiving them, and that the cloth was a door, and that she, Fausta, had been let through it by

being a girl who did hair and did not exist. On the Ides of June the cloth was off. The Augusta was sitting up, in the plain gown, with the plain face that was not plain at all when you were three paces from it, because it was a face that had decided a long time ago exactly how much of itself to show and showed precisely that; and Matidia was in the room on her stool with her book, and did not turn a page; and Marcia was at the Augusta's shoulder with the comb; and the Spaniard was there.

He was sitting on the end of the Augusta's couch in a toga with the tribune's stripe, which he had worn since December, with his beard and his shoulders and a scroll in his hand that he was not reading, and he was talking to the Augusta in Greek about a poem. The Augusta was listening with the look of a woman who had heard a great many poems from this man and intended to hear a great many more; and Fausta stood by the wall with the box of pins and did her work, which was to be furniture with hands, and did not look, and saw.

She saw what she had seen from the roof. That was the thing; it was the roof again, five years on, from the inside. The Augusta was looking at the Spaniard the way she had looked at the road, walking into Rome: straight ahead, at a thing that had been arranged for her to walk through and that she had agreed to. Not love. The eleven girls would have said love and been wrong, as they were wrong about modesty. It was *work*. It was a woman of fifty with no children and a husband who thought about the Danube, looking at the only man in the family under forty, and having decided, somewhere, in a room, perhaps this one, that this was the one. That it was her business to see that he was the kind of man who deserved it, since nobody else on the hill was going to make him so; and the Spaniard knew it, and read her his poem, and was, Fausta thought, three paces from him with a pin in her hand, the most owned man in Rome after the emperor, and the only one who had chosen it.

Matidia turned a page. Marcia's comb went through the grey hair. The Spaniard finished the poem and the Augusta said a thing about the metre that made him laugh, the real one, the loud one, and he got up, which took the couch some time, and kissed her hand and went out with the scroll, and did not look at the wall, and the room let out its breath.

"Well," the Augusta said, to the ceiling, with the cloth off. "Tertulla's girl. You've been in this room twenty times and that's the first time you've seen anything in it worth telling her. What will you tell her?"

Fausta did not look up from the pin. "That the tribune reads Greek well, Augusta, and that you corrected his metre."

"That's what you'll tell her. What did you see?"

She thought of the wall at dusk and *I want your face to do nothing*. She thought of a room off a peristyle and *the street's not for sale; the hand is*. She thought that this woman could see through a cloth and had taken it off, and that a lie to her would be the one Phaedrus had warned about, the one about the only person it was not safe to lie to, and that the thing on the couch was not a test of her reading but of what she would do with it, which was the only test there had ever been, from the slate on.

"That you've chosen him, Augusta," she said, to the pin. "And that he knows. And that you don't love him, and he doesn't need you to, and that's why it will work."

The room was very quiet. Matidia did not turn a page.

Then the Augusta laughed. Not the sound under the cloth; the real one, short, dry, a laugh like the lady's shoulders moving but with breath in it, and she said, "Marcia. Did you hear that?"

"I heard it, Augusta."

"Twenty times with a comb and on the twenty-first she tells me the thing you've been forty years not saying. Where did Tertulla find her?"

"Behind a chair, Augusta. Watching Sura."

"Yes. Well. Sura's got a boy who does the same for him, from the same street, I'm told; they breed them on that coast like fish." The Augusta looked at the girl by the wall, finally, directly, with the plain face that showed exactly what it decided to, and it was deciding, Fausta saw, to show her something, and the something was not kindness. "Girl. You've just said a true thing in a room where true things are not said, to a woman who could have you in the Tiber by the Kalends for it, and you said it because you worked out that I'd asked. Good. That's reading. Now here's the other half, which Marcia will teach you, because I haven't the time and she has the patience: a true thing said at the right moment buys you a place in the room. A true thing said at the wrong one costs you your tongue. The art isn't seeing. Every clever slave sees; that's what slaves are for, Nicias will have told you, Tertulla says he had you. The art is *waiting*. I've waited twenty-three years for that man to be the thing I needed him to be, and I've not said so once, and I'll not say so till my husband's dead and perhaps not then. You said it in a breath. You were right. Don't do it again for ten years." She lay back. "Marcia, teach her the long game. She's got the short one. Tertulla's girl, you'll do my hair on the Kalends and the Ides and you'll not speak in this room again until I ask you a question, and I'll not ask you one for a year, and at the end of the year if you've held your tongue I'll give you a thing, and if you haven't I'll give you to Tertulla's son, who I'm told is patient." A pause. "Yes. I know about that too. Everyone on this hill has a son. Go on."

She went on. She went down the long wall behind Marcia with the box of pins and her face doing nothing and her feet under her, and at the door the freedwoman stopped, with the comb, and said to it, in the Nemausus Latin, very low:

"She's given you a year and a threat. That's more than she gave me; she gave me twenty and no threat, because she didn't think I'd need

one. You will. You've the short game and it's fast and it's good and it'll get you killed in a house like this before you're twenty-five." The fingers moved a pin. "The long game is this. You've a paper under your gown — don't; I'm not asking what; everyone's got a paper — and a steward on the coast who asked a question in front of a praetor's man so it's on a sheet, and a boy on Sura's stool who nodded when you asked him for a thing and will do it, and a widow who'll sell you to the Palatine the day the price is right and thinks she's doing you a kindness, and a man over the stables who's patient. Five things. None of them's yours. That's the board." The comb went into the box at Marcia's belt. "The long game is to make one of them yours, outright, so that the other four have to go through it. Not the widow; she's never been anyone's. Not the steward. Not the man. The boy, or the paper. Pick one. Then wait ten years and make it true." She opened the door. "I picked a woman from Nemausus with a headache. Took me from a stool to a door. Go and do the widow's hair; she'll want to know what the tribune read."

Fausta went and did the widow's hair. She told the lady the tribune read Greek well and the Augusta corrected his metre. The lady's shoulders moved the width of a stylus and she said, "And?" — the lady's *and*, not her mother's; a woman asking for the rest — and Fausta said, "And nothing, domina. I've been told not to speak in that room for a year," and the lady looked at her in the bronze for a long moment and said, "Have you. By whom?" and Fausta said, "By the room," and the lady said nothing at all, which was praise, and was, Fausta understood, the first time the widow Tertulla had been told by her own girl that there was a thing she would not be given, and had let it stand.

That night, in the dormitory over the bakehouse, with the twelve breathing and the Strabo and the paper against her skin, she took out the last sheet of the Rhodian's papyrus and wrote, under the thing she had not sent: *Five things, none of them mine. Pick one and wait ten*

years. She said the boy or the paper. I know which I'd pick if picking were a thing I were allowed. I know which one's already stopped doing the sum. And then she did not write any more, because the long game was waiting, and she had been told, and she was her mother's, and could carry a thing once it was decided; and she put the sheet away with the others, and lay in the dark, and felt her feet.

16

The Ring

Rome and the Danube, spring and summer 105

The ring came on the Ides of March, from a clerk, in a room, and weighed less than the denarius.

That was what he noticed. He had expected — he did not know what he had expected; his father had been describing the thing for eighteen years and had never once described the moment, only the stone it would be cut on — and it was a room in the old palace below the Palatine with a clerk in it, a freedman of Capito's with ink on his cuff, who read his name off a sheet, *Gaius Laecanius Celer, son of Gaius, of the tribe Falerna, property qualification attested at four hundred and six thousand in land in the territory of Capua*, and looked up, and said, "That's you?" and he said yes. The clerk made a mark and reached into a box and took out a plain gold ring of the kind the clerk had seen a thousand of and put it on the table between them and said, "There. You're on the roll. The stripe you buy yourself; the tailor's in the Argiletum, tell him Capito's office sent you and he'll not cheat you more than usual. Next."

He put it on. It was loose. He would have it made smaller, in the Argiletum, by the tailor's brother, who did rings. He walked out of the old palace into the Forum with it on his hand and the hand felt no different and he stood at the foot of the Palatine for a while looking up at it with the gold on his finger and found that he was thinking not of his father, or the stone, or the four hundred and six thousand in vines he had never seen, but of a chandler's stair in the dark and a girl saying *that's done, you'll find it's easier than counting*. That the ring was the same: a thing that had been described to him his whole life as the whole of it, and that turned out to be a clerk, and a box, and *next*.

He wrote to his father. He wrote four lines, in the square hand, *the roll, the Ides, Capito's office, the ring*, and under them, because he had been told by a woman at a loom that the gods liked to see a face and because he had struck the man and the man had said *I think I've got it now*, he wrote a fifth: *I'll come to the stone when the war's done and stand by it with you. Not for the stone. For you. — C.* And he sealed it and gave it to Philon for the post and went to the Argiletum to be cheated.

◆

He took rooms. An eques on Sura's staff did not sleep in a room with a window on a wall in a Spaniard's house; Sura's steward said so, and found them, on the Aventine below Sura's, three rooms over a wine-shop with a stair and a door of their own and a view, if you leaned, of the river. And an eques with rooms needed a household, the steward said, and Celer, who had never in his life owned anything but a denarius and a knife he had given away, went to the market in the Subura on a morning in April with Sura's steward's boy to show him where, and bought a woman.

He would not pretend, afterwards, that he had not known what he was doing. He had known since a chandler's stair. He stood on the dealer's platform's edge in the April sun with the ring on his hand and the boy at his elbow and looked at a row, and he was not his father's patron with a lamp in a women's room and he was exactly that. He knew it, and he looked along the row anyway, because he needed a household and a household was a thing you bought, and he stopped.

She was Greek — Corinthian, the dealer said, which meant nothing; they were all Corinthian when the buyer had a Greek face — and twenty, and had been a merchant's in Puteoli, which was why he had stopped, and knew it, and did not let it stop him from stopping. She was tall and brown and had a long plain face that she had arranged to show nothing, and the arrangement was good but not thirty years good; he could see through it, as he could see through most things

now, to a thing underneath that was not fear and was not the pen-look and was simply a woman on a platform doing the sum. Her name was Chrestê. It meant *useful*. The dealer said it as if it were a selling point and Celer thought of a steward in a common room saying *she'll be useful* about a girl of ten, and of the splinter it had been, and he said the price without bargaining, which the boy told him afterwards was a mistake and which he had done because he could not stand on the platform's edge any longer.

She was good. That was the thing he would have to say to himself, honestly, in the rooms over the wine-shop in the months after, when he looked at what he had done. She was good at all of it. She kept the three rooms as a merchant's woman kept a house, with the accounts on a slate — she could read; the dealer had not said so; she had not said so either, until he found the slate and she had looked at him with the long face arranged and said *you didn't ask* — and she bought at the market for less than the steward's boy did and she cooked, which he had not expected, and in the evenings she sat in the outer room with mending and did not speak unless he did, and when he did she answered, in a Greek with the Gulf in it, exactly as much as was wanted.

And on the ninth night he went into the inner room where she slept, because that was what the room was for, and what she was for, and what he had bought. He knew all of that and went in anyway, because he was eighteen and had been in a tent for four years and a Spaniard's house for two and had not, since a chandler's stair at thirteen, been in a room with a woman where the woman's attention was on him; and she was awake, and sat up, and looked at him with the long face in the lamp, and did not arrange it, for once; she let him see the sum being done, which was *so, now*, and *well, he's young, and clean, and hasn't hit me*, and *better now than a year of waiting for it*; and then she arranged it, and said, in the Gulf Greek, "Yes. All right. Come here, then. I'd rather it was you than the steward's boy, who's

been looking."

He went. He would remember it, as he remembered everything, by what he saw; and what he saw was that she was the one in the room who knew what was happening, again, as the Bithynian girl had been, and that she took his hands and put them where they went, as the Bithynian girl had, and that he was not thirteen now, and had learned a thing or two from nothing and nobody. That it was not brief; and that her body under his hands was long and brown and warm and real and had a scar on the hip that he put his mouth to without deciding to and felt her go still and then not; and that when it was done she did not say *there, that's done*; she lay with her arm over her eyes in the lamp and breathed and said nothing for a long time, and then said, to the ceiling, "You're kind. I'd heard you were. The steward's boy said you paid without bargaining. I thought: that's a fool or a kind man, and either one's a thing I can work with." She moved her arm and looked at him. "Which?"

"I don't know."

"No. You wouldn't." She reached and touched the ring on his hand, turned it, once, on the finger, where it was still loose. "A kind man with a ring and a woman he bought in the Subura. That's Rome, that is. That's the whole city in one bed." And she turned over, and slept, and he lay beside her with the lamp going down and the river somewhere beyond the wall and thought, as he had thought at the foot of a stair at thirteen, that he had liked it — not the act, which had been long and strange and partly hers; the other thing. The being the one in the room who was not a task. And that she had just told him, to his face, in his own bed, with her hand on his ring, that she knew it, and would work with it, and that this was what *useful* meant, and that he had bought it for the price of a good mule and had not bargained because he could not bear to. That not being able to bear a thing was not the same as not doing it, and never had been, and that his father had known that for thirty years and had built a tomb on it.

He was kind to her. He would say that too. He never raised a hand or a voice; he paid her a wage, which the steward's boy said was mad; he let her keep the slate and did not check it, which she noticed and said nothing about; and in the mornings, when he went up the hill to Sura's stool, she stood at the top of the stair over the wine-shop with the mending and watched him go with the long face arranged. He could not read her, and did not try, because he had learned on a mole that there were faces he could not read and had decided that this was going to be one of them, on purpose, because the alternative was to read her, and know, and go in anyway, and he was not yet the man who could do that with his eyes open. He would be. He could see him from here. But not yet.

She told him about Puteoli on the last night before the staff went north, in the inner room, with the lamp, after, when she lay with her arm over her eyes and he had learned that this was when she talked, if she was going to.

"The merchant was called Aulus Granius. Wine. He had a house on the slope above the macellum, two streets from a freedman's with columns that weren't marble." Her voice was the Gulf Greek, level, a manifest. "I was his for four years. I did his accounts, because his wife couldn't and he couldn't and somebody had to, and I did the other thing, because that's what a girl in a merchant's house does when the wife's at Nola with her mother. He wasn't unkind. He was a man who'd stopped at me and kept stopping because it was easier. When he died the wife sold me in a lot with the furniture, which was fair; I'd been furniture, mostly." She moved her arm and looked at the ceiling. "I knew your father's house. Everyone on that slope did. The Augustalis with the tomb he kept changing. I never saw you; you'd gone north by then, they said, with the patron's son. But I knew the girl."

He did not move.

"From the lodging-house by the harbour. The Dolphin. Granius sent me down there once a month with the slate to settle what his factors had drunk. There was a girl kept the book — thirteen, fourteen, with her mother dying up the stairs and a face on her like a shutter — and she'd go down my slate with her finger and find the place where Granius's factor had leaned on the stylus and say, *that's not what he drank, that's what he wished he had*, and take the lower figure, and look at me while she did it, so I'd know she knew I'd been told to pass the higher." The long face in the lamp was not arranged. "I liked her. I'd not have said so to her; you don't, between houses. But I thought: that one's not going up the stairs. That one's going somewhere else. Did she?"

"The Caelian," he said. "A widow's. She does the empress's hair."

Chrestê was quiet for a moment.

"Well," she said. "Then I was right, and it's the only time I've been right about anything on that coast." She turned on her side, toward him, with her hand under her cheek, and looked at him in a way she had not before, which was the way the girl had looked at her over a slate: so that he would know she knew. "You bought me because I'd been Granius's in Puteoli. The dealer said it and you stopped. I saw you stop. I thought: there's a man who's buying a street." She did not say it unkindly. She said it as a figure. "I'll work with that too. I've worked with worse. But I'd rather you knew I'd seen it, because a thing you know I've seen is a thing you'll not have to perform, and I'm tired, and I'd rather keep house for a kind man who's honest about what he bought than for a kind man who thinks he's kind."

He lay in the lamp with her hand under her cheek and her eyes on him and the river beyond the wall, and found that he had nothing to say that was not either a list or a lie, and he had been told by a girl with a slate not to do the thing where he decided what was true first.

"Yes," he said. "I bought a street. I didn't know I was doing it till you said. I'd have told you otherwise if you'd asked yesterday, and I'd

have believed it." He looked at the ceiling. "I don't know what that makes me."

"It makes you your father's son with a ring," said Chrestê, "which is what you were when you walked onto the platform, and what you'll be when you come back from the war, if you do, and I'll keep the slate and the three rooms and not ask you what the street's for, because I know, and you know, and the only person who doesn't is the one with the shutter, and she's on the Caelian doing an empress's hair and will never in her life set foot over a wine-shop on the Aventine." She closed her eyes. "Go to sleep. You've a bridge to see. The steward's boy says it's a mile long and built by a Syrian who shouts. Count the piers for me; I've never seen a thing that size that wasn't a debt."

He went north in the morning. At the top of the stair over the wine-shop she stood with the mending and watched him go, as she did, and this time he did not try not to read her, and read her, and what was there was a woman who had been sold with the furniture and had told the truth to the man who bought her and was waiting to see what it cost; and he went down the stair with the ring on his hand and the sum undone and the knowledge, new and cold and exact, that he had two things now in Rome that he could not bear to look at and had bought anyway. That one of them was over a wine-shop and the other was on the Caelian, and that the one over the wine-shop had just told him which was which.

◆

The king broke the terms in June, as the sum had said, and the emperor went north, and the staff went with him, and Celer saw the bridge.

He had heard of it for a year. Everyone had; it was the thing the war had been doing while it waited, in the gorge below Drobeta where the river came out of the Iron Gates and ran, for a mile, straight and deep and fast between two banks of rock, and a Syrian from Damascus with a beard and a temper and the emperor's ear had been

building across it, since the spring of the second year, a thing nobody had built across that river in the history of the world. The staff came down to it in July by the road the first war had cut along the gorge-wall, and the road came round a shoulder of rock, and there it was. The staff stopped, all of it, the way the mole had stood up for one ship in February; and Celer, on a horse he had bought with the vines and did not yet sit well, looked at it and did not have anything, as he had not had anything for the mountains. Nicias would have had Homer. He had: twenty piers. He counted them. Twenty piers of stone in the river, each the size of the Dolphin, in a line from bank to bank, with the brown water piling up against their upstream faces and going white, and on the piers, arches, of timber, great curved ribs of oak lashed and pinned, and on the arches a road, wide enough for four men abreast, with rails, going across the river in the air for a mile; and at either end a gate-tower of stone with the eagle on it; and on the far side, on the Dacian bank, where the road came down, the fort. The camp, and the army, already across, in its thousands, which had walked over the river, on a road, as if the river were not there.

"Well?" said Sura, beside him, on a better horse. "One thing."

"It's not for the war, sir."

"Go on."

"The army crossed on boats in the first war and it can cross on boats in this one; the river's the same and the boats are cheaper. It's not for crossing. It's for *after*. It's a road, and a road's a thing you pay on every mile of it, to someone, and a road into a kingdom with a gate-tower at either end is a tax-gate. He's not building a bridge. He's building the first mile of a province." He heard himself say it and heard, under it, a dead Greek by a brazier, *a road is a thing you pay on, boy*, and did not say that.

Sura was quiet for a moment, on the shoulder of rock, with the bridge below them in the sun.

"Yes," he said. "That's what Apollodorus says, when he's drunk. That he's not an engineer, he's a surveyor, and the emperor's not a soldier, he's a man who's decided that the Danube's the wrong border and the Carpathians are the right one and that the only way to move a border is to put a road through it that can't be rolled up." He gathered his reins. "Don't say that in the tent. The Senate still thinks this is about terms. Say it to me on rocks."

They went down. They crossed.

The sound came first, before the bridge itself: the whole of the Danube going through the Syrian's piers with the voice a river had when it was made to go through something instead of round it, a sound that was felt in the teeth as much as heard, and under it, as they came onto the roadway, the other sound, which was the sound of a legion on timber. Six thousand men on planks do not march; they are told not to, because a march on a bridge is a thing that can bring the bridge down. They walk, out of step, deliberately, and the walk of six thousand men out of step on oak over water is a noise like rain on a roof that does not stop, and he was in it, and it went on for the whole of the half-mile, and when he came off the far end onto the stone he found that he had been holding his breath for a long time without deciding to. He crossed on a road in the air over a river half a mile wide with the water going by white underneath between the ribs and the planks moving, very slightly, the whole length of it, like the mole in a swell, like the bridge of boats four years ago that the horses had been blindfolded for; and the horses were not blindfolded now, they walked. The men walked behind them with their eyes open, which he had thought four years ago was the wrong way round and thought now, on the Syrian's road, was simply what happened when a thing had been built that a horse could believe in; and at the far gate-tower, in the shadow of the eagle, a big man with a beard and a Damascus face and lime on his hands to the elbow was standing with a tablet, counting the cohorts across, and looked up as the staff came through,

and saw Sura, and said in Greek, without greeting, "Lucius. It holds. Tell him it holds. He's asked me four times by letter and I've told him four times and he'll believe it from you." And then the eyes went past Sura to the boy on the bad horse and the man said, "Who's that? He's counting my piers."

"Hermes's son. He counts everything. He's just told me your bridge is a tax-gate."

Apollodorus of Damascus looked at the freedman's son for a long moment with the lime drying on his arms.

"Is it," he said. "Well. He's right. Don't tell the Senate." And then, turning back to his tablet: "Twenty piers. Nobody else has counted them. They look at it and say *the bridge* and go across. He counted. Lucius, when this is over and you've got your province and your triumph, give me that one for a month; I've a forum to build out of the side of a hill in Rome and I'll want someone who can tell me what it weighs."

◆

Aper found him on the bridge the second night, as Aper found everything.

He came along the roadway between the rails with a lamp he should not have had and a skin he certainly should not, and sat down on the planks beside Celer with his legs over the river, forty feet above water that could be heard and not seen, and said, "I've been made a tribune. Laticlave; no — angusticlave; I never remember which is the one for people like me. The thin stripe. My father wrote to a man and the man wrote to the emperor's man and I'm to go to the Fifth in the spring and stand in front of six hundred men who've been soldiers longer than I've been alive and tell them things. Drink."

Celer drank. The river went under them, all of it, the whole weight of the Danube, and the piers the Syrian had sunk in it stood against the weight and did not move, and the planks under them did not move, and he had come out here for that, to sit on a thing that did

not move over a thing that did.

"I'll be bad at it," Aper said.

"You'll not."

"I will. I can't add and I can't shout. I'll be liked and I'll be bad at it, and in two years I'll go home to the salt and be a magistrate in Ariminum and marry somebody's daughter, and in twenty I'll be fat, and I'll tell people I sat on Apollodorus's bridge with the man who weighed the gold." He drank. "You'll weigh gold. I know it. Everyone on the staff knows it. Sura looks at you the way my father looks at the salt-pans."

"That's not a kind thing to say about either of us."

Aper laughed, out over the river, loud, so that the sentry on the far tower called out and Aper called back his name and the sentry said, *oh, it's you, sir,* in the voice everyone used about Aper, and let it go. "That's the first joke you've made in three years. Write it down. No — you'll have it in your head; you have everything in your head." He was quiet, and then said, in a voice that was not for the sentry, "I'll miss the tent. That's all. I know it's not a thing men say. I'm from a salt-pan; we say things." He got up, unsteadily, with the lamp. "Come to the Fifth's lines when we cross. I'll have a tent to myself and nobody in it who can read my hand, and I'll be lonely and I'll pretend I'm not, and you can sit there and not talk, which is what you do, and I'll feel better."

He went back along the planks, with the lamp swinging, singing something from Ariminum about a girl and a salt-cart, badly; and Celer sat on the bridge a while longer with the skin, over the river, and found that the thing he had come out there to feel, which was the piers holding, had got mixed up with another thing, and he could not take them apart, and did not try.

The Spaniard had a legion.

That was the thing about the second war that was not in the first: the emperor's great-nephew by marriage, who had sat on the end of a

couch on the Aventine and asked a dead Greek's name, was legate of the First Minervia, five thousand men and their auxiliaries, and was across the river ahead of the staff and up in the hills west of the king's city doing, by the sheets that came back, exactly what a legate of a legion in his first command was supposed to do, which was to be where he was sent and to win small things and send long letters about them in good Greek. Celer read the letters. Sura set them aside and Celer read them after, on the stool, and told Sura one thing, and the thing was always the same and he said it differently each morning so as not to be sent back to Rufus: *he's writing for a reader who isn't you.*

"Yes," said Sura, on the fourth morning. "He's writing for the box. He knows there's a box. He's known since he was quaestor; I told him, the way Philon told you, so he'd not find it by accident. Every letter that man sends from the Minervia is a letter he expects to be read in twenty years by someone deciding what kind of legate the emperor was. He's right to. I'd do the same. I *did* the same; it's in the third room with the wax unbroken." Sura did not move. "The difference is that I wrote for one reader and he writes for eleven, and one of the eleven is himself, and that's the one he can't stop performing for. Watch for it. It's the hole in him. A man who reads his own letters as posterity will is a man who can be made to do a thing by being told how it will look."

Celer watched for it. He saw it in August, when the Minervia took a hill-fort in the western valleys and the Spaniard's letter about it ran to four sheets and had, in the third, a sentence about the fort's garrison — *they fought as men fight who have been promised a thing and have ceased to expect it* — that was his own sentence, from a margin, from a granary, three years ago, with the words moved; and he sat on the stool with the sheet and felt a thing go through him that was cold and clear and that he had not felt before and recognised at once, because he had watched his father feel it across a lamp in a strong-room: it was the feeling of seeing your figure in another man's

column, uncredited, and being *pleased*.

He did not tell Sura that one. He told Sura the Iazyges.

◆

Philon put the letter into his hand in September without a word, in the camp on the far bank below the king's mountains, with the seal already looked at, as Philon looked at everything; and it was two sheets, in his father's hand, and the second was the one.

The first was the house. The *Isis* had made the bounty. The new man at the grain-office had learned what he was worth and was being paid it. Bassus's debts had come to Rufus and Rufus had come to Hermes, as foreseen, and Hermes had lent, against the Baian villa this time, with the slipped tile and all, and held, now, in his strong-room, a paper that said that if the young master did not pay by the Kalends of the third year the house of Hermes would own the headland that the house of Hermes had been walking up to on foot every April for sixty years to stand in an atrium and be called *my people*. *I'll not take it,* his father wrote. *I'll never take it. A freedman who forecloses on his patron's villa is a freedman the whole coast turns its back on and his son's ring with him. But I'll hold the paper. There's a thing about holding a paper that a man like Rufus understands in his legs before he understands it in his head, and I've watched him understand it, in my strong-room, on a stool I gave him, and it was worth the four hundred thousand and the olives and the rest. He sat down. He sat down in my strong-room. Your stepmother says I've not slept since for smiling and she's not wrong.*

The second sheet was shorter.

The steward. You'll know he asked the girl a question in front of a praetor's man at the funeral. You'll know because you were in the street; Thallus has a boy who told him so, and told me, so that I'd know what Thallus knows. And you wrote to your stepmother, after, about an egg-seller's husband in the lower town and a quarter's payment for nothing, and she did it, and told me she'd done it, because she's a good

woman and doesn't lie to me about things that cost money. I've let it stand. The man's paid. He'll be paid while he lives. That's done and I'll not undo it.

But hear me. Thallus asked the question for one reason, which is that Rufus owes me the villa and Thallus knows it and Thallus is a steward whose master has been bought and who needs, therefore, to find a thing the buyer wants that the buyer can't get from the paper. He's looked round the house of Laecanius for that thing and he's found it on the Caelian with a box of pins. He thinks the girl is a hook in you. He's wrong about what kind, but he's not wrong that she's one; a man who strikes his father for a sentence is a man with a hook in him, and I'd not have told Thallus that for the villa, and I've not, and he's guessed it anyway, because he's never once in his life stopped counting.

So. Do nothing. The egg-man's paid; that's the end of what you do. Don't write to the Caelian. Don't write to the Nola woman about the Caelian. Don't let the Spaniard, who asks for you every time he's made something, ask for you about this. The house is with us — Rufus is in my strong-room on a stool and his steward knows it and the girl is the empress's hair and the empress is the one person on that hill Thallus can't count, which is why he asked the question in front of a praetor's man and not in front of her. He's put it on a sheet. Let it sit on the sheet. A thing on a sheet that nobody picks up is a thing that didn't happen; you've been in Sura's boxes two years, you know that better than I do. Pick it up and it's a thing. Leave it and in three years Rufus has paid or hasn't and either way Thallus is an old man with a key to a house that isn't his and a question nobody's answering.

Do nothing. I've never asked you to do nothing before. I'm asking now. It's the hardest thing I know and I've done it for thirty years and it got you a ring. — Your father.

She'd say "and?" I know. I've thought about it in the strong-room and I think I've got it now: it means the sum's done and there's nothing left over. Well. There's something left over. There's the villa, and I'm

not taking it, and there's you, and I'm not spending you, and that's the "and." That's a father's. Hers was a dying woman's. They're not the same and I'll not pretend they are.

He read it twice, on a stool, in a tent, on the far bank, with the king's mountains above and the Syrian's bridge a day behind and the Spaniard's four-sheet letters in a box at his elbow; and he sat with it for a long time, and the sum came out the same three times, which was *do nothing*, which was right, which was true, which was the thing he was good at.

And he did nothing. He did not write to the Caelian. He did not write to the Nola woman. When the Spaniard came into the staff tent in the last week of September with lime on his boots from a visit to the bridge and said, in Greek, in passing, *Hermes's son — Lucius tells me the widow Tertulla's hair-girl is from your street; the Augusta's taken a fancy to her, she does the hair the old way, Plotina says she's the only one on the hill with the hands for it; is she as clever as the Augusta thinks?*, he said, *cleverer, sir*, and nothing else, and the grey eyes looked at him for a moment and went on, and he did nothing with that either. He put the letter in the box with the rest. He fed the Lares from Nola, which he had carried north again, in the tent, with bread, because a woman at a loom had said they liked to see a face; and he thought, doing it, that his father had said *a hook in you* and had been right, and that his father had said *do nothing* and had been right, and that he had a woman in three rooms over a wine-shop on the Aventine who knew he was kind and worked with it and whom he had bought because he could not bear to stand on a platform's edge, and a ring that weighed less than a denarius, and a stone with an *F* on it. That none of these was the hook, and that the hook was a girl on a mole holding him off at the length of her arm and saying *not for nothing*, and that he had put it in the column, and that the column did not balance, and that he was going to go up into the mountains in the spring and write the inventory of a kingdom with it open, because that was what his father

had asked, and his father had never asked him to do nothing before, and it was the hardest thing he knew, and he was good at it.

17

The Year of the Tongue

The Palatine and the Caelian, 105 to 106

She did not speak in the room for a year, and the year taught her what a room was.

It was twenty-four mornings. She counted them, as she counted everything, and set them out afterwards in the place where she kept things like the Rhodian's bill, one under another: Kalends, Ides, Kalends, Ides, July to June, the comb and the box of pins and the woman on the couch with the cloth on or off and the Spaniard's wife on her stool and Marcia at the shoulder and the lady on the bench outside and the long wall and the door. Twenty-four mornings of being furniture with hands. And she learned, in them, the thing that Nicias had said was the only thing he had owned in fifty-five years, and that she had thought, at ten, she understood: that a woman who was not spoken to was a woman who could not be lied to, and that in a room where everyone was performing for everyone, the one person nobody performed for was the one who could see the whole of the play.

She saw Matidia. The Spaniard's mother-in-law, with the book and the plain hair done by her own hand, who turned a page when the legate's wife laughed, and who was, Fausta understood by September, the only woman in the room the Augusta did not manage. She did not need to. They had made the thing together, the two of them, the way her mother and the egg-woman's mother had made the thing in the back room at the Dolphin: one with the hands and one holding the lamp, and no need afterwards to say which had been which. Matidia had given her daughter to the Spaniard. The Augusta had made the Spaniard worth giving a daughter to. Between them they held a man

in a legion in the Dacian hills the way two women held a sheet to fold it, each with her corners, and the man knew, and wrote four-sheet letters about hill-forts in good Greek, and did not come to the room, because he did not need to; he was in it.

And she saw the daughter.

Vibia Sabina was twenty-two that year, and had been married five, and came to the room on the Ides, not the Kalends, because the Kalends were her mother's and she would not share them; and she sat on a stool by the window that was not her mother's stool, with no book, with her hands in her lap, and looked at the room with a face that had been given everything a face could be given on that hill — the blood, the marriage, the future — and had decided, somewhere, to find all of it insufficient. She was beautiful. It was a thing that was said about her and it was true and it did not help; she had her grandmother's long bones and her mother's stillness and something of her own that neither of them had, a kind of dry disappointed intelligence that sat in the beautiful face like a tenant who had not chosen the house. She did not speak to the benches. She did not speak to the Augusta, who was her husband's patroness and her great-aunt by marriage and who had made her a wife at seventeen to a man who read her poems about other people. She spoke, when she spoke, to Marcia, in a low quick voice, about nothing, and Marcia answered about nothing, and the room watched them do it and understood that this was the one person in it who was not owned by anyone and hated it.

On the Ides of October she spoke to Fausta.

It was after the hair. The Augusta had the cloth on and had said *that's it, that's my mother's* and had turned her face to the wall, and Marcia had gone out to the benches with the comb, and Fausta was by the door with the box of pins waiting to be let through it, and Sabina, on her stool by the window, said without turning her head, in the low quick voice: "You're the one who doesn't speak."

Fausta said nothing. She had been told.

"Yes. I heard. A year, and then a thing, and if not, Tertulla's son." The beautiful face did not move. "She does that. She gave my husband a year once, before the marriage, to stop writing to a boy in Athens, and he stopped, and she gave him me. That was the thing." A pause. "I'd have taken the son."

Fausta looked at the floor. She felt the long game in her like a stone held in the mouth.

"You can't answer. I know. I'm not asking you to; I'm telling you, because you're the only person in this room who can't repeat it, and I've wanted to say it to someone for five years and the slaves repeat everything and the women repeat it better." Sabina turned her head, finally, and looked at the girl by the door with the long bones and the dry tenant intelligence, and it was not an unkind look; it was the look of a woman examining a wall to see if it was load-bearing. "You've got a face like a shutter and a nose like a consul and you do an old woman's hair the way her mother had it and you've not said a word in four months in a room where I've never once heard the truth, and I thought: that one's not performing. Everyone else is. My husband is. My mother is. *She* is —" the smallest movement of the head toward the couch, where the cloth was — "she's been performing a headache for twenty years and it's the best thing on this hill. You're not. You're just standing there, seeing it." The beautiful face went back to the window. "I wanted you to know somebody'd noticed. Go on; Marcia's waiting with her comb and her one thing a Kalends. Tell her I said nothing. It'll be true of more than forty."

She went out. She told Marcia nothing. Marcia's fingers moved a pin and the round face said, "Sabina spoke to you."

"I didn't answer."

"No. You wouldn't. That's the year." The comb went into the box. "She speaks to no one. She's spoken to me and to a Greek girl who died and now to you, and the Greek girl died of a fever and not of

anything else, before you ask, but the Augusta had her moved to Laurentum first, where the air's better, and where she couldn't be spoken to by the Spaniard's wife in a room with the door shut." Marcia did not look at her. "That's not a threat. I don't make them; she does, and she's made you one already, and she doesn't make two. It's a thing to know. The one person in that room who isn't owned is the one person it's not safe to be seen by. Don't let her choose you. She's lonely and she's clever and she'll make you the only true thing on the hill, and then the hill will have to do something about it."

◆

Marcia asked her about Puteoli in February, with the comb, in the Nemausus Latin, so lightly that she almost did not hear it was a question.

"The war eats wheat," the freedwoman said, to a pin. "Four legions on the far bank and the Guard and the Syrian's bridge-builders and the horses, and the Danube depots can't feed it; it comes from Egypt, round by sea, into the Italian ports and up the roads and across. The grain-office pays by weight. The Augusta's had the figures from the prefect — she has everything from everyone; it's what the headache's for — and she's looked at them, which the prefect didn't expect, because emperors' wives don't look at modii, and she's found a thing." The fingers moved. "The Puteoli carriers claim the bounty for early delivery nine years in ten and are docked for short weight never, and the Ostia carriers claim it three in ten and are docked twice a season. Same ships. Same sea. Same Egyptian wheat. Different port. Different scale." A pause the width of a stylus. "You grew up a street from a man with three hulls in that trade. The Augusta said: *Tertulla's girl kept a lodging-house book at thirteen; she'll have read every slate in the lower town.* I said: she's not speaking this year. The Augusta said: *then she'll have a year to decide what it's worth.*" The comb went into the box. "I've not asked you a question. The year holds."

Fausta stood by the wall with the pins and the shutter to and the thing in her that she had read at eleven in a strong-room while a boy counted jars — *pondere, non mensura*, the fourth line of the second column. The sail that was wet on the day the prefect's man weighed, and *the baker in the Subura gets a loaf that's a tenth water and nobody counts that because the baker's a baker* — and she did not move, and she did not speak, and she thought, in the slate way, very fast: *they've found it. Not from me. From the figures. They've found it the way Celer found the depot, from a column that wouldn't reconcile, and they've come to the only person on the hill who could tell them what the column means, and they've come in a year when I can't speak, and they've told me that the year's a mercy.*

And under that, where she kept the things that were not sums: *it's his father. It's the house with the columns that aren't marble. It's the man who sent the widow his son's hand in a manifest and said "the daughter of my patron's freedwoman" so she'd think of us as a pair. It's the four hundred thousand and the olives and the vines in the Falernian hills with an F on a stone.*

And under that: *it's not Celer. He's on the far bank with a ring, writing the inventory of a kingdom. He's never once in his life done a thing by weight that he could do by measure. But he's his father's; he said four hundred and twenty in a tutor's room and looked at me while he said it and I said all right.*

She said nothing. The year held. She went down the long wall behind the comb.

In the litter the lady said, "Well?" and she said, "The Augusta's looking at the grain figures, domina. Marcia told me so. She said it to a pin so it wasn't a question," and the lady was quiet for a street and then said, "Yes. I'd heard. Sura's people have been at the prefect's office since the autumn; it's a war, and wars are paid for by somebody, and the somebody's usually a man with ships who's been doing a thing for ten years that nobody counted till the bill came in." The

shoulders moved. “Your Hermes.”

“I don’t know, domina.”

“No. You don’t. And you’ll not know, this year, because you can’t speak and I’ll not ask, and that’s the only kindness I’ve got for you, child, and I’m giving it because I can see what it’s costing you to hold your face and I was fifteen once in a room where the truth would have hanged a man I’d eaten with.” The lady did not look at her. “But the year ends in June. And in June they’ll ask, and you’ll have to decide whether a man’s hulls are worth more to you than a woman’s door, and I’ll tell you now that I know which I’d choose and that I was wrong, at your age, and it took me thirty years to be glad of it.”

◆

There was a hairpin on Phaedrus’s table in March, in the slaves’ court, in the morning, lying by itself on the wood where the day’s lists should have been, and it was silver, and the steward was standing well back from it.

It came through Phaedrus, which was how the son sent anything to his mother’s side of the house: a thing left on the steward’s table in the slaves’ court in the morning with a word, *for the Puteoli girl, from the stable wing, with compliments on her advancement*, and Phaedrus brought it to her in the corridor nobody used, where Momus sat at the end, and put it in her hand and stood back to watch her look at it.

It was ivory. It was old — older than the house, Momus said afterwards, turning it in his short fingers; Greek, from the islands, the kind of thing a consul’s grandfather brought back from a province and that lay in a box for a hundred years until somebody opened the box. It had a head carved as a woman’s face, very small, very fine, with the hair done the old way, plain, as a woman on a coast built on ash had it, as the Augusta’s mother had had it. And it was, she saw, turning it in the corridor’s bad light, broken: the shaft had been snapped, once, long ago, and mended, with a thread of gold wound round the break, so that it held, and showed.

"He's telling you three things," Phaedrus said, in the Greek like water, very low. "He's telling you he knows what you do on the hill and for whom, because the hair's the old way and he's never seen the Augusta's hair in his life; someone's told him, carefully, which means he's asked, carefully. He's telling you he can put a thing in your hand through me, in his mother's house, and I'll carry it, because I will, because a steward who refuses the son a hairpin is a steward who's declared a thing, and I've twelve years in this house and no wish to declare anything. And he's telling you the third thing with the gold." The Alexandrian looked at the mended shaft. "A pin's a small thing. It breaks. It can be mended, and look better for it, and be worth more. He's patient. He's saying so, in ivory, with compliments."

She stood with it in her palm. The small carved face looked up at her with the plain hair and the expression that faces carved on pins had, which was nothing, which was the shutter, which was hers.

"What do I do with it?"

"You wear it." Phaedrus did not hesitate. "On the Kalends. In the Augusta's room. In your own hair, where Marcia will see it, and ask, with two fingers, and you'll say *a gift from the lady's house*, which is true. Marcia will know within the day whose, because Marcia knows what's in every box on this hill, and then the Augusta will know, and then the thing he's put in your hand through me in his mother's house will be a thing the Palatine has seen in the Palatine, and he'll have told the one woman in Rome he can't count that he's sending her hair-girl ivory." He stepped back. "That's what you do with a pin from a patient man. You make it public, and you make it *hers*. It's the only move there is. He'll know you've made it; he'll have expected it; that's why it's broken and mended and not whole — he wants you to wear it knowing he knows you'll wear it to the hill. He's playing the long game, girl. He had it from his mother and she had it from this house. You're not the only one who's been given a year."

She wore it. On the Kalends of April, in the Augusta's room, in her own hair, at the side, where the lamp caught the gold on the break; and Marcia's fingers came to it and stopped, and the round brown face did nothing, and the freedwoman said, to the pin, "That's island work. That's older than the hill. Where?" and Fausta said, "A gift from the lady's house," which was true; and the fingers went away; and on the couch the woman with the cloth over her eyes said, to the ceiling, in the voice she used for metre, "Marcia. What's she wearing?"

"Ivory, Augusta. Old. Mended with gold. From Tertulla's house."

A silence under the cloth.

"From Tertulla's *house*." The Augusta did not move. "Well. He's a man who knows what a thing looks like from the outside; I'll say that for him, it's the one thing his mother gave him that took. Girl. You've two months left of your year. You've worn a patient man's pin into my room so that I'd see it, which is the cleverest thing you could have done with it and which you were told to do by an Alexandrian who's been twelve years in this house not declaring anything, and it's worked, because I've seen it, and now it's mine, the way everything in this room is. Keep wearing it. Every Kalends. Let him hear that you do." The cloth did not move. "And when the year's up, I'll give you the thing I said, and it'll be a thing he'll understand better than a pin, because he's his mother's and his mother was raised on paper."

He found her in the peristyle on the Nones, by the fountain that had stopped and been started again, in the hour after the lady's rest, and he did not come close this time; he stood on the far side of the basin with the water between them and his hands behind his back, in the tunic from the stable wing, and looked at the pin in her hair.

"You wore it to the hill."

"Yes, domine."

"On the Kalends. Where the Augusta's woman would see it. And the Augusta asked, and now it's hers." He said it the way a man said *the roof held* after a storm he had built the roof for. "Phaedrus told

you to."

"Yes, domine."

"Good. I'd have thought less of him if he hadn't, and less of you if you'd not done it." He looked at the water. He was thirty-one and the heaviness was in the shoulders now and not yet in the face, and the face was his mother's, narrow and patient and raised on paper, and it had on it the expression of a man who had made a move he had expected to be answered and was pleased, in a way that had nothing to do with her, to have been answered correctly. "You understand what I did."

"You told the Palatine you were sending me ivory, domine. Through me. So that I'd be the one who'd told it."

"Yes. And now it's known, on the hill, that Tertulla's son has an interest in Tertulla's girl, and that the girl wore it, and that the Augusta saw and said *keep wearing it*, which Marcia will have told the benches by now, because it's the kind of thing Marcia tells." The slow turn of the head. "Which means that when my mother dies — not this year; she's strong; but she's sixty-four and she's had the cough since the winter and the doctor from Laurentum looks at her the way doctors look — when she dies, and the house comes to me, and you with it, there'll not be a woman on that hill who's surprised. It'll be the thing everyone already knew. That's what the pin was for. Not you. The *knowing*." He took one hand from behind his back and rested it on the basin's rim, where it had rested a year ago when he had said *lamp lit*. "I'm not a man who takes a thing by force, Puteoli girl. I'm not a soldier. I've never been north of Ariminum. I'm a man who puts a thing where it'll be seen and waits for the seeing to do the work. I had it from her. She had it from this house. You've learned it yourself, in a year, from the Alexandrian and the Nemausus woman and the one with the headache, and you've just played it back at me across a fountain and played it well. I'm telling you so you know I'm not angry. I'm the opposite."

She stood with the water between them and her feet under her and did the sum, and it came out where it had come out in November on a lamp: that he was telling her the truth, which was the worst of him. That there was a road he had been walking up for a year and a half with his hands behind his back and that he had just told her the name of the house at the top of it and that it was his mother's death.

"Domine," she said. "The Augusta said a thing."

"I'm sure she did."

"She said the pin was hers now. The way everything in that room is. She said to let you hear that I wear it every Kalends." She kept her voice flat. "I think she meant you to hear the first part, domine. Not the second."

The patient face did not change. The hand on the basin's rim did not move. But something behind the face moved, the way a slate did when a figure was carried from one column to another, and she saw it, and he saw her see it, and he smiled, slightly, for the first time in her knowledge of him, and it was not a pleasant thing and it was not an unpleasant one; it was a man acknowledging that the piece he had moved had been moved back.

"Yes," he said. "She would. That's her game; mine's only a copy." He took the hand off the rim. "Then we both wait, you and I. She's fifty-five and I'm thirty-one and my mother's sixty-four with a cough, and one of those numbers will move before the others, and when it does we'll see whose the pin is." He turned to go, and at the colonnade's edge turned back, with the heaviness in the shoulders. "Keep wearing it. I mean that as she did. Let *her* hear that you do. It's the only thing we'll ever agree on, the Augusta and I, and I'd not waste it."

He went. She stood by the fountain until the sound of him was gone down the colonnade and the water had gone back to being water, and then she went in by the corridor nobody used, and Momus, at the end of it, looked up at her face as she passed and said,

"Ah. He's told you what he's waiting for," and she said, "Yes," and the dwarf said, "Then you've a number to beat, and it's the lady's cough, and I'll tell you now for nothing that I've heard that cough on three women in this house and buried two," and went back to his stool.

◆

The year ended on the Ides of June, and the Augusta gave her the thing, and it was paper, and it was more than she had asked for on a mole or a wall or a last clear morning with the sea in the glass, and she did not weep, because she had decided.

The room was empty. That was the first thing; the door at the end opened and Marcia stood in it and said to the benches, "The Augusta thanks you and is engaged," as she did, and the room stood and bowed and went, the lady with it, with a look back at her girl that was a question and a permission at once; and Marcia said to the girl by the wall, "Not you," and the room emptied. She went through the door with the box of pins into a room with one woman in it, on a couch, sitting up, with no cloth and no book and no Spaniard and no daughter and no Matidia, and the window open on the June morning and the whole city below it going about its noise.

"Sit," said the Augusta. "There. The stool. Sabina's. She'll not mind; she's not here, and if she were she'd mind everything, so it's the same."

She sat on Sabina's stool. She had never sat in the room. She put the box of pins on her knees and her hands on the box and her face did nothing and her feet were under her.

"A year," the Augusta said. "Twenty-four mornings. You've not said a word in this room since you told me I'd chosen a man and didn't love him and that was why it would work, which was true, and which I'd have had you drowned for if you'd said it twice. You've done my hair the way my mother had it. You've worn Tertulla's son's ivory where I'd see it. You've been asked about the grain by Marcia with a pin and you've said nothing to her and nothing to Tertulla but

the fact of the asking, which Tertulla told me, because Tertulla tells me everything she thinks I don't know in order to find out which things I do." The plain face that showed exactly what it decided to was deciding, Fausta saw, to show her something again, and this time it was not the thing from a year ago, the thing that was not kindness; it was something she had not seen on it, and did not have a word for, and would decide, much later, was the nearest the woman ever came to being tired. "And Sabina's spoken to you, and you've not told anyone what she said, and I know what she said, because she says it to everyone she thinks can't repeat it and they all can, and you haven't. So. You've held your tongue in the one room in Rome where it's hardest and you've done it for a year and I said I'd give you a thing, and here it is." She reached beside her on the couch and took up a sheet, folded, with a seal on it that Fausta did not know and would come to know better than her own, and held it out. "Read it. Then I'll tell you what it is, because what it says and what it is are not the same, and you're a girl who's known that since a slate."

She took it. She unfolded it. It was a copy, in a clerk's hand, of a thing she had by heart.

Fausta, daughter of Hilara, freedwoman of Lucius Laecanius Bassus, born free in the house by the harbour at Puteoli on the fourth day before the Ides of May, in the consulship of — and the names, and the witnesses, the Rhodian's father and the egg-woman's husband. The Puteoli magistrate's seal drawn in, and under it, in another hand, a line: *Exemplified from the register of the basilica at Puteoli at the instance of the Augusta and lodged in the archive of the prefect of the city, this day,* and a date, which was the Kalends of June, and a seal, which was the prefect's.

She read it twice. She looked up.

"That's what it says," said the Augusta. "What it *is*, is this. There's a steward on the coast who asked you a question in front of a praetor's man at a funeral so that it would be on a sheet. I had that from Marcia

who had it from Tertulla's dwarf who had it from you, in a litter, on the way down the Caelian. He asked it because his master owes a shipowner a villa and he needed a thing the shipowner's son would pay for, and he'd worked out that you were it, and he was right about that and wrong about how. His sheet says a question was asked. It doesn't say what the answer was. A sheet like that sits in a box till a man with a reason picks it up, and the reason comes when the shipowner's son is something and the steward is old and wants a thing from him, and on that day the steward goes to Puteoli and finds an egg-seller's husband who's sixty and drinks and asks him, with a coin in his hand, whether he remembers signing anything. The egg-seller's husband remembers whatever the coin says." The plain face did not move. "Somebody's been paying the egg-seller's husband a quarter for nothing since February of last year. I know that too. It's a good move and it's a boy's move; it buys a man's memory till the next coin. This —" she nodded at the sheet — "buys the register. The register's been copied. The copy's in the prefect's archive under my seal. Nobody counts a thing I've filed; it's the one use of a headache. The steward can go to Puteoli with every coin on the coast and the egg-man can forget his own name and it won't matter, because the paper's not in Puteoli any more. It's here. On the hill. Mine." She sat back. "That's the thing. You asked a boy for the egg-man and he gave you the egg-man. I've given you the hill. Which is what a woman gives, when she's got it to give. We don't pay quarters. We move the box."

Fausta sat on Sabina's stool with the sheet in her two hands and the box of pins under it and the ivory in her hair with the gold on the break and the paper under the hearth-stone against her skin, which she had carried for four years and had by heart and had not burned and did not, now, need, because the thing it said had been said again by someone nobody would ask *why did you think you'd need it*; and she felt — she would be honest, later, in another room, to a woman with a comb who laughed — she felt her feet, and under her feet, for

the first time since a shutter that would not bar, the floor.

"Augusta," she said. It was the first word in a year. "What does it cost?"

The woman on the couch looked at her for a long moment with the face that showed what it decided to, and the thing on it that was nearly tiredness went, and the other thing came, the thing from a year ago, and it was not kindness.

"Good," she said. "Good. That's the right first word. Tertulla said you'd say *thank you* and I said no, that one'll ask the price, she was raised in a lodging-house." She folded her hands. "It costs this. Marcia asked you about the grain with a pin and you said nothing. In a month, she'll ask you again, without the pin, and you'll say what you know. All of it. The weight and the measure and the sail and the name. And it'll go to the prefect, and to Sura's office, which has the war to pay for and a young man on a stool who counts, and the house with the columns that aren't marble will pay for ten years of water in the Subura's bread, and you'll have done it. The boy on the stool will know you did, because he reads every sheet Sura sets aside and this one Sura will set aside for him to read on purpose, because Sura's cruel in the only way that's any use, which is that he lets a man see the figure." The Augusta did not look away. "That's the price. Your street for your paper. I've had the paper moved already; you've got it in your hands; I'm not a woman who takes a thing back. You could walk out of this room with the hill in your gown and tell Marcia nothing in a month and I'd not have you drowned, because I said I'd give you a thing and I have. But you'd have taken a gift from me and given nothing for it, and you'd know, and I'd know, and Marcia would know. The long game would be over before you'd played a piece, because the one rule on this hill is that nothing's free and the people who pretend it is are the ones who end up in Laurentum with the good air." She lay back, finally, and reached for the cloth. "Go and think. You've a month. It's more than most get. I had a night, with

Nerva's letter, and a husband in Cologne who didn't know yet what I'd decided he was."

Fausta stood. She folded the sheet along the clerk's folds and put it in her gown with the Strabo and the letters and the thing she had by heart, and picked up the box of pins, and went to the door, and at the door she stopped, because she was her mother's and there was a thing to be said and it was true and she had decided on a mole never to pretend about what was true, only about what it cost.

"Augusta. The boy on the stool."

"Yes."

"He's never once in his life done a thing by weight that he could do by measure. The sail was his father's. The fourth line of the second column was his father's. He read it to me when he was eleven and looked at me while he did it and I said *all right*." She kept her voice level. "When Sura sets the sheet aside for him, it'll have my name under it, and his father's over it, and he'll read it four ways, because he's been taught, and one of the ways will be true and it won't be the one he picks. I'm telling you so that you know what I'm paying. It's not the street. The street's ash; it's been ash since the Ides of March four years ago. It's him. It's the only paper I had that nobody could burn, and you've asked me to put it in Sura's box with the wax unbroken."

The woman on the couch did not move the cloth.

"Yes," she said, under it. "I know. I knew when I asked. That's why I gave you the month." A breath. "Marcia picked a woman with a headache. You've picked a paper over a boy, or you will, in a month, because you're not a fool and you've felt the floor. It's the right choice. It's the one I'd make. It's the one I *did* make, with a different boy and a different paper, in Nemausus, when I was seventeen, and I've not been sorry a day in thirty years, and I've not been anything else either." The cloth did not move. "Go and do Tertulla's hair. She'll want to know what the thing was. Tell her it was paper. She'll

understand; she was raised on it."

18

By Weight

Sarmizegetusa and the river Sargetia, summer and autumn 106

Crescens died on the eleventh day, at the second wall, in the morning, and it took him the length of time it took to say so.

Celer saw it because he was there, which he should not have been, and was because Sura had sent him up with a sheet for the Seventh's legate, a thing about water, the king's conduits having been found and cut and the staff wanting to know by noon how many days the city had in its cisterns, and the legate had been at the second wall where the engines were. Celer had gone up to the second wall, on foot, with the sheet, between the mantlets, with the stones coming down from the king's towers at the long slow intervals that meant they were saving them, and had found the legate, and given him the sheet, and turned, and seen a man he knew at the foot of a ladder.

He had not seen him in four years. Four years, a war, a tent-camp, a bridge; the Seventh had wintered on the far bank both winters and the staff had wintered in Rome, and the house's post went through Philon and not through the Seventh's lines, and the last he had had of Crescens was a line in his father's hand in the first war's second year, *the centurion asks after you; I've sent him oil*. And here he was, at the foot of a ladder, in the morning, under the second wall of the king's city, with the transverse crest on and the vine-stick in his belt and the Seventh's cohort round him, forty-seven now, grey in the beard, the ugliness and the kindness both gone to leather; and he looked round, as a man did who had been in walls for twenty-six years and felt a thing behind him, and saw a tall freedman's son in a staff tunic with a ring on his hand. The leather face did a thing Celer had seen once before, on a quay, when a Seventh man had come off the *Pelican* and

said *wine*.

"Well, look at that," said Crescens. "The nose. Lucius Sura's boy, they say. With a ring." He did not come over; he was a centurion at the foot of a ladder and a ladder was a thing you did not leave. He raised the vine-stick, a little, by way of greeting, and the voice came across the ten feet of trampled ground and the noise exactly as it had come across a moonlit beach at Castra Vetera, *the Rhine. Be ashamed later, it's cheaper*. "Your father's made it, then. Good. He'd the right of it from the start; I'd not have given you a sword if you'd begged. Get down off this wall, boy, you've no helmet. Go and count something."

"Sir —"

"That's *not* a thing I'm saying twice." And he turned back to the ladder, and put his hand on it, and looked up its length at the wall and the king's men on it, and said to the men round him in the flat Picene Latin a thing Celer did not hear, and the men laughed; and the stone came down.

It was not a big one. That was what he would remember, with the rest, in the order he kept things: it was not one of the great ones from the towers that came at the long slow intervals, it was a hand-stone, a thing a man on a wall threw, the size of a loaf, and it came off the parapet above the ladder without a sound in all that sound and struck Crescens on the side of the head below the crest where the helmet's cheek-piece did not reach. The centurion of the Seventh who had been at Vetera in Domitian's day and had carried a freedman's son across the Rhine on a boat and sat on a crate on a quay and said *there was never a right moment, that's the trick of them*, went down, as a sack went down, all at once, with the vine-stick still in his belt and his hand still on the ladder, so that the hand dragged on the rung as he fell and left skin on it. He did not make a sound. He lay at the foot of the ladder on his side with the leather face turned up and one eye open, and the eye was looking at nothing, and the blood came out of the ear

on the struck side slowly, as if it too had been told there was no right moment, and then faster; and the men round him did what men round a fallen centurion did, which was to look at him for the time it took to see, and then at the optio. The optio said the thing the optio said, and the cohort went up the ladder anyway, over him, because that was what the ladder was for; and the legate of the Seventh, who had Sura's sheet in his hand and had seen it all, looked at the staff boy with no helmet standing ten feet from a dead man with his mouth open, and said, not unkindly, in the voice of a man who had seen a thousand of these and would see a thousand more, "You knew him?"

"Yes, sir. He — yes."

"Then you'll want to tell someone. Tell them it was quick. It's the only thing anyone wants to know and it's even true." The legate looked at the sheet. "Four days in the cisterns, tell Sura. Five if they stop washing. Now get off my wall."

He got off the wall. He went down between the mantlets with the stones coming at the long slow intervals and his hands at his sides and the noise all round him and he did not run, and he did not weep. He did not have Homer, and at the bottom, in the lee of the first wall, where the engineers were, he stopped and was sick into the trampled ground, briefly, the way a man was who had not eaten, and wiped his mouth, and went on to the staff tent and told Sura four days, five if they stopped washing, and Sura looked at him and said, "What else?" and he said, "A centurion of the Seventh. Crescens. He took me across the Rhine. A hand-stone, at the second wall," and Sura said, "Was it quick?" and he said, "Yes, sir," and Sura said, "Then write to whoever it is and tell them so, tonight, before you've thought about it. A thing like that's better written by a man who's still stupid with it. Tomorrow you'll want to make it mean something and it didn't."

He wrote to his father that night, by the lamp, the four lines, *Crescens. The second wall. A hand-stone. It was quick*, and under them, because he was still stupid with it: *he said get down off this wall, boy,*

you've no helmet, go and count something. I did. And he sealed it and gave it to the post and fed the Lares from Nola and did not sleep, and in the morning the king's city had four days of water and the staff knew it and so, by noon, from the towers, did the king.

They burned the Seventh's dead on the third evening, below the first wall, where the ground was flat enough, on a pyre of the king's own timber from the breached palisade, and he went down to it, because Sura said *go*, in the voice that was not a kindness, and stood at the back of the cohort with his hands at his sides while the optio who had said the thing said the other thing, the one that was said at pyres, in the flat Picene Latin, badly, because the optio was a man who could hold a ladder and not a man who could speak; and the fire took. The cohort stood, and the smoke went up the mountain toward the city that had four days of water, and the men on the king's towers watched it go up and did not throw anything, because there were things even a man with four days of water did not do.

Afterward the optio found him. He was a short man with a broken nose and the look that optios had, of a man who had been doing a centurion's work for a year without the pay and would now have the pay and would rather not; and he had a thing in his hand wrapped in a bit of cloak, and he held it out, and said, "You're the shipowner's son. Hermes's. He talked about you. Not much; he didn't talk much; but when the oil came from Puteoli he'd say *that's the boy's father* and pass it round, and we'd know." He unwrapped the cloak. "This is yours, he said. If it came to it. He said it two winters ago, drunk, on the far bank, when the Pannonian horse had been through us and we'd lost nine; he said *if it comes to it the stick goes to Hermes's boy, he'll know what it's for, and if he doesn't his father will*. So."

It was the vine-stick. The centurion's, the vitis, the length of a forearm, a thing cut from a vine on a Picene hill and seasoned and carried for twenty-six years and used, on men's backs, for the things

men's backs were used on, and worn smooth at the grip by one hand until it had the shape of the hand in it; and the optio put it in his and he stood with it below the first wall of the king's city with the smoke going up and found that it weighed, like the ring, less than he had thought a thing like that would weigh. That this was going to be true, he understood, of every thing he was ever handed that had been described to him first.

"I don't know what it's for," he said.

"No. He said you wouldn't." The optio wrapped the cloak back round his own hands, which were empty now and did not seem to know it. "He said: *he'll put it in a box and count it. That's what it's for. Somebody ought to.*" And the broken nose went back to the cohort, and the cohort went back up the hill to the ladders, because the city had three days of water now and the ladders did not hold themselves.

He put it in the box. He did not count it; there was one of it. He wrote on the inside of the lid, in the shorthand, *Crescens. Vetera. The Rhine. The Pelican. The second wall*, which was the inventory, and closed the lid, and went back to the stool, and that night when he fed the Lares from Nola he set the stick beside them on the camp-table in the tent, because a woman at a loom had said that the gods liked to see a face and he had decided, on a beach, at fourteen, that a man was his face, and this was the nearest to one that Crescens had left.

◆

The head came in on the sixth day after, in a bag, and he counted that too.

He would have said, if anyone had asked, that he had not expected it to be a thing he saw. He was on a stool in a tent with a box; the war happened outside and came in as sheets. But the king had broken out of the burning city with his guard on the fourth night, west, into the mountains, the way the sum had said he would, because a man with nothing to bargain with bargained with distance; and the emperor had sent the cavalry after him, as the sum had said; and the cavalry were

auxiliaries, Pannonians and Moesians under Roman decurions, and one of the decurions, a Moesian from Philippi called Tiberius Claudius Maximus who had been a trooper in the Seventh when Crescens was a young centurion and had been promoted out of it for being the kind of man who did not stop, had run the king to earth in a gully at the end of a ridge with the horses blown and the guard dead or gone, and had come up on him with four troopers as the king sat against a rock with his own curved knife in his hand; and the king had looked at the Moesian and the Moesian at the king. The king had put the knife into his own throat, under the beard, and drawn it across, as a man did who had been told there was no right moment and had decided to make one; and the Moesian had got off his horse and gone to him and taken the knife out of his hand and the head off his shoulders, because that was the thing you brought back, and had ridden four days to the staff camp below the city with it in a saddlebag and had come into the emperor's tent at noon with the bag in his hand and the whole of the staff standing, and had put it on the table in front of the emperor, and said, in the Latin of Philippi, "Decebalus, lord. He did it himself. I was too late for anything but this."

Celer was at the back, against the tent-wall, with the box.

He saw it. The emperor stood up, which he did not do for legates, and looked at the thing on the table, and it was a man's head, with the beard and the long hair and the cap the Dacian nobles wore still on it, somehow, the Moesian having been careful. The eyes half open and the mouth a little open and the throat under the beard cut in a way that was not neat and was the king's own doing; and it was a face, as Apollonios's had been a face, and it had been an enemy of Rome for twenty years and had taken Fuscus's eagle and made terms and broken them and built a city on a mountain with conduits and cisterns and had looked at the Moesian in a gully and done the sum. The emperor looked at it for a long time. The staff did not move. And then the emperor said, in the slow Spanish Latin that had made Hermes of

Puteoli stand up in an inn, to the Moesian, "You were too late for nothing. You were in time. That's the whole of soldiering; a man who's in time," and took off his own ring, the signet, not the gold, and put it on the Moesian's hand, and said, "Decurion no longer. You'll have your rank by the Kalends and a sheet to say why. Sura; see it's written so a man can read it on a stone in Philippi." And then to the tent: "Have it carried round the camp. Every legion. Let them see it. Then send it to Rome, to the steps, where the Senate can see it, since they've been asking what the terms are." And he sat down again, and the sheet in front of him was the one about the conduits, and he went back to it.

Sura wrote the Moesian's citation that evening, and Celer sat on the stool beside him and told him one thing, which was the name of the Seventh's centurion who had been on the Rhine when the Moesian had been a trooper there, and Sura wrote it in, *formerly of the Seventh Claudia under the centurion Crescens*, and looked at him sideways and said, "That's for the stone in Philippi. Not for you. I'll not have you think I've done you a kindness," and Celer said, "No, sir," and understood that the man had, and that the understanding was the thing that must not be shown, and did not show it; and Sura, who could read anything, read that, and nodded once, and went back to the sheet.

◆

Before the treasure there was the list, and the list was people, and he wrote it.

The city had burned and the king was a head in a bag and what was left on the mountain and in the valleys below it was a kingdom with nobody in charge of it, and the emperor wanted it counted. Not the gold; that came after. The people. How many, where, of what kind, able to walk, able to work, able to be sold, able to be settled, able to be sent to the Syrian's cut in Rome to carry baskets. Sura gave it him on a sheet in the Spanish, *the inventory of the kingdom; begin*, and

he began, on a stool in a tent on the far bank with the Seventh's clerks bringing him tallies from the valleys and the auxiliaries' decurions bringing him tallies from the hill-forts and the slave-dealers who had followed the army up from Moesia like birds behind a plough bringing him their own tallies, which were higher, because a dealer counted what he hoped.

Fifty thousand. That was what it came to, by the end of September, on his sheets, in columns — men, women, children under ten, children over, the old, the hurt, the nobles separately because nobles were a different price and a different problem — and he wrote it the way he had written a granary and a sail, in the square hand, with no story. The figure was the figure, and it was fifty thousand people, and he sat on the stool with the sheet and understood that he had just done the thing his father had said a man in Rome did who was a man, which was to write a number that other men would be moved by, and that the men being moved were in the columns and could not read them.

Sura read it. He read it the way he read everything, fast, with his lips still, and put it down, and said, "That's a province. That's what a province is; it's a sheet like that with a governor's name at the top. You've written the first one of this reign that wasn't a story. Hadrian will read it tonight and write four pages about it in good Greek for the box." He coughed, which was new that autumn, and looked at the boy on the stool. "You've a face. Say it."

"They're people, sir."

"Yes. Fifty thousand of them. And in ten years half will be dead and a quarter will be farming in Moesia under Roman names and a tenth will have carried the Syrian's hill away in baskets and a few hundred will be the household slaves of men who sat in the Senate today and voted the games, and one or two will be free, and rich, and will build tombs by a road with their names cut a hand taller than their patrons', and will sit in strong-rooms with the lid off teaching

their sons what a thing weighs." Nothing in the thin face moved. "Your father was on a sheet like that once. Delos, probably, or Puteoli's own market; I don't know; he's never said and you've never asked. He was a figure in a column and a man wrote him and a man bought him and he's spent forty years making sure his son would be the one with the stylus and not the one in the column. He's done it. You're holding it. Fifty thousand people in your hand on a stool and you're the one who wrote them." A breath. "Don't put it down. That's the only thing I've got to teach you about that sheet. Men who put it down are the ones who stop seeing it's people, and men who can't pick it up are no use to anyone. Hold it. It's heavy. It's meant to be."

He held it. He gave it to the courier for the Senate with the rest. And that night, with the Lares fed and Crescens's stick beside them, he did not write to his father about it, because there were things his father had never said and he had decided, on a stool, with fifty thousand people in his hand, that he would not be the one to ask.

◆

The treasure was under the river.

It came out in August, from a man called Bicilis, who had been the king's friend, in the way that men who had been a king's friend in a burning city were anyone's friend by the time they reached the staff tent; and what he had, for his life and a farm on the Moesian bank, was the river. The Sargetia ran under the city's mountain in a gorge. The king, in the winter after the first war's terms, when he had known what the terms meant and what he would do about them, had taken a cohort of his own prisoners and diverted it — a dam above, a channel cut round, the bed laid bare for two hundred paces — and dug the bed, and put into the digging everything the kingdom had that could not be spent on a war he had already lost, and filled the digging, and broken the dam, and let the river back, and killed the prisoners. Bicilis had held the torch. He drew it, on a sheet, in the staff tent, with a

shaking hand: the bend, the dam-site, the paces from a rock shaped like a sheep.

Apollodorus did it in nine days with four cohorts and the Seventh's engineers. Celer watched him do it; the staff went up to the gorge, because the emperor went, because this was the thing the war had cost and the emperor wanted to see it come up out of the ground with his own eyes; and the Syrian stood on the sheep-rock with lime on his arms and shouted. The dam went up and the channel went round and the river, which had run in its bed under the king's mountain since before there were kings, moved over, sullenly, in a brown slide, and left the bed bare and steaming in the August sun, two hundred paces of wet stones and silt and the bones, already, of the men who had dug it the first time, lying where they had been thrown in before the water came back; and the cohorts went down into it with mattocks.

It came up on the third day of digging. It came up as the sum had said it would, not as a thing but as a column: first a stone slab, then under it a chamber lined with oak, then in the chamber the jars, and in the jars, when the first was broached and tipped, in the bed of a river in front of the emperor of Rome and his staff and a Syrian with lime on his arms, the gold. Not coin. The kingdom had not minted much. Bar and ingot and vessel, the plate of the king's house, the arm-rings of twenty years of nobles, the cups of the temples, the things taken from Fuscus's dead in Domitian's day with the eagles still on them, all of it gone to lumps and bars in the king's furnaces that last winter so it would pack, and packed, and sunk, in jars, under a river, by a man who had known he would lose and had wanted, at the end, to have the last word in the only language the people he was losing to understood.

The emperor looked at it. He said, "Sura. Weigh it. All of it. Every bar. I'll have a figure for the Senate that's a figure and not a story." And Sura turned on the sheep-rock and looked at the boy with the box and said, "Celer. You've a stool. Get it."

So he weighed it. He sat on a stool on the sheep-rock above the bed of the Sargetia for forty-one days with a scale the engineers had built out of a beam and a quartermaster's weights, and a tablet, and two clerks from the Seventh. The cohorts brought it up out of the river in baskets and set it on the pan and he wrote the figure, and the clerk read it back, and the other clerk marked the bar with a punch, and it went into the wagon, and the next came. Bar. Ingot. Cup, flattened. Arm-ring, cut. A thing that had been a breastplate. A thing that had been an eagle, once, and had been melted and had not quite taken and still had, in the lump, the line of a wing. He weighed them all, and wrote them, and did not look at the line of the wing longer than at anything else, because he was on a stool and that was what he was for. He was good at it; and on the fourth day, with the tablet in his lap and the pan going down under a bar the size of his forearm, he understood what he was doing, and stopped, with the stylus up.

He was doing it by weight.

Not by measure. Not by jar or basket or bar; by the pan. *Pondere, non mensura.* The fourth line of the second column of a sail-maker's bill in his father's strong-room when he was eleven, read aloud to a girl who had said *all right* and looked at him while she said it, the thing his father had taught him was a figure and that a woman on the Caelian had, by now — he did not know this; he knew it; he had been told by nobody and knew it as he had known Apollonios would be in the room before he was — had decided what it was worth. He sat on the sheep-rock with a king's gold on the pan and a river going by in a channel a Syrian had cut and knew, with the clarity that came after the sum and never before it, that somewhere behind him, in Rome, on a hill, the house with the columns that weren't marble was being read, line by line, by someone who had been eleven in the strong-room. That the line being read was this one, and that he was sitting on a rock doing it right, in front of an emperor, for a figure that would be a figure and not a story, while his father had done it wrong for ten years

for a Subura baker's loaf that was a tenth water.

"Celer." Sura, from the wagon. "You've stopped."

"Sir." He wrote the figure. The clerk read it back. The punch came down. "Twenty-two pounds, four ounces. Bar. Forty-first."

"Good." Sura came up the rock with the knife-face and stood behind him and looked at the tablet over his shoulder, as he had looked at a granary sheet in a tent four years ago, and said, very quietly, in the Spanish, so the clerks would not have it: "You did the sum. I saw you do it. It went across your face like a sail going over. What was it?"

"My father, sir."

"Yes. I thought it might be. The prefect's people have been in his books since the autumn and the Augusta's had the figures from Puteoli since the spring and there's a sheet on my table in Rome that I've not opened and that Philon tells me has a girl's name under it." The voice did not change. "I'll open it when we're back. I'll set it aside. You'll read it. I'll not spare you that and I'll not pretend I would; it's the only way you'll ever be any use to me, if you've read the worst sheet there is with your own name on the next page and gone on counting." The hand came down on his shoulder, once, as it had on the stool on the Aventine when he was fourteen and had said *he's going to be emperor*; a weight, and gone. "Now weigh the king's gold. All of it. By weight. It's the one honest thing that's happened on this river and I want a boy from Puteoli to have done it, because the Senate'll ask who did the figures and I'll tell them, and some of them will laugh, and the ones who don't will be the ones to watch."

The balance was the Syrian's, and it was the biggest Celer had ever seen: a beam of oak eight feet long bound with iron, hung from a tripod of ship's spars sunk in the river-bed, with a pan at each end the size of a cart-wheel, and the weights were the army's, the stamped bronze and lead of a legion's quartermaster, brought up from the river-camp on two mules and laid out on a hide in the order of their

size with a Guardsman standing over them who had been told, by the emperor, that if one went missing it would be his own weight that was taken in its place.

He began at the first hour, when the light was enough to read a stamp by, and he did not stop till the ninth, and that was the first day, and the other forty were the same.

The gold came up out of the river-bed on the men's shoulders, bar by bar, in a line, and onto the boards; the Syrian's men, stripped to the waist and wet to the thigh, with the mud of a king's river on them to the hair. A bar was laid in the left-hand pan. It took two of them to lay it. The beam went down on that side with a sound the spars made, a groan, and he said the weights, by name, and the Guardsman handed them, and he set them in the right-hand pan himself, with his own hands, one and then the next, in the order the sum said — the hundred, the fifty, the twenty, the ten — and watched the beam, and it came up, slowly, the way a thing came up that had made up its mind, and hung, and he looked along it from the end with one eye shut against the Syrian's mark cut in the oak, and said *level*, or did not, and took a weight off, or put one on, and looked again. Then he wrote it. Then the bar came out, and the next went in, and the beam groaned.

By the third hour the sun was on the river-bed and the bed held it like a kiln, and the men bringing the bars had stopped talking, and the sweat ran into his eyes and he wiped it with the back of the hand that held the stylus and left a mark on his face that was there till night. By the fifth his shoulders had a thing in them from the lifting of the weights that he knew would be worse tomorrow, and the figures on the tablet had begun to do what figures did when a man had looked at too many, which was to come loose from what they meant, and he stopped, and went to the river's edge where the Syrian had the water turned aside, and knelt, and put his whole head in, and held it there with his eyes open in the brown cold until the figures went back

where they belonged, and came up, and went back to the beam.

There was a bar on the sixth day that was wrong.

Not in the weighing. In the hand. He had it in the pan and the weights in and the beam level and he had written it and the men had their hands on it to lift it out, and he said *wait*, and they waited, and he did not know why he had said it. Then he did. The bar was the same as the others, a rough block the length of his forearm with the king's furnace-mark on it; and it had come up lighter than the others by a tenth, which happened, since a king's furnace was not a mint, and he had written it; and it was the colour. Not much. The colour a thing was when it had been made to look like a thing and was not quite. He had seen it once before, at eleven, in a strong-room, on a coin his father had put in his hand and said *tell me*. He took the bar out of the pan himself, which he had not done with any other, and it was heavy, and he turned it, and on the underside where it had lain in the river there was a place where the surface had gone, with the water and the years, and under the surface was not gold.

"Lead," he said. He said it in Greek, to the Syrian, who had come across at the *wait*. "Cased. A finger thick. The king's people have put at least one bar in the river that they'd not have wanted him to find in his own treasury."

Apollodorus looked at the bar, and then at the river-bed, where there were still, by the sum, four thousand to come up, and then at the boy, and said, "Or the king knew, and had it put in with the rest, and laughed. I'd have." He turned the bar over with his foot. "Can you tell them by the look? Standing?"

"No. By the weight, against the size. I'll have to measure every one as well as weigh it. It'll be slower."

"Then it'll be slower." The Syrian went back to his water. "Write that one on its own sheet. The emperor will want to see it. He'll want to hold it. Men like him always want to hold the one that was a lie."

He measured every one after that, with a cord knotted at the Syrian's thumb's width, length and breadth and depth, and did the sum on each against its weight, in his head, as it came up, so that by the end of the forty-first day he had done the sum more times than there were men in the army and had found nine more that were lead, and had them on their own sheet, and could do the figure for a bar of king's gold from its measure alone, standing, before it touched the pan, within a fiftieth, and knew that this was a thing nobody else in the empire could do and that it would be of no use to anyone ever again.

He weighed the king's gold. Forty-one days. The figure, when it was done and the last wagon had gone down the gorge toward the Syrian's bridge and the road and Rome, was a figure, and not a story. He gave it to Sura on a sheet in the square hand and Sura gave it to the emperor and the emperor read it and said *that'll pay for the forum* and gave it to the Senate's courier; and the figure went down the road behind the head, and became, in Rome, within the year, a story anyway, because that was what Rome did with figures, and the story had no boy in it, and the ones who did not laugh asked, as Sura had said they would, and were told, and remembered.

◆

Aper came to the sheep-rock on the seventh, with the Fifth's foraging party, on a horse, in the thin stripe, with his round face thinner than it had been and a scar through one eyebrow he had not had in the spring; and he got down and stood at the edge of the Syrian's pit with the gold going by below him on the boards, and looked at it for a long time, and did not say anything at all, which Celer had never known him do.

Then he said, "How much?"

Celer told him. The figure for the day; not the whole.

"Gods." Aper looked at the boards. "I've a cohort that's not been paid since the Ides of May and there's a king's ransom going past me

on a plank." He looked at Celer. "You've got thin. You've got that face on you that Sura has. The one that's reading something that isn't there."

"I'm counting."

"You're always counting. That's not the face." Aper sat down on the rock with his legs out, as he had sat on a bridge, and on a pallet, and on everything, and pulled a skin from his saddle-bag and held it out, arm straight. "Drink. I've something to say and I'll not say it dry." Celer drank. "The Fifth's going back to Moesia in October. I'm going with it. And then I'm going home. My father's had the stroke they all have and my brother's a fool, and somebody's to see to the salt, and it'll be me, because I'm the one that can be liked by the men who rake it." He took the skin back. "I'll not come to Rome again. Not for years. Maybe for a triumph. I'd like to see you walk in a triumph behind this lot with your lips moving."

Celer looked at the gold. The forty boards. The men going down into the river-bed and coming up with the thing on their shoulders that had been under a king's water for three years.

"You were the only one," he said. He had not planned to say it. It was the first thing in four years that had come out of him without his having turned it over.

"The only what?"

"The only one who never once asked what my father was."

Aper was quiet. Then he said, in the voice he kept for the inside of a tent, "I asked. The first night. I asked the day-book man before you came in, and he told me, and I thought, *well, that's nothing to do with me,* and went to sleep." He stood up and brushed the rock off his tunic. "That's not virtue, Celer. It's a salt-pan. We don't have the time." He put his hand on Celer's shoulder, once, hard, and took it away. "Write to me in Ariminum. Not about the gold. About you. I'll not be able to read it and I'll have my steward's boy do it, and it'll embarrass us both. Do it anyway."

He rode off with the foraging party down the valley, singing; and Celer stood at the edge of the pit and counted the next board, and got it, and wrote it, and found that he had to write it twice, because the first time his hand had put down the figure for the board before, which it had never done. He looked at the wrong figure for a while before he rubbed it out.

The Spaniard came to the sheep-rock on the ninth day.

He came up the gorge on foot from the Minervia's lines with two of his own staff and the lime of the dam on his boots and stood below the rock in the August evening looking at the river in its channel and the bed laid bare and the baskets coming up, and then at the boy on the stool with the scale, and said in the Greek, to nobody, "He's done it by weight. Of course he has. Lucius told me he would and I didn't believe him; I thought you'd count the bars and be done. Nobody weighs. Weighing's for merchants." The grey eyes came up. "You're a merchant's son."

"A shipowner's, sir."

"Same god, different altar." The Spaniard climbed the rock. He was thirty, and a legate, and had taken four hill-forts and written sixteen sheets about them, and he stood on the sheep-rock beside the stool as if it were a couch on the Aventine, and looked at the tablet, and read it, upside down, fast, the way Sura read, and said, "Twenty-two pounds four ounces, forty-first bar. You've a hand like a surveyor's. Apollodorus wants you for the forum; he's told the emperor so, in front of me, which is how I know he means it. Lucius says no. Lucius says *until I'm dead*." He looked at the river. "Lucius has a cough this year. Have you noticed?"

Celer had noticed. He said nothing.

"No. You wouldn't say. That's why he keeps you." The Spaniard's face did the thing it did, the thing that was not quite a smile and was the look of a man who found everything interesting, and a little short of what it might have been. "I'll not ask you to leave him. I asked once

and he told me his sum and he was right. I'll tell you a thing instead, since we're on a rock and Lucius isn't, and you can do what you like with it, which is what you'll do anyway." He crouched, so that the grey eyes were level with the stool. "The sheet on Lucius's table. The one with the girl's name under it. I've read it. Not the original; the Augusta's copy; she sends me what she thinks I'll want, which is most things. I know what it says and I know what your father did and I know, because the Augusta told me, in the one sentence she spends on such things, what the girl paid to say it, which was a year of her tongue and a thing she'd rather have kept." He let that sit. "Lucius will set it aside for you, because that's Lucius; he thinks a man's made by the worst sheet. I think a man's made by what he does on the next page. And I think, Hermes's son, that when you've read it four ways you'll pick the wrong one, because you're nineteen and you were raised on a figure, and I'd like you to know, before you do, that there's a man on this hill who's read it and read *her* and thinks she did the only thing a woman in a room with no door could have done, and would have done it himself, and has." He stood. "Weigh your gold. Apollodorus says the wing on the forty-first was the Fifth Alaudae's and I think he's right; it's the only eagle Fuscus lost that wasn't found."

He went down the rock. His staff fell in behind him. Celer sat with the stylus and the tablet and the forty-second bar on the pan and the Spaniard's back going away down the gorge in the evening with the lime on its boots, and did not weigh the bar for the length of time it took the river to move a hundred paces in its channel, and then did.

"Nineteen pounds, eleven ounces. Bar. Forty-second."

"Nineteen eleven, forty-two," said the clerk, and the punch came down.

And that night, in the tent, by the lamp, with the Lares fed and the figure for the day in the box and Sura coughing two tents away, he did the thing that Sura had told him not to do and that he had not done for Crescens and did now, which was to try to make it mean

something; and he sat with the tablet on his knee and wrote, in the square hand, on a sheet he would not send, in the house's shorthand that only one other living person could read: *F. — I've weighed a king by the pan on a rock in a river. 41st bar had a wing on it. Crescens is dead; a hand-stone; it was quick; he said go and count something. You'll have told them by now. I know what. I know why. I've not read it and I know, because I'm on a stool and that's what I'm for and it's not for nothing. I'll read it four ways when I'm back and I'll pick one and the Spaniard says I'll pick wrong. Say "and?" I've nothing after it. — C.*

He read it once. He held it to the lamp. He watched it go, the way he had sat on the end of a mole in the dark with a girl's hand flat on his chest holding him at the length of her arm, and no further; and when it was gone he put the stylus down and sat with his hands open on his knees in the tent on the far bank of the Danube in the last year of a kingdom and listened to Lucius Licinius Sura cough, and counted the coughs, because he counted everything. The number was higher than it had been in June.

19

What the Column Means

Rome and Laurentum, summer and autumn 106

She told Marcia on the Ides of July, in the room, with the comb, and it took the length of a hair.

She had thought about how. She had thought about it for a month, in the corridor nobody used and the litter and the dark of the room off the lady's with the ivory on the sill where she could see the gold on the break; and what she had decided was that it should be done the way her mother would have done it, which was all at once and without ornament, as a slate was read to a Rhodian who had drunk eleven. Not a confession. A column. She was being asked for a figure and she would give a figure and the figure would be true and what it cost was not on the sheet, and she would not put it there, because the Augusta had said *nothing's free* and she had understood that to mean, among other things, that you did not make the person you were paying watch you count the coins.

So on the Ides, when the room emptied and Marcia did not say *not you* but only looked at her from the door with the round face and the comb, she went through the door. The Augusta was on the couch with the cloth, and Marcia stood at the shoulder, and Fausta stood by the wall with the box of pins, and began, in Latin, in the eggs voice, to the comb.

"The grain-office pays the carriers by weight at the quay, domina. Pondere, non mensura — by the pound, not the measure. The man who weighs is the prefect's and the man who provides the scale is the port's and in Puteoli the port's man for twenty years was a freedman of the house of Granius who's dead now and whose son has the place. Hermes of Puteoli has three hulls in the Alexandria run. His manifests

state the cargo in modii from Egypt and in pounds at the quay, and the pounds are right. The pounds are always right. The prefect's man weighs what's on the pan. What's on the pan is wheat and a sail." She did not look up. "A wet sail. The carriers run with a spare mainsail stowed over the forward hold, and in the night before they're weighed it's gone over the side on a line and come up and been stowed again, and the forward hold is weighed with the sail across the hatch-boards because that's how it was stowed and the prefect's man's not a sailor. A wet sail is four hundred pounds. Three hulls, four hundred pounds a hull, nine voyages a year in a good year, ten years. And that's the bounty, because a hull that's over weight is a hull that's early and full and nobody docks a hull that's over. The Ostia carriers don't do it because the Ostia port's man is Sura's cousin's freedman and has been since Nerva. The Puteoli carriers all do it; Hermes isn't the only one; he's the only one who wrote it down." She let a breath go. "The fourth line of the second column of a sail-maker's bill in his strong-room, eleven years ago. *Pondere non mensura*, in his hand, in the margin, with the figure for a spare mainsail of the heavy canvas, and a second figure under it that's what the mainsail weighs wet, in his hand, because he's a man who writes the sum down. He reads everything twice and writes it once and it's never wrong and he's never burned a sheet in his life. The bill's in the second room off the strong-room in a pine box with the other sail-makers' bills from the year the *Isis* was bought and fitted, which was the year the old emperor adopted the Spaniard. The box has his seal on the lid and the lid's been off; I saw it."

The comb had stopped. She did not look at it.

"That's the column, domina. That's what it means. The short weight in the Subura bread for ten years is a wet sail in the forward hold of three hulls in Puteoli and a dead port-man's son on a scale, and it's in Hermes's own hand in a pine box, and if the prefect's people go to the box they'll find it, and if they go to the port-man's

son first they'll find nothing, because he'll have had a boy in the strong-room before them. Hermes has boys everywhere. It's what he's for."

She stopped. The room was very quiet; the city went about its noise under the window.

Under the cloth, the Augusta said: "The name of the box."

"Pine, Augusta. Sail-makers. The *Isis* year. His seal."

"Marcia."

"I have it, Augusta."

"Then it's done." The cloth did not move. "Girl. The Spaniard's wife's stool. Sit."

She sat. She put the box of pins on her knees. She had not wept and would not. She had given the figure all at once without ornament as her mother would have, and it had taken the length of a hair, and now it was in Marcia's round head and would be on a sheet by evening and in Sura's office by the Kalends and on a stool, read, by whoever was on the stool, and she had done it. There was a thing in her that was not the shutter and was not the floor and that she had not had a name for since a shutter would not bar, and she decided, on Sabina's stool, that she would call it the price, and keep it, and look at it when she needed to know what a thing cost.

"You told it like a manifest," the Augusta said. "Hull, weight, voyage, year. No *I*. Tertulla told me you'd do that and I said no, there'd be an *I* in it somewhere, she's eighteen; and there wasn't. So I was wrong, which happens once a year, and I'll mark the day." A pause. "What did you leave out?"

"Nothing, Augusta."

"Yes you did. You left out that the boy read it to you. You left out that you said *all right*. You left out the pine box's lid being off because you were in that room when it was, and the only reason a shipowner's strong-room has a freedwoman's daughter in it is that the shipowner's son put her there." The voice under the cloth was level,

metrical, the voice for Horace. "I'm not asking you to put it in. It's not the figure. I'm telling you I know it's missing so that you'll not think you got it past me, because the day you think that is the day you start leaving things out that *are* the figure, and then I've no use for you and you're in Laurentum. Do you understand?"

"Yes, Augusta."

"Good. Then here's the other half, which Tertulla doesn't know, because I've not told her, because she's got the cough and I'll not spend her on it." The cloth came off. The Augusta sat up, and the plain face that showed what it decided to showed, now, something Fausta had seen once on it and had decided was nearly tiredness, and was. "Sura's back in October with the emperor and the gold. He's got the cough too, worse than Tertulla's; Hadrian writes me so, in the one sentence he spends on Lucius. The sheet goes to his office and he'll set it aside for the boy, because that's what he does. And the prefect's people will go to Puteoli with the sheet and the box, and Hermes of Puteoli will be fined. Not ruined; fined. He'll pay it, and it'll be most of what he has that isn't in his son's name, and he'll know in a day who read the column. He has boys everywhere." She looked at the girl on the stool. "You've not killed a man. You've made a man's figure wrong for the first time in his life, in front of his son. I've done it. It's worse."

"Yes, Augusta."

"*Yes, Augusta.*" The Augusta lay back. "You've got the voice for it already. I had it at twenty." The cloth went over the eyes. "Marcia. The sheet. Tonight. And have the girl taken home the back way; Tertulla's son has a boy at the foot of the hill who counts her in and out and I'd rather he counted her late today, and wondered."

◆

The lady's cough took her to Laurentum in August, and Fausta did not go.

That was the lady's doing, and the Augusta's, and she understood both and was permitted to argue with neither. The lady went to the sea because the doctor from Laurentum said the air, and because she was sixty-four and had buried a husband and a daughter and had decided, Fausta thought, watching her decide it, that if she was to do the thing the cough was for she would do it where she could see water. And the girl stayed on the Caelian because the Augusta's hair was the Kalends and the Ides and the Augusta did not go to Laurentum in August, the Augusta went nowhere, the Augusta was a woman on a couch with a cloth on a hill and the hill did not move; and so the girl who did the hair did not move either. The lady said so, in the atrium, with the litter waiting and the cough in her chest like a thing with a grip, and the pale eyes on her girl.

"You'll stay. Phaedrus has the house. Momus has you. The son's at the stable wing and the stable wing's the stable wing; he's not set foot in my side of this house uninvited in thirty-one years and he'll not start because I've gone to breathe." The thin hand came out of the litter and did not touch her face; it touched the ivory in her hair, at the side, with one finger, on the gold. "You'll do the Augusta's hair and you'll write to me on the Nones with what the room said and you'll write it in the Latin I taught you and not the eggs, and when I'm back we'll talk about Puteoli, because the Augusta's told me you've paid, and I'd like to hear from you what, since she'll only tell me the figure."

"Yes, domina."

"And child." The pale eyes held. "I've told Phaedrus a thing and I'll tell you so you know he's been told. If the son comes to my side of the house while I'm gone, for any reason, Phaedrus is to send to the Augusta the same hour. Not to me. To *her*. The son knows this; I told him at dinner, in front of the dwarf, so he'd know the dwarf knew. It's the only thing I can do from Laurentum and I've done it." The hand went back into the litter. "It'll hold. He's patient. Patient men don't break a thing they've waited for. That's what patience *is*."

The litter went. Fausta stood in the atrium with the pools and the ancestors looking down and Momus on his stool by the door, and the dwarf said, low, when the sound of the bearers had gone down the hill, "She's wrong, you know. About patience. It's not that they don't break a thing. It's that they wait till breaking it's cheaper than waiting. I've known three patient men and they all had a number, and the number moved."

"What was his number?"

"Her cough," said Momus. "I told you. And it's gone to Laurentum, and the doctor looks at it the way doctors look, and he knows that, because he was at dinner too, and so he's doing his sum again, girl, and I'd not be alone in a corridor till it's done."

◆

She was not alone in a corridor. She was alone in the room off the lady's, in September, in the night, on the Nones, with the letter to Laurentum written and sealed on the sill beside the ivory. The door barred, because she barred it, because she had barred every door she slept behind since a shutter that would not, and the bar was oak and the brackets were iron and the lady's house was a consul's and built by people who had meant it.

He did not come through the door.

She would understand, afterwards — not that night; that night she understood nothing, she was a thing in a room — that there was a second door. That the room off the lady's had been, once, before it was a girl's, a dressing-room, and that a dressing-room in a consul's house had a slaves' door, narrow, in the panelling behind the chest where the lady's winter things were kept, that gave on a passage that ran behind the lady's rooms to the slaves' court, and that had been papered over, and was known to the people who had been born in the house, and not to the people who had been in it twelve years, or three. Phaedrus did not know; he had twelve years and a key to every door he had been shown. Momus knew, because Momus had forty years and a

stool at the end of the corridor it opened onto, and had thought it bricked. The lady knew and had forgotten, because a door you have not used since your husband died is a door that is not there. And the son knew, because he had been born in this house and had been a small patient boy in it, finding doors.

She woke because the lamp had moved. She kept a lamp lit; the lady had said so, the first week, *you keep a lamp lit, child, that's the first thing*, and she had, every night for three years, low, on the sill by the letter and the ivory. It had moved, the light had moved, because a door she did not know was a door had opened in the panelling behind the chest and the air had come through and the flame had leaned; and she was awake, all at once, the way she had been awake at eleven in a lodging-house with the Rhodian on the stair, and he was in the room.

She would keep it. She kept everything. But she would keep it the way she had kept the egg-woman's mother's hands on her mother's body at the end, which was by looking at the lamp, at the ivory, at the sealed letter on the sill with the lady's name on it in the Latin the lady had taught her, and not at the thing itself; and so what she kept was the lamp, and the ivory, and the letter, and the sound of her own breath, which was the eggs voice and did not stop being it; and his weight, which was the heaviness that had gone to the shoulders; and his patience, which was the worst of it, which was that he was not quick and not rough and not drunk and did not speak, and did it as he did everything, as a man did a thing he had put where it would be seen and waited for; and that she did not scream, because the lady had told her at dinner in front of the dwarf that the son knew the dwarf knew, and so she understood, at the start, with the lamp leaning, that a scream was a thing he had already counted and that whatever he had counted it against was heavier; and that she did the sum, in the eggs voice, under his weight, with her eyes on the ivory. The sum was *live*, and she lived; and that it was not long, and that it was not brief; and that when it was done he stood up in the leaning light and arranged

his tunic as a man did who was going back to the stable wing by a passage, and looked at her, with his mother's narrow patient face, and said the only thing he said, which was, "Now it's known. It was always going to be known. I've only moved the day," and went out by the door in the panelling and pulled it to behind him, and the lamp straightened.

She lay in the straightened light. The letter to Laurentum was on the sill with the lady's name on it. The ivory was beside it with the gold on the break. She looked at them for a time she did not count, which was the first thing in eight years she had not counted, and then she got up, and unbarred the oak door that had held, and went out into the corridor nobody used, and down it, in her shift, with her hair down, to the end, where a stool was, and a dwarf on it who did not sleep, and who looked up at her face in the corridor's bad light and got down off the stool without a word and went past her, fast, on the short legs, toward the slaves' court and the steward's room. She stood in the corridor with her back to the wall and her feet under her and waited, as she had waited for a Rhodian's eleven to come right, and it came right, because Phaedrus came, with a lamp, and a face like water with a stone dropped in it, and looked at her, and said, in the Greek, very quietly, "The panelling door."

"Yes."

"I never knew it was there. Twelve years, and I never knew. He did." The Alexandrian's face went blank the way a face did when a steward who had not declared anything in twelve years understood that he had just been made to. "I'm sending to the hill. Now. As she said. Not to Laurentum; to *her*. Momus is at the gate; he'll go himself; nobody stops a dwarf at the Palatine postern at night, they think he's a gift." He held the lamp up and looked at her the way the Augusta had, to see what was load-bearing. "Can you stand until the morning?"

"I'm standing."

"So you are." He lowered the lamp. "Then stand in my room. It has one door and I'll be in front of it. And in the morning Marcia will come, or someone Marcia sends, and you'll say it as a manifest, the way you said the sail, because that's the only way it'll be heard on that hill, and if you say it any other way it'll be a girl's story and girls' stories go to Laurentum." He turned. "Come. I'll not touch you. I'd not have anyone touch you tonight. But come."

She went. She stood in the steward's room with its one door and the Alexandrian in front of it with his back to her on a stool and the lamp between them until the light came grey through the shutter, and she did not sit, and she did not weep, and she did not sleep, and somewhere toward the end of it she found that she had put her hand to her hair, where the ivory would have been. That it was not there, and that she had left it on the sill, and that she would go back for it, in the morning, and wear it, because it was hers now in a way it had not been, and because the Augusta had said *keep wearing it*, and because a thing he had put in her hand to be seen was now a thing she would be seen in, and the seeing would do the work, and he had taught her that.

It was Zaidê who came in the morning, before Marcia, before anyone, with water.

Not sent. The house did not send a cup-washer to the steward's room at the first hour; the house did not know, yet, what there was to send for. She came because she had seen the Alexandrian's door shut at midnight with the lamp behind it and the Alexandrian's stool against it from the inside, and had done her own sum on that, nine years in the house being enough to do it with; and she came in past Phaedrus, who let her, with a basin and a jug and a clean shift over her arm, and set them on the table, and looked once at Fausta standing where she had stood all night, and at the ivory not in her hair, and at the hem, and said nothing at all.

She poured the water. She did it the way she did everything with a jug, without a drop on the table, and stood back.

Fausta washed. Her hands first; then her face; then she took off the shift she had on and Zaidê took it from her without looking at it, and gave her the clean one, and folded the other over her own arm with the inside in, as a woman folded a thing that was going to the fuller's and not coming back, and that was all the acknowledgement there was, the fold.

"The room off hers," Zaidê said. Not a question. To the basin. "There's no bolt on it. There's one on the bakehouse hatch; I put it there myself, the second year, with a nail and a strap. Nobody asked me why."

"No."

"Nobody asks me anything."

Zaidê nodded. The flat face did nothing; it had never, in four years, done anything, and Fausta understood now that this was not stupidity and had never been, and that the Smyrna Greek had been wrong about it the way the whole house was wrong about it, and that a girl bought at six in Antioch had learned the shutter without a mother to teach it her, on her own, from need, and had kept it so well that even the lady had stopped looking for anything behind it. "I'll burn this. Not the fuller's; they talk. The bakehouse, tonight, when the ovens are banked. Nobody counts the linen in this house but me." She went to the door, and stopped, and said with her back turned, in the Syrian that Fausta had enough of now to follow, "I slept in that room. The first year. Before I knew. Somebody should have told me and nobody did, and I told you what I could on a roof, and you'd your reasons for the room, and I'd like to know what reason's worth that, and I'll not ask." She went out.

Fausta stood in the clean shift with her wet face and looked at the door. Four years, and she had done the sum on everyone in the house, the lady and the steward and the dwarf and the son and the twelve, and had left one girl out of it because the girl had a face like a dish and washed cups, and she put her in now, late, at the bottom of the

column, and found that it altered the total.

◆

Marcia came herself.

She came at the second hour with two of the Augusta's Germans, who stood in the atrium under the ancestors and did not look at anything, and she came into the steward's room with the round brown face arranged as it was in the room on the hill and sat down on Phaedrus's stool without being asked and folded her hands and said, in the Nemausus Latin, "Say it."

She said it. As a manifest. The hour, the lamp, the panelling, the chest, the passage behind the lady's rooms, the weight, the words he had said. No *I* that could be left out. It took the length of a hair.

Marcia listened. When it was done she sat for a moment with her hands folded and then she said, "The Augusta had Momus at the postern at the third hour of the night and had me out of bed at the fourth and I've been with her since, and I'll tell you what she said, all of it, because she told me to, and because you've earned the whole and not the figure." The round face did not change. "She said: *he's moved the day.* She said: *he's done his sum and the sum was that his mother's dying and the house comes to him and the girl with it, and that when it does, it's known, and that a thing that's going to be known can be made known sooner at the cost of one night's risk, and the risk was me.* She said: *he's wagered that I'll not move a hair-girl against a consul's son for a thing done in his own mother's house where the law gives him more than it gives her, and that by the time Tertulla's dead and the question's whose the girl is, the answer will already be in every mouth on the hill, and I'll find it easier to let it lie.*" Marcia unfolded her hands. "She said: *he's not a fool. That's a good sum. It's the one I'd have made in his place.*"

Fausta stood by the wall. The price was in her, where she kept it, and she looked at it.

"And then?"

"And then she said: *but he's made it against the wrong woman, because I'm not a hill, I'm a headache, and a headache doesn't do what's easier, it does what's* quiet. And she said this, and I'm to say it to you exactly: *tell the girl that I'll not move a hair against him. Tell her that. Tell her that the law's his and the house is his mother's and that nothing that happened in that room happened, on the hill, because if it happened then I have to do something about it and the thing I'd have to do is loud. Tell her I'm sorry; I've said it once in thirty years and I'm saying it now, through you, so it's not in my mouth. And then tell her that there's a procuratorship in Mauretania Tingitana, the lesser one, the one that counts the corn-ships at Tingis, that's been vacant since the spring because nobody with a consul's name will take it, and that the emperor's secretary for appointments owes me a thing from the year of the adoption, and that a man who's never been north of Ariminum could be in Tingis by the Kalends of November if his name went in a letter this week, and that Tertulla's son's name is a consul's name, and would do.*" Marcia stood up. "She said: *that's not justice. Justice is loud. That's paper. Ask the girl if she wants paper. If she says yes, she writes the letter herself, to me, in her own hand, asking for it, and I keep the letter, and she knows I keep it, and that's the price, and it's the last thing I'll ever give her for free, because after this she's not a hair-girl, she's a woman who's had a man sent to Africa, and women like that pay for everything.*"

The room was quiet. Phaedrus, by the door, had not moved. Outside, in the atrium, the Germans stood under the ancestors.

Fausta said, "He'll know who."

"Yes. He'll know. He'll count corn-ships in Tingis for five years knowing. When Tertulla goes you come to the hill, to Sabina; she's asked twice and been refused and won't be a third time." Marcia went to the door. "He's a patient man. In five years he'll come back and you'll be twenty-three and whatever the Augusta's made you by then, and he'll have to do his sum again. I'd not like to be him." She stopped

at the door and looked back, and the round brown face, for the first time in Fausta's knowledge of it, did something that was not arranged. "I'm not sorry. Sorry costs and buys nothing. But I'll tell you this, girl. When I was fourteen in Nemausus there was a man in my mistress's house with a patient face, and there was no panelling door, and no dwarf, and no hill to send to. There was a river. I'll say no more about it than that. When you write your letter asking for Tingis I'll put it in the box with the only other letter like it I've ever kept, which is mine, to her, in the year of the adoption." She opened the door. "Write it today. The secretary for appointments dines with the Augusta on the Ides and I'll want it in her hand by then. Ink's in the steward's desk. Phaedrus will bring you the sheet. Then go and get your pin. It's on the sill. You'll want it for the Kalends."

She wrote it. In the Latin the lady had taught her, not the eggs, to Marcia, freedwoman of the Augusta, from Fausta, daughter of Hilara, freedwoman of Lucius Laecanius Bassus: that she understood the procuratorship of the corn-ships at Tingis was vacant, and that she begged the Augusta's freedwoman to recall to the Augusta that the lady Cornelia Tertulla's son was a man of a consul's name and unemployed, and that the lady Cornelia was ill at Laurentum and might be eased by knowing her son had a post. Four lines. No *I* that could be left out. She sealed it with the Dolphin, the brass fish, which she had carried against her skin for four years and had not used for anything but a lease, and gave it to Phaedrus, and went down the corridor nobody used to the room off the lady's, and in by the oak door. The lamp was out, and the letter to Laurentum was on the sill, and the ivory was beside it.

She put it in her hair. At the side. Where the lamp would catch the gold on the break.

Then she sat down on the bed, for the first time, and looked at the panelling behind the chest where a door was that was not a door, and did the sum, slowly, out loud, to the empty room, because there was

no one to hear it and she wanted to hear what it sounded like: "A man to Africa, for a letter. That's one. That's the first I've done by paper. Momus says a patient man has a number and the number moves. Mine's five years. I'll count them." And then, after a while, in her mother's voice, which she had not used since a mole: "And?"

There was nothing after it. She had known there would not be. She sat with it anyway, in the room with two doors, until Phaedrus knocked on the one that barred and said through it, in the Greek like water, that the sheet had gone to the hill with Momus, and that the son had left for the stable wing's country place at Tibur an hour ago with two mules and no word, and that the lady's letter was still on the sill and would she like it sent, or would she write it again.

"Again," she said. "She'll want to know what the room said. I'll tell her. It said Tingis."

◆

On the Kalends of October she did the Augusta's hair, and the Augusta said nothing about it, which was the thing.

She had known she would not. She had been told, through Marcia, in words meant to be exact, that nothing had happened on the hill because if it had the hill would have had to be loud; and she went up it in the litter alone, with Momus walking beside the bearers because Phaedrus would not have her go up it without a face from the house, and through the gate and along the long wall into the room with one window and eleven women. The benches looked at her as they had looked for three years, which was not at all, and that was the first thing she kept from that morning: that it had held. Whatever the son had counted on, the thing being in every mouth on the hill by the Kalends, it was not. The mouths were shut. A headache had shut them. She did not know how and would learn, over years, that it was not done by any one thing but by a woman on a couch having been for thirty years the person nobody wanted to be the one to tell.

She went through the door. The Augusta was on the couch with the cloth off and the book, and Matidia was on her stool with hers, and Sabina was not there, because it was the Kalends and the Kalends were her mother's; and Marcia stood at the shoulder with the comb and the round face arranged, and said, "The old way," as she said, and Fausta put down the box and began.

She had done it on wax heads, forty times, in the coast woman's room, and twice on Marcia, who had sat for it with her eyes shut saying *no* and *again* and *no*; she had never done it on the head of a living empress who was reading, and her hands knew the difference before she did, and went cold, and she let them, and put them in the hair.

The old way was nothing. That was its difficulty. The new way, the Spaniard's wife's, was a thing of forty pins and a frame and a hairpiece and took two hours and could hide a bad hand under its own weight; the old way, the Nemausus way, the way the Augusta's mother had worn it in a town in Narbonensis where nobody had been looking, was the hair parted at the centre with a bone comb and drawn back in two plain wings over the ears and gathered at the nape in a knot that was held with three pins and nothing else, and every hair that was out of place in it could be seen from the door, and the Augusta had worn it for twenty years in front of the Senate for exactly that reason. The part first. She drew the comb from the brow to the crown and the crown to the nape in one movement and it ran true, which it did one time in three on the wax, and she did not breathe out. Then the wings. The hair was fine, as grey hair went fine, and dry, and wanted to lift off the comb with the October air in the room; she wet her fingers from the dish, barely, and drew it down and back, left and then right, and it lay. Behind her she heard Marcia not move. The Augusta turned a page. At the nape she gathered what she had in her left hand and turned it on itself twice, the way the coast woman had shown her with a rope, and held it, and reached for the first pin with

her right without looking, and it was there, because Marcia had put it where her hand would go, and she set it; and the second; and the third, which was the one that held, and that had to go in at an angle no one had ever been able to tell her and that her hand found, that morning, without her.

It had taken the length of a short letter. Her hands had stopped being cold at the second wing and she had not noticed when.

The Augusta read. She turned a page. Her hair was fine and grey and had been plain, once, on a coast built on ash, and Fausta's hands did what the coast woman had taught them in a steward's room three years ago, which was nothing, done perfectly, and the room was quiet, and the city went about its noise under the window. The ivory at the side of her own head caught the light from the one window on the gold at the break; and when it was done, and the last pin was in, the Augusta put the book down and turned her head, once, to the left and the right, as she did, and said to the ceiling: "That's it. That's my mother's."

And then, without looking at anyone: "The secretary for appointments dined on the Ides. He tells me the lesser procuratorship at Tingis is filled, by a man of consular family who's been wanting a post, and that the man sails from Puteoli on the first fair wind. Tertulla will be pleased. She's always wanted him to do something." A page turned, though the book was closed; it was Matidia's. "Marcia. Have we anything else?"

"No, Augusta."

"Then the room may go."

That was all. Fausta picked up the box and went to the door, and at the door, as she had once before, she stopped, because there was a thing to be said and it was not true, and she had decided on a mole never to pretend about what was true, only about what it cost; and she turned, with the box, and said, "Augusta. Thank you."

The plain face that showed what it decided to looked at her from the couch for a long moment, and decided.

"No," said the Augusta. "That's the wrong word. You've said the right one once and I'll not have you unlearn it. Try again."

Fausta stood with the box. Matidia had looked up from the book, which she had not done in three years. Marcia's fingers had stopped on the comb.

"Augusta," she said. "What does it cost?"

"Better." The Augusta lay back and reached for the cloth. "It costs this. When Tertulla dies — and she will, the doctor writes me so, in the voice doctors use when they've stopped lying — you'll come here, to Sabina, and you'll be hers, the way you've been Tertulla's, and Sabina will love you, because she's lonely and clever and you don't perform, and she'll make you the one true thing in a house that's going to be the emperor's one day, and I'll let her, because I need one, and I'd rather it was you than a Greek girl who dies of a fever." The cloth went over the eyes. "And then one day a man I've chosen will look at you, the way he looks at everything that's interesting and a little short of what it might have been, and you'll have to decide what you are. That's the cost. It's not now. It's in five years, or ten. I've bought you from a patient man and I've put you in a room with a worse one and I've done it with my eyes open, and so, girl, have you, and I'd not have it otherwise. Go home. Write to Tertulla. Tell her the room said she was always wanting him to do something."

She went down the long wall behind the comb. In the litter at the foot of the hill, Momus climbed in without being asked and sat opposite her with his short legs out and looked at her face, and said nothing for three streets, and then said: "He sailed this morning. The first fair wind. I had it from the stable wing's boy, who's drunk because nobody told him he'd have to go too." The dwarf looked out at the Caelian going by. "Five years. You said you'd count them."

"I've started."

"Good. Count them out loud, now and then, where I can hear. I've counted a lot of things in that house and I'd like, once, to count one that comes out."

20

Four Ways

Rome, autumn 106 to winter 107

Sura set the sheet aside on the third morning back, and Celer read it, and it was shorter than the sail.

That was what he noticed first, because he noticed first what a thing weighed. It was one sheet. It was in a clerk's hand, the prefect's office's, headed and dated and numbered as a thing was that had been through four hands before it reached a fifth; and the body of it was eleven lines, and the eleven lines were the manifest — hull, weight, voyage, year, *pondere non mensura*, the spare mainsail of the heavy canvas, the forward hold, the port-man's son, the pine box, the *Isis* year, his father's seal, the lid off — and under the eleven lines was a line in another hand, the Palatine's, that said *from information laid before the Augusta by Fausta, daughter of Hilara, freedwoman of L. Laecanius Bassus, of the household of Cornelia Tertulla*, and under that, in Sura's, in the Spanish, small: *Read it. Then come and tell me one thing.*

He read it four ways.

He read it first as his father would have, which was as a figure, and the figure was right. Every line. He had been eleven in the strong-room and he had read it aloud to her and she had said *all right* and she had kept it eight years, the way she kept everything, in the place where she kept the Rhodian's eleven and the sound a slate made, and it had come out of her, when it came, exactly as it had gone in, with no *I*. He knew that. He could hear it. He could hear the eggs voice saying *the pounds are always right* to a comb, in a room he had never seen, on a hill, and he could hear that it had taken the length of a hair and had not shaken, because it would not have; she had told a

dying woman's slate to an Alexandrian in the same voice. The figure was right. That was the first way and it took no time at all.

He read it second as Sura would have, which was as a move, and the move was good. A girl in a widow's house with a paper under a hearth-stone and a steward on the coast asking her birth-year in front of a praetor's man, and a woman on a couch who had the hill to give and did not give things free; and the girl had been asked for a figure and had held it a year, which was the long game, and had given it when the price was right, which was the only game; and what she had bought with it he did not know and could guess, because he knew what a girl with a false paper needed. It was a true one, and the only true one was the hill's. She had sold the street for the hill. The Spaniard had said *the only thing a woman in a room with no door could have done* and the Spaniard was right and Sura would say the same and he said it himself, on the stool, in the Spanish, under his breath: *good move*. That was the second way.

He read it third as the Spaniard had told him he would, which was as a boy raised on a figure, and he did not want to and did it anyway, because a man who did not read the way he would be tempted to read was a man who did not know where his own hole was. And the third way was this: that she had known whose it was. Not the house's; *his*. He had read it to her. Not his father; he had. In a strong-room, at eleven, with the lid off the pine box because he had taken it off to show her, because he had wanted her to see what he could see, and she had looked at him while he read it and said *all right*; and eight years later on a hill she had given a comb the fourth line of the second column and the figure for the wet mainsail *in his hand*, and the one thing she had left out, the one thing the eleven lines did not have, was *the boy read it to me*. She had left him out. She had put his father's name and his father's seal and his father's box and his father's margin on a sheet for a prefect, and had not put the boy. He sat with that on the stool and felt it go through him cold and clear and recognised it,

because he had felt it on a sheep-rock reading a Spaniard's four pages: it was the feeling of being left out of a column on purpose, and he did not know, and could not from the sheet, whether it had been done to spare him or because he had not been worth the line.

That was the third way, and it was the hole, and he knew it was the hole and sat in it anyway for the time it took the clerks in the outer room to go through one box.

And then he read it the fourth way, which was the one he had not been taught, and he read it because on a sheep-rock a man with lime on his boots had said *I think a man's made by what he does on the next page*, and because a woman over a wine-shop had said *I'd rather keep house for a kind man who's honest about what he bought*, and because a woman at a loom had said *the gods like to see a face*, and none of these was a figure; and the fourth way was: *what did it cost her?*

He did not know. The sheet did not say. The sheet said *from information laid before the Augusta* and it did not say *for a year of her tongue and a thing she'd rather have kept*; the Spaniard had said that, on a rock, and the Spaniard had had it from the Augusta in one sentence, and he had not. He had eleven lines and a name. And he sat on the stool and understood, the way he had understood on a mole that she was holding him off at the length of her arm and that the arm was the thing and not the holding, that the sheet had been written to be read by his father and by Sura and by the prefect and by the eleven in the Spaniard's box. That it had not been written to be read by him, and that this was either the cruellest thing she had ever done or the kindest, and that he could not tell which from the paper, and that he would have to ask her, and that his father had said *do nothing*, and that he was good at it.

He got up and went in to Sura.

◆

"One thing," said Sura, from the couch, where he lay now in the mornings with the cough, which had got worse on the road home and

worse again in the Roman damp; and the knife-face was thinner and the eyes were the same.

"She left me out, sir."

Sura looked at him for a moment.

"Yes," he said. "She did. I noticed. I thought you'd lead with the figure; it's right, by the way, the prefect's people were at the pine box on the Ides and found the margin, your father's seal, the two sums, wet and dry, the whole thing in his own hand, and I've the inventory on the table there if you want to see your father's handwriting copied by a clerk, which is a thing I'd not wish on anyone." He coughed, into a cloth, and looked at the cloth, and put it away. "But you led with that. Good. It's the right thing. It's the thing that's not on the sheet and it's the only thing on the sheet that matters to you, and a man who goes to the thing that matters to him first and the figure second is a man who'll be some use when he's forty, if he lives, which I'll not." He put the cloth down. "She left you out. Why?"

"I don't know, sir."

"No. You don't. And you'll not from here. You'd have to ask her and you can't, because your father said *do nothing* and because I've told you the Caelian's barred and because the Augusta's got her now and nobody asks the Augusta's people anything." Sura lay back. "So you'll not know. You'll carry it. It's the first thing you'll carry that you can't put in a box and count, and I'm glad to have been in the room when you picked it up, because I've carried one for thirty years and I'd like to have seen what it looked like from outside, once." The eyes closed. "I'll tell you one thing about it, since you've told me one. A sheet with your father's name on it and not yours is a sheet that doesn't touch the roll. Your name's on the roll at four hundred and six thousand in vines and the vines are yours and the sail was his. If she'd put *the boy read it to me*, there's a man in the prefect's office who'd have asked whether the boy knew, and when, and whether the vines were bought with the sail, and whether a man who knew and said

nothing for eight years was a man who should have a ring. She didn't put it. So nobody asked. So you've a ring." The eyes stayed closed. "That's one way to read it. There are others. I don't know which is true and neither do you and I'd not trust anyone who told you they did, including her. Go and draft the thing for the prefect."

"Sir?"

"The finding. The figure. Somebody has to write what the emperor's office recommends be done about a shipowner in Puteoli who's been weighing wet sails for ten years, and it's this office, and in this office it's the man with the best hand and the clearest head for a figure, and that's you, and I'll not spare you it because it's your father, because if I spared you it you'd be a man who'd been spared, and that's no use to me or to the Spaniard or to anyone." Sura opened his eyes. "Write it straight. The figure is the figure: ten years, three hulls, a sail, the bounty on the short weight, doubled, as the law says, less the credit for the *Pelican*'s Rhine run, which I'll have put in because it's true and because the emperor stood up in an inn for it. Don't soften it. Don't sharpen it. Write it the way she said it, as a manifest, with no *I*. And when you've written it, sign it, with your name and the ring, because the prefect will want to know who in this office did the sum, and when he knows, he'll know what kind of office this is, and what kind of man I've got on the stool, and that's worth more to you than your father's fine, which he can pay, and will, and will never forgive, and that's between you and him and not between you and me."

He wrote it. It took the afternoon. It was two sheets, in the square hand, and it was the figure. He did not soften it and did not sharpen it and wrote the credit for the *Pelican* in as Sura had said, and at the end of it he wrote the sum, which was four hundred and eighty thousand sesterces, which was a little more than the vines and a little less than the villa and was, he knew, almost exactly what his father had in the strong-room that was not in his son's name; and he signed it, *G. Laecanius Celer, eques, of the office of L. Licinius Sura*, and pressed the

ring into the wax, and the ring weighed less than a denarius and the wax took it, and he sat for a while looking at his own name under his father's figure and thought that she had left him out of her sheet and that he had just put himself on the next page, in his own hand, and that the Spaniard had said that was where a man was made, and that he did not feel made. He felt like a boy who had read a bill aloud in a strong-room to show a girl what he could see, and had been seen.

◆

Chrestê knew before he told her. Everyone did; it was Rome.

He came down the hill in the dark to the three rooms over the wine-shop with the thing in him that he had not put in a box and she had the lamp lit and the slate on the table and the long face not arranged, and she said, in the Gulf Greek, before he had the door shut, "The Puteoli girl. The sail. It's in the wine-shop; the steward's boy had it from Sura's kitchen. Your father's fined and she's the one." She looked at him. "Sit down. You've the face your father had when the *Pelican* was late."

He sat. She put bread in front of him and he did not eat it and she sat down across the table with the slate between them and did not pick it up.

"I wrote the finding," he said. "The figure. Sura made me. I signed it."

"Of course he did. He's a Spaniard; they think a thing's not done unless it's cost you." She was quiet a moment. "How much?"

"Four hundred and eighty."

"Then he'll pay it and hate her and keep the villa paper and the hulls and the vines in your name, and in five years he'll be richer than he was, because men like your father always are, and he'll still hate her, because the money's not the thing, the thing's that he was *read*." Chrestê looked at the lamp. "I kept a merchant's books four years. I know what a man's face does when someone's been in his column. It's not the money. It's that he thought the column was his."

"She left me out of it."

"I know. The steward's boy said. *Hermes's hand, Hermes's seal, Hermes's box, and not a word about the son who was in the room.*" She looked back at him. "And you've been up there since the second hour reading that four ways, and you've come down the hill with the fourth one, which is *why*, and you're going to ask me, because I'm the only person you've got who knew her, and I'll tell you now that I knew her over a slate once a month for a year when she was fourteen and that's not knowing a woman, that's knowing her arithmetic." She reached across and turned the ring on his finger, once, where it had been made smaller and was not loose. "But I'll tell you what her arithmetic was. It was: *take the lower figure and look at the man so he knows you know he was told to pass the higher.* That's what she did with Granius's factor's slate. She'd not take the higher figure even when it was mine to lose and not hers. She took the lower one and looked at me. Every month." Chrestê let go of the ring. "If that's the girl, then she left you out because you were the higher figure and she took the lower, and looked at the Augusta while she did it, so the Augusta would know she'd seen the higher one was there. That's not sparing you. It's not forgetting you. It's a girl keeping a book straight. You were a thing she could have put in and didn't, and she wanted the other woman to know she could have." A pause. "Which is the cruellest thing or the kindest. I can't tell you. I don't think she can."

He sat with it. The lamp went down.

"Come to bed," said Chrestê, after a while. "You'll not sleep and I'll not either and I'd rather not sleep beside you than across a table from you with your father's face on."

He went. And in the inner room with the lamp she did a thing she had not done in the eighteen months he had owned her, which was that she did not wait for him; she took the tunic off over her head herself, standing, in the light, with the long brown body and the scar on the hip, and looked at him with the long face not arranged, and

said, "I'm not her. I'm telling you so you'll not have to tell yourself. I'm a woman you bought in the Subura who's kept your slate honest and your rooms clean and has been on her back for you when you came to the door and has liked it more than she'd planned to, which is a thing I'd not have told you a year ago and am telling you now because you've got a face on you tonight that wants someone to say a true thing to it. So. I'm not her. Now come here and be nineteen for an hour and leave the sheet on the hill."

He came. He would remember it, as he remembered all of it, by what he saw; and what he saw, this time, was her, and not the Bithynian girl, and not the chandler's stair, and not the eggs voice saying *that's done*; he saw a woman of twenty-two who had been sold with the furniture and who put her hands on him now not where they went but where she wanted them, which was different, and he felt the difference, and it undid something in him that the sheet had tied; and he took her with the lamp going down, slowly, with his mouth on the scar on the hip and her hand in his hair holding him there, hard, so that he understood it was not a thing she was giving but a thing she was taking. That she had decided to take it, tonight, from him, on purpose, because he had come down the hill with his father's face and she had wanted to see if she could take it off; and she could; and she did; and when she came it was with a sound he had not heard from her, low, surprised, as if she had not planned that either, and her nails in his back, and her eyes open on his, in the light, with the long face unarranged entirely, so that he saw, for the length of it, the thing underneath that was not fear and was not the pen-look and was a woman in a bed who had, for once, not done the sum first; and then he followed her, because he could not have done anything else, with his face in her neck and the Gulf Greek in his ear saying his name, which she had never used, *Gaius*, not *domine*, not *Celer*, the praenomen, the one nobody had said since his mother; and afterward she lay with her arm over her eyes and breathed and said, to the

ceiling, after a long time, "Well. That's the first time I've done that and not been working. I'd not planned it. Don't make anything of it. It's a thing that happened in a room with a lamp and it's not on anyone's sheet."

"No," he said.

"Good." She moved her arm and looked at him. "I'll keep house for you till you free me, which you will, because you're your father's son and he freed his, and I'll not ask when. And I'll say this once. The girl on the hill has done a thing to your father that you'd never have done, and she's done it to you by leaving you out of it, and you've written the figure with your own name under it, and you'll go to Puteoli, because he'll send for you, and you'll stand in his strong-room and he'll say what he said before about her and you'll not strike him this time, because you're nineteen and not seventeen and because he'll be right about the figure and wrong about the woman and you'll have learned by now that a man can be both." She turned over. "Go to sleep. The forum's being cut out of the hill and the Syrian wants you and Sura's dying and the Spaniard's waiting and your father's fined and the girl's on the Palatine and you've a woman in your bed who's just called you by your name. That's a lot for one night in three rooms over a wine-shop. Count it in the morning."

◆

Sura lent him to the Syrian for a day in November, and the Syrian showed him the hill.

It was the saddle between the Capitol and the Quirinal, where the old Forum ran out of room and the ground went up, and for a hundred years emperors had looked at it and said *there* and done nothing, because it was a hill, and a hill was a hill; and the Syrian had looked at it and said *it's a hundred and twenty feet of tufa and clay and I've a king's gold and ten thousand prisoners and a man who can count*. The emperor had said yes. They had been at it since the summer. Celer stood with Apollodorus on the edge of what had been

the saddle and was now a cut, a raw red wound in the city a hundred paces across with the Quirinal's shoulder standing above it sheer where it had been sliced. The gangs going down into it in lines with baskets and coming up in lines with baskets, and the carts, and the dust, which was everywhere, which was in the bread on the Aventine by evening and in the Augusta's room on the Palatine, they said, where the one window had to be shut.

"A hundred and twenty feet," said the Syrian, with lime on his arms, in the Greek. "I'll put a column there, when it's done, exactly that high, so nobody forgets there was a hill. Lucius says it's vanity. Lucius is right. It's also the only way to make a man believe a thing's been moved, which is to leave the measure standing." He pointed with a whole arm. "Basilica there. Libraries there and there, Greek and Latin, facing, so the scholars can glare at each other across the column. The temple he'll not let me put in because he says a man doesn't build his own temple, which is true until he's dead, and then his nephew does it. And the market, up the side of the Quirinal, in a curve, in brick, six storeys, because the shopkeepers I've moved off the saddle have to go somewhere and I'd rather they went up than out." He dropped the arm. "You see what it is."

"It's a road, sir. Like the bridge. You've put a road through a hill so the border can't be rolled up."

"Ha." The Syrian looked at him sideways. "Lucius said you'd say that. He said you say everything's a road. He's not wrong and neither are you. It's a road from the old Forum to the Campus and from the Republic to whatever he thinks he's making, and he's made me cut a hill in half to lay it, and in twenty years nobody will remember the hill, only the column. That's what a forum is. It's a thing that makes you forget what it cost." He began to walk along the edge of the cut, and Celer walked with him. "I asked for you for the figure. The gold's paying for it and the Senate's asked three times how much is left and Lucius sends them a story and they want a figure and I want a man

who'll give them one that's true, because a true figure's the only thing that shuts a senator. You'll do it in a week. I'll give you a table in the hut and a clerk who can't read, which is the kind I prefer." He stopped. "And I asked for another reason, which Lucius doesn't know, and I'll tell you because I'm a Syrian and we don't do the thing you Romans do where you let a man find out."

Celer waited.

"The Augusta walks here. Not often; she doesn't walk anywhere often. But the emperor's asked her to see it, because he can't, and she comes on a morning in a litter with the curtains shut and gets out at the far end, there, by the shoulder, where nobody is, and stands, and looks at it, and goes. Twice since the summer. And the second time she had a girl with her who does her hair, Lucius says, a tall one with a nose, who stood a pace behind and looked at the cut the way you're looking at it now, which is the way I look at it, which is to say counting; and the Augusta said to me, as she got back into the litter, *this one's from Puteoli; she knows what a thing weighs; one day you'll want to show her the column*, and got in, and went." The Syrian looked at the boy with the lime drying on his arms. "I don't know what that was. I'm an engineer. But I've been on the hill long enough to know that when that woman says *one day* in front of a man she's never spoken to, she's laying a stone, and I thought the man who's going to count my forum should know there's a stone laid in it with a girl's name on, and that the woman who laid it did so in front of me on purpose so that I'd tell him." He turned back to the cut. "Come to the hut. The clerk's called Blaesus and he's deaf as well, which is why I keep him."

He went to the hut. He did the figure, in a week, at a table, with a deaf clerk, and it was true. It shut the Senate; and every morning of the week he came up the Aventine in the dark and along the Forum and up to the edge of the cut, early, before the gangs, and stood at the far end by the shoulder where nobody was, and looked at the hill

being taken away a basket at a time, and did not see a litter, and had not expected to, and stood there anyway, for the time it took the light to come, because a woman on a couch had said *one day* in front of a Syrian, and because he was his father's son and knew what it was to be told a thing had been laid for you and to go and stand by it before it was cut.

◆

His father's letter came on the Kalends of December, and it was one sheet, and it was the shortest thing Hermes of Puteoli had ever written him, and he read it standing, in the outer room, with Chrestê at the table with the slate not looking.

The prefect's people were at the box on the Ides of November. They had the line. They had the year. They had the sail wet and dry in my hand and they had a sheet from Rome that told them which box, and the sheet had a name under it and the name was hers. I've seen it. I have a boy in the prefect's office in Puteoli and have had since Nerva. Four hundred and eighty thousand, less the Pelican. I'll pay it. It's most of what I've got that's not yours. I'll not touch yours. I'll not touch the villa paper. I'll pay it from the strong-room and from the Isis, which I'll sell to the Alexandrian who's wanted her, and I'll have two hulls and a tomb and a paper on a headland and a son on the roll, which is more than I walked off a ship with, and I'll say that to the gods in the morning with the bread and mean it.

You wrote the finding. The boy in the prefect's office says the sheet from Sura's has your hand and your ring. I'd have done the same. I'd have made you do it, in Sura's place. I don't hold it. A man who puts his name on a true figure is a man, and that's what I built the stone for, and if the figure's mine, then it's mine, and I've had ten years of water in the Subura bread out of it and I knew what I was doing and so did every carrier in this port and I'm the one who wrote it down because I'm the one who writes things down. That's the and. There's nothing after it.

But hear me, and I'll say it once, and I've thought about how to say it since the Ides and I've decided to say it the way I said it two years ago, because it was true then and you struck me for the sentence and not the truth, and I'll take the sentence back and keep the truth. She's gone up that hill on what she had, and what she had was my strong-room, and she's sold it, and the price was the hill, and she's got it. I don't blame her. I'd have done it. I did do it; I sold a patron's dock to a corn-office for forty years and built columns on it. She's mine, that one, more than she's her mother's; she's a freedman's child who found a thing in a box and knew what it weighed. I'd have been proud of her, in another house.

But she's not in another house. She's on the Palatine with my column in her mouth and my son's name left off it, and I know why she left it off, and so do you, and it's not kindness. It's that she's keeping you. For later. A woman on that hill with a boy on the roll whose name she could have put on a prefect's sheet and didn't is a woman with a paper on him, the way I've a paper on Rufus's villa. She's not spent you. She's holding you. She learned it from me, in my strong-room, with the lid off, and I'd have told her she'd learned it well if she'd stayed on the coast long enough to be told anything.

Come to Puteoli when Sura can spare you. Not for the fine. For the stone. I said I'd stand by it with you and I'd like to do it before the spring. I'm fifty-five and my hand's worse and your stepmother says I've stopped smiling since the Ides, and she's right, and I'd like to stand by the stone with my son before I've forgotten how. — Your father.

He read it twice. He folded it. He put it in the box with the stick and the Lares and the forty-one days of a king's gold, and closed the lid, and stood with his hand on it.

"Well?" said Chrestê, to the slate.

"He says she's holding a paper on me."

"Is she?"

"I don't know." He took his hand off the lid. "He says come to Puteoli for the stone."

"Then go. Sura can spare you; Sura can't spare anyone and spares everyone, it's the cough. Go and stand by your father's stone and let him say what he says, and don't strike him, and come back." She looked up from the slate, finally, with the long face arranged again, as it was in the day, and the thing under it that he could read now and did. "And Gaius. Before you go. There's a thing in the wine-shop that I'd rather you had from me than from the steward's boy on the road. Tertulla's son. The one on the Caelian. He's gone to Africa — Tingis, the corn-ships, the post nobody takes. The Augusta's secretary did it, on the Ides of September, in a week, which is not how posts are given, and the wine-shop says there was a night in Tertulla's house while Tertulla was at Laurentum, and a dwarf at the Palatine postern at the third hour, and the Augusta's Germans in the atrium at the second hour of the morning, and the girl doing the Augusta's hair on the Kalends with a pin in it as if nothing." She held his eyes. "That's all the wine-shop has. It's a wine-shop. But I kept a merchant's books four years and I know what a column looks like with a line missing from the middle of it, and so do you, and I'd not have you hear it on the Appian road from a boy who thinks it's a story about a girl who's had a man sent to Africa. It's not that story. You know what story it is. You've read it four ways; read it a fifth."

He stood in the outer room with his hand on the box.

"Yes," he said, after a while. "I know what story it is."

"Then go to Puteoli," said Chrestê, "and stand by the stone, and when your father says she went up the hill on what she had, you'll know what else she paid, and you'll not strike him, and you'll not tell him either, because it's not yours to tell, and because he'd put it in a column, and it's the one thing on that hill that shouldn't be."

21

The Lease

Laurentum and the Palatine, winter 106 to spring 107

The lady sent for her in November, and she went to Laurentum, and the lady was dying by the sea in a room with a window, as she had decided.

It was a small house. That was the first thing Fausta kept of it: that the consul's widow who had a house on the Caelian with twelve girls and an Alexandrian and a dwarf and a corridor nobody used had, by the sea, four rooms and a terrace and a doctor and one woman, and had had them for thirty years, and had gone there every August of those years to be, for a month, a woman with four rooms. The terrace looked at water. Not the Gulf; the open sea, grey in November, with nothing on it, no Alexandrian hulls, no mole, no *Dolphin* going out to burn; the sea that was simply the sea and had no manifest. The lady lay on a couch on the terrace in the cold with four blankets and the cough and the pale eyes and looked at it, and when the girl came out onto the terrace with the dust of the road on her she did not turn her head, but said, in the old Latin, "You've come. Good. Sit where I can see you without turning; the doctor says turning's a thing I've done enough of."

She had gone down the Caelian's stair for the last time the morning before with nothing in her hands, because Phaedrus had sent the chest ahead, and at the foot of the stair, by the hatch to the bakehouse, Zaidê had been standing with her arms folded and her plait over her shoulder, as if she had been there a while.

"You'll not come back."

"No."

"Good." The flat face. "I'll have the parapet, then. On the roof. In August. It's the coolest place and nobody wants it because of the drop." She did not unfold her arms. "The stoker's been sold. To a bath on the Esquiline. They don't tell you; you go to the furnace and there's a Thracian. So." A shrug, of the kind the house taught, that moved nothing. "I'm to be the one who pours for the son's wife when he has one. Phaedrus says. He says I've the face for it; nobody looks at it."

"They don't," said Fausta. "That's a thing you can use."

"I know what it is. You're not the only one in this house who learned where to stand." Zaidê looked at her, once, the whole length, from the ivory in the hair to the hem, the way she had looked at her in the steward's room with the basin, and said, "Go on, then. Up your hill. I'll not say I'll think of you. I'll think of the figs." And she unfolded her arms and took the jug from the sill beside her, which had been there the whole time, full to the brim, and carried it away across the court without a drop going over, which was a thing she had learned to do, Fausta understood, watching the plait go, in the same month, four years ago, on the same stairs, for the same reason.

Fausta sat. The sea went about its business below.

"The Augusta told me the figure." The lady's voice was a thread of what it had been, and the thread had the whole of the voice in it, as the egg-woman's mother's hands had had the whole of a lifetime of doing a thing. "Puteoli. The sail. I'd like to hear what it cost. She wouldn't tell me and Marcia only tells me what the Augusta's said she may, and I'm dying, child, and I've a right to the one thing on that hill nobody will give me, which is the price of something."

So she told her. On the terrace, in the cold, in the Latin the lady had taught her and not the eggs, with the sea below: the year of the tongue, and Sabina on her stool, and the pin, and the fountain, and the month. The Ides of July with the comb, and what she had left out and why, and what the Augusta had said about it, and the paper from

the prefect's archive under the hearth-stone with the other one. She did not tell her the panelling door. The lady knew, because Phaedrus had written on the Nones, as instructed, to *her* and not to Laurentum, and the Augusta had told the lady what she decided to; and the lady did not ask, and Fausta did not say, and it sat between them on the terrace like a third blanket.

When she was done the lady was quiet for a long time, looking at the sea.

"Tingis," she said at last. "I'd not have thought of Tingis. I'd have thought of Sardinia; it's nearer and worse. But Tingis is a port and he'll have to count things, and he's never counted anything in his life but days." The pale eyes did not move from the water. "I wrote to him. Did you know? The week after. Not about — not about anything. I wrote and said I was glad he'd a post and that his father would have been and that he was to write to me from Africa on the Kalends, and he's written twice, and the letters are about corn-ships and the heat. That's how I know. A patient man who's been sent somewhere writes about the weather." She coughed, and it took a while, and the one woman came and went. "I'll not see him again. The house goes to him; the law's the law. You're not in it when it does. You go up the hill the day I'm burned and you don't look back at the Caelian. I'd have had that door bricked up if I'd remembered it was there. I didn't. That's mine."

"Domina —"

"No. Let me. I've a thing to say and not much breath." The thin hand came out of the blankets and lay on the couch's edge, palm up, open, as it had never been in three years; and Fausta looked at it and understood that she was being asked to take it, and did, and it was cold and light and had nothing in it, and the lady's eyes stayed on the sea. "I took you for a price. You know that. I'd not have you think I was kind. I wasn't. I was a widow with a son I didn't like and a house I couldn't fill and I took a freedwoman's child off a coast because she'd

a nose like a consul and a face like a shutter and I thought I'd see what she'd do." The hand closed, a little, on hers. "I've not been so entertained in thirty years. I'll not pretend it was anything higher than that. You'd know."

The sea went on. The hand in hers was very light.

"There's one more thing. The lease."

Fausta did not move.

"The Dolphin. Phaedrus has had a letter, from the young master's steward on the coast — the one who asked your birth-year. He's in Rome. He's come up with the young master, who's in the Senate now and finds he has to be seen in it, and he's written to my steward asking, very politely, whether the lady Cornelia's household includes a girl from Puteoli who holds a lease on a lodging-house by the harbour, and whether the girl might be willing to discuss its sale, since the young master is settling his father's affairs and the harbour's being rebuilt and the lodging-house is in the way." The pale eyes came off the sea, finally, and found her. "He's not come for the lease. You know that. A steward who wants a lease sends a boy. He's come to see you. He's come to put himself in a room with you and watch your face while he tells you a thing, because that's what he does; he did it to your mother for ten years and he did it to you at a funeral and he'll do it again, and I'd have Phaedrus send him away, except that I'll be dead by the time he comes and the house will be my son's and Phaedrus will be my son's steward and will have to let him in." The hand tightened. "So hear me. See him on the hill. Not the Caelian. Have Marcia give him a room in the Augusta's outer court with a German at the door and see him there, in your pin, with your feet under you, and let him say his thing, and sell him the lease, because it's ash and you know it and holding ash is a boy's move; and when he's gone, go and do Sabina's hair, and never think of Puteoli again as a place you could go back to. You can't. Your mother knew that in the shed on the mole. It's why she sent you; it's the whole of what she sent you

with. *Don't come back. Go up.*"

She died on the Ides, in the night, with the window open and the sea doing nothing below it, and the one woman woke the girl at the first hour and said *it's done*. Fausta went out onto the terrace in the cold and stood where she could see the water without turning and said the thing that was said, in the old Latin, badly, because she had only ever heard it said once and that had been by a grave in Puteoli in the eggs voice; and then she went in and did the lady's hair, the old way, plain, for the burning, because the one woman could not and someone had to and it was, she understood with the comb in her hand, the last price in a house that had been nothing but prices, and the only one she had set herself.

◆

Sabina's rooms were on the north side of the hill, where the Augusta's were not, and had three windows, and were cold.

She came up the day of the burning, as the lady had said, with Momus walking beside the litter and the ivory in her hair and the box of pins and the Strabo and the letters and the two papers and the brass fish, which was all she had come from the coast with and all she took from the Caelian. She did not look back at it, as instructed, and found that she did not want to; and at the top of the hill Marcia met her at the postern and took her not along the long wall to the room with one window but the other way, north, through courts she had not seen, past Germans and gardeners and a fountain that worked, to a door, and through it, to a woman of twenty-three sitting by a window with her hands in her lap and no book, who looked round with the beautiful disappointed face and said, in the low quick voice, "Oh. You. Good. She said she'd send you and I thought she'd send a Greek. Come here. Let me look at the pin." And looked at it, close, with the dry tenant intelligence, and said, "Island work. Mended. From the man she's sent to Africa. And you're wearing it. You're wearing it *into my rooms*." And sat back. "Yes. All right. You'll do. Marcia, go away;

she's mine now, you've said so, and I'll not have you standing there counting her."

Marcia went. The door shut. Sabina looked at the girl in the middle of the cold room with her box and her feet under her and said, "Sit down. Not the stool; the couch. There. I'll say this once and then we'll never mention it, because I've been in this house twenty-three years and I know what's mentioned and what's not." She folded her hands. "I know what the Augusta did for you and what she did it for. I know what she'll want you for in five years, because I know who she's chosen and I know what he looks at. I'm his wife. I've been his wife since I was seventeen and I've watched him look at things that are interesting and a little short of what they might be, and I'm telling you now, the first day, so you'll have had it from me and not from Marcia with a pin: when he looks at you, and he will, I'll not hate you for it. I'll have expected it. I'll have *arranged* it, if I'm honest, by keeping you in my rooms where he can't help seeing. Because the one thing I've learned on this hill is that the only person a man like that can't own is the one his wife's already got." The beautiful face did a thing that was nearly a smile and had no warmth in it and a great deal of something else. "So. You're mine. I'll be kind to you because I've no one else to be kind to and because you don't perform, and I'll use you, because that's what the hill is, and you'll know I'm doing both, because you're not a fool, and we'll get on. Do my hair. Not the old way; I'm not an old woman from a coast built on ash. The new way. The way the legate's wife had it last Ides that made my great-aunt put the cloth on. I want him to come in from his forum and see it and not know for a moment who I am."

She did Sabina's hair. The new way. And when the Spaniard came in that evening, in the Greek cloak with the dust of the cut on it and the grey eyes, and stood in the door of the cold room and looked at his wife by the window, he did not know her for a moment. Fausta saw him not know her, from the corner by the chest where she stood with

the box, and then saw him know, and saw the look go on past the wife to the corner, and find a tall girl with a nose and a pin, and stop, for the length of time it took a flame to lean; and then go on, to the window, to the wife, with the thing on the face that found everything interesting and a little short; and he said, in the Greek, "Vibia. You've done something to your hair. It suits you. Who's the girl?"

"Plotina's," said Sabina, not turning from the window. "Mine now. From Puteoli. She knows what a thing weighs; your Syrian says so." And then, in the low quick voice, to the glass: "You've seen her before. On a rock, Apollodorus says, you went to see a boy count gold, and she's the girl who put the boy's father on a sheet. Don't pretend. I hate it when you pretend; it's the one thing you're bad at."

The Spaniard stood in the door. The grey eyes went to the corner again and this time did not stop, but rested, and the face did nothing, and then it loosened, and he said, in the Greek, to the corner, "Puteoli. The sail. Yes. I read it. I've read everything on that hill; it's my only vice." A pause. "Lucius has the boy. He's doing the figure for the forum. It's true, which is more than the Senate's used to." And then, to the window: "I'll dine with Plotina. She's asked. Don't wait." And he went, and the door shut, and Sabina laughed, once, short, dry, at the glass.

"There," she said. "Now he knows where you are. That's a stone laid. My great-aunt lays them in front of Syrians; I lay them in front of him. We're a family of masons." She turned from the window. "Sit with me. I'll not sleep. Tell me about the coast. Not the sail; I know the sail. Tell me about a lodging-house with a book and a girl who kept it. I've never kept anything in my life and I'd like to hear what it's like."

So she told her. Not the whole of it; she had learned on the Caelian that the whole of a thing was a price and you did not pay it on the first night. But she told her the slate, and the Rhodian's eleven, and the stairs, and the egg-woman's mother with her hands in a basin.

The shed on the mole with the sea in the glass, and Sabina sat by the window with her hands in her lap and the beautiful face turned to the dark and listened in a way nobody on the hill listened, which was without waiting to speak; and when Fausta stopped, at the shed, because the shed was where she stopped, the Spaniard's wife was quiet for a while and then said, to the glass, "A book. A real one. With a Rhodian in it who drinks and a figure that comes out right or doesn't. I've a husband who writes four sheets about a hill-fort and a great-aunt who's performed a headache for twenty years and a mother who's turned the same page of the same book every Kalends since I was born so she'd have somewhere to look, and I've never in my life been in a room where a thing was simply *counted*." She turned. "Teach me."

"Domina?"

"The slate. The book. How it's kept. Teach me. I'll not need it; I'm the emperor's niece's daughter and the next emperor's wife, if my great-aunt has her way, and she will, and I'll never settle a Rhodian's bill in my life. But I'd like to know how it's done. I'd like one thing in my head that's true because it adds, and not because somebody on this hill decided it would be." The dry tenant intelligence looked out of the beautiful face at her with something in it that was nearly need and had been trained, for twenty-three years, never to show as that. "You'll do my hair and you'll sit with me when I can't sleep, which is most nights, and in the mornings before the room you'll teach me a lodging-house book. That's the price of these rooms. It's a better one than you got on the Caelian and you know it."

"Yes, domina."

"And don't call me that when the door's shut. I've heard it from Greeks for twenty-three years and I hate it. Vibia. Or nothing. Say nothing, mostly; it's what I liked about you. And yes, I know the shipowner's widow's a Vibia too; Marcia told me; it's the commonest name in Italy and I've never once been let use it."

Marcia found her in the morning, in the court with the fountain that worked, going to the Augusta's room with the box, and fell in beside her along the wall with the comb, as if the Caelian had never been.

"You told her the coast."

"Some of it."

"Yes. Some of it. She'll have the rest in a month; she's patient when she wants a thing and she's never wanted anything she could have." The round face was arranged. "I've a thing to tell you, since you're on the hill now and not under it, and it's this. When you came, three years ago, I did a sum. I always do. I counted five things in that room that weren't yours and that somebody would use if you didn't: the paper, the steward's sheet, the boy, the widow, the son. I said to myself, that one's got five doors in her and no key to any, and the first one that gets a key is the one that'll own her, and it had better be the Augusta, because the rest are worse." Marcia did not look at her. "The paper's yours. The Augusta filed it; it's done. The steward's sheet's dead; he came up the hill to tell you so himself, Momus says, which I'd not have believed of a steward. The widow's burned. The son's in Tingis counting corn-ships, and that's a door with your own hand on it, and you know what it cost and so do I. That's four." The comb went into the sleeve. "One left."

"The boy."

"The boy. On Sura's staff and the Spaniard's eye and his father's roll, and standing by a stone this morning on your coast beside a man who's just had a stroke in a strong-room, Momus says, with the fine's receipt in front of him; and you've put the father on a sheet and left the son off it. The whole hill knows you did and nobody knows why, including, I think, you." Marcia stopped at the Augusta's door. "I'll tell you what the Augusta said about that. She said: *the girl's kept one door shut on purpose. Good. A woman with no doors is a woman nobody comes to. But she'd better know which it is, because one day I'll need to go*

through it, and I'd rather she opened it than I had it broken." The round face turned to her, finally. "That's the sum. You've four of five. The fifth's yours or it's nobody's and I'd not wait ten years to find out which, because the Augusta's fifty-six and Sura's coughing and the Spaniard's thirty-one and the emperor's fifty-three and in this house the numbers move. Now go in. She's got the cloth on. It's a receiving day."

◆

The man the German let into the room in March was old, and it took her the length of his walk from the door to the table to understand that it was Thallus.

That was what she had not counted on. He had been fifty-five in a lodging-house common room in the eggs voice saying *she'll be useful*, and sixty-two in a room with a stool and a slate saying *your birth-year*. He was sixty-four now and it had gone to his hands and the skin of his face, which had been a steward's face, hard and reasonable, and was a map now, with the reasonableness still in it like a road through country that had been fought over. He came in behind the German in a good cloak that was the young master's giving and stood in the middle of the room and looked at her, in her pin, on a stool, with her feet under her and Momus on a stool by the wall because Sabina had said *take the dwarf; a steward from the coast will not know what to do with a dwarf and I'd like to hear what he does*. His face went still the way a steward's did when it had carried a figure for eight years and was about to set it down.

"Fausta."

"Thallus."

Not *domine*. He noticed. He had always noticed everything; it was what he was for. He looked at the German's back in the door and at the dwarf and at the room, which was the Augusta's and said so in every surface, and he sat down, because she had not asked him to and because he was sixty-four and the road up the hill was long.

"You'll know why I've come."

"The lease."

"The lease." He took a sheet from the cloak and put it on the table between them. "The harbour's being rebuilt. The Syrian's man's drawn it; the mole goes out another two hundred feet and the lodging-houses on the front come down for a customs-hall, and the young master, who's settling his father's affairs and finds that his father's affairs were a villa he doesn't own and a dock he's leased to a man who's just paid the emperor four hundred and eighty thousand for a sail, would like to sell the ground under the Dolphin to the port before the port takes it. He can't while your lease stands. Your mother was clever. Twenty years, in her daughter's name, witnessed, sealed. Eight left." He pushed the sheet an inch. "He'll give you five thousand for the eight. It's generous. It's ash."

"It's generous," she agreed. "It's ash."

"Then sign."

"In a moment." She did not look at the sheet. "You didn't come up the Palatine for five thousand, Thallus. You'd have sent a boy. You've come to put yourself in a room with me and tell me a thing and watch my face, because you've done it since I was ten and you can't stop, and I'd rather you did it now, with the German there, than carried it back down the hill unsaid and sent it to me in a letter I'd have to burn." She folded her hands. "Say it."

He looked at her for a long time with the map of a face.

"You've grown into the nose," he said. "I thought you would. Your mother had the mouth and the voice and you had his nose and his way of sitting, and I watched you in that common room at ten and thought, that one's going to be a problem for somebody, and I've spent twelve years trying to make sure it wasn't me." He turned the sheet with one finger. "Two things. I'll say them both and you can do what you like with them; I'm an old man with a key to a house that isn't mine, as Hermes says, and I'd like to put them down."

"Go on."

"Hermes's boy wrote to his stepmother in the spring of the year Bassus died, about the egg-woman's husband, and the stepmother paid, and told Hermes, and Hermes let it stand. You knew that; you asked for it. What you'll not know is what Hermes said, in his strong-room, in July of the year before, with the boy on a stool, about how you'd come up the hill. He said *on her back*. In so many words. And the boy got up off the stool and struck him. Open hand. Across the face. In his father's strong-room, with the Lares watching. I had it from the man I've kept in Hermes's kitchen since Nerva, who had it from the boy who was outside the door." The steward's hands lay still on the table. "Hermes took the sentence back. He's never taken a figure back in his life and he took that one, and ordered the boy to write you nothing for a year, and the boy didn't, except the egg-man, which was a thing you'd asked and not a letter. That's the first thing. I tell you because I think you've been doing a sum for two years with a figure missing and I'd like, once, to have given you a figure instead of taken one."

She sat. The price was in her and she looked at it and it had moved, and she did not let her face do anything, because the shutter was hers and had been since a lodging-house, and Momus, by the wall, did not move either.

"The second."

"The second's smaller. Hermes has had his stroke." Thallus said it flat, a steward reporting a roof. "The Nones. In the strong-room, at the table, with the fine's receipt in front of him and the *Isis*'s bill of sale, doing the sum of what was left. The left side. He can't speak. He can write, with the right hand, badly, and what he writes is figures. The boy's been sent for; Sura's let him go; he'll be in Puteoli by now, standing by a stone with an *F* on it beside a man who can't say his name." The old hands moved, finally, and folded. "I've no stake in it. The villa paper's in his strong-room and the young master owes it and

if Hermes dies the paper comes to the boy and the boy's on Sura's staff and the Spaniard's, and the young master's a senator who finds he has to be seen, and I'm sixty-four. I've done my sum. It comes out: sell the girl the truth, cheap, before someone sells her a story dear, and go back to the coast and count what's left of a house that was a consul's and is a man in the Senate who sits on a stool in a freedman's strong-room because the freedman's son has a ring." He looked at her. "Sign the lease. Take the five thousand. The Dolphin's ash; your mother's in the ground by the road; the egg-woman's husband's paid till he dies and after that it doesn't matter, because the paper's in the prefect's archive under the Augusta's seal, which I also know, because I've a man in that office too, and have had since before you were born, and I'll tell you now that I've never once used him for anything but to know." He stood. He was slow about it. "I asked you your birth-year at a funeral because I needed a thing on a sheet and I've never picked it up and I never will, and I'd like you to have that from me and not from the fact that nothing's happened. Nothing's happened because I decided. I'm the only one on that coast who ever did, and I'd like somebody on this hill to know it before I'm dead."

She signed the lease. In the Latin a dead woman had taught her. *Fausta, daughter of Hilara.* She sealed it with the brass fish, and gave him the fish's print and kept the fish, and he took the sheet and the five thousand went to a banker's on the Sacred Way in her name, which was the first money she had ever had that was hers and not in a hem. He went to the door, where the German was, and at the door he turned, as people did at doors on that hill, and looked at the dwarf by the wall.

"You're Tertulla's," he said. "The one who went to the postern."

"I'm hers now," said Momus. "The one who counts."

"Then count this, for me, since you're there and I'll not be. Twelve years. From a common room to the Augusta's outer court with a German at the door. On her feet. I'd have said it couldn't be

done and I've been in the house of Laecanius forty years and seen three generations try it from above and fail." The map of a face did nothing. "Tell her, after I've gone, that her mother said *and?* to me once, when I'd finished laying out the terms of the Dolphin's rent in the year the girl was born, and I didn't understand it then, and I do now. It means: *that's your figure; where's mine.*" And he went out past the German and down the hill, and did not come up it again in her lifetime, and she heard of his death four years later from a letter and found that she could not remember what she had felt in the room, only that she had signed, and that the fish had taken the wax, and that Momus had said, when the door shut, "Well. There's a man who's just told you the truth because it cost him nothing, and you'll not get many of those, so I'd keep it."

"I'm keeping it."

"Which part?"

"The strong-room." She stood up. Her feet were under her. "He struck his father for me. Two years ago. With the Lares watching. And then did nothing for two years because he was told to, and he's good at it." She picked up the box of pins. "That's a figure I didn't have. I'll put it in the column and see what it does to the sum."

"And the stroke?"

"That's not mine," she said. "That's his. He'll be standing by the stone by now. He can count that himself." And she went back through the courts past the fountain that worked to the cold rooms on the north side where a woman of twenty-three was waiting by a window with no book to be told what a steward from the coast did with a dwarf, and told her, and Sabina laughed, once, short, and said, "He *talked* to it. Oh, that's good. Nobody on this hill talks to Momus; they think he's furniture. Your coast is better than my hill, Puteoli. Do my hair. The new way. He's coming in from the cut and I want him to not know me again."

22

The Stone

Puteoli, spring 107

His father could not say his name, and wrote it instead, on a wax tablet, in figures, which was the only hand he had left.

Celer came down the Appian road in March on the horse he had bought with the vines and sat better now, with Chrestê's bread in a bag and Crescens's stick in the saddle-roll because he had not been able to leave it in a box in Rome and did not know why, and came over the shoulder of the hill above the town in the afternoon with the Gulf opening below him grey and flat and the mole out in it and the new work beyond the mole where the Syrian's man was pushing it two hundred feet further into the sea. The lodging-houses along the front half down already, so that he could not have said, from the hill, which gap had been the Dolphin; and he did not stop to work it out. He went down through the upper town past the house where a Greek had died by a brazier and along the slope past the house of a merchant called Granius where a woman he owned had kept the books, and in at the door between the columns that were not marble. His stepmother was in the atrium, and had been, he understood from her face, since the boy had seen the horse on the hill; and she put her arms round him, which she had never done, and said into his shoulder in the Nola Latin, "He's in the strong-room. He'll not be moved. He sleeps there, on a pallet, with the lamp, and the Lares; he'd not have them brought to him, he had himself brought to them. Go in. He's been writing your name since the Nones and I can't read it."

He went in. The strong-room was as it had been when he was eleven: the lamp, the table, the pine boxes on the shelves with the seals, and one box with the seal broken and the lid set beside it, which

was the *Isis* year and the sail-makers' bills, and which nobody had put back; and on a pallet against the far wall, with a blanket and the Lares on a shelf above him and a tablet on his knee, his father.

The left side of the face had gone. That was the first thing, and he made himself look at it, because he had decided on a beach that a man was his face and this was his father's now: the left eye half-shut and the left corner of the mouth down and the left hand lying on the blanket like a thing that had been set there. The right side of the face his father's, exactly, the shipowner's face, hard and reasonable and tired, with the right eye on him, and the right hand with the stylus. Hermes of Puteoli looked at his son from the pallet with half a face and made a sound, which was not a word, and then stopped trying, and looked down at the tablet, and wrote.

Celer knelt and read it. It was a column. It was in the house's shorthand, which only two living people could read and one of them was on the Palatine; and it was:

406. 480. 2 hulls. 1 paper (R.) 1 stone. 1 son.

And under it, a line, and under the line, nothing.

He read it twice. He looked up. The right eye was waiting.

"The sum's wrong," he said.

The right side of the mouth did something.

"You've left out the villa paper's worth, which is the headland and the atrium and sixty years of walking up it, and you've left out Vibia, and you've left out the man in the prefect's office you've had since Nerva, and you've left out the Lares from Nola, which I've carried across the Danube twice and fed in a tent on the far bank with bread while a king's city burned." He kept the voice level; the manifest voice; his father's. "And you've put the four-eighty on the wrong side. It's not a loss. It's a figure you paid for ten years of a thing you did with your eyes open, and you said so in a letter, and I believed you. Put it in the other column."

The stylus moved. Slowly, with the right hand, badly, the way a man wrote who had written ten thousand sheets and now had to think about the shape of a four. He crossed out the 480. He wrote it again, to the right, in another column that had not been there. And under it, in the first column, he wrote, in letters, not figures, which took a long time:

F.

And looked up.

Celer knelt by the pallet in the strong-room with the lamp and the open box and his father's half-face waiting, and did the sum, and it came out where it had always come out, which was that there was a thing on the tablet that could be read four ways and that he would have to pick one, and he picked.

"The stone," he said. "You mean the stone. Yes. I'll stand by it. Tomorrow, if Vibia says you can be carried. That's what I came for."

The right eye held his for a long moment. Then it closed, and opened, which was a nod. The stylus went down on the blanket, and Hermes of Puteoli lay back on the pallet with the Lares above him and the sail-makers' box open on the shelf and let his son be right about what the letter meant, which was, Celer would understand much later, on another hill, the last thing his father ever gave him, and the only lie.

◆

They carried him to the stone on the Ides, four of the house's men with a chair, up the road out of the town between the tombs, in the morning, with the Gulf behind them and the vines on the hill above still bare; and Celer walked beside the chair with his hand on its arm and his stepmother behind with the boy who had been outside the door. Nobody else, because his father had written *nobody* on the tablet and underlined it, and the Augustales who would have come had been told the family was private and had understood, because they had all walked off ships once and knew what it was to want a thing to be

yours for an hour before the town had it.

The tomb was finished. He had not seen it finished; he had seen it as a plan, and a plinth, and a plinth with a stone on it; and now it stood by the road on its own ground with a wall round it and a gate and a cypress somebody had planted and that had taken. It was, he saw, coming up the road, exactly what his father had said it would be in every letter for eighteen years, which was *the biggest on the road*, and it was, and it was also — he had not expected this and did not know what to do with it — handsome. Plain. Travertine, not marble, because his father had priced marble and said *no, a freedman in marble is a joke and I'll not be one on my own stone*; good travertine, dressed square, with the relief above the inscription that showed a ship, a corn-hull, with the sail set, going somewhere, and under it the words, which he had read as a plan and read now cut:

C. LAECANIUS HERMES, FREEDMAN OF LUCIUS, AUGUSTALIS, SHIPOWNER, BUILT THIS FOR HIMSELF AND FOR VIBIA HIS WIFE AND FOR C. LAECANIUS CELER HIS SON, EQUES ROMANUS, AND FOR THEIR FREEDMEN AND FREEDWOMEN AND THEIR DESCENDANTS.

Eques Romanus. It had been cut in the winter, after the Ides of March two years ago, by a mason who had been told to leave the space and had left it, and the letters were newer than the rest and had not weathered, and his father had had them cut a hand's breadth taller than the rest, so that a man going by on the road to Capua would see that before he saw anything else, and his father had said so, in a letter, *a hand taller, so they see it from a horse*.

They set the chair down in front of it. Celer stood beside the chair with his hand on its arm. His father looked up at the stone with the right eye, for a long time, in the morning, with the cypress moving a little and the Gulf behind and the vines above, and then the right hand came up off the blanket and found the son's wrist and held it, hard, with what was left. The half-face turned up and the mouth

tried, and made the sound, and stopped, and tried again; and Celer bent, and put his ear by his father's mouth, as a woman at a loom had told him you did with the gods, so they could see a face; and his father said, with the half-mouth, in a voice that was not a voice, two words, which were the first since the Nones and the last, and which were:

"Not nothing."

He straightened. He stood with his father's hand on his wrist and the stone in front of him with his name on it a hand taller than his father's, and the sum went through him and came out, and he said, "No. Not nothing," and his father's hand let go, and lay on the blanket, and the half-face went back to looking at the stone, and that was all.

They carried him back down. He died nine days later, on the pallet, in the strong-room, in the night, with the lamp and the Lares and the open box, and Vibia woke the son in the room with the window on the wall and said *it's done*, and he went in. His father was dead with the right eye open on the shelf where the gods were, and the tablet on the blanket, and on the tablet, in the figures hand, one line, which the stylus had been in the middle of and had dropped from:

and

No mark after it. Not a question; not a stop. The word, and the wax smooth.

He stood and looked at it. Then he picked up the stylus from the blanket where it had fallen and, under his father's *and*, in his own square hand, in the shorthand only two living people could read, wrote the answer his father had worked out in a strong-room two years before and written him in a letter: *the sum's done and there's nothing left over*; and then crossed it out, because it was not true, because there was a tomb and two hulls and a paper and a woman at a loom and a son with a ring and a girl on a hill who was holding a door shut, and wrote instead, under the crossing, the thing he had never said to his father living and said now to the wax, which was: *the villa,*

and me, and I'm not spending it either. — C. And closed the tablet, and put it under his father's right hand, and went out to tell Vibia what was to be done, because he was the house now and that was what the house did.

◆

Rufus came to the funeral.

He had not been asked. The Augustales had been, this time, because the house was Celer's and Celer had decided, in the strong-room with the tablet under his father's hand, that a man who had built the biggest tomb on the road had meant it to be walked to by the whole town, and that *nobody* had been for the stone and not for the fire; and so the whole town came, on the ninth day, up the road between the tombs behind the bier, the Augustales in their best with the fasces they were allowed and the ship-masters and the sail-makers and the port-man's son who had kept the scale, who had the grace to walk at the back. The Alexandrian who had bought the *Isis*, and the Rhodian who had drunk eleven at the Dolphin and was seventy now and walked with a stick and wept, because the Rhodian wept at everything; and at the front, behind the bier and before the son, where the patron walked if the patron came, Lucius Laecanius Rufus, senator, in a toga, with his father's nose and his father's walk and none of his father's weight, and Thallus a pace behind with the map of a face, back from Rome a week.

Celer did not look at him. He walked behind the bier with Vibia on his arm and the stick in his belt, which was a thing nobody but a centurion wore at a funeral and which he had decided to wear and had not explained, and at the tomb he said the thing that was said, in Latin, in the square voice, badly, because he had only heard it said once, over Nicias, and had not been listening then, and then the fire. The town stood, and the smoke went up over the vines, and the Rhodian wept, and it was done.

Afterward, at the house, in the atrium between the columns that were not marble, with the town going through the door and the slaves with the wine and Vibia being what a widow was, Rufus found him.

He was thirty-six. He had been praetor and was waiting to be something else and had, Celer saw, close, for the first time in five years, the look of a man who had sat on a stool in a strong-room and been shown a paper and understood it in his legs; it had gone into the face, under the nose, and would not come out. He stood in front of the freedman's son in the freedman's atrium with the toga and the senatorial stripe and said, in the voice that was his father's voice with the certainty taken out: "Celer. I'm sorry. He was — my father said he was the only man on the coast who ever made him feel he'd been *counted*. I didn't understand that when he said it. I do now."

"Thank you, sir."

"Don't." Rufus looked round the atrium. "I've come to say a thing and I'd rather say it standing, because the last time I sat down in this house it cost me more than I had." He lowered his voice. "The paper. The villa. It's yours now. You know that; you've been in Sura's boxes five years, you know what a paper is. You could call it on the Kalends and I couldn't pay and the headland would be yours and my father's atrium with it, and every freedman on this coast would spit when they said your name, and you'd be the richest man in Puteoli and never asked to dinner." He held the freedman's son's eyes with his father's nose. "I'm not asking you not to. I'm telling you I know you could. That's — that's the only thing I've got to give that your father would have valued, I think. That I know."

Celer looked at him. The town went through the door behind.

"I'm not calling it, sir."

"No. He said you wouldn't. Thallus had it from him, in the winter, on the tablet: *the boy'll hold it and never call it and that'll be worse for Rufus than calling, and better for the boy, and I'll not be here to see either.*" Rufus's mouth did something that was nearly a smile

and was the family's and he had not earned it. "He was right. It's worse. I'll walk up that headland every April for the rest of my life knowing whose it is and so will my sons, and you'll never say a word, and that's — that's a freedman's revenge, and it's better than any I've seen in the Senate." He straightened the toga. "There's one other thing. I'm told you wrote the finding on the fine. With your name and your ring."

"Yes, sir."

"Then hear this, from the patron, in front of your father's gods, since I'm here and it's the only use I'll be." He raised his voice, slightly, so that the men nearest heard, which was the point. "The fine was just. The sail was weighed. My father's dock was leased to a man who did a thing and the thing was found and paid for, and the man's son did the figure himself, straight, and signed it. That's the house of Laecanius's view and it'll be said in the Senate if anyone asks, and if anyone on this coast says otherwise about Hermes's son, they'll say it to me." And then, lower, to Celer alone: "That's for the ring. It's not nothing; a senator's word on a freedman's son's figure is a thing that goes on a roll. It's the only thing I've got that doesn't cost me the headland, and I'd like, once, to have given this house something instead of sat in it."

He went. Thallus went behind him, and at the door the steward turned, as people did at doors, and looked at the freedman's son in the atrium with the stick in his belt, and said nothing, and went; and Celer stood with the town going by and understood that he had just been given, by the patron, in his father's atrium, the one thing his father had wanted for eighteen years and had not lived nine days to hear, which was a man of the house saying *just* about a freedman's figure in front of the town. That it had been given because the man could not afford anything else, and that his father would have said *that's the and*, and that it was.

◆

He went down to the mole on the evening after the fire, alone, because the house was full of the town and the town was full of his father, and he wanted, once, before he went back to Rome, to stand at the end of a thing and look out.

He could not. That was what he found. The old end was gone under the new work, the Syrian's man's stone going out another two hundred feet into the Gulf with a gang on it and a crane and a tower begun, and where two children had sat in March in the dark with the villa lamps on the water there was a wall of new blocks higher than his head and a man on top of it with a plumb-line who shouted down in Greek to get back; so he got back. He stood where the old mole met the new, with the fish-market behind him and the gap in the front where the Dolphin had been and the evening coming down over Capri the colour it came, and looked at the Gulf through the gap between the crane and the tower, and the Gulf was the Gulf, and it had no manifest, and he stood anyway.

"You're Hermes's."

An old woman. With a basket, empty, going home from the market; small and brown and bent, with a face that had been doing one thing for sixty years and had the shape of it. He did not know her. He knew what she was before she said it, because his father had taught him to read a hull from the quay by how she sat.

"I settled my eggs with the girl," the old woman said. "At the Dolphin. When she was ten and kept the book on the stair. Every week for four years. She never once passed the higher figure. I'd put it to her sometimes, to see — a dozen for eleven — and she'd look at me and write eleven and say nothing, and I'd think, that one's going somewhere, and she has." The old woman looked at the gap in the front. "My man's paid. A quarter, for nothing, since the year the old master died. He drinks it. I know who pays and I know why and I've told him he's to remember what he signed, if he's asked, and to say so, and he says he will, and he will, because I've told him." She shifted the

basket. "I saw your father's fire from the hill. I'd have come down but I'm not Augustales and I'd not have been let in the atrium. He was a hard man and he weighed a sail and he sent oil to a centurion every year and never said, and that's three true things about him and I've known men with fewer." She looked at the tall man in the road with the stick in his belt. "You've her nose. Not the consul's; the other one. The one that goes somewhere. Tell her the egg-woman's man remembers. Tell her that's paid for, and she needn't send any more coin, and I know she will anyway, because that's her, and I'll not stop her, because he drinks it and it keeps him quiet."

She went. He stood at the join of the old mole and the new until the man with the plumb-line came down off the wall and the gang went home and the crane stood alone against the evening, and then he went back up through the town past the house of Granius and the house where a Greek had died by a brazier to the house with the columns that were not marble, which was his, and full of the town, and in which his father's stool was by the loom and empty.

◆

Vibia was at the loom when the town had gone, in the room off the atrium where she had always been, with the lamp, and the shuttle going, because that was what her hands did when the rest of her could not.

He stood in the door. She did not stop. She was forty-four and had been a freedwoman of a Nola wool-merchant and then a shipowner's wife and now a shipowner's widow, and she had the Nola face, broad and brown and unsurprised, and she had put her arms round him in the atrium and would not again, he understood, because once was what it had cost her and she had paid it.

"Sit," she said, to the loom. "There. His stool. He sat there in the evenings this winter when he could still walk, and watched me, and said nothing, which was new. Thirty years I'd wanted him to say nothing for an hour and when he did I'd have given the house to have

him back at the sum." The shuttle went. "You wore the stick."

"Yes."

"Good. He'd have liked that. He didn't know Crescens — met him once, on the quay, the day the *Pelican* came in — but he sent the oil every year and he said to me, the year you went north, *that man's doing the thing I can't, which is standing next to him*. He was jealous of a centurion. He'd not have said so. He's not here now so I can." She reached for the next thread. "I've a thing to tell you and then a thing to ask, and then I'll not speak of either again, because I'm from Nola and we say a thing once."

"Go on."

"The letter. In the box behind the gods. You'll find it tonight because you'll go through the strong-room tonight, you're his; so I'll tell you now how it came. It came on the Nones of March, from Rome, by the house's post, the day after Thallus had been up the hill there to see her, and it was in the shorthand, and I can't read it, and he could, with the one eye, and he had me hold it for him because the right hand had the stylus and the left was gone. I held it. I watched his face." The shuttle stopped, for the first time. "I've watched that man's face over a letter for twelve years, Celer. Over the emperor's letter about the *Pelican*. Over yours about the ring. Over the fine. I know what it does. And I'll tell you what it did over that one, because you'll want to know and he can't say and I'm the only one who saw." She looked at him, finally, with the broad brown unsurprised face. "It did nothing. For a long time. And then the right side of it — the side that was still his — smiled. Not the way he smiled at a figure. The other way. The way he smiled at you on the quay the day you came off the *Pelican* with your hand on your own knife. And then he made the sound, the one that's not a word, and I thought he was trying to say your name, and he wasn't; he was trying to say *hers*; I could see the shape of it; and he couldn't; and he took the stylus and wrote on the tablet, and I've kept what he wrote, because I can't read it and I

thought you should."

She reached under the loom and brought out a tablet and gave it to him.

In the figures hand, badly: *She's mine. I said so. I was right. Tell the boy she's not holding him. She's holding* — and then the stylus had failed, or the hand, and there was a mark that was not a letter, and then, lower, smaller, as if written later with the hand rested: *the door. Not him. The door. He'll not see it. I didn't, at his age. Tell him.*

He read it. He read it again. The loom did not start.

"I don't know what it means," said Vibia. "I've never known what you two were saying to each other in that hand; it was the one room in the house I wasn't in. But I know what his face did, and I've told you, and now I've given you the tablet, and that's the thing I had to tell."

"And the thing to ask."

"The woman. In Rome. Over the wine-shop." She started the loom again, and did not look at him. "Your father knew. The steward's boy writes to Thallus's man who writes to Thallus who told Hermes everything, because that was their game, the two of them, for forty years, each telling the other what the other already knew so they'd both know they knew. He knew you'd bought a Puteoli merchant's woman in the Subura and paid without bargaining and that she kept your slate and called you by your name. And he said to me, on the stool, in the winter, when he could still speak: *he'll free her. He's mine. I freed you.*" The shuttle went. "I was his for six years before he did. I'd kept his house and his bed and his books when he was at sea and I was twenty-eight and I'd stopped expecting it, and he came in one evening from the Augustales' dinner, not drunk, and said *Vibia, I've been to the magistrate, you're free, I'd like you to stay and I'll not blame you if you don't*, and went to bed. I stayed. I stayed because he'd said *I'll not blame you*, which no man on this coast had ever said to me about anything." She looked at him, once. "So that's the thing to ask. Not whether. When. Because there's a difference between a

man who frees a woman because he's going to and a man who frees her because he's just stood by his father's stone and found out what a thing weighs, and I'd rather you were the second, and I'm asking you to be, because I'm from Nola and I'd like someone in this family to do a thing before they've done the sum on it."

He sat on his father's stool with the tablet in his hands and the loom going.

"When I'm back," he said. "The first day. Before I go up the hill to Sura."

"Good." The shuttle. "And Celer. When you do it. Say the thing he said. *I'll not blame you.* It's the only thing a woman in that place has never heard and the only thing worth saying, and he knew it, and he'd not have told you, because he thought it was a weakness, and it was the best thing he ever did."

◆

He opened the strong-room on the last night, alone, with the lamp, because the house was his and someone had to count it.

He went through the boxes. He did not need to; he had Philon's habits now and knew what was in a box by the dust on its lid; but he went through them anyway, because it was the thing his father would have done on the last night of a house, and because a woman over a wine-shop had said *count it in the morning* and he was counting it at night, which was the only time he had. The *Isis* year. The *Pelican* year with the Rhine run and the emperor's letter, which he read, standing, *the man who sent the Pelican is the man I want fed by*, and put back. The villa paper, in its own box, with the Spaniard son-in-law's seal and Rufus's, and he looked at it a long time and put it back without unfolding it, because he had told the patron he would not call it and a thing you did not call was a thing you did not read, either, or it began to read you. The Lares from Nola, which he would take; the Lares of the house, which stayed. The tablet with the figures, under his father's hand still, because Vibia had not let anyone move it and he had not

either; and he took it now, and read the column again. His own two lines under it, the crossed and the kept, and closed it, and put it in the box with the stick and the forty-one days and his father's last letter, which was the box he carried, and which was getting heavy, and which he understood he would carry until he could not, as his father had carried a sail-maker's bill for ten years because he was the one who wrote things down.

And at the bottom of the last shelf, behind the Lares, in a box with no seal and no dust, which meant it had been opened often and recently, a thing he had not known was there.

Letters. Not many. In his own square hand, the four lines each, from Vetera, from the far bank, from the tent, from the Aventine: *the roll, the Ides, Capito's office, the ring*; *Crescens, the second wall, a hand-stone, it was quick*; all of them, every letter he had ever written his father, from the first at fourteen that said *the Rhine is wider than the Gulf* to the last, kept, in order, tied; and under them, in the box, in another hand, one more, which was not his, and which he unfolded, and which was in the house's shorthand, and was not addressed, and said:

Hermes. The paper's in the prefect's archive under the Augusta's seal. I don't know if you'll have heard; I'm telling you so you've a figure and not a story. The steward's sheet is dead. I'll not come back to the coast. I know what you said in the strong-room, about how I came up; Thallus told me, on the hill, in March, with a German at the door. I'd like you to know that it was by my feet, and that I'd have been proud to have been yours in another house, because you were right about that, and because you taught me what a thing weighs with the lid off, and I've never forgotten the lesson or the man. The sail was the price of the hill. I paid it. You'd have paid it in my place; you said so. I left him off the sheet. You'll know why; it's the same reason you've not called the villa. — F.

He stood in the strong-room with the lamp and his father's gods and the letter in his hand that a girl on a hill had written to a man who could not read it, in March, after Thallus, after the stroke, knowing he could not read it, in a shorthand only two living people could read; and one of them was dead now. The other was standing in his strong-room with it, which was, he understood, the whole of why it had been written in that hand, to that man, at that time: so that it would be found here, by this lamp, by the one person left who could read it, after the one it was addressed to was past reading; and that this was either the cruellest thing she had ever done or the kindest, and that he had been in that place before, on a stool, with a prefect's sheet, and had not been able to tell, and could not now, and that his father had written *F.* on a tablet and he had said *the stone*, and his father had let him.

He read it again. *The same reason you've not called the villa.*

He put it in the box he carried, with the stick and the tablet and the forty-one days and the rest. He closed the strong-room. He fed the Lares from Nola in his old room with the window on the wall, with Chrestê's bread, which was stale now and was what he had, and said to them, out loud, in the house's shorthand, because they liked to see a face and there was nobody else in the house who could read it: "She's holding a paper on me. He said so. And she's just told him she knows it, and she's told him why, and the why's a thing I'd have had to do the sum for and she's done it and left it in a box for me to find. I don't know if that's the kindest thing or the cruellest. He'd have known. He'd have said it's both, and that both's a figure, and that I'd better learn to carry it, because he's not here to tell me what it weighs."

In the morning he rode back to Rome with the box on the saddle and the stick in the roll and the house in his stepmother's hands, because she had kept it for a shipowner for twelve years and could keep it for his son; and on the shoulder of the hill above the town he stopped, once, and looked back, not at the Gulf or the mole or the gap

where a lodging-house had been, but up the road to the right, where a travertine stone stood on its own ground with a cypress and a ship on it going somewhere, and a name cut a hand taller than the rest, so that it could be seen from a horse; and he saw it; and rode on.

23

The Hearth-Stone

The Palatine, spring 107

She taught the Spaniard's wife a lodging-house book in the mornings, and the Spaniard's wife was quick, and it was the first thing in Fausta's life that she had given away for nothing and watched be taken.

They did it on the floor. Sabina would not have a table; she said tables were for men with sheets, and sat on the cold floor of the north rooms in a gown worth the Dolphin's lease ten times with a slate on her knees, as a girl had sat on a lodging-house's bottom stair, and Fausta sat across from her with the second slate and made up a house. Eleven rooms. A Rhodian who drank. A sail-maker who paid in canvas and called it coin. A merchant's woman who came once a month with a factor's figure that was what he wished he'd drunk. And Sabina did the sums, in a hand that had been taught by a Greek to write Homer and had never written a number that meant anything, and got them wrong, and got them right, and looked up with the beautiful disappointed face lit from inside by a thing that was so plainly new to it that Fausta looked away, the first time, as from something she had not been meant to see.

"It *comes out*," Sabina said, the third morning, with the slate. "You see? I've done the Rhodian's week and the sail-maker's canvas at what it's worth and not what he says and the factor's figure at the lower, and it comes out. There's nothing left over." She looked at it. "Nothing on this hill ever comes out. There's always a thing left over and the thing's always a person."

"That's what my mother said, domina. With the last of her breath."

"Then your mother was the only honest woman between here and Puteoli and I'd have liked her." Sabina put the slate down. "Again. Make me a harder house. Put a man in it who's been told to pass the higher figure and knows I know."

She made her a harder house. And in the evenings, when the Spaniard came in from the cut with the dust on him and stood in the door and did not know his wife for a moment, and then did, and then looked past her to the corner, Fausta stood in the corner with the box of pins and let him look, because a dead woman had said *let the seeing do the work* and because Sabina had said *I'll have arranged it*, and because she had decided, on a terrace by a sea with no manifest, that she would stop pretending about what was true, only about what it cost; and what was true was that the grey eyes rested on her now, each evening, for the length of a flame leaning. That the face lit, interested and a little short, and that she did not know yet which she was, and that neither, she thought, did he.

He spoke to her once in April. Not in the north rooms; in the Greek library, the old one, Augustus's, on the south side, where she had been sent by Sabina with a tablet to find a line in Sappho that the Spaniard's wife wanted for a reason she would not give, and where the Spaniard was, alone, at a table, with four scrolls open and the Greek cloak over the chair and no staff, reading; and he looked up when the girl came between the shelves and said, in the Greek, without surprise, "Puteoli. What does she want?"

"Sappho, sir. The one about the apple."

"On the topmost bough. The one the pickers forgot; no, not forgot, couldn't reach." He did not get up. He pointed with the stylus. "Third case, second shelf, the roll with the red tag; it's a bad copy but it's the one she'll have read as a girl and she'll want the bad copy, she always does." The grey eyes did not go back to the scroll. "She's teaching you Sappho and you're teaching her a slate. Plotina told me. Plotina tells me most things; the rest I read." A pause.

"Which is the better bargain?"

"Hers, sir."

"Why?"

"Because she'll never need the slate and I'll need the Sappho, sir. A thing you'll never need is a gift. A thing you'll need is a price."

The Spaniard looked at her for a long moment across the four scrolls, in the old library with the light coming grey through the high windows onto the cases where Augustus had put the Greeks so he could say he had them, and the face lit, and then — she saw it; she kept it — it did another thing, which it had not done in the north rooms, which was to stop finding her interesting for the length of a breath and simply *look*, as a man looked at a column he had not expected to reconcile.

"Hermes's son said a thing like that on a rock," he said. "About a bridge. That it wasn't for crossing, it was for *after*. Lucius says you two were raised in the same street and read the same bill at eleven. I'd not believed it till now." He turned back to the scroll. "Take her the red tag. And Puteoli — when you've done with the slate, and she's done with the Sappho, and Plotina's done with your hair, come back here. Not for anything. I read alone in the afternoons and I've never had anyone in this room who knew what a thing cost, and I'd like to find out whether it's as tiresome as I think it'll be."

"Yes, sir."

"Hadrian. When the door's shut. Vibia's told you the same about *domina*; I know, she tells me what she's told you so I'll not undo it. We're a family that labels its doors." He did not look up. "Go on. She'll be counting the time you've been gone and putting it in a column."

She took the red tag. Sabina was counting. Sabina looked at the roll and at the girl's face and said, in the low quick voice, "He spoke to you," and Fausta said, "He said to come back to the library when the slate's done," and Sabina was quiet, and then laughed, once, short,

dry, at the glass, and said, "Already. I'd given it till the summer. Well. He's quicker than I thought or you're better, and I'll find out which by watching, and either way it's a stone laid, and I laid it, and don't you forget that, Puteoli, when you're in that library in the afternoons. I laid it." And then, differently, with the slate on her knees: "Make me a house. A hard one. I don't want to think about the library and I'd rather not think about him and the only thing that stops me thinking is a Rhodian who drinks."

She went back to the library on the fourth afternoon. Not because she had been told to; because Sabina had said, with the slate, *go, or he'll think I kept you, and I'd rather he thought I sent you*, and because a dead woman had said *let the seeing do the work* and she had decided to find out what the work was.

He was at the table. He did not look up. She stood between the cases with her hands empty, because she had not brought a tablet and had not been sent for a line, and after a while he said, in the Greek, to the scroll, "Sit. There. Not across; beside. I don't talk across tables; it makes a thing of it." She sat. The chair was his staff's and too low. He read for a time, and she sat, and the light came grey through the high windows, and she found that she did not mind it, the sitting, which was new; on the Caelian and in the Augusta's room sitting had been a thing you were permitted and here it was simply a chair.

"Lucius is dying," he said, eventually, to the scroll. "You'll know. Everyone does. He coughs in the mornings now where the clerks can hear and he's stopped pretending it's the damp. A year, the Greek says; two if he goes to Baiae, and he'll not go to Baiae, because the emperor's here and the boxes are here and Lucius has never in his life been anywhere the boxes weren't." He turned a column. "When he dies, his office goes to someone. The emperor will say it goes to his freedman Phlegon, who's a good clerk and can't think, and Plotina will say it goes to Capito, who's a good friend and can't be spared from the rolls, and in the end it'll go where the boxes go, and the boxes

will go where the man is who's read them." Now he looked up. "Hermes's son has read them. All of them. The third room too; Lucius showed him the sealed box in his second year, which he's done for nobody else, not even me. When Lucius dies that boy will know more about how this emperor was made than anyone alive but Plotina, and he'll be twenty by the autumn, with a ring, and a father's fine on the roll with his own name under it, and a woman he's freed, and no patron but a dead Spaniard. He'll need one." The grey eyes rested. "I'm telling you because you'll be asked. Not by me; by her. She asks the people who know a man what the man will do, and she'll ask you, because you read the same bill, and I'd rather you'd had time to think about the answer than gave her the one she wants."

"What does she want, sir?"

"Hadrian."

"What does she want?"

"She wants him on my staff. Where I can see him. Where the boxes are, when they're mine." He said it without weight, as a man said the time. "She's wanted it since he was fourteen and said a thing on a stool about who'd be emperor. I've wanted it since a rock. Lucius has said no for six years because Lucius is the only man on this hill who's ever loved anything that wasn't useful, and the thing he loves is that boy's figure, and he'll not give it to a man who'll use it. He's right. I will." The face lit. "So when she asks you whether Hermes's son will come to me when Lucius is dead, you'll want to say yes, because yes is what the hill says. And I'd like you to say what you think. Because I've read your sheet, Puteoli, and your sheet had no *I* in it and left a boy out on purpose, and a woman who can do that is a woman who can tell Plotina a true thing about him, and there's not another on the hill who could."

She sat in the low chair with her hands in her lap and her feet under her and the cases going up into the grey light, and did the sum, and did not pick the first way it came out, because a boy on a stool

had taught her that by doing it wrong on a mole.

"He'll come, sir. Not because the boxes are yours. Because Sura will tell him to, with his last breath, in the Spanish, and he's a man who does what he's told when the telling's right." She did not look away. "And he'll hate it. Not you. The being used. He's read the sealed box; he knows what a man looks like who writes letters for eleven readers; he said so to Sura and Sura told him to watch for it, and he's watched, and he's seen it in you, and he's seen it in himself, and he'll come to you anyway because he's got nowhere else to put his figure, and he'll do it with his eyes open, and he'll be the best man you've got and the only one you'll never own." She stopped. "That's what I think. It's not what she wants. She wants a man who's hers. He's not. He's been nobody's since he was eleven in a strong-room with the lid off. It's the only thing we've got in common that isn't a bill."

The Spaniard looked at her for a long time. Then he laughed — once, short, surprised, the way Sabina laughed at the glass, so that she understood for the first time where the wife had got it — and put the scroll down.

"*The only one you'll never own.*" He shook his head. "Lucius said you'd say something I'd not have thought of. He said it on the rock, with lime on his boots, about both of you. *They were raised in the same street by a dying woman and a shipowner and the one thing neither of them learned is how to be had.*" He stood, and took the Greek cloak from the chair. "Come tomorrow. Bring the Sappho; I'll show you where the bad copy's wrong and why it's better. And Puteoli." At the door of the library, where people on that hill turned. "When she asks — and it'll be this week — say it to her exactly as you said it to me. The whole of it. *The only one you'll never own.* She'll not like it. She'll remember it. And in a year, when she's deciding whether you're the thing she thought you were, she'll weigh that sentence, and it'll be heavier than the hair."

The Augusta asked on the Ides, under the cloth, after the hair, with the room emptied and Marcia at the shoulder and Matidia's page turning.

"Hermes's son. When Lucius dies. Will he come to Hadrian?"

She said it exactly. The whole of it. *The only one you'll never own.*

The cloth did not move for a long time.

"Yes," the Augusta said at last, to the ceiling. "That's what Lucius says too, and Lucius is dying and tells the truth now because it's cheaper. I'd hoped you'd say otherwise; I'd have known you were lying and I'd have known why, and it would have been a thing I could use." The voice for metre. "Instead you've told me the one true thing about him that I can't use, which is that he's nobody's, and you've told me that you're the same, in the same breath, which I'd worked out, and now you've said it in my room, where things that are said become so." A pause. "Marcia. Write it down. *The only one you'll never own.* Put it in the box with the girl's letter about Tingis. When she's thirty I'll want to read them together and see which one was true."

"Augusta."

"I've not finished. Here's your instruction, since Hadrian's given you his and Sabina's given you hers." The cloth came off. The plain face sat up and showed what it decided to, and what it decided to was the thing that was nearly tiredness, and was not. "You'll go to the library in the afternoons. You'll let him look. You'll say true things to him; it's what he's short of. You'll not go to his bed, this year or next. If he asks, you'll say *what does it cost* in the voice you've got for it, and he'll laugh, and not ask again for a while. You'll be Sabina's, and she'll love you, and you'll let her. I made her the price of him; he can't take her down." The face did not change. "I told you a year ago it was five years or ten. I was wrong. Sura's cough has moved the day. The triumph's in June. You'll be in the box with Sabina. He'll be in the procession, with the staff. And I'll be watching your faces, both. I've

bought the two of you from a coast for the price of a sail and a man in Africa and I'd like, once, to see what I've paid for."

◆

"The shipowner's dead," Marcia said at her shoulder, with the comb, on the Kalends of May, in the Nemausus Latin, so lightly that the Augusta under the cloth could pretend not to hear.

"The shipowner. Puteoli. On the pallet in his strong-room; nine days after they carried him to the stone. The son's back; he came up the Aventine on the Ides with a box and a centurion's stick and went to the magistrate's before he went to Sura's, which is a thing the wine-shops have noticed." The comb moved. "He freed the woman. The Corinthian. First day. The steward's boy says he said a thing to her in the Latin and not the Greek and she sat down on the floor, and then got up and went on keeping the house, and that she's called Laecania Chrestê now and has a wage and a room with a door of its own and he's not been through it since." The fingers found a pin. "That's all the hill has. I tell you because it's the fifth door and I said I'd not wait ten years."

Fausta's hands did not stop. The Augusta's hair was fine and grey and plain and her hands did nothing with it, perfectly, and the room was quiet, and under the cloth the Augusta said, to the ceiling, in the voice for metre, "Marcia. What's the girl's face doing?"

"Nothing, Augusta."

"Good. Then she's heard it." The cloth did not move. "Girl. I'll say one thing about it and then it's not mine, it's yours. A man who frees a woman on the first day back from his father's stone is a man who's just learned what a thing weighs and wants to put one down. That's not kindness. It's a man emptying a box so he can carry a heavier one. I've watched my husband do it with provinces." A page turned; it was Matidia's. "You'll not ask me what the heavier one is. You know. You left it off a sheet."

She did the hair. She went down the long wall behind the comb and across the courts past the fountain that worked and into the north rooms, where Sabina was on the floor with a slate and looked up and saw the face that was doing nothing and said, "Go away. Not away; go and stand somewhere. You've a thing in you that's not for my rooms and I'll not have it in them. Momus. Take her to the terrace. The one on the west; nobody uses it; it looks at the Capitol and the cut and it's where I go when I want to be furniture." And she went.

The terrace looked at the city. Not the sea; the city, from the top of its own hill: the Capitol with the temple gold in the May light and under it the old Forum with its roofs and beyond it the raw red wound of the cut, where the Syrian was taking a hill away a basket at a time, and the dust standing over it in the still air like a thing that had been breathed out and not yet in. Momus climbed onto the parapet's bench, where he could see, and sat with his short legs out, and said nothing, which was the thing he was for.

She stood with her hands on the parapet. The price was in her, and she looked at it, and it had moved, as it had moved in a room with a German at the door when a steward had said *open hand, across the face, with the Lares watching*; and she did the sum, slowly, inside. It came out where it had been coming out since a terrace by a sea: that she had put the father on a sheet and left the son off it, and had told herself it was the lower figure, and had told the Augusta it was *him, the only paper I had that nobody could burn*, and had told a dead woman on a terrace nothing, and had written a letter to a dying man in a hand only the son could read, so that it would be found; and that all of these were true and none of them was the figure; and that the figure was that she had said *not for nothing* to a boy on a mole with her arm out straight and he had said *all right* and put it in a column, and that she had been right, and that she had held him off at the length of her arm ever since because the arm was the only thing on the mole

that had been hers.

"Momus."

"Girl."

"The paper. The false one. Under the hearth-stone in the room off the lady's; I brought it up the hill with the other. It's in my gown now. I've carried it five years." She did not turn. "The true one's in the prefect's archive under the Augusta's seal. The steward's dead to it; he said so with his own mouth. The egg-man's paid. Hermes is dead. The only people who ever knew it was false were my mother and Thallus and the magistrate's clerk who took the coin, and my mother's in the ground and the clerk's drunk it and Thallus has decided." She took it out. It was soft with five years of being against skin, and the fold had gone through, and the seal was a smear. "There's no one left to show it to."

"Then burn it," said Momus. "There's a brazier in the Augusta's outer court that's kept lit for the Germans' hands. I'll walk you. Nobody stops a girl with a dwarf; they think I'm hers and she's mine and they're half right."

She did not move.

"Girl."

"If I burn it," she said, to the city, "then I'm what the Augusta's paper says. Born free, in the house by the harbour, with witnesses. And that's true, now, because she's filed it, and nobody counts a thing she's filed." Her hands were on the parapet. "And I'll have nothing left on me that says what it cost. The Strabo's a book. The brass fish is a lease that's sold. His letters are small things from Sura's office with postscripts. This is the only thing I own that says: *your mother bought you a name at a magistrate's for the price of a quarter's rent, with an egg-seller's husband for a witness, and sent you up a hill with it, and said don't come back.*" She looked at the smear of the seal. "I don't want to be a woman who burned the price. I've seen them. They're on the benches. They've all got a true paper somewhere and none of

them remembers what it cost and they sit in that room and perform."

Momus was quiet on the parapet for a long time, with his legs out, looking at the cut.

"I was sold at four," he said. "To a man who made us. You know what I mean; you've seen the ones who didn't survive it, at the games, on sticks. He had a cage. You grew in it the way it let you and then you were worth something. I was in it two years and then I was Tertulla's father's, and then hers, and I've been on a stool at the end of a corridor for forty years counting people in and out, and I'll tell you, girl, as the only person on this hill who's been in a cage and come out shaped by it, that there's two kinds of people who keep the price. There's the ones who keep it so they'll remember. And there's the ones who keep it so they'll have a thing to hold onto when the floor goes." He turned his face to her. "You've felt the floor. You told me. On Sabina's stool, with the Augusta's sheet in your hands. You've not had it since you were ten and a shutter wouldn't bar and you've got it now, and you're standing on it, and you're holding a soft bit of paper with a smear on it because you're afraid that if you let go the floor was only ever the paper." He looked back at the cut. "It wasn't. The floor's her seal and your feet and a man in Africa and a sail. You bought it. It's yours. Burn the receipt."

She stood a while longer. The dust hung over the cut. Somewhere under it, in a hut, with a deaf clerk, a man she had known since she was five was doing a figure for a Syrian, and she could not see him from here and had not expected to and stood anyway.

"Walk me," she said.

He walked her. Through the courts, past the fountain, along the long wall, into the Augusta's outer court where the Germans stood and the brazier was, for their hands, lit in May because Germans were cold in any month; and the two by the brazier looked at the tall girl with the pin and the dwarf and stepped back, because she was the Augusta's hair and the dwarf was a gift. She stood over the coals with

the soft folded thing and did not say anything, because there was nothing that was said, and put it in.

It went slowly. Five years of skin had made it damp. It curled, and browned, and the smear of the seal went first, and then the magistrate's drawn stamp that a drunk clerk had been paid to draw, and then the names, the Rhodian's father, the egg-woman's husband, and last, because it was in the fold where the paper was thickest, *Fausta, daughter of Hilara*; and she watched it, as she had held a boy on a mole with her hand flat on his chest, at the length of her arm and no further; and when it was gone she stood a moment longer with her hands empty and her feet under her, and found that the floor was there. That it was, as the dwarf had said, not the paper, and that she had known that, and had wanted to be told by someone who had been in a cage.

"There," said Momus. "Now you're what the Augusta says. Born free. Witnesses. It's a terrible thing to be and you'll get used to it." He looked up at her. "What's left on you?"

"The Strabo. The fish. His letters." She did not touch her gown. "And the one from the prefect's archive, with her seal."

"Then that's your paper. And the letters are the door." He turned for the courts. "Come on. Sabina's counting. She'll want to know what you did on the terrace and she'll not believe *nothing*, so tell her *burned a thing*, and she'll make you a harder house to stop her thinking about it, and you'll do it, and that's the hill; that's the whole of it; a woman on a floor with a slate and a woman at a brazier with a receipt and neither of them saying what the other knows."

◆

She came on the two of them together once that spring, in the steward's court behind the Augusta's kitchens, and stood in the arch and was not seen, and kept it.

They were quarrelling about a stool. That was what it was; it was not what it was about. Momus's stool, the one he had brought up the

hill from the Caelian in the litter with the chest, and had set by the postern where he sat, and which the Augusta's under-steward had moved, twice, because a dwarf on a stool by the postern was not a thing the Augusta's household had a line for in its book; and Marcia had the stool, by one leg, in the middle of the court. Momus had it by the other, and neither of them was pulling, and they were speaking in the low voices of two people who had spent a lifetime each not being heard across a room.

"It goes in the under-steward's store with the other stools," Marcia said, "and you draw it in the morning and you put it back at night and he writes it in his book, and then it's the house's stool and nobody moves it, because it's in the book."

"It's my stool."

"Nothing on this hill is anybody's. That's the first thing. You've been here four months; I've been here forty years; it's the first thing."

"It was the old master's stool on the Caelian, and then it was the lady's, and then it was mine, because she said so with her mouth, by the sea, with the doctor there to hear it." The dwarf did not let go of the leg. "I'll not draw it from a store like a mop."

"Then it'll be moved. Every day. By a boy who's doing what he's told and who'll be whipped if he stops, because the under-steward's a fool and the Augusta can't be troubled with a stool, and you'll sit on the step like a parcel. The girl will see you on the step every morning and know you've lost, and that's a thing she'll carry up the stairs on her face, and I'll see it on her face, and I'll have to arrange it off again before the cloth comes off." Marcia's round brown face was perfectly pleasant. "I don't care where you sit. I care what's on her face at the shoulder. Give me the stool."

Momus looked at her. Then he looked at the stool, with his short arm out holding it, and then he did a thing Fausta had never seen him do on the Caelian, which was laugh, once, through the nose, like a man who has been shown a sum he should have seen himself.

"You're a hard woman, Nemausus."

"I'm a freedwoman with a comb. You're a freedman with a stool. Between us we've got the one girl on this hill who's worth the trouble, and we're standing in a kitchen-court holding furniture." She let go of her leg. "Store. Mornings. Book. And when the under-steward dies, which he will, because he eats like a Gaul, I'll see it's written as yours, and nobody will ever move it again, and you'll have won, and it'll have taken four years, which is quick, for here."

"I don't like you," said the dwarf, picking up the stool.

"No. I don't like you either. It's the most useful thing about us; she'll never have to wonder which of us is lying to her for the other's sake." Marcia turned to go, and saw the girl in the arch, and did not change her face at all, and said, "There you are. The cloth's on in a quarter-hour. Momus has a stool to put in a store," and went past her, and the dwarf came after with the stool under his arm and the seamed face arranged, and said as he passed, very low, "Four years. She's right. It is quick, for here," and went on toward the under-steward's door.

Fausta stood in the arch a moment longer, and put it in the column: that the two people who guarded her on that hill could not stand each other and had just, in a kitchen-court, over a stool, divided her between them like a province; and that she had never once in four years had to wonder which of them was lying, and had thought that was luck.

Her birthday was the fourth day before the Ides of May, and she was nineteen, and the Spaniard's wife gave her a book.

Not a scroll. A book — the new kind, cut and sewn, leaves of parchment between boards, that the Spaniard had brought back from Athens when he was a boy and that nobody on the hill used because they looked like account-books; and that was why, Sabina said, with the beautiful face doing its nearly-smile, handing it across the floor between the slates. "It's blank. Every leaf. I had the binder on the Argiletum make it and he asked what it was for and I said *a*

lodging-house and he thought I was mad." She sat back. "You've taught me a book. I've nothing to teach you that you'll need except Sappho and you're getting that from him, in the afternoons, in the library, and I won't compete with a man who reads better than I do. So here's a thing you'll not need. A book with nothing in it. For whatever you keep. I know you keep things; you've a face like a shutter and a shutter's for keeping. Keep them in that. Not the slate kind. The other kind. The kind that doesn't come out."

Fausta held it. It was heavy, for its size; the boards were oak. She opened it and the first leaf was blank and the second and all of them, and she sat on the cold floor of the north rooms with a book with nothing in it on her knees and understood that she had just been given the only gift of her life that had not been a price in advance. That she did not know what to do with it, and that the Spaniard's wife was watching her not know with the dry tenant intelligence and was, Fausta saw, pleased, in a way that had nothing to do with the hill.

"Thank you," she said. It was the wrong word on the Augusta's side of the hill and she said it anyway, because it was Sabina's side and the doors were labelled.

"Don't. I'll start to like it." Sabina picked up her slate. "What will you put in it first? Don't tell me. I'll guess. The sail."

"No."

"The man in Africa."

"No."

"Then what?"

Fausta looked at the blank first leaf. Her hands, which had done a dying woman's hair and an empress's and had held a soft paper over coals, were still on the oak.

"A mole," she said. "In the spring. Two children on it, counting ships. One of them says *not for nothing* and the other one says *all right*. That's the first thing. The rest comes after it, in order, and it's long, and it doesn't come out, and I've been carrying it in the place

where I keep the Rhodian's eleven for six years and I'd like, once, to put it down somewhere that isn't me."

Sabina was quiet. The slate lay on her knees.

"Then that's the fifth door," she said at last, in the low quick voice, to the glass. "Marcia's five. She told me; she tells everyone; she thinks a thing's not a secret unless she's said it. The paper, the sheet, the widow, the son, the boy. Four shut, one yours." She did not turn from the window. "Write it in the book, Puteoli. Then read it. Then you'll know which it is." The beautiful face turned, finally, and was not performing, and was not kind, and was, Fausta thought, as near as it could come to either. "I know. I've one too. His name doesn't matter; he's in Athens and married and I've never written it down. Make me a house. A hard one. It's your birthday and I'd like to get something wrong."

24

I'll Not Blame You

Rome, spring 107

He went to the magistrate before he went up the hill, as he had told a woman at a loom he would, and it took less time than buying her had.

The praetor's clerk in the basilica by the Forum had seen a thousand of these and looked at the tall young man with the ring and the dust of the Appian road still on him and the woman beside him in a good plain gown with a long face arranged, and said, "Name," and he said, "Chrestê, Corinthian, twenty-three, bought in the Subura in the consulship of —" and the names. The clerk wrote, and said, "Manumission before the magistrate, by the rod; the lictor's there; touch her with it when he says and say the words; she's a citizen when you've said them and a freedwoman of your house and takes your name; fee's on the table. Next." And the lictor came with the rod, bored, and touched her shoulder, and Celer said the words, which were old and short and had been said by his father in this basilica or one like it for a woman from Nola, *I wish this woman to be free*, and the clerk made a mark, and it was done, and the ring had weighed less than a denarius and the words weighed less than the ring and she was standing in the basilica of the Roman people a citizen, with his name, *Laecania Chrestê*, and the clerk was already saying *next*.

They walked back along the Forum toward the Aventine. She did not speak. He did not. At the foot of the hill, by the wine-shop, with the stair going up to the three rooms, she stopped, and he stopped, and she looked at him with the long face arranged and said, in the Gulf Greek, "Well. I'm free. What now? You've not said. You've walked me to a magistrate and said four words and walked me back and you've not said what now, and I've kept your slate for two years

and I'd like to know what the next line is."

He had thought about it on the Appian road for four days, with a tablet in a box that said *the door, not him*, and a loom going in his head; and he said it, in the Latin, not the Greek, because his father had said it in Latin to a woman from Nola, and because the Greek was the language he had bought her in.

"The rooms are yours to keep, if you want them, at the wage, as a freedwoman keeps a house. Your own room, with the door; I'll not come through it. The slate's yours; I've never checked it and I'll not start. If you want to go — Puteoli, Corinth, anywhere — there's two thousand at the banker's on the Sacred Way in your name as of this morning, which is what my father gave Vibia, and it's yours whether you stay or not." He stopped. He made himself look at her face while he said the rest, because a man was his face and this was the only thing he had ever been told by his father that he knew to be the best thing his father had done. "I'd like you to stay. And I'll not blame you if you don't."

She looked at him for a long moment, at the foot of the stair, in the April noon, with the wine-shop's noise behind her and the long face arranged; and then it was not arranged, and she sat down.

On the step. All at once, as a sack went down, with her gown in the dust of the Aventine and her hands in her lap and the long face turned up to him with nothing on it at all, not the sum, not the pen-look, not the thing underneath; nothing; a woman of twenty-three on a step who had been sold with the furniture and had just been told the one thing in the world she had decided at fourteen she would never hear and had arranged her face for nine years so as not to be seen waiting for it. She did not weep. She sat. People went past on the stair and round her.

"Say it again," she said, after a while, in the Latin.

"I'll not blame you."

"No. The other."

"I'd like you to stay."

She sat a moment longer. Then she got up, and shook the dust out of the gown, and arranged her face, and it was the long plain Corinthian face he had bought in the Subura and it was not, because something under it had moved and was not going back, and she said, in the Gulf Greek again, briskly, as a manifest: "Then I'll stay. At the wage. In my room, with the door, and you'll not come through it, and I'll not come through yours, because a freedwoman who goes to her patron's bed the week she's freed is a woman the wine-shop has a word for and I've been called it. I'll keep the slate. I'll keep the rooms. I'll keep *you*, as much as a woman can keep a man who's nobody's; I've watched you two years and I know what that is now." She started up the stair. At the turn she stopped, and looked down, and the thing that had moved was in her eyes and she let him see it. "And the two thousand stays at the banker's. I'll not touch it. It's the first money I've ever had that wasn't a price and I'd like to look at it now and then and not spend it. Your father's woman did the same; I'd wager on it. We're a kind, us. We keep the receipt."

◆

Sura was on the couch, and the couch had been moved to the window, because the man wanted to see the hill while he coughed.

Celer came in with the box under his arm and the stick in his belt and stood, and Sura looked at him from the cushions with the knife-face gone to bone and the eyes exactly the same and said, in the Spanish, "You freed her first. Before you came to me. The steward's boy had it from the wine-shop before you were up the Aventine." A breath, with a sound in it. "Good. Your father would have done it second and hated himself. You're better than him by one place in the order, which is the most a son gets." He moved a hand. "Sit. Not the stool. Here, where I can see you without turning; the Greek says turning's a thing I've done enough of."

He sat. The hill was in the window, the Palatine, across the valley where the Circus was, with the palace roofs and the pines and, if he looked, the north side, where the Spaniard's wife's rooms were, with three windows, cold.

"Your father."

"On the pallet. In the strong-room. Nine days after the stone." He did not say the rest. "Rufus came. He said the fine was just, in front of the town, and that the house of Laecanius would say so in the Senate."

"Did he. Well. That's the first useful thing Rufus has done since he was born and he did it because he couldn't afford the other." Sura coughed, into the cloth, and looked at it, and this time did not put it away, but held it, in his lap, as a thing he had stopped hiding. "It'll go on the roll. Capito's already had it; I sent it the day the boy told me. A senator's word on a freedman's son's figure, in a patron's atrium, in front of Augustales. It's the kind of thing that makes a roll a roll and not a list." He looked at the window. "You've done it, you know. The thing he wanted. You're on the roll at four hundred and six, with a patron's word, and the fine paid, and a freedwoman of your own house, and a stone with your name a hand taller. That's the whole of it. That's what a man walks off a ship at nineteen and builds for forty years. It's done. How does it feel?"

Celer sat with the box on his knees and the hill in the window and did the sum, and it came out, and he said it.

"Like a clerk, and a box, and *next*, sir."

Sura laughed. It turned into the cough, and the cough went on, and when it was done he lay back and said, "Yes. That's it exactly. That's what the consulship felt like, and the second, and the house, and the day I wrote the eleventh letter from Cologne and knew the thing was made. A clerk and a box and *next*. Nobody tells you. They can't; you'd not believe them; you'd think it was a rich man's sorrow and you'd be right, and it would still be true." The eyes came back from the window. "I've a thing to say and I'll say it now, because I've

not got the breath to save it for a better day and there's not one coming."

"Sir."

"When I'm dead — and it's this year; the Greek says two with Baiae and I'll not go to Baiae — the boxes go to Hadrian. Not by my will; a man can't will the emperor's letters. By the fact. He's read what I've let him and he knows there's a third room and he's the one who'll be standing when the door's opened, because Plotina will see to it, because she's been seeing to it since he was fourteen. And he'll want the man who's read them, because a box is nothing without the man, and the man is you." A breath. "I've said *until I'm dead, then do your own sum*. I've said it to him and I've said it to you and I meant it both times. I'll say the sum now, since I've done it, and you can do yours after and see if it comes out the same."

Celer waited.

"Go to him. The day I'm burned. Go to him with the box under your arm and the stick in your belt and say *Sura said*, and he'll take you, and he'll use you, and you'll be the best man he's got and he'll know it and you'll know it and neither of you will ever say so. He'll be emperor. You said it on a stool at fourteen and you were right and I've known it since and I've kept you from him for six years because — " Sura stopped. The knife-face did a thing Celer had not seen it do, which was hesitate. "Because I'm a man who's spent forty years making things useful and I wanted, once, to have a thing that wasn't. That's the whole of why. Your figure. The way you look at a bridge and say *it's for after*. I wanted it in my office and not his for as long as I had an office, and that's a vanity and I've had worse, and it's done now, and you'll go to him."

"Yes, sir."

"And you'll hate it."

"Yes, sir."

"Good. Hate it with your eyes open. The ones who love him are furniture and the ones who hate him are dead." Sura turned his head, slowly, as if it were a thing he had been told not to do, and looked at the freedman's son. "She said the same. Did you know? Plotina asked her, on the Ides, whether you'd come to him when I'm dead, and she said — Hadrian told me, laughing; he'd not laughed since the rock — *he'll come, and he'll hate it, and he'll be the best man you've got and the only one you'll never own.*" The eyes held. "Plotina had Marcia write it down. In ten years it'll be true of one of you and not the other, and I'll not be here to see which. I'd have liked to." He lay back. "Go away now. Come back in the morning with the Syrian's figure; the Senate's asked again."

Celer stood. He stood with the box under his arm and the hill in the window and the Spaniard on the couch with the cloth in his lap and did not go.

"Sir. One thing."

"One."

"You showed me the sealed box in my second year. You've shown nobody else. Not him." He kept the voice level. "Why?"

Sura looked at the hill for so long that Celer thought he had not heard, or had decided not to.

"Because you'd have found it," he said finally. "You count everything. You'd have counted the boxes in the third room and found one that didn't balance and you'd have opened it, because you're your father's and your father never let a lid stay on, and then you'd have known the thing by accident, which is the worst way to know a thing, because you'd have had to decide what to do with it alone. I'd rather you knew it on purpose. From me. With the wax looked at and not broken." The eyes closed. "That's all. It's not a kindness. It's an old man who's made one emperor by letter and wanted the boy who'd read the letters to know he'd been *let*. Go and do the figure."

◆

Philon set him to the third room the week after, because Sura had said *the boxes go where the man is* and the man would need to know what he was carrying.

The archivist was sixty-one now and the cough he had had at fifty-eight had not killed him and had not gone. He stood in the door of the third room with the lamp and Sura's father's ring and watched the freedman's son go along the shelves with a tablet, as he had watched him in the first year, and said, when the boy reached the end of the second shelf, "You've not opened one."

"I don't need to, sir. The dust."

"No. You don't. I taught you that and you've learned it better than I know it." Philon coughed. "Open the fourth on the third. The pine one with no seal. It's not Sura's. It's mine. I've kept it since the year the Caelian was barred and I'd like you to see it before the Spaniard's people are in here with their lists and it goes in a cart with the rest and nobody knows what it was."

He opened it. It was letters. Not many: a year's worth, perhaps, on the cheap papyrus a widow's household used for small things, in a clerk's Latin, headed, each one, *the lady Cornelia Tertulla asks*; and under the heading, the request, a small thing from Sura's office, a date, a name, a sum; and at the foot of each, in a different hand, a line, sometimes two, in the Latin a consul's widow had taught a lodging-house girl, saying what the lady wished to know and why. He knew the hand. He had seen it at eleven on a slate and at fifteen on a shutter and at seventeen in a postscript that said *I know the sum, do the other thing*. He had never seen a year of it together.

"She wrote them," Philon said from the door. "Not the clerk; the lines at the foot. Sura had me keep them separate from the Caelian's other correspondence because he said the lines were worth more than the requests. He said: *there's a girl on the Caelian who's learned to ask a thing so that the man she's asking knows exactly what it costs her to*

ask, and that's a thing I've seen three men do in forty years and no woman, and I want it in a box." The archivist coughed again. "You answered two in three. No postscript. He noticed that too. He said *the boy's been told to do nothing and he's doing it with his hand on the pen, which is the hardest way*."

Celer stood with the box open and a year of her hand in it. He read one. *The lady wishes to know whether the priesthood is still refused, because she has promised Bassus's daughter an answer and will not give her a false one.* He read another. *The lady asks for the name of the man who took the Nola grain-office because her freedwoman's cousin's husband was passed over for it and she would like to be able to say by whom.* He read a third, the last in the box, from the spring of the year his father had said *on her back*: *The lady asks nothing this month. I am writing because the Kalends have come and the lady's house sends a letter on the Kalends and I would not have Sura's office think the house had stopped. — F.*

He put them back. He closed the lid.

"Keep it," said Philon. "Not in the cart. Take it to the Aventine. Sura's said so; he said *the boy'll know what it weighs, and the Spaniard would only read it*." The archivist turned in the door with the lamp. "I'll be dead by the winter; the Greek's said. I've kept the boxes of two Spaniards for forty years and I've never once in that time taken a thing out of them for myself, and I'd like, before the cart, to have given one away. That one. It's the only box in this house that was never useful to anyone, and that's why he kept it, and that's why I'm giving it to you, and that's all the philosophy an archivist has."

He took it to the Aventine. He put it beside the other, the one with the stick and the tablet and the forty-one days, and did not open it again that spring, and Chrestê, who saw everything, looked at the two boxes side by side on the shelf under the Lares and said nothing about them for a week, and then, over the slate, one evening, with her door open: "Two boxes. One's your father's and one's hers. You've

put them under the gods where you'll see them when you feed them. That's not nothing, Gaius; that's an altar. I kept a merchant's books and I know what a man's shelf says." And went back to the slate.

The Spaniard came to the house on the last day of April, to see Sura, as he did now every third day, and found the freedman's son in the outer room with the Syrian's figure and stopped.

"Hermes's son. He's sleeping?"

"Since the sixth hour, sir. The Greek gave him the poppy."

"Then I'll wait. I'd rather wait here than in the room; he hates to be watched sleeping, he thinks it's a thing you do to the dead." Hadrian sat, uninvited, on the clerk's bench, in the Greek cloak, with the dust of the cut on it, and looked at the tall young man with the tablet, and the face lit, briefly. "You've a freedwoman now. Chrestê. The wine-shop says you said a thing to her at the foot of a stair and she sat down in the road. I've had that from four people and none of them knew what the thing was and all of them wanted to."

"It was my father's, sir. Not mine to tell."

"No. Nor would you." The grey eyes rested. "Puteoli says the same about you. *Not mine to tell.* She said it to Sabina about the sail — Sabina asked whether you'd read it to her as a boy and she said *that's his to tell*, and Sabina, who gets everything out of everyone, got nothing, and told me, which is how I know." He leaned back against the wall. "She sits in the library in the afternoons. In the low chair. Did you know? I read and she sits, and now and then I ask her what a thing costs and she tells me, and it's never what I'd have said, and it's always right. Lucius says you do the same with bridges. I've begun to think the two of you were made by the same man."

"The same woman, sir. Her mother. She kept a book."

"Ah." The Spaniard was quiet. "Yes. Plotina said. *A dying woman and a shipowner.*" He looked at the door of Sura's room, which was shut. "When he's dead you'll come to me. He's told you. He's told me he's told you. I'll say one thing about it now and not again, because

it's not a thing I say. I'll use you. You know that; she said so, in the room, *he'll hate it*. But I've read the sheet you signed with your father's figure on it, and I've read the Syrian's figure you did in a hut with a deaf clerk, and I've read a girl's line at the foot of a widow's letter that Lucius keeps in a box, and I'll tell you, Hermes's son, that I've never in my life been short of men who'd say yes to me, and I've been short all my life of men who'd tell me the figure, and I've found two. They were raised in the same street by a woman who kept a book, and I'm not fool enough to think that's an accident or wise enough to know what it is." He stood. "Tell Lucius I came. Tell him I'll come on the Nones. Tell him I said the Syrian's figure is right; I checked it myself, in the hut, against the Senate's copy, at night, because I'm that kind of man, and there wasn't a line wrong, and I was almost sorry."

◆

He took a sheet to the library on the Nones, in the afternoon, because the Spaniard had asked for the Syrian's figure in his own hand and Sura had said *take it yourself; he'll want to see the man who made it, and you'll want to see the room*.

The old Greek library on the south side, Augustus's, with the cases going up into the grey light from the high windows and the Greeks on the shelves where an emperor had put them so he could say he had them. He had never been in it. He went between the cases with the sheet and came to the table. The table had four scrolls open on it and the Greek cloak over the chair and no one in the chair, because the Spaniard had been called to Plotina's room an hour before and had left the scrolls as a man did who meant to come back to them; and beside the table, a pace from it, a second chair, low, a staff's chair, the kind a man sat in to be read to, with nothing on it.

He stood with the sheet. The room was quiet in the way rooms were that had been quiet for a hundred years. The low chair had been sat in; the cushion had the shape of someone in it, lately, that afternoon, a shape that was tall and had sat upright with its hands in

its lap and its feet under it, because that was how the cushion had taken the weight, evenly, at the back and not slumped, as a woman sat who had been taught on a Caelian floor that a chair was a thing you were permitted; and on the table, by the Spaniard's scrolls, a fifth, smaller, with a red tag, rolled, that was not the Spaniard's hand on the tag but a copyist's from Pergamum, and was Sappho, because the tag said so, and was the bad copy, because a man who read for pleasure kept the bad copy by him for someone else.

He put the sheet on the table where the Spaniard would find it. He did not sit in the low chair. He stood beside it for the length of time it took the light to move across one case, which was a thing he could count, and looked at the shape in the cushion, and did the sum, and the sum was that she had been here an hour ago, in this chair, a pace from a man who read for eleven, saying what a thing cost. That she had gone up to Sabina's rooms when the Spaniard was called, and that he was standing in the one room on the hill where she sat every afternoon and she was not in it and he had been sent here by a dying man on purpose, because Sura sent nobody anywhere by accident, and because Sura had said *you'll want to see the room*, and had meant the chair.

He went out between the cases. At the door, where people on that hill turned, he did not turn; he had learned from a steward's girl at a dinner that you told a person how far up the room you were by what you did not do. He went back down to Sura's and said, "The figure's on his table, sir. He wasn't there," and Sura, on the couch at the window, said, "No. Plotina had him. I knew she would; it's the Nones; she has him on the Nones," and looked at the freedman's son's face, and read it, and said nothing else, which was the kindness, and was not one.

◆

Capito sent for him on the Kalends of May, to the old palace below the Palatine, to the room with the clerk and the box where he had

been given a ring, and the clerk was not there; Capito was, at the clerk's table, with the ink on his own cuff, which was the thing about Titinius Capito, that he had been secretary to three emperors and still did his own ink.

He was sixty. He had the face of a man who had been in the room when Domitian was killed and had not been asked how he felt about it and had never said; and he looked at the freedman's son across the table where a ring had been and said, in the Latin, without preamble, "Sura's dying."

"Yes, sir."

"He's written me. About you. Four lines; he's not the breath for more. *The boy. The figure. Hadrian when I'm dead. Until then, give him something to do that isn't watching me cough.*" Capito turned a sheet. "So. The triumph's in June. The Kalends or near it; the Syrian says the road's clear enough through the cut for the procession to come round the Capitol the new way and the emperor's said yes, because he wants the city to see the hill gone before they see the gold. There'll be the gold. All of it, your forty-one days, on carts, with the figure on a board beside each cart in letters a hand high, because the emperor's said he'll have a triumph that's a figure and not a story and the man who weighed it is to see the boards are right." He looked up. "That's you. You'll walk with the carts. Not ride; walk. Behind Sura's horse, with the staff, in the stripe, with the stick if you want it, Sura says you've a centurion's stick and the emperor's asked why and been told and said *let him*. You'll have the boards. Every board. If a figure's wrong on the Sacred Way in front of a hundred thousand people and the Senate, it's your name on it, as it was on the fine." He put the sheet down. "It's not nothing. In twenty years men will look up at the Syrian's column and say *and the gold, how much was it*, and the answer will be the one on your boards."

"Yes, sir."

"And one other thing, which Sura didn't ask for and which I'm doing because I was secretary to Nerva for sixteen months and Nerva said to me, on the day the letter came from Cologne, *Capito, a man who's made by another man's letter owes the next one*, and I've never forgotten it." Capito took a second sheet from under the first. "The roll. Your entry. *G. Laecanius Celer, son of Gaius, Falerna, four hundred and six thousand in land.* I've added a line. Rufus's word on the fine; I've entered it as a patron's attestation, which is unusual, and under it a thing of my own, which is more so." He turned the sheet so Celer could read it. Under his name, in Capito's own hand, with the ink still dark: *Weighed the Dacian treasure at the Sargetia, by the emperor's order, forty-one days, the figure accepted by the Senate without amendment.*

Celer looked at it.

"That's a thing that goes on a stone," said Capito. "Not your father's; yours, one day, wherever it is. I've put it on the roll so that whoever cuts the stone will have it from the record and not from a story." He drew the sheet back. "You'll not thank me. Sura says you don't; he says you ask what a thing costs. It costs nothing. That's why I've done it. In this building almost nothing is free and I've been here thirty years and I'd like, once before I'm as old as Sura, to have written a true line on a roll for a man who didn't pay for it."

He walked back along the Forum with the box under his arm. The cut was ahead and to the right, the red wound in the saddle with the dust standing over it, and the gangs going down, and the Syrian somewhere in it shouting; and he stopped at the edge of the old Forum where the new road came round, and looked at it, and did the sum, as his father would have, on the last night of a house.

A ring, which weighed less than a denarius. A roll, with four lines on it now, which was more than most. A patron's word in an atrium. A freedwoman in three rooms with a door he would not go through. A dying Spaniard who had *let* him. A living one who would use him.

The boards, in June, with his figure on them a hand high in front of a hundred thousand. A stone on a road with a cypress. A stick in his belt. A box under his arm with a tablet in it that said *the door, not him*, and a letter in it in a hand only he could read that said *the same reason you've not called the villa*.

It was his father's plan. The whole of it. Every line. *Eques Romanus*, a hand taller, seen from a horse. It was done, and he had done it, and his father had been nine days short of hearing a patron say *just*, and it had cost a sail and a fine and a stroke and a tomb and a girl's year of silence and a man in Africa and a woman sitting down on a step. He stood at the edge of the Forum with it done and felt what Sura had said, which was a clerk, and a box, and *next*; and under that, where he kept the things that were not figures and had been keeping them since a beach, he felt the other thing, the thing he had not had a word for since a mole and had now, because his father had given it him on a tablet with the stylus failing: *not nothing*. That was the sum. It was done and there was something left over, and the something was not the ring or the roll or the boards or the stone; it was that he was standing at the edge of a hill being taken away a basket at a time, and somewhere on the other hill, across the valley, in a cold room with three windows, a girl who had been eleven in a strong-room was teaching an empress's niece a lodging-house book and saying to a dying man's wife in a room with the cloth on that he was the only one nobody would ever own; and that she had said it about herself in the same breath; and that the Augusta had written both down; and that he was going to walk down the Sacred Way in June behind a cart of gold with his figure on a board and she was going to be in a box with Sabina. They were going to see each other across a hundred thousand people, and a woman with a headache was going to be watching both their faces to see what she had paid for.

He fed the Lares that night with Chrestê's bread, which was fresh, because she had baked, in her own room, with the door open, which it

had not been before. He said to them, in the shorthand, out loud: "Done. Every line. Father, it's done. And?"

And from the open door, in the Gulf Greek, not unkindly, because she had been listening, as she always had: "That's the wrong word. The girl on the hill's got the right one; the wine-shop says so; she says *what does it cost*. Learn it. You'll need it in June."

25

The Low Chair

The Palatine, early summer 107

He asked her to see the cut on the Ides of May, in the library, with the Sappho open between them, and she said what she had been told to say, and he laughed, and it was not the laugh she had been told to expect.

"Apollodorus wants to show you the column," he said, to the scroll. "Not the column; the hole where the column goes. He's dug the footing. It's a hundred and twenty feet of hill measured out in a pit and he's as pleased with it as if it were a child. He says Plotina told him *one day you'll want to show her*, and he's decided the day's tomorrow, because the triumph's in three weeks and after that the whole city will have seen it and he'd like one person to have seen it who'll know what it weighs." The grey eyes did not come up. "I'll walk you down. In the morning, before the gangs. No litter. The Augusta's said yes, which you'll have guessed, because she says yes to things that put you where she can watch."

"Hadrian." The door was shut; the doors were labelled. "What does it cost?"

He looked up. And he laughed — but it was not the short dry surprised laugh of a man who had been told the figure and liked it; it was lower, and went on longer, and had in it a thing she had not heard in him and kept, because she kept everything, and turned over afterwards on the west terrace with Momus on the parapet and could not name until the dwarf named it for her, which was *relief*.

"Plotina told you to say that."

"Yes."

"She told me she had. We're a family that labels its doors." He put the stylus down. "She's always right; it's the most tiresome thing about her and the reason my uncle's emperor. But she's never once in thirty years asked him what a thing costs *him*. Nobody has. You just did." The face stopped doing anything; it simply looked, as it had once across four scrolls. "It costs this. If you walk down to the cut with me in the morning, alone, the hill will have it by noon, and the wine-shops on the Aventine by evening, and a man who's making boards for the carts will hear it from his freedwoman over a slate. And he'll do nothing. He's good at it." He held her eyes. "Not you. Him. I've read the sheet you left him off. I'm a man who learns."

She sat in the low chair with her hands in her lap and her feet under her and the cases going up into the grey light and did the sum, and it came out where she had known it would, and she said it.

"Then no. Not before the triumph."

"After?"

"After the triumph the whole city will have seen it. You said. Then it's a hole in the ground and a Syrian and a girl who knows what a thing weighs, and the hill's got nothing to say about it, and nobody hears a word over a slate." She did not look away. "I'll see the column when it's a column. Not when it's a thing to be seen seeing."

The Spaniard looked at her for a long time. Then he picked up the stylus.

"Lucius said a thing about you two on the rock," he said, to the scroll. "I've told you half. Here's the rest. *The one thing neither of them learned is how to be had — and the one thing neither of them will ever learn is how to be had by each other, because they were raised on the same mole, and a mole's a thing you stand on side by side and look out from, and nobody on a mole ever turns round.*" He turned a column. "He's dying, and says true things because they're cheaper. Go and do Sabina's hair. Tell her I asked and you said no and she'll be pleased with you and furious with me, which is the arrangement, and which

she arranged."

◆

Sabina was not pleased.

She was on the floor with the slate and she looked up when the girl came in and read the face that did nothing and said, "He asked. You said no. Good." And then, with the slate, not looking: "What did he say when you said no?"

"That Sura said we were raised on a mole, domina. The boy and I. And that nobody on a mole turns round."

The slate stopped. Sabina sat with it on her knees and the beautiful disappointed face turned to the window, and said, after a while, in the low quick voice: "That's the cleverest thing Lucius has ever said and he said it about you and not about me, and I've been his friend's wife for seven years and he's never once said a clever thing about me, because there isn't one; I'm a stool by a window." She put the slate down. "I'll tell you what I am, Puteoli, since you've told me what you are. I'm the price of him. My great-aunt said so, in that room, to your face; Marcia told me; I made her. *I made her the price of him.* That's what I've been since I was seventeen. A thing he had to take to have the other thing, and knows it, and I know he knows it, and we've been very civil about it for seven years in three cold rooms." She looked at her hands. "And now there's a girl in my rooms who does my hair the new way and teaches me a book and says *what does it cost* to him in a library and he laughs, and the laugh's a thing I've never had out of him, and I arranged it, and I'd arrange it again, and I'd like — once — to hate you for it, and I can't, because you came in and told me the mole." The dry tenant intelligence came up out of the beautiful face and looked at her. "Sit down. Here. On the floor. I'm going to say a thing I've not said to anyone and you're going to keep it in your book and not in your mouth."

Fausta sat.

"I'll never have a child. I've seen to it. There are women on the Subura who know how and I've been to one, twice, since the marriage, and I'll go again if I have to, and Plotina knows, because she knows everything, and has said nothing, because a child of his would be a thing she'd have to plan round and she'd rather not. So there it is. I'm the price of him and I've made sure the price has no change." Sabina's hands lay still on the slate. "I'm telling you because in a year, or five, when he looks at you the way he looks at a thing he wants, and he will, and Plotina says you'll say *what does it cost* and he'll not ask again, she's wrong about the second part. He'll ask again. He's patient; he had it from her. And when he does, and you're deciding, I'd like you to have one true figure in the column that nobody else on this hill will give you, which is: *his wife will not hate you. His wife has nothing to lose that she hasn't already thrown in a Subura basin.* Put it in the book. It's the only gift I've got that's worth more than the boards it's bound in."

Fausta sat on the cold floor. The slate was between them with a Rhodian's week on it that did not come out.

"Vibia," she said. It was the first time.

"Don't. I'll start to like it." But the beautiful face did a thing, and it was not the nearly-smile; it was the other thing, the one the Augusta's face did that was nearly tiredness, and Fausta understood, sitting on the floor, that it ran in the family like the long bones. "Make me a house. No. Not a house. Tell me the mole. The two of you on it. Counting ships. I'd like to hear what it's like to stand beside someone and look out and not turn round. I've never done it. I've spent seven years turned round."

So she told her the mole. Not for the book; for the floor. And Sabina listened without waiting to speak, and when it was done — at the kiss with his eyes open, at the arm held to its length — the Spaniard's wife said nothing for a long time and then said, to the glass: "*Not for nothing.* You said that. At twelve. On a mole, to a boy, with

your arm out straight, and he said *all right* and put it in a column." A breath. "My husband has never once in his life said *all right* to me about anything, and I've never once had the arm to hold him off with, and I'd not have known what to hold. Go and do my hair. The new way. He's coming in from the cut with the Syrian's hole in his head and I want him to not know me, and then to know me, and then to look past me at the corner, and I want to watch him do it, because it's the only time in seven years I've seen him want a thing he couldn't have, and I'd like to see it again before the triumph, when the whole city will be watching him want a thing he's got."

◆

Matidia spoke to her on the Ides, which she had not done in four years, and it was in the Augusta's room, after, with the cloth on and the benches gone, and the Spaniard's mother-in-law closed her book.

She was forty-four. She had been widowed young and had not remarried, which on that hill was a decision and not a misfortune, and she had the long bones she had given her daughter and a face that had been handsome and had chosen, at some point, to be plain instead, as a woman on a coast built on ash had chosen her hair. She closed the book on her finger, to keep the place, and looked at the girl by the wall with the box of pins, and said, in a Latin that had no province in it at all: "You've taught my daughter a lodging-house book."

"Yes, domina."

"She showed me. On the floor. She made me sit on the floor, which I've not done since I was six, and she did a Rhodian's week and a sail-maker's canvas and it came out, and she looked at me the way she looked at me when she was four and had built a thing out of blocks that stood up." The page under the finger did not move. "I've never seen her look at anything that way since she was four. I've given her everything there is on this hill and none of it made her look like that, and a freedwoman's child from Puteoli has done it with a slate and a man who drinks." Matidia did not smile. She was not a woman

who did; it was the other thing she had given her daughter. "I'm not thanking you. The Augusta says you've the wrong word for it anyway. I'm telling you I've seen it, and that I've been turning the same page of the same book in this room every Kalends for twenty years so that I'd have somewhere to look that wasn't my daughter's face, and that on the Ides I looked at it, and it had a thing in it I'd given up on."

Under the cloth, the Augusta said: "Matidia. You're performing."

"I'm not. You know I'm not; it's why you let me in the room." Matidia did not look at the couch. "She told you about the basin."

A silence under the cloth.

"Yes. She told me about the basin. She told me because she was told by a dwarf that I'd keep it in a book and not a mouth, and she was right, and I'm telling *you* I know she told you, so that you'll not think it's a thing you have over me." The long handsome plain face held the girl's. "I knew. I've known since the first time. I'm her mother. I went to the Subura after her, both times, and paid the woman again, more, to be careful, and never said. The Augusta knows I know; it's the one thing between us we've never spoken of in a room, because it's the one thing on this hill that's not a move." Matidia opened the book. "That's all. You've one true figure from Sabina. I've given you the figure under it. Put them both in your book and never say either in this room, and when my daughter's the emperor's wife and has nothing and knows it, be in her rooms, because I'll be dead, and the Augusta will be dead. The Spaniard will be in Athens or Antioch or wherever a man like that goes to not be in a room with his wife, and she'll need one person on the hill who sat on the floor with her and made a thing come out."

"Yes, domina."

"Matidia. When the door's shut. We label them." She found her page. "Go. She's counting."

The benches had a new face on them on the Kalends of June, and it was the one face on the hill that Fausta had never expected and

should have, and it looked at her, and knew her, and said nothing, and that was the first thing she kept of it.

Laecania Paulla. Bassus's daughter, who had married a Spaniard from Italica the year a girl of five had carried a slate up to the house with columns and been told to say nothing; who had been nineteen then, and plain, and kind in the way daughters of consuls were kind to freedwomen's children, and had gone away to Baetica with a man who had land and olives, and had never, in Fausta's knowledge, been back. She was thirty-four now, on the fourth bench from the door, in a good gown that was five years behind the hill, with a face that was her father's without the weight and her mother's without the sweetness; and she had come to the Augusta's room because her husband was in Rome for the triumph, because every Spaniard with land was, because the emperor was a Spaniard and the Spaniard's nephew was going to be, and a woman from Italica with a consul's name went to the Augusta's room on the first Kalends she could to be counted; and she sat on the fourth bench and looked along the long wall at the tall girl at the Augusta's shoulder with a comb and an ivory pin. Her face went blank the way a face did when it had been given a figure it had not known was in the column.

She did not speak. The room did not permit it. But when the hair was done and the door opened and Marcia said *the Augusta thanks you and is engaged*. The benches stood, Paulla did not go with them; she stood by the fourth bench with her hands folded and waited until the room had emptied to the two of them and the Germans at the door, and said, in the Latin of Baetica now, which had the coast under it still: "Hilara's girl."

"Yes, domina."

"My father's freedwoman's child. From the lodging-house. You carried a slate up to the house when you were five and stood in the atrium and my father said *that's Hilara's* and you didn't look at the floor." Paulla's hands did not move. "My brother wrote me you'd

gone to the Caelian. He wrote that Tertulla had taken you for a price. He didn't write what the price was and I didn't ask; I'd a house in Italica and olives and three sons and I thought: well, Hilara's girl's gone up, good, Hilara was the only one in that house who ever told me a true thing about my hair." She looked at the pin. "And now you're the Augusta's, and doing her hair the way her mother had it, and the whole of Baetica knows it, because the whole of Baetica's in Rome this month and talks of nothing else, and I've sat on a bench for an hour watching you not look at the floor and thought: *that's my father's house. That's the last of it. A freedwoman's child at the Augusta's shoulder with a pin.*" The plain face did a thing. "My brother's in the Senate and sits on a stool in a freedman's strong-room. My father's tomb's by the road with his debts on it. The Falernian land's my husband's and the olives are good. And the house of Laecanius is a girl with a comb on the Palatine and a boy with a ring behind a cart of gold, and neither of them's ours, and both of them have the name, and I came to this room to be counted and I've been, and I'll go back to Italica and tell my sons that the house went up after all; it just went up without us."

She turned to go. At the door, where people turned, she turned.

"Fausta. He asked about you. My father. At the end; my brother wrote it. He couldn't speak much, by then, and what he said was *Hilara's girl, is she placed*, and my brother said yes, the Caelian, and he said *good*, and then he said a thing my brother didn't understand and wrote to me because he thought I might. He said: *the nose was always going to go somewhere.*" Paulla's face did nothing. "I didn't understand it either. I think you do. I'd rather not know."

She went. Fausta stood by the wall with the box, and under the cloth, on the couch, the Augusta said, to the ceiling, in the voice for metre: "That was the consul's daughter."

"Yes, Augusta."

"And she's just told you, in my room, with the Germans listening, what the consul said about your nose. Which I've known since the day you walked in with Tertulla, and Tertulla knew before that, and Marcia worked out in a morning, and the whole hill has decided not to know, because it's the kind of thing a hill decides." The cloth did not move. "It changes nothing. You were born free, with witnesses; it's in the prefect's archive under my seal. But you'll put it in your book, because it's a figure, and you'll never say it in this room, because in this room it would be a *thing*, and I've enough things. Go and do Sabina's hair. Tell her the consul's daughter was on the fourth bench. She'll want to know what Baetica's wearing."

◆

Momus had the baker's wife's message on the Kalends, and brought it to the terrace, and it was from a woman neither of them had met.

"The Corinthian. Chrestê. Laecania Chrestê, as she is now; she signs it, the baker's wife says, on the shopkeepers' slates she's begun doing for a fee, which is how a freedwoman two streets from a wine-shop talks to a dwarf on the Palatine: by way of a loaf." He climbed onto the parapet. "She sends: *tell the girl with the shutter that I settled Granius's factor's slate with her once a month for a year when she was fourteen and she took the lower figure every time and looked at me, and I've never forgotten it, and I've told him so. Tell her the boxes are under the gods and I said "altar" to the wine-shop on purpose. Tell her he goes to the far end of the cut every morning from the first hour to the second and has since November. Tell her I'm free, at a wage, in my own room with a door he's not been through, and that I liked it more than I planned and I'm telling her that because she'd rather have the whole figure than the clean one. And tell her I'd not be the woman on the stair, whichever way it goes, and that I've not decided yet what that means for me but I've decided it for her.*" The dwarf looked at the cut. "She's a Corinthian who kept a merchant's books. She counts the way we do. I'd have liked to meet her and I'll not; people at the ends of

corridors don't; we send loaves."

Fausta stood with her hands on the parapet.

"What do I send back?"

"Nothing. You don't send a Corinthian a figure; she's got them all. You send her a thing she hasn't." He thought. "Send: *the egg-woman's husband was paid by his hand and I never asked him for anything else, and that's the only thing I ever asked him for myself, and she can have that, because she's told me the only thing she had.*" He looked at the girl. "That's not a figure. That's a receipt. She'll know the difference. She keeps them."

She sent it. By the baker's wife, by the wine-shop, by the steward's boy, by a loaf; and it came back, four days later, by the same road, one line, in a merchant's Greek on the edge of a slate the baker's wife had been asked to show and not give: *received, and kept, and he'll never know you sent it, because I've decided that too. — L.C.*

◆

Marcia told her about the box on the day before the Nones, at the shoulder, with the comb, in the Nemausus Latin — an extra morning, not a Kalends or an Ides, because the hair was to be seen by a hundred thousand people the next day and the Augusta wanted it tried — and it was not owed, and Marcia gave it anyway, and Fausta's hands did not stop.

"Philon's given Hermes's son a box. The archivist; Sura's father's man; the one with the cough. Out of the third room, where nothing comes out. The steward's boy had it from Philon's boy, who carried it down the Aventine and says it was light and the young master carried it like it wasn't." The fingers moved a pin. "It's your letters. A year of them. The lady Cornelia's requests with your lines at the foot. Sura had them kept separate; he said the lines were worth more than the asking. Philon gave the box to the boy because Philon's dying too and wanted to give one thing away before the Spaniard's lists, and he said the boy would know what it weighed." The comb went into the box.

"It's on a shelf on the Aventine under the Lares from Nola, beside his father's, the freedwoman says. She says it's an altar. She says it to the wine-shop, which is how I have it, and she says it on purpose, because she's a Corinthian who kept a merchant's books and knows that a thing said in a wine-shop goes up the hill by evening, and she wanted it to."

Under the cloth, the Augusta said nothing. Matidia's page did not turn.

"That's all," said Marcia. "The fifth door. He's put your hand on a shelf under his gods. I've told you. I'd not wait."

Fausta put the last pin in. The Augusta's hair was fine and grey and plain, her mother's, and done; and the woman on the couch turned her head, once, to the left and the right, and said to the ceiling, "That's it," and then, after a moment, in the voice that was not for metre and that Fausta had heard perhaps four times: "Girl. The triumph's tomorrow. You'll be in the box with Sabina, on her left, standing, with the pin. He'll be in the procession behind the gold on foot with a centurion's stick, which the emperor's allowed because he was told why and said *let him*. I said I'd be watching your faces. I will. And I'll tell you now what I'll be looking for, because I'd rather you knew than guessed, and because you've asked me the price of everything I've given you and I've told you, and this is the price of the box." The cloth did not move. "I'll be looking to see whether either of you turns round."

She went down the long wall behind the comb. Across the courts. Past the fountain that worked. And not to the north rooms; to the west terrace, where nobody went, where the city was, and the cut, and the dust standing over it; and Momus was there already, on the parapet, with his legs out, because he had been told by Sabina that the girl would come, and had come first, and did not say so.

She stood with her hands on the parapet. Below, in the saddle, the Syrian's pit was a dark square in the red, where a column would go

that was a hill's height, so nobody would forget.

"He's put the letters under his gods," she said.

"I heard. The whole hill's heard; the Corinthian saw to it." Momus looked at the cut. "She's clever, that one. She's told the hill a thing about him he'd never tell, so that he'll not have to, and so that you'll know it without his having said it, which is the only way a man like that can say anything. She's done you a kindness and him a worse one and she knows it and she'd do it again. I'd like to meet her. I've a feeling we'd count the same."

"What do I do?"

"Nothing, before tomorrow. The Augusta's said what she's looking for, and she's never said that in forty years, Marcia says. She wants it seen. A thing on the hill is hers. So you'll stand in the box and look at the gold and he'll walk behind it and look at the boards." The seamed face turned up. "And then, girl. After the Nones. When the dust's settled on the cut. There's a Syrian who's been told *one day*. And there's a man who goes there every morning before the gangs to stand at the far end by the shoulder, the Corinthian says, and has done since November, and has never once seen a litter, and goes anyway." He looked back at the cut. "That's not mine to arrange. I'm a dwarf on a parapet. But I'd not have you go to your book tonight without the figure."

She stood a long time. The dust hung. Somewhere under it, a man was checking a board.

"Momus."

"Girl."

"My mother said *and?* And then she died. And my whole life since I've thought it meant: *that's your figure; where's mine.* Thallus said so. I believed him; he'd known her longer." She did not look away from the cut. "It doesn't. I've been doing a lodging-house book on a floor with a woman who's thrown her children in a basin and I've been saying to her *it comes out, there's nothing left over*, and I heard myself,

this morning, and I thought: that's not what she meant. My mother never once in her life had a book come out. She had a thing left over every month and the thing was me, and she carried it, and she sent it up a hill, and she said *and?* to the egg-woman's mother with her last breath because she wanted to know what was *next*. Not what was owed. What was next." Her hands were on the parapet. "She was asking. Not telling. She'd done her sum and there was a thing left over and she wanted to know what it would do."

Momus was quiet on the parapet.

"Then that's the first line in your book," he said at last. "Not the mole. That. Go and write it. Sabina's counting, but she'll let you have the hour; she told me so; she said *the girl's got a face on her like a slate that's about to come out and I'd rather it did it in her book than in my rooms*."

She went in. The north rooms were empty; Sabina had gone to the Augusta's to be shown what she would wear in the box, and to dislike it. The book was where she kept it, in the chest, under the Strabo, with the letters and the brass fish and the prefect's copy under the Augusta's seal; and she took it out and sat on the cold floor with it on her knees and the ink from Sabina's table and the first leaf blank, as it had been for three weeks because she had not been able to decide; and she wrote, in the Latin a dead woman had taught her, in the small hard hand that had kept a lodging-house book at ten, the first line, which was not the mole:

My mother said "and?" and died. I have been four years working out what she meant. I think she was asking.

And under it, after a while, because she was her mother's and there was a thing to be said and it was true:

He has put my letters on a shelf under his gods. His freedwoman told the wine-shop on purpose so that I would know without his saying. The Augusta will be watching on the Nones to see if either of us turns round. We will not. We were raised on a mole. But after the Nones

there is a hole in the ground a hill's height and a Syrian who has been told "one day," and a man who goes to the far end of it every morning before the gangs and has never seen a litter. I am writing this down so that I will not be able to say, later, that I did not know the figure.

She closed the book. The boards were oak and heavy and it had been a gift and not a price. She put it under the Strabo and went to do Sabina's hair, because the Spaniard's wife would be back from the Augusta's with the look she had when she had been dressed by someone else, and would want to not be known for a moment, and then to be, and then to be looked past; and that was the hill; and Fausta had decided on a terrace by a sea that she would stop pretending about what was true, only about what it cost. The cost was a man walking behind gold on the Nones with a stick, and her not turning round, and she could pay it; she had paid worse; she had the receipts.

26

The Boards

Rome, the weeks before the triumph, 107

The emperor came to see the boards on the Ides of May, alone, which was a thing he did, and which nobody on the staff had ever learned not to be frightened by.

They were in a shed behind the Temple of Peace, where the carts were, forty of them, under canvas, with the Guard round the shed in a ring that did not look like a ring; and in the shed, along the wall, the boards: forty, of pine, a man's height, whitewashed, with the figures on them in black in letters a hand high that a sign-painter from the Argiletum had done and Celer had checked, each one, against the tablet from the sheep-rock, which he had in the box, which was on the trestle by the door with the stick lying across it. Blaesus the deaf clerk was on a stool at the end of the shed with a brush, touching up a nine. Celer was halfway along with the tablet, at the twenty-second board, reading it for the third time, when the light from the door changed, and he looked up, and it was the emperor.

He was fifty-three. He had the face that was on the coins and the face was not a lie; it was simply that the coins left out the thing the face did when it was looking at a figure, which was become, for the length of the looking, entirely still, as a man's face did who had learned on a frontier that a figure was a thing men died of. He came down the shed in a plain tunic with no one behind him and stopped at the first board and read it, and went to the second, and read it, and Celer stood at the twenty-second with the tablet and did not move, because a man who was reading did not want to be spoken to and this man least.

He read all forty. It took the time it took. Blaesus, who was deaf and had not heard the door, went on touching up the nine and did not look round, and the emperor, reaching the fortieth board, looked at the clerk on his stool with the brush and then at the boy with the tablet, and said, in the slow Spanish Latin that had made Hermes of Puteoli stand up in an inn, "He's deaf."

"Yes, Caesar. Apollodorus keeps him for it."

"Sensible. A man who can't hear can't be told what to write." He came back along the boards, not reading now, and stopped in front of the freedman's son, and looked at him, which he had done once before in a tent with a dead Greek on the floor and once on a sheep-rock from thirty feet, and never from three. "Sura's boy. Hermes's. The one who weighed it."

"Yes, Caesar."

"Forty-one days on a rock. Capito showed me the roll; he's put it on, in his own hand, which he does for nobody." The emperor looked at the board behind Celer's shoulder, the twenty-second, and then at the tablet in his hand. "You're checking them against the original. Third time, Sura says. He says you'll do it a fourth on the morning and a fifth on the Sacred Way with your lips moving." The still face did not change. "Good. I've asked for a triumph that's a figure and not a story and the Senate thinks I'm being modest, and I'm not; I'm being a soldier. A story's a thing men argue about in twenty years. A figure's a thing they can't. In twenty years when I'm dead and my nephew's doing whatever he's going to do with what I've left him, somebody in the Senate will say *the Dacian gold was never what Trajan said*, and somebody else will say *the boards were checked by a boy from Puteoli five times against a tablet from the river and Capito put it on the roll*, and that'll be the end of that." He turned to go. He stopped. "Your father died."

"In April, Caesar."

"Sura told me. I stood up for him in an inn once; the *Pelican*. I'd stand up for him again. The fine was just and the man was good and both of those are true and I've never met anyone who could hold both at once without wanting to put one down." The coin-face looked at him a moment longer. "You're holding both. I can see it. Hold them till the Nones and then put the boards down and go and find out what's next. That's an order, since I'm the only man who can give you one Sura hasn't. There's always a next. It's the one thing I know that Sura doesn't; he's never had to march the morning after."

He went out. The light in the door changed back. Blaesus finished the nine, and looked round, and saw the boy standing with the tablet and a face on him, and said, in the loud flat voice of the deaf, "Who was that?"

"The emperor."

"Oh." Blaesus looked at the door. "Did he like the nines?"

"He didn't say."

"Then they're right," said Blaesus, and went to the next board.

◆

He knew the hand on the Nones of May before he had the seal off, the Nola hand that made its letters as if they were threads, and he knew from the thinness of the packet that it was not about the house.

The Rhodian's dead. The one who drank eleven and wept at your father's fire. In his bed, the week after, with his stick beside him, and the egg-woman's husband found him, who goes in now and then because he's paid a quarter for nothing and has decided he ought to do something for it. I thought you'd want to know. You'll not remember him. She would.

They've taken the front down. All of it, from the fish-market to the old customs-shed, for the Syrian's man's new hall. I went to look. I don't know why; I'd never been in the Dolphin in my life; your father had the lease in his books for twenty years and I never once walked past it. There's nothing. A line of foundation-stones and a stair going up to no

floor, and a hearth-stone in what was the kitchen, lifted, with the earth under it dark where something was kept. I stood where the stair was. There was a woman behind me, old, with a basket, and she said "that was Hilara's," and I said "I know," and she said "the girl's on the Palatine, they say," and I said "I know," and she said "she kept the book at ten, I settled my eggs with her, she never once passed the higher," and went on. I think it was the egg-woman. I didn't ask.

They've begun on the mole. It goes out another two hundred feet, in stone, with a tower. The old end's gone under the new work; you can't stand where the children stood. I tried. There's a gang on it and a man with lime on his arms who shouts in Greek, which the town says is the Syrian's man and I think may be the Syrian's brother, they all look the same, and he told me to get back, so I got back.

That's all. I'm writing because the house is quiet and your father's stool is by the loom and I sat on it last night and it was the first time, and I thought: he'd want the boy to know the Rhodian's dead and the mole's gone. He kept a figure for both. I've kept his place in the book. — Vibia.

The Lares have the bread. I say your name to them and hers, both, because he did, the last winter, with the one side of his mouth, and I can't read what it meant but I can say what I heard.

He read it in the shed, by the twenty-second board, with Blaesus touching up a four. He folded it. He put it in the box with the rest. Then he stood a while with his hand on the lid and did a thing he had not known he was going to do, which was count: the mole, the Dolphin's stair, the hearth-stone, the Rhodian, the egg-woman with her basket, the shed where a dying woman had been carried to see the sea in a glass; and the number was the number of things on that coast that had been there when two children stood at the end of a mole and were not there now. It was high, and the only two left that he could put a hand on were the stone with the cypress and a girl at an empress's shoulder with a pin, and one of those was travertine.

"Who's dead?" said Blaesus, loud, from the four. He had not heard the letter; he had seen the face.

"A Rhodian. He drank."

"They do," said Blaesus, and went on with the four.

Rufus came to the shed on the Ides, in the toga, with no steward, because Thallus was on the coast counting what was left, and stood in the door the way the emperor had and was not the emperor, and knew it, and came in anyway.

"Celer."

"Sir."

"I'll not keep you. I've seen the boards from the door and I've not the head for them; my father had it and I've his nose and not his head, which everyone on the coast has known since I was ten." He stood with his hands in the toga's folds. "I've come to tell you a thing before you hear it in the Senate tomorrow, since you'll be walking past it. I've moved a motion. On the *Pelican*. The Rhine run, the winter of the first war; the emperor's letter, *the man I want fed by*. Sura's office entered a credit against the fine for it, and I've moved that the credit be doubled, on the grounds that a shipowner who sent a hull up the Rhine in December for a legion he'd never see is owed more than a shipowner who's weighed a sail is docked, and the Senate's voted it, because it's the week of the triumph and the Senate votes anything that has the Rhine in it this week." He did not look at the boards. "It's eighty thousand. Back to the estate. To you. It's not the fine; the fine stands and it was just and I've said so in the Senate and I'll not unsay it. It's the other half of the sum, which Sura's office left out because Sura's office is a Spaniard who thinks a man's made by the worst sheet, and I'm a patron who thinks — " He stopped. "I don't know what I think. I think my father sat in your father's strong-room on a stool and that I've sat there too, and that a house that's had two generations on a freedman's stool owes the freedman's son one line in the Senate's record that's not about a sail. "

Celer stood with the tablet.

"Sir. Thank you."

"Don't. Sura says you ask what a thing costs. I'll tell you. It costs me nothing, because I can't pay anything, and I'd like you to know I know that too." Rufus turned in the door, as people did at doors, and looked at the stick lying across the box on the trestle. "That's Crescens's."

"Yes, sir."

"He carried you across the Rhine. My father sent him oil for it every year and never told anyone, because he thought it was a weakness. I found the receipts in the strong-room after." The consul's son's face did a thing that was the family's. "He'd have liked that you wear it. He'd have liked the whole of this, the boards and the roll and the stick, and he'd have said nothing to you about it and told everyone else, and I'm the only one left who knows that about him, and I thought you should have it, since it's the one thing in my father's estate that didn't go to debts."

◆

"I told the wine-shop," Chrestê said, over the slate, on the Kalends of June, with her door open, and did not look up. "On purpose."

"The shelf. The two boxes under the gods. I said it to the steward's boy and the wine-shop's woman and the baker's wife on the stair, in that order, in a day, in the Greek, and I said *it's an altar*, because that's the word that goes up a hill. It was on the Palatine by evening. Marcia had it at the Augusta's shoulder on the day before the Nones — not today, it's not a Kalends up there this week, they've moved the hair for the triumph — I'm telling you now so you've the day before and not the day after." The stylus moved on the slate. "You'll want to know why."

"Yes."

"Because you'd never have told her. You've a box of a year of her hand under your father's gods and you'd have fed the gods in front of

it every night till one of you was dead and never once said so to anyone, because you were raised by a man who wrote things down and never said them. She was raised by a woman who said one word and died, and the two of you have been not saying things across a valley for five years, and I've kept your slate for two of them and I'm free now and I've decided I'll not keep it for a man who's an altar and won't say so." She looked up. The long face was arranged and under it the thing had moved and was not going back. "So I've said it for you. In a wine-shop. Where it costs you nothing but being known, which you hate, and which is the only price a man like you ever pays for anything. You can be angry. I'd not blame you."

He stood in the outer room with the day's tablet. He was not angry. He looked for it and it was not there, and what was there instead was the thing he had felt at the foot of a stair when a woman had sat down in the road: that a thing had been said that he could not have said and that it had been said *for* him, which was a thing nobody had done since a girl had taken his hand on a mole and held his arm to its length so that he would not go to the edge.

"No," he said. "I'm not."

"Good. Then sit down and eat; you've been in the shed since the first hour and your face is grey." She pushed the bread across. "And Gaius. She knows now. The whole of it, as much as a wine-shop can carry: the box, the shelf, the gods, the far end of the cut every morning since November. Marcia will have given it her as the one true thing, and the Augusta will have said something under the cloth, and the dwarf will have said something on a parapet, because that dwarf sees the cut from the west terrace and he's been counting you in at the shoulder for seven months, the steward's boy says, through the wine-shop's gossip, the same as I've been counting her." She picked up the stylus. "That's all. I've done the thing I could. The rest is two people on a mole, and I was never on it; I only settled the factor's slate there once a month and watched a girl take the lower figure."

The Syrian showed him the pit on the last day of May, and told him he had missed a litter by an hour.

"Here. Look. A hundred and twenty feet of hill in a hole; I've measured it four times and I'll have you measure it a fifth before I set a stone, because I don't trust a figure I've made myself when I've been drinking, and I've been drinking since the gold came up." Apollodorus stood at the pit's edge at the far end with the lime on his arms and the Quirinal's sliced shoulder going up behind him, and the pit at his feet was square and deep and dark and exactly what he had said, and Celer looked at it and counted, because he counted, and the Syrian watched him count and said, "Yes. That's what she did. Stood there. Counted. You could see it go across her face the way it goes across yours, like a sail."

Celer did not move.

"This morning. The third hour; you'd gone to the shed. The Augusta's litter came down the new road with the curtains shut and stopped at the near end and the Augusta didn't get out, which she's done twice before and didn't today, and the girl got out instead, alone, and walked the length of the cut on the edge, there, where you're standing, with her hands at her sides, and stopped at the pit, and looked down into it, and counted, and said to me — I was in the pit; I'd come up the ladder — she said, in the Latin, *is it really that deep*, and I said *a hundred and twenty feet*. She said *from the terrace it's a square*, and I said *most things are*, and she stood a while longer and went back along the edge and got in, and the litter went up the hill." The Syrian looked at the boy. "An hour. You'd been at the far end from the first to the second as you are every morning and gone to the shed, and she came at the third. I didn't arrange it. I'm an engineer. But I've been on that hill long enough to know when a thing's been arranged by someone else, and that litter came at the one hour of the morning when the man who measures my pit isn't at it, and the

woman in it with the curtains shut knows your hours better than Blaesus does." He turned to the ladder. "I thought you'd want the figure. She was here and you weren't and the Augusta saw to both. It's a move. I don't know what kind. Lucius would."

He stood at the pit's edge after the Syrian had gone down the ladder shouting, and looked at the place on the edge where a girl had stood an hour before with her hands at her sides and counted, and the sand had three hundred men's feet in it and hers were not to be told from any, and he did the sum. The Augusta had brought her at the third hour. On purpose. So that she would have stood where he stood, and he would be told so by a Syrian, and neither of them would have seen the other, and both would know. It was a move. It was the move of a woman who had said *I'll be watching to see if either of you turns round* and wanted, before the day, to have shown each of them where the other had been standing, so that the not turning round would cost what it ought to.

"Sir," he said, down the ladder, to the shouting. "Did she say anything else?"

The shouting stopped. The Syrian's head came up over the edge.

"She said: *tell him it's a hundred and twenty feet. He'll want it from someone who measured.*" The Damascus face came as near a smile as it went. "I didn't ask who *him* was. I'm a Syrian. We don't do the thing where we let a woman find out we've understood her." And went back down.

◆

Sura sent for him on the eve.

Not to the couch at the window. To the third room, where Philon had the lamp and the boxes were in rows now with the Spaniard's lists pinned to them, and where Sura was, in a chair, carried there by two of the house's men because he had said he would see the room once more while he could still count it; and he sat in the chair in the middle of the third room with the cloth in his lap and the ring of his father's

on Philon's hand beside him, and looked at the freedman's son in the door with the stick in his belt, and said, "Shut it."

Celer shut it.

"Tomorrow," said Sura. "I'll ride. The Greek says I'll not and I've told him I've ridden with a fever on the Danube and I'll ride down the Sacred Way behind the man I made with a cough, and if I fall off, I fall off in front of the Senate, which is where I've done everything else." A breath with a sound in it. "You'll walk behind me with the carts and the boards. Capito's told you. I've a thing to add and it's not Capito's to tell."

"Sir."

"The box. The imperial box, on the Sacred Way, at the turn below the Palatine, where the road comes out of the cut. Plotina will be in it, and Matidia, and Sabina on the left with her hair done the new way, and a girl at Sabina's left shoulder, standing, with a pin." The knife-face, gone to bone, did not change. "Plotina told the girl, with the cloth on, in front of Marcia, that she'd be watching your faces. Both. To see — her words — *whether either of you turns round*. She said it on purpose, so it'd come down the hill to you by the wine-shop, and it has, or you'd not have that look. She wants it seen. Which means she wants it *not done*. If either of you turns round on the Sacred Way in front of a hundred thousand people and the Senate and her, it's a thing on the hill, and a thing on the hill is hers, and she'll have bought the two of you for a sail and a man in Africa, and the price will have been right."

"Yes, sir."

"So you'll not turn round. You'll walk behind the twenty-second cart with the stick and your lips moving over a figure, and she'll stand at Sabina's shoulder and not look at the road, and Plotina will see that." Sura coughed, and held the cloth, and went on. "The day after. The gold's in the treasury, the boards are kindling, the city's drunk, the Spaniard's in his library and I'm on my couch. Nobody on that

hill has a thing to say about where a freedman's son stands at the first hour. Nobody has a thing to say about a girl who goes to see a Syrian's hole in the ground, because the Augusta said yes to it in April and the girl said *not before the triumph*." The eyes held his. "I'm not telling you to go. I'm telling you where the far end of the cut is on the morning after."

Celer stood in the third room with the boxes in their rows and the Spaniard's lists on them.

"Sir. Why?"

"Why what."

"Why tell me. You've said *do your own sum*. You've kept me from him six years for a thing that wasn't useful. This isn't useful to you. You'll be dead."

Sura looked at him for a long time, in the lamp, with Philon at his shoulder and the cloth in his lap.

"Because I wrote eleven letters from Cologne in a month," he said, "and made an emperor out of a soldier and a widow out of a girl from Nemausus, and I've never once been sorry, and I've never once been anything else. I've spent forty years making things useful. I'd like, once, at the end, to have told two people where a hole in the ground is and let them do what they like with it." He raised a hand, slightly. "Go home. Feed your gods. Check the boards a fourth time in the morning. And Celer." At the door, where people in that house did not turn, the freedman's son turned. "The stick. Wear it. I'd like the Senate to see a centurion's vitis in a freedman's son's belt behind a cart of a king's gold and have to ask what it means. That's a story. I know I said the triumph's a figure. A man's allowed one."

◆

He did not sleep. He had not expected to. He lay in the room with the shelf under the Lares and the two boxes on it and the stick across them. The window open on the June night and the river beyond the wall and the city making the noise a city made on the night before a

thing, which was the noise of a hundred thousand people not sleeping either; and some time after the middle of it he got up and dressed and went down the stair past Chrestê's door, which was open, and in which she said, from the dark, not asleep, "The cut."

"Yes."

"It's not the morning after. It's the morning of."

"I know."

"Then go and stand there anyway. You've done it seven months without a reason; you can do it once with the wrong one." A pause in the dark. "And Gaius. Tomorrow, on the road, behind the cart, when you're not turning round. Don't not turn round the way your father didn't call the villa. Don't make it a thing you're *holding*. Just walk. Read your boards. Let her stand. That's all a mole is, the dwarf says, and he'd know; he's stood at the end of a corridor forty years not turning round, and he's the only one on that hill who's happy."

He went down the Aventine in the dark, and along the river, and through the Forum Boarium with the cattle-smell and the first carts already moving toward the Campus where the procession would form, and past the Circus and under the Palatine's shoulder where the imperial box stood built out over the Sacred Way in timber and hangings with the Guard already at its foot, and did not look up at it, and came out along the Sacred Way into the old Forum, where the stands were up and the sweepers were out and the sand was down, and through it, and past the Curia, and up to the edge of the cut.

The far end. The shoulder of the Quirinal, sheer where the Syrian had sliced it, with the pit at its foot where the column would go, dark in the red, a hill's height measured out in a hole. Nobody was there. The gangs would not come today; the Syrian had given them the triumph, as the emperor had given the city. The dust had settled in the night with no baskets to raise it and the cut lay bare and raw and quiet in the grey before the light. He stood at the far end of it with his hands at his sides and the stick in his belt and the box left on the shelf for

once, because today the figure was on forty boards and not in a box, and he looked at the hole where the column would go, and did what he had done every morning since November, which was nothing.

He did not expect a litter. He had not expected one for seven months. He stood and the light came, grey, and then not grey, over the Esquiline behind him, and touched the top of the sliced shoulder first, and came down it, and the red went from black to brown to the colour it was. The pit at the foot stayed dark a while longer because it was deep; and he thought, as he had not let himself think on a stool with a sheet or a rock with a king's gold or in a strong-room with a tablet, the whole of the thing, in order, the way he kept things: a mole in the dark, and a kiss with his eyes open, and an arm held to its length, and a wall and a shutter and a false paper and a lamp, and a dinner on the Caelian where she had not looked at him and he had understood that she was telling him exactly how far up the room she was, and a street where she had asked him for the egg-man, which was the only thing she had ever asked him for herself and which he had done, and a sheet he was left off of, and a letter to a dead man that said *the same reason you've not called the villa*, and a box of her lines under his gods that a Corinthian had told a wine-shop about so he would not have to, and a dying Spaniard in a third room saying *side by side and look at the same thing*.

He did the sum. It came out. There was something left over, and he knew what it was, and it was not a figure, and he had known since a mole, and he said it, out loud, to the cut, in the house's shorthand, in the voice his father had used for the gods, because they liked to see a face and there was nobody else awake in Rome who could read it: "Not for nothing. You said it at twelve, with your arm out straight, and I heard *no*, and said *all right*, and put it in the column, because I was my father's son and that's what he'd have done with it. I've been doing the other thing for six years because I thought *all right* was the sum." He looked at the pit. "It wasn't. It was the thing left over. Your

mother would have known. She said *and?* and you thought she was telling you and she was asking."

The light reached the bottom of the pit. He turned — not round; away, toward the Campus, where the carts were, and forty boards with a figure on them, and a Spaniard who was going to ride with a cough behind the man he had made, and an emperor who had said *there's always a next* — and went to check them a fourth time, because that was what he was for, and because he had been told, by the only man who could give him an order Sura had not, to hold both until the Nones and then put the boards down.

Behind him, at the far end of the cut, where nobody was, the Syrian's hole lay full of morning, a hill's height, so that nobody would forget.

27

The Box

The Sacred Way, the Nones of June, 107

She did two heads before light, and the second was the Augusta's, and the Augusta spoke while she did it, which she did not do.

The north rooms first. Sabina at the glass in the dark with one lamp, in the shift, with the long bones showing and the beautiful disappointed face already arranged for a day it had decided to dislike, saying, "The new way. No. The *newest*. The thing the legate's wife had on the Ides that nobody's dared copy. I want to sit beside my great-aunt in my great-uncle's box with my hair done like a woman from the provinces who's trying too hard, and I want her to see it and say nothing, because today she can't put the cloth on." And then, as the comb went in: "He came in last night. Late. From the Campus. He stood in the door and looked at me in the glass and said *tomorrow, don't look at the box; Plotina's watching for a thing and it's not us*, and went to bed. In seven years he's never once told me where not to look. I've decided to be pleased." The hands went where they went. Sabina's hair was heavy and dark and took a thing well, and Fausta did the thing, the newest way, with the pins the Spaniard's wife had chosen and the Augusta would dislike, and when it was done Sabina turned her head to the left and the right in the glass and said, in the low quick voice, "There. I look like someone who wants something. Good. Go and do hers. She'll have been awake since the third hour; she's awake every triumph, Matidia says, she sits up and does the sum of the thing again to see if it still comes out."

The long wall was dark. The benches were empty; there was no receiving on the day of a triumph, there was a woman in a room with one window getting dressed for a chair. Marcia let her in with the

comb and did not say *the old way*, because it was understood, and the Augusta sat on the couch's edge in the gown that had been chosen by the emperor's freedmen and was purple and heavy and that she wore, Fausta saw, exactly as a woman wore a thing that was a uniform and not a choice; and the fine grey hair was down. The plain face in the one lamp had been awake since the third hour and showed it, which it did not do in daylight.

"The old way," the Augusta said, to the wall. "My mother's." The hands began. The Augusta was quiet for a time and then said, in the voice that was not for metre, "Lucius will ride. The Greek's forbidden it and he's forbidden the Greek. He'll not fall; he's never done a thing badly that he was watched for. Then he'll go home to his couch and die by the autumn." A breath. "He sent for the boy last night. The third room. Marcia had it from Philon's boy. And at the first hour this morning the boy was at the far end of the cut, before the carts, before anything, standing. The Guard at the Curia let him by; he had the stripe and a centurion's stick and they took him for the Syrian's." The hair was half done. "On the morning *of*. Not after."

Fausta's hands did not stop. The pins went in.

"You know why I'm saying this."

"So that I'll know it before the box, Augusta. Not after."

"Yes. Because after the box you'll have not turned round, and you'll have paid, and I'd not have you pay for a thing without the whole of the figure, because that's what a hill does to a girl and I decided four years ago that I'd rather do it to you myself, on purpose, with the figure in your hand, than have it done to you by Tertulla's son's pin." The plain face in the lamp did nothing. "That's the last thing I'll give you before the triumph. He stood at the far end of the cut this morning in the dark and said something out loud to the hole. The Guard didn't hear it; it was in a hand they couldn't read. Momus says you'll know what it was without hearing it and I've decided to believe a dwarf, which is new."

The last pin went in. The Augusta turned her head once to the left and the right and said, "That's it. That's my mother's," and stood, in the purple, heavy, a woman in a uniform, and Marcia came with the veil, and the Augusta said, from under it, as the comb went into the box: "Girl. In the box, you'll stand at Sabina's left shoulder. You'll be able to see the road and the Capitol and the cut's mouth and the twenty-second cart when it comes, because the Syrian's loaded the forty-first bar on it and the boy walks behind the board he's answerable for. I've arranged that. I arrange everything. It's what the headache's for." The veil settled. "Don't look. I'll be watching. And I'll tell you tonight what I saw, because I've never once lied to you about a figure, and I'm not going to begin on the day my sum comes out."

◆

The box was timber and hangings and stood out over the Sacred Way on posts at the turn below the Palatine where the road came out of the cut, and from it, if you were standing, you could see the whole of the city that mattered, which was the part that was looking back.

She stood. Sabina sat, on the left of the Augusta, who sat on the left of the empty chair that was the emperor's and would be empty all day because the emperor was in the road; and Matidia sat on the Augusta's right with no book, for once, with her hands in her lap and her long face turned to the Capitol; and behind Sabina's left shoulder, a pace back, where a woman stood who was somebody's and not furniture, Fausta stood, with the ivory in her hair at the side where the June light would catch the gold on the break. The box of pins left in the north rooms because today there was nothing to pin; the hair was done, both heads, the old way and the new, and would hold till dark.

It was the fourth hour. The procession had been forming since before light on the Campus and had come in through the Triumphal Gate at the second, and the sound of it had been coming up the Sacred Way toward the box for an hour the way the sea came up a

beach: not a thing you heard arrive but a thing you found you had been hearing. The crowd was the sound. A hundred thousand, the Augusta had said, and she had not been exaggerating, which she never did; they were on the stands and the steps and the roofs and the Capitol's slope and in the windows of every house with a window on the road and on the scaffolding of the Syrian's basilica where the Guard had tried to stop them and given up. They were making a noise that was not cheering yet, because there was nothing yet to cheer, and was the noise of that many people waiting, which she had never heard and would not forget.

"You've not looked at the road," said Sabina, not turning her head, in the low quick voice that the sound ate at a pace.

"No, domina."

"Good. Don't. Not till the gold. Then look at the gold and nothing else, and when the boards come, read them, because you'll be the only person in this box who can, and I'll want to know afterwards if a nine was wrong." The beautiful face was turned to the Capitol, with the hair done the new way under a veil the Augusta had chosen and Sabina disliked. "She's watching you already. Don't look at her either. Look at the Capitol. It's gold and it's been there four hundred years and it's the one thing on this road today that nobody's going to have to pay for."

She looked at the Capitol. Beside her, a pace forward and to the right, the Augusta sat with no cloth, because today was not a receiving day, today was the one day in twenty years when Pompeia Plotina was simply a woman in a chair at her husband's triumph, and the plain face showed what it decided to, and what it had decided to show was nothing, perfectly, and Fausta, who had done that face's hair for four years, could see from behind and to the left the one thing it could not decide, which was that the eyes were moving.

The Senate came first. That was the order; it had been the order since there were triumphs, the magistrates and the Senate walking ahead of the thing they had voted so that the city could see who had voted it; and they came up the Sacred Way out of the Forum in their hundreds in the white and the stripe, slowly, with the lictors. The crowd did not cheer them and did not jeer them, it let them pass, which was what the crowd did with the Senate; and she did not look, and then did, once, because Sabina had said *the Capitol* and the Senate was between her and the Capitol, and saw, in the third rank, a man with a consul's nose and none of his weight, walking with his hands in his toga, looking at nothing, who was Rufus, who had sat on a stool in a strong-room, and who had, Marcia said, moved a motion on a hull and had it carried because it was the week of the Rhine; and she looked away from him to the Capitol and found that she had felt nothing, which she kept, because it was a figure.

Then the spoils. The carts began, and the sound changed, because this was what the sound had been waiting for: the first cart came out of the Forum under the Capitol's slope piled with the arms, the Dacian curved swords and the long shields and the dragon-standards with their cloth bodies that the wind had filled on the far bank and that hung now limp from their poles in the June air. The crowd made a noise that was the first noise of the day and it went along the road ahead of the cart like a wave going up a mole, and she felt it through the timber under her feet. More carts. The pictures — the great painted boards on frames, each one a thing from the war, the bridge, the city on its mountain burning, a man in a gully with a knife at his own throat, each one carried past the box and tilted toward it so that the women in it could see what the emperor had done; and Matidia looked at every one, and the Augusta looked at none, and Sabina said, to the Capitol, "That's the bridge. Apollodorus painted it himself; he'd not let anyone else. Twenty piers. He said a boy counted them." And then the prisoners, in chains, in their hundreds, the Dacian

nobles with the caps and the long hair walking as men walked who had been told what the road ended in and had decided to walk it as if it did not; and she did not look at them long, because she had been eleven in a lodging-house with the Rhodian on the stair and knew what a face looked like that was doing the sum *live*, and these faces had done it and the sum had not come out.

And then the gold.

It came round the turn out of the Forum and the sound stopped. That was what she kept: that a hundred thousand people stopped, for the length of a breath, the way the mole had stood up for one ship in February, because the first cart came into the light below the Capitol and it was not a cart, it was a thing on wheels that the light could not get past. Bar on bar on bar, stacked, lashed, the lumps and ingots and flattened cups and cut arm-rings of a kingdom's twenty years, gone to blocks in a king's furnace so they would pack and sunk under a river and dug up by a Syrian and weighed by a boy on a rock. They were not polished and did not need to be; they were gold, in the sun, in the June, in a quantity that the eye did not have a figure for; and beside the cart, carried on a pole by a Guardsman, a board, pine, whitewashed, a man's height, with black letters a hand high that said what the cart weighed.

She read it. She was the only one in the box who could, and she read it, and it was right, and the second cart came behind it with its board and she read that, and the third; and the sound came back, all at once, as it had gone. It was not a cheer, it was a roar, the roar of a city that had been told a figure and had not believed it and was being shown; and it went up the road and over the box and up the Palatine behind and she felt the timber move under her feet; and she stood at Sabina's shoulder and read the boards, one after another, as the carts came, and did not look at the road behind the carts, because she had been told what the Augusta was looking for and because she had decided, on a parapet, with a dwarf, that she could pay it.

Forty carts. She read forty boards. On the twenty-second she stopped reading for the length of a flame leaning, because the board was right and the figure on it was one she knew — *twenty-two pounds, four ounces, bar, forty-first* had been one line on a tablet on a rock, Marcia had said, with the Spaniard crouching to read it upside down. The cart that carried the forty-first bar was the twenty-second cart because that was how the Syrian had loaded them, and behind the twenty-second cart, on foot, a pace back from its tailboard, where the man walked who was answerable for what was on the board, in the narrow stripe and the plain tunic with his lips moving, with a centurion's vine-stick in his belt and his hands at his sides and his face turned to the board and not to the box, a tall man with a nose, walking.

She did not turn round. She was on a mole. She read the twenty-third board.

Beside her, a pace forward and to the right, the Augusta's eyes had stopped moving.

"There," said Sabina, very low, to the Capitol, with the roar eating it. "That's him. With the stick. Reading. He's not looked up once since the Forum; Hadrian's man on the roof says so, I had him put there." The beautiful face did not move. "You've not turned round. He's not turned round. She's seen it. It's done. You can look at the gold now like everyone else, Puteoli; you've paid."

She looked at the gold. It went by. Forty carts. And behind the last of them, on a horse, in the purple-bordered toga of a man who had been consul twice, upright, with a face gone to bone and a cloth in his left hand that he did not raise, Lucius Licinius Sura, riding with a cough down the Sacred Way behind the man he had made in front of the Senate, which was where he had done everything else; and the crowd knew him, and the roar changed shape for him. He did not look at the box either, and she understood, watching the knife-face go by below her, that he had told the boy where the far end of the cut

was, because that was the kind of thing a dying man did with his last useful breath, and that the boy had gone there anyway, this morning, before the carts, because he was good at doing nothing and had decided, once, to do it in the wrong place on purpose.

And then the emperor. The four white horses, and the chariot, and the man in it with the painted face and the laurel and the slave behind him holding the crown over his head and saying the thing the slave said, *remember you are a man*, which nobody could hear and everybody knew; and the roar went past being a sound and became a thing you were inside; and the Augusta, in her chair, with no cloth, looked at her husband going by below her in a chariot behind a king's gold with the Senate ahead and the legions behind and the whole of the city that mattered on its feet. Her face showed what it had decided to, which was nothing, and the eyes did a thing that Fausta saw from behind and to the left and had never seen them do and did not have a word for, and decided, that night, in the book, was *arithmetic*: a woman looking at a sum she had written in eleven letters from Cologne, come out.

Behind the chariot, on a horse, in a legate's cloak, with the grey eyes on the road and the face doing nothing, the man she had chosen. He did not look at the box either. He had been told what the Augusta was looking for and he was a man who learned.

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The legions came last, and she had not expected the legions to be the thing, and they were.

Not all of them; four, with their eagles uncased now and the standards and the horns, in cohorts, in step, in the sound that forty thousand men made walking on sand that had had a king's gold go over it, which was not a sound so much as a thing the ground did; and the crowd, which had roared for the gold and gone quiet for the emperor and roared again, did neither for the legions; it *stood*, the whole of it, the stands and the roofs and the Capitol's slope, as a town

stood for one ship, and let them pass. The First Minervia, which was the Spaniard's, and he turned his horse at the head of it and rode back along its first cohort for the length of the box and did not look up. The Fourth Flavia. The Thirteenth. And the Seventh Claudia, which had wintered on the far bank both winters and gone up the ladders at the second wall, and which came up the Sacred Way with a gap in its second cohort where a century should have been and was not, because the Seventh did not fill a century that had lost its centurion at a wall until it was home. It was not home; and at the back of the Seventh, behind the last cohort, walking, not in step, because they could not, the ones who had come back with less than they went with: the one-armed, the men with a stick instead of a leg, the man with half a face who walked with his good side to the box; and the crowd stood for them as it had not stood for the gold.

"Look at that," said Sabina, to the Capitol, in the low quick voice, and for once the voice had a thing in it that was not dry. "My great-uncle's put them at the back on purpose. He said at dinner, *the Senate's seen the figure; now they'll see what it cost, and they'll see it last, so it's what they go home with.* Plotina said it was a story and he said *yes, Pompeia, a man's allowed one.*" A pause. "There's a gap in the Seventh. Second cohort. That's a century with no centurion. Hadrian says the boy with the stick was at that wall when it happened and was sick in the lee of the first wall after and wrote to his father that night *it was quick*, and Lucius told Hadrian, and Hadrian told me because he tells me what'll hurt." The beautiful face did not move. "I'm telling you because you've read forty boards and you'll want the figure for the stick, and that's it. A hand-stone. A man who carried him over the Rhine. It's in your column now. Don't look at the gap."

She did not look at the gap. She looked at the Capitol. The Seventh went by with its century missing and its broken men at the back, and the crowd stood, and the sound the ground made went up the Sacred Way and over the box and up the Palatine behind and she

felt it in the timber under her feet, and under that, where she kept the things that were not figures, she felt a thing she had not felt since a shed on a mole with the sea in a glass, which was that a sum could be right and still be the wrong thing to have written. That the people who knew that were walking at the back of a legion not in step, and that one of them had been carried over a river by a man whose stick was in a boy's belt behind the twenty-second cart, and that none of it would be on a board.

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It was the ninth hour before the last cohort had gone up to the Capitol and the box could be left, and the Augusta did not leave it.

The others went. Matidia first, with a look at her daughter and no word, up the covered stair to the Palatine's postern. Sabina, standing, shaking out the gown she disliked, with the veil in her hand, saying to the girl behind her shoulder, in the low quick voice, "Come up. No. Stay. She wants you; I can see it in her back. I'll do my own hair tonight; I've watched you long enough to get it wrong on purpose." And gone, with the Germans. And then the box was the Augusta in her chair and the girl standing, and the road below with the sand churned and the crowd going home over it in its hundred thousands making the noise a city made after, which was lower, and tired, and had wine in it, and would go on till morning.

"Sit," said the Augusta. "Sabina's chair. You've stood nine hours. I had it from a Guardsman that you read forty boards and never once looked past the tailboard of the twenty-second, and that he never once looked up from it, and that Lucius rode past with his eyes on his horse's ears, and that Hadrian looked at the road. Four people on the Sacred Way today who didn't look at my box, and three of them were my doing, and the fourth was Lucius, who's never done what I wanted in his life and has been right every time." She did not look round. "Sit."

Fausta sat. The ivory was in her hair. Her feet were under her and the floor was timber over posts over a road where a king's gold had gone by.

"I said I'd be watching your faces. I was. I'll tell you what I saw, since you'll want the figure and I've never once in four years lied to you about one." The plain face looked at the road. "I saw a girl read a board. Forty of them. With her lips still and her eyes moving and the face she keeps, and on the twenty-second the eyes stopped for the length of a breath and went on, and that was all, and if I'd not been watching for it I'd have thought she was checking a nine. And I saw a man with a stick walk behind a cart reading the same board with his lips moving, and on the twenty-second — my Guardsman says, and he's a man who sees — the lips stopped, for the length of a breath, and went on." The Augusta was quiet. The city went home below. "Neither of you turned round. Neither of you *looked*. And I sat here in my husband's chair at my husband's triumph with the thing I wrote in Cologne going by on four white horses and I found I wasn't watching it; I was watching two children from a coast not look at each other across a hundred thousand people with their lips stopped, and I thought: I've paid a sail and a man in Africa for this, and it's the best thing I've bought in thirty years, and I don't know what it is."

"Augusta."

"Yes."

"What does it cost?"

The Augusta turned her head, finally, which she did not do, and looked at the girl in Sabina's chair, and the plain face showed the thing that was nearly tiredness, and then the other thing, and then — Fausta kept it; she would write it that night under the arithmetic — something she had never seen on it in four years and had been told by Marcia did not exist, which was uncertainty.

"I don't know," said Pompeia Plotina. "That's the first time I've said it since Nemausus. I know what I've paid and I know what I've

got and I can't do the sum. There's a thing in it that's not a figure." She turned back to the road. "I wrote eleven letters from Cologne. He read them. We've been very civil for thirty years across a table and never once stood on anything together and looked out." The face showed nothing. "It's not a receiving day. I'd like, once, to have said a true thing to someone who'll put it in a book and not a mouth."

The city went home. The sand on the Sacred Way was churned to the colour of the cut.

"Go up," said the Augusta. "Not to Sabina; she's doing her own hair wrong on purpose and wants to be found at it. To your book. Write the day. Write the twenty-second board. Write what I said; I'll not say it again and I'd like it kept somewhere." She lay back in the emperor's wife's chair with no cloth. "And girl. Tomorrow. The city will be drunk and the Senate will be voting games and Hadrian will be in his library and Lucius will be on his couch, if he's alive, and I'll have the cloth on, because it'll be a receiving day again and I've a headache to perform. And there's a Syrian with a hole in the ground who was told *one day*, and the day's not mine any more; I said yes to it in April and the triumph's over. Where you go in the morning before the room is a thing I've decided not to know. It's the first thing in thirty years I've decided not to know. I'd like to see what it feels like."

She went up. The covered stair to the postern, the courts, the fountain that worked, the north rooms, where Sabina was at the glass with her hair half down and a pin in her teeth and said round it, "Don't. I'm getting it wrong. Go and write. Momus is on the terrace; he's been there since the gold; he says he counted forty carts and one stick and he'd like it known he was right about the stick."

She went to the terrace. The dwarf was on the parapet with his legs out and the city below going home in the long June dusk, and the cut beyond the Forum a dark square in the red, and he did not look round, and said, "Well?"

"I didn't turn round."

"I saw. I saw from here; you've a back like a shutter. He didn't either. His freedwoman will have it from the wine-shop by now and be pleased and not say so." Momus looked at the cut. "And the Augusta?"

"She said she doesn't know what it costs."

The dwarf was quiet for a long moment.

"Then that's the first true thing anyone's said on this hill in forty years," he said, "and she said it to you, in her husband's box, on the day of his triumph, and you'll put it in your book, and nobody will ever read it, and that's exactly right." He turned his face up. "Tomorrow. Before the room. I'll walk you. Nobody stops a girl with a dwarf at the Syrian's cut; they think she's come to see the hole and I'm the measure."

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She wrote it that night, on the cold floor, with Sabina asleep at last in the next room with her hair wrong, and the lamp, and the book open on her knees at the third leaf, in the small hard hand.

The Nones of June. The triumph. I stood nine hours at Sabina's left shoulder and read forty boards and did not turn round. He walked behind the twenty-second with Crescens's stick in his belt and did not look up. The Augusta watched both and said afterwards, in the emperor's box, in the emperor's chair's shadow, that she does not know what it costs. I am writing that down because she will never say it again and because it is the first time I have heard her say a thing she had not decided to.

Her eyes did a thing when the chariot went by. I have called it arithmetic. I think it is what my mother's face did when a month came out, which it did twice in my memory.

He stood at the far end of the cut this morning before light and said something to the hole in a hand only I can read. I was not there. I know what it was. I have known since a mole. I said it at twelve with my arm out straight and he said "all right" and I thought "all right" was his

price for it. It was not; it was the thing left over, and I have been six years carrying it in the place where I keep the Rhodian's eleven, and tonight the Augusta said she has decided not to know where I go in the morning, and Momus says he will walk me, and I have decided.

I will go and look at a hole in the ground a hill's height, with a dwarf, because a Syrian was told "one day" and the day is not hers any more. If he is there, we will stand side by side and look at the same thing, which is what Sura says a mole is. If he is not, I will have seen the column's footing, and the Syrian will have been pleased, and I will come back and do two heads.

I do not know what it costs. That makes two of us on this hill tonight, and the other one is the Augusta, and I would not have believed, on a lodging-house stair at ten, that I would ever write that sentence.

And? — I am asking. Not telling. I have worked that out. It took four years and a woman who threw her children in a basin saying "it comes out" on a floor. My mother was asking what was next. So am I.

She closed the book. The boards were oak. She put it under the Strabo with the letters and the fish and the prefect's copy under the Augusta's seal, and lay down on the floor by the chest in her gown with the ivory still in her hair, because she would not sleep and there was no reason to be comfortable not sleeping, and listened to the city be drunk below, and counted, because she counted everything, the hours till the first.

28

The Twenty-Second Cart

The Sacred Way and the Aventine, the Nones of June, 107

He walked behind it with his lips moving, as Sura had said he would, and the figure was right forty times, and on the twenty-second his lips stopped.

The Campus at the first hour had been the whole army of the thing in a field in the grey, forming: the Senate at the front in a white mass with the lictors trying to make it a column, the carts behind in their forty with the canvas off now and the Guard round them and the boards on their poles, the pictures on their frames with the paint still tacky where the Syrian had touched the bridge up at midnight, the prisoners in their chains sitting on the ground because nobody had told them to stand, the white horses being walked, the legions beyond in their cohorts with the eagles cased until the gate, and the sound of it, which was not yet a sound, which was forty thousand men and animals and wheels in a field being quiet. He had checked the boards a fourth time by lamp. He had put the tablet in the box and the box on a trestle in the shed with Blaesus sitting on it, because Blaesus had asked to and because a deaf man on a box was the safest archive in Rome. He had the stick. He stood behind the twenty-second cart's tailboard with his hands at his sides and the stripe on and the sandals the Argiletum had sold him for this and waited for the horns, and when they came he walked.

The gate. The Circus Flaminius, the Velabrum, the Forum Boarium with the cattle-smell under the flowers, the Circus Maximus with its hundred and fifty thousand on the stands making the first real noise, and then the long turn under the Palatine's flank toward the Sacred Way, with the sound coming up ahead of them the way the sea

came up a beach; and he did not look up. He read the board. Twenty-two carts ahead of him twenty-one boards had gone by and he had read each as it came out of the shed and again at the gate and again at the Circus and they were right; and the twenty-second was his, the one he walked behind, *twenty-two pounds four ounces* in the eleventh line of its column, bar, forty-first, with the line of a wing in it that nobody on the Sacred Way would see because it was under eleven hundredweight of other bars. He read the board, in letters a hand high, as the cart came round the turn below the Palatine where the road came out of the cut and the box was.

The pictures had gone ahead of the carts, on their frames, and he had not looked at them on the Campus because he had been checking boards; but at the Circus, where the procession slowed for the turn and the carts closed up on the frames in front, he saw the one that was nearest, tilted toward the stands so the hundred and fifty thousand could see, and it was the second wall. The Syrian had painted the bridge himself and left the rest to the Argiletum, and the Argiletum had painted a wall and a ladder and men going up it and a thing coming down from the parapet the size of a loaf, caught in the air, and at the foot of the ladder a man with a transverse crest with his hand on a rung, looking up; and it was nobody; it was a painter's centurion; and the hand on the rung was the right hand and the skin was on it still, because the painter had not known; and he walked behind it for the length of the Circus with his lips moving over a figure and the picture going before him on its frame with the painter's centurion looking up at a stone that had not yet arrived. The vine-stick in his belt, and did not look at it again, because a man who had seen the thing did not need the picture, and because he had a board to read.

He knew where the box was. He had walked past it in the dark at the first hour with the Guard at its foot. He did not look. He read the board. And the sound did the thing, stopped, all of it, for the length of a breath, as the first cart came into the light below the Capitol, and

then came back as a roar that he felt through the sandals and the road. The twenty-second cart rolled on into it with its board on its pole and he walked behind with his lips moving over a figure he had by heart and had been told by a dying man and a freedwoman and a dwarf he had never met not to make into a thing he was holding.

And his lips stopped.

Not because he looked. He did not look. Because the roar, which was a hundred thousand people being shown a figure, had a shape, and the shape had a hole in it, and the hole was above him and to the right, at the turn, where the box was. It was the shape of a dozen people in a box on posts *not* making a noise while a city did; and he felt the hole go over him as the cart went under the box the way he had felt a sail go over his face on a sheep-rock, and in it, for the length of a breath, with his eyes on the board, he knew where she was standing as exactly as he had known on a Caelian couch where she was in a room he had not looked at, which was at the left shoulder of a woman in a chair, a pace back, with a pin, reading his board.

Then the cart was past the turn and the hole was behind him and the roar was whole again and his lips moved, *twenty-two four, bar, forty-first*, and he walked on toward the Capitol with the stick in his belt, and did not turn round, and found that it was not a thing he was holding. It was a thing he was walking beside. Chrestê had said *just walk* and the dwarf had said *that's all a mole is* and Sura had said *side by side and look at the same thing*, and the same thing had been a board with a figure on it that he had made on a rock and she had read from a box. They had both read it and neither had looked at the other and that was, he understood on the Sacred Way with a king's gold in front of him and an empress's box behind, the first thing they had done together in six years.

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Sura did not fall. He rode the whole of it, behind the fortieth cart, upright, with the cloth in his left hand and his eyes on his horse's ears,

and at the Capitol, where the emperor got down and went up the steps to the god and the Senate followed and the prisoners were taken away to the thing the road ended in, the two consuls' lictors had to lift him from the saddle. He let them, and stood, and said in the Spanish to the nearest, "There. In front of the Senate. Tell the Greek," and was carried to a litter.

The gold went into the treasury under the Capitol's slope by the back way while the god was being thanked on the steps above. He went with it, because the boards went with it and he was answerable; and in the vaults under the Temple of Saturn, where the Roman people had kept what it had since before there were emperors, Capito's clerks took the bars off the carts one by one and set them on the treasury's own scale, which was older than the Syrian's beam and better, and read the weight, and a clerk with the treasury's book read the figure from the board, and they matched, and the bar went onto the shelf, and the next came. Forty carts. He stood by the scale with the stick in his belt and the roar coming down faintly through the rock from the steps above and watched a king's gold be counted a second time by men who had not been on a rock and had no reason to be kind. It matched, every bar, and some time in the second hour of it the twenty-second cart's load came down and the clerk set a bar on the pan that had the line of a wing in it.

"Twenty-two four," the clerk said, reading the pan. "Bar. Forty-first." And then, because he was a treasury clerk and had been counting bullion for thirty years and had never once seen a thing in it: "There's a mark. Here. Under the surface. It didn't take in the melt."

"It's an eagle," Celer said. "The Fifth Alaudae's. Fuscus lost it in Domitian's year and it was never found. Apollodorus thinks the king put it in the furnace last and it didn't go."

The clerk looked at it. Capito, who had come down the steps from the god to see his own clerks do their work, looked at it over the clerk's shoulder with the ink on his cuff.

"It's gold," Capito said. "It goes on the shelf with the rest. The treasury doesn't keep eagles; the legions do, and the Fifth's gone, there's nobody to give it back to." He was quiet a moment, looking at the line of a wing in a lump of a king's plate. "But I'll write the line. *Forty-first bar, twenty-two pounds four ounces, bearing the mark of the eagle of V Alaudae, lost under Cornelius Fuscus, identified by the weigher.* In the treasury's book, which nobody reads and everybody keeps. In three hundred years somebody will open it looking for something else and find that, and not know what to do with it, and that's what a record's for." He nodded to the clerk. "Shelf it."

The bar went on the shelf. The next came. He stood by the scale until the fortieth cart was empty and the shelves were a thing the eye had no figure for, and then the clerks swore to the sheet, and Capito put it on the roll, and the vault was locked. He went up the back way into the light and the roar and the smell of a hundred thousand people, with the boards left behind in the dark against the wall, which was where boards went when the figure was in the book.

Celer found him in it, at the Capitol's foot, in the shade of the arch, with the roar still going on above and the gold being counted into the treasury by Capito's clerks with his boards beside them; and Sura looked out of the litter's curtain with the knife-face gone grey under the bone and said, "Well?"

"Forty boards, sir. All right. Capito's men have them against the tablet now."

"Not the boards."

"No, sir." He stood with the stick. "I didn't turn round."

"No. Hadrian's man on the roof says not. He says your lips stopped at the turn. He says hers did too, or her eyes; he's not sure which; he was a long way up." Sura coughed, and it was bad, and went on, and the litter-bearers looked at each other. "Plotina's seen it. She'll say something tonight to the girl in the box, because she's a woman who can't leave a sum alone once it's come out, and the girl'll put it in

a book, Marcia says there's a book now, Sabina gave it her. And tomorrow." The eyes closed. "Tomorrow I'll be on my couch at the window and I'll not know. For the first time in forty years there'll be a thing on that hill I've not had from someone by noon. I've decided to find out what that's like. Plotina's decided the same, Marcia says; she told the girl *I've decided not to know where you go*. Two of us. Not knowing. On purpose. It's the strangest thing that's happened on this hill since Cologne." The curtain began to fall. "Go to the feast. The emperor's asked for you. He'll ask you a thing. Answer it. Then go home and don't sleep, and in the morning do what you've done since November, and don't tell me. Ever. If I'm alive in the autumn I'll not ask and if you tell me I'll have you sent to Capito."

The feast was in the Syrian's basilica, which was not finished and had no roof, because the emperor had said *I'll dine in it with the sky on and the Senate can look up and see what the gold's for*; and the Senate looked up, and dined. The gold was in the treasury with forty boards beside it, and some time after the second course a Guardsman came down the long table to where the staff were and said to the freedman's son, "Caesar," and he got up and went.

The emperor was at the high table under the open sky with the laurel off and the paint washed off and the face that was on the coins doing the thing it did when it was looking at a figure, and the figure, this time, was a tall young man with a stick in his belt, standing. The Spaniard was on his left, in the Greek cloak, with the grey eyes on his cup. The Augusta was not there; the Augusta did not dine with the Senate; the Augusta was in a room with one window, or a box, or wherever a woman went who had just watched her sum come out.

"Sura's boy." The slow Spanish Latin. "I said I'd give you an order. Hold both till the Nones; then put the boards down; then find out what's next. It's the Nones. The boards are in the treasury. I'm asking." The still face did not move. "What's next?"

He stood under the open sky in the Syrian's unroofed basilica with the Senate behind him and the Spaniard's grey eyes on a cup, and did the sum, and did not pick the first way it came out, and said it.

"Sura's office, Caesar, until Sura's dead. Then the Spaniard's, because Sura's said so and the telling's right. The forum, because Apollodorus has asked and I can count what it weighs. The roll, because Capito's written a line on it in his own hand and I'd not have it be the last." He stopped. He had been asked what was next and he had been taught by a woman at a loom to say a thing once and by a woman over a slate to say it in the voice. "And a thing that's not Caesar's, and not Sura's, and not the Spaniard's, and that I'll not say at this table, because it's not a figure, and the tables on this hill are for figures."

The emperor looked at him. The Spaniard's eyes came up off the cup and rested, and the face lit, interested and a little short; and then went out; and simply looked.

"Not a figure," said the emperor. "At my table. On the day of my triumph. From the boy who weighed the gold." The coin-face did a thing the coins left out, which was, Celer would think afterwards, nearly amusement and was not; it was the face of a man who had marched the morning after a great many things. "Good. There's always one. Nobody tells you. Sura didn't tell me; Plotina did, in a letter from Cologne, the eleventh, at the end, after the sum, in a line I've never shown anyone: *and there will be a thing left over, and it will be you, and I have decided to carry it.*" He picked up his cup. "Go home, Hermes's son. You've an order. Find out what's next. It's not here."

Capito stopped him on the way back down the long table, with the ink on his cuff even here, and a tablet.

"Yours. From the rock. The treasury's done with it; the boards matched, every line, and the clerks have sworn to it on a sheet I've put on the roll under your name, because I said I'd write one true line for a

man who didn't pay for it and I find I've written two." He held it out. "Keep it. The Senate's figure is the Senate's now; it's in the treasury's book in a clerk's hand and nobody will ever read the original again. But a man should have the thing he did the sum on. I've my own, from Nerva's year; it's a wax tablet with sixteen months on it and I look at it when I need to remember I was in a room." He let go. "And Hermes's son. The Syrian's looking for you. He's at the far end with the engineers, drunk, and he's asked three times for the boy who counts, and I've told him three times you were with Caesar, and he's said each time *then Caesar can spare him for a pit*."

Apollodorus was at the far end, under the scaffold where the apse would be, with lime on his arms still because he had come from the cut to the feast without washing, and six engineers, and a great deal of wine, and he saw the boy with the tablet and the stick and shouted, in the Greek, over the Senate, "There. The weigher. Come here. Sit. No, stand; you'll be standing in the morning." He put an arm along the engineers' end of the table as if it were a pier. "Tomorrow. The footing. I'm setting the first course of the column's base at the second hour, because the emperor wants it begun the day after and not a day later, and I want it measured first by a man who'll give me a figure and not a story, and my own men are all drunk and will be, and Blaesus can't hear a plumb-line." He looked at the boy with the Damascus face. "You'll be there. At the far end, by the shoulder, with the rod. Before the gangs. I've told the Guard. I've told Lucius. I've told the Augusta's woman, because she asked me what I was doing at the pit in the morning and I'm a Syrian and I don't lie to women with combs." The arm came off the table. "And I've told the dwarf."

And at the bottom of the lowest table, among the thin stripes who had come up from the legions for the day and would go back, there was a round face burnt the colour of a tile under hair the colour of wet straw, and it had seen him before he saw it, and was grinning, and lifted a cup an arm's length out across the table so that the man beside

him had to lean back.

He went down. He had not meant to; he was Sura's and should have stood where Sura's people stood. He went down the length of the roofless hall with the sky in it and the Senate turning to see where the weigher was going, and Aper got up off the bench and did not embrace him, because he knew better, and held out the cup instead, arm straight, and said, "You walked. I saw you walk. Behind the twenty-second cart with your lips going. I told the man next to me *that's my tent-mate* and he didn't believe me and I've had to drink his wine to punish him."

"You said you'd not come."

"I said maybe for a triumph. I've a magistracy in Ariminum and a wife since the spring and I came up on a mule like a farmer to see a king's gold go past on a plank, and I've seen it, and it was a figure, like you said it would be, and I didn't care about the figure; I was looking at the back of your head." He drank. "You look worse. You look like you've been told something by a dying man."

"I have."

"Don't tell me what. I'd not understand it and I'd want to." Aper looked up at the sky over the unroofed hall, and then at the high table where the Spaniard was watching a freedman's son at the bottom of the room with the face that was interested, and said, lower, "That one. The one with the beard. He's looking at you the way my father looked at a horse he'd decided to buy."

"Yes."

"Does he know you can't be bought?"

Celer looked at the cup in his hand, and then at the round face, which had known him in a tent with mules, and had never once in five years done a sum on him, and said, "He knows the price. It's not money. He's working out what it is."

"Then he's cleverer than me, and I liked you anyway." Aper sat down. "Go back up. Sura's looking. Write to me. You never did; I had

my steward's boy watch the post for a year. Do it now. About you. Not about gold."

Celer stood.

"Which dwarf, sir?"

"Tertulla's. The Augusta's niece's. The one on the west terrace who counts. He came to the hut on the Kalends with a message from nobody, which is how messages come on that hill, and said: *the Syrian was told "one day" and the day's after the triumph; which morning?* And I said the morning after, the second hour, I'm setting a course and I'll want the boy to measure it first. And he said *then I'll bring the measure*, and went." The Syrian drank. "I don't know what that was. I'm an engineer. But I've been on the hill long enough to know that when a dwarf says *measure* he doesn't mean a rod, and I thought the man who's going to hold my rod at the second hour should know there's a dwarf coming to the pit with something that isn't one." He turned back to the engineers. "Second hour. The rod's in the hut. Blaesus will give it you; he sleeps there; shout."

He went. At the basilica's end, under the arch where the Syrian's scaffold was, the Spaniard caught him up, alone, in the Greek cloak, and walked beside him three paces in the dark and said, in the Greek, to the ground, "The library. Tomorrow. I'll be in it from the first hour. I've decided. Plotina's decided not to know a thing and Lucius has decided not to know a thing and I've decided to be in a room with four scrolls and the door shut, so that I'll not be able to say, later, that I was anywhere else." Three more paces. "I asked her in April to see the cut with me. She said *what does it cost* and I told her, and the cost was you, and she said *not before the triumph*. The triumph's over. I'll not be at the cut. I'd like that known by the one man on this hill who'd not tell anyone." And was gone, back toward the high table, and the sky with no roof.

Chrestê had the lamp lit and the slate put away and her door open and a bundle on the table, and she was sitting beside it with her hands in her lap and the long face arranged. He stood in the door of the three rooms with the day in him and looked at the bundle and understood it before she spoke, because he had learned, at last, to read her, on purpose, and she had let him.

"I've taken rooms," she said, in the Gulf Greek. "Over the fuller's, two streets down. Mine. On the two thousand's interest, which the banker says is enough for a freedwoman with a slate who'll do accounts for the Aventine's shopkeepers, who can none of them add. I go in the morning. Before light. Before you go to the cut." She did not look at the bundle. "You'll want to know why."

"Yes."

"Because I'll not be the woman at the top of the stair when you come back from it. Whichever way it goes." She said it as a manifest. "If she's there, I'll not be here to be kind about it. And if she's not — you'd come to my door, Gaius. You would. And I'd open it, because I liked it more than I planned. I was that woman for a merchant in Puteoli for four years." The long face did not change. "So I've taken rooms. Over a fuller's, in the Subura; it stinks and the light's good. I'll keep your slate from there. I'll come on the Kalends and do it on this table and go."

He stood in the door. The two boxes were on the shelf under the Lares with the stick across them, and the room was the room he had bought a woman to keep, and the woman had kept it, and was going.

"I'd like you to stay," he said. He said it because it was true and because his father had said it to a woman from Nola and it had been the best thing his father had done. "And I'll not blame you."

"I know. You said it at the foot of a stair and I sat down. I'll not sit down twice; a woman gets one." She stood. She picked up the bundle. She came to the door, where he was, and stopped, close, with the long face a hand from his, and did not arrange it, and let him see the thing

underneath, which had moved on a step and was not going back, and which was, he saw now with the lamp behind her, not fear, not the pen-look, not the sum, but a woman of twenty-three who had told the truth to the man who bought her and had been told it back and was leaving before it cost either of them more than they had. "Gaius. Two things, and then I'm on the stair. The first. You're kind. I said at the start I'd heard it and I'd work with it and I have, and it's true, and it's not the thing about you. The thing about you is that you read a bill aloud to a girl at eleven to show her what you could see, and you've been looking for someone to show it to ever since, and you showed it to Sura and Sura kept it in a box, and you showed it to a Syrian and he put it on a board, and you've never once shown it to the one person who was in the room when you first did, because you were told to do nothing and you're good at it. Stop being good at it. For one morning. That's the first."

"And the second."

"The second's the dwarf's. He sent it down the hill by the wine-shop on purpose, the steward's boy says, the way I sent the altar up, because he and I count the same and we've never met and we've decided between us, through four wine-shops, that the two of you need telling things by people who don't count on the hill." She shifted the bundle. "He said: *tell the shipowner's boy that the girl's mother said "and?" and the girl's worked out this month that it was a question. Tell him she's going to ask it. Tell him to have something after it this time, because he said once that he'd nothing, and burned the sheet, and she's never seen the sheet and knows it was burned, because the Corinthian told the wine-shop that too, because the Corinthian tells the wine-shop everything he'd never say, and the Corinthian's leaving, and this is the last.*" She stepped past him onto the stair. "That's all. Go to the cut. Take the stick; it's the only thing you own she's never seen and you should have one. Don't take the boxes. They're an altar and you don't carry an altar to a hole in the ground; you leave it where the gods can

see it and go and find out what's next, which is a thing your emperor said, and he's the only man alive who's done it the morning after and lived."

She went down. He stood at the top of the stair over the wine-shop and watched her go, with the bundle, in the dark, in the drunk city, two streets to a fuller's, and did not try not to read her, and read her, and what was there was a woman who had been sold with the furniture and had just freed herself of the last thing she was owned by, which was him; and he found that he was glad, in a way that was not the feeling at the foot of a stair and was its other half. That he would miss her at the slate on every day but the Kalends for the rest of his life, and that both were a figure, and that his father would have said *both's a figure, learn to carry it*, and that he could.

He went up the stair, and at the turn of it, where she had stopped the day he freed her, a man was sitting on the step in the dark with a wineskin, and looked up, and had the Seventh's belt-plate on and one arm.

"That's a vitis," the man said, in the Picene Latin, not drunk enough. "In an eques's belt. I saw it on the road today behind the gold and I thought, that's wrong, and then I thought, no, I know that stick, I've had it across my back, that's Crescens's, from the second cohort, the one who went down at the second wall with a hand-stone and no sound." He looked at the tall man on the stair. "You're the one he carried over the Rhine. In Domitian's year. The shipowner's boy. He talked about it, once, drunk, on the far bank; he said *I carried a freedman's son across the Rhine on a boat and he was sick in it and I told him to be ashamed later and he's the only man I ever told that to who did it*."

Celer stood on the stair.

"The optio gave it me. After the wall."

"Aye. He'd have said to. He said a lot of things about you to us that he'd never have said to you, and I'll not say them now; I've one

arm and a skin and I've walked behind the eagles today for the last time and I'm sitting on a stranger's stair because it was the first one I came to." The man drank. "I'll say the one. He said: *that boy counts everything and one day he'll count something that matters and he'll not know it till it's counted, and I'd like to be there, and I'll not be.*" He got up, slowly, with the arm. "I saw the stick. I wanted the man who wears it to know a man from the cohort saw it and knew it. Go up. You've a face on you like a man who's got somewhere to be in the morning."

He did not sleep. He fed the Lares from Nola with the last of her bread. He put the stick in his belt and left the boxes under the gods, as instructed, and at the end of the third hour of the night, when the city was as quiet as it was going to be, he went down the stair past a door that was open on an empty room, and down the Aventine, and along the river, and through the Forum Boarium where the flowers from the morning were being swept into the cattle-dung, and under the Palatine's flank past the box on its posts with the hangings down and no Guard at its foot now, and did not look up at it, and out along the Sacred Way through the sand that was churned to the colour of the cut, and past the Curia, where the Guard knew him now and did not stop him, and up to the edge, and along it, in the dark, to the far end, by the shoulder, where the pit was, and nobody.

He stood. He did what he had done since November. The light would come over the Esquiline behind him in two hours and touch the sliced shoulder first and come down it. He did not expect a litter. He had not expected one for seven months and he had been told by a dying man where the far end was and by a Corinthian to stop being good at nothing and by a dwarf through four wine-shops that a question was coming. He stood in the dark at the end of a hill being taken away a basket at a time with a dead centurion's stick in his belt, and waited, which was not the same as doing nothing, and which he had not known, until that morning, was a different thing.

29

The Measure

The Palatine to the cut, the morning after the triumph, 107

She had not slept, and at the end of the third hour of the night she stopped pretending that lying on a floor was a thing she was doing for a reason, and got up, and did her own hair.

Not the old way; not the new. The way she had done it at ten on a lodging-house stair with no glass, which was back, and tied, and out of the way of a slate; and then she stood with the ivory in her hand in the one lamp and looked at it, the small carved face with the plain hair and the gold on the break, and did the sum, and put it in. At the side. Where the light would catch it. Because a patient man had put it in her hand to be seen and she had made it hers by being seen in it, and because it was the one thing she owned that had been a price and had come out, and because — she was honest; she had decided on a terrace — he had never seen it. She would like him to see the one thing on her that the hill had given and she had kept, so that he would know what she had been wearing while she was not turning round.

The Strabo, the fish, the prefect's copy under the Augusta's seal, and his letters stayed in the chest under the book. She had decided that too. You did not carry a receipt to a hole in the ground. You left it where it could be found and went to find out what was next, which was a thing her mother had asked with her last breath and she had taken four years to hear.

Sabina was awake. Sabina was at the window in the shift with her hair still wrong from the night and the beautiful face turned to the dark where the city was being quiet at last, and said without turning, in the low quick voice, "You've done your own. Back and tied. Like a girl with a slate." A pause. "Good. He's never seen it any other way,

has he. Not the old way or the new; those are ours. That's yours." She turned. The dry tenant intelligence looked at the girl in the door with the pin and the plain hair and the face that did nothing, and did a thing Fausta had not seen it do, which was soften, briefly, as a thing softened that had been held hard a long time and was tired.

"He told me a thing. In the door, at midnight, before the library. He doesn't tell me things; he tells me where not to look. But he stood there with the sky still on him from the Syrian's roofless feast and said: *the emperor asked Hermes's son what was next, at the high table, in front of the Senate, and the boy said Sura's office and mine and the forum and the roll, and then he said there was a thing that wasn't Caesar's or Sura's or mine and that he'd not say it at a table because the tables on this hill are for figures. And my uncle said "good, there's always one," and told him to go home and find it, and said Plotina had written him the same in the eleventh letter from Cologne, at the end, in a line nobody's seen.*" Sabina's hands were still in her lap. "And then my husband said — to the glass, not to me; he'd caught sight of himself — *I've sat at that table seven years and never once said a thing at it that wasn't a figure, and a freedman's son with a stick has done it on the day of the triumph and been told "good."* And he went to the library and shut the door." The beautiful face did the nearly-smile, and for once there was something in it besides the nothing. It was not kind to anyone, least of all its owner. "He was jealous, Puteoli. Not of you. Of *him*. Of a boy who had a thing left over and said so at a table. I've been married to that man since I was seventeen and I've never seen him want a thing he couldn't buy or read or outwait, and last night he wanted to be a shipowner's son for the length of a sentence, and couldn't, and went and read Sappho about it. I'd like that in your book. It's the only thing I've ever had over him and I'll not have it again."

"Yes, Vibia."

"Don't. I'm getting fond of it." She turned back to the window. "Go on. Momus is at the postern; he's been there since the second hour of the night, Marcia says, sitting on the step like a parcel. My husband's in the library with the door shut; he went at midnight; he told the Germans he was not to be disturbed by anyone for any reason until the room, and the Germans have never once in seven years heard him say *anyone*, and they've decided it means me, and it doesn't." The nearly-smile, with nothing in it and everything. "He's decided not to know. So has she. So has Lucius, if he's alive. My mother's asleep; she never needed to know anything to be in a room." She turned back to the window. "Go and see your hole. Come back and do my hair. I'll want to be told nothing, and I'll know anyway. I'll see your back."

The palace at the fourth hour of the night after a triumph was a thing she had not seen before and would put in the book: a house that had been full of a hundred thousand people's noise and had been emptied of it all at once, so that the quiet had a shape, like the mark on a floor where a couch had stood. The long gallery was unlit. Garlands had come down off the columns in the night and lay where they had fallen, laurel and myrtle gone limp in their own smell, and a woman's sandal, one, gilt, with the strap broken, stood by itself in the middle of the marble as if it had walked there. Someone had put down a cup of wine on the base of the Augustus and not come back for it. The German at the gallery's end was asleep on his feet with his spear in the crook of his arm and his chin on his chest, which she had been told they could not do, and she went by him without a sound, as she had been taught, and he did not stir.

The kitchens were awake. She heard them before the smell: the first ovens, the slap of dough, a boy being shouted at in a Gaulish accent for the state of a spit. Smoke came along the service passage low, under the lintel, and lay in the courts. Three slaves she did not know were on their knees in the second court scraping candle-grease off the paving with shells, and did not look up, because a woman

going somewhere at that hour with her hair tied back was not a thing you looked up at in that house; you looked at the grease.

She went by the library. She had not meant to. The way to the covered stair went by it, and she went that way, and the door was shut, and there was light under it, the flat light of two lamps that have burned a long time and been trimmed once; and she stopped. Not long. The time it took the smoke in the court behind her to shift when a door opened somewhere in the kitchens. The door in front of her did not open. Nobody moved behind it. A man who had told the Germans *anyone* was sitting in there with a book he was not reading and had decided, on the one morning he could have come to a window, to keep a door between himself and it. She looked at the light under the door, and at the sill, which had been worn hollow in the middle by the people of six emperors, and went on.

Marcia was on the covered stair.

Not at the postern; on the stair itself, halfway, in the dark, where the Germans could not see her from either end, with no comb, in a cloak, and she stood up off the step as the girl came down and did not say anything for a moment, and the round brown face in the no-light was not arranged, and Fausta understood that the freedwoman from Nemausus had been sitting on a stair in the dark since some hour of the night in order to be met by accident.

"She's asleep." Marcia said it first, as the one true thing, because that was what she gave. "The Augusta. Since the fourth hour. She said the arithmetic and lay down and slept, which she's not done on the night of a thing in thirty years; I've sat by her for all of them and I know. I've left her. The Germans have the door. She'll wake for the room and put the cloth on and not ask me where you were, and I'll not tell her, and that'll be the first morning in forty years I've had a thing she hasn't." The round face did a thing. "I'd like to know what it's like too. It seems to be going round."

"Marcia."

"I've a thing. Then go." The freedwoman took it out of the cloak. A sheet, folded, soft at the folds, with a seal on it that was a brass fish. "Yours. The letter. Tingis. In your hand, to me, asking. I said I'd put it in the box with mine and I did, and they've sat there a year, the two of them, and last night after the box she said — not to me; to the ceiling, with the cloth off, which is how she says the things that are to me — she said: *Marcia, the girl's letter. Give it back. I've one sentence of hers in that box and I'd like to see if it stays true without the other.*" She held it out. "The sentence she's keeping is *the only one you'll never own*. She's giving you back the one that's the price of a man in Africa. I don't know what that means. I've worked for her forty years and I've never once not known what a thing she did meant and I don't know this, and I've decided that's what she wants, and I've decided to let her have it."

Fausta took it. It weighed nothing. The fish had taken the wax and the wax had held a year in a box on the hill with another letter like it from Nemausus, and she stood on the covered stair in the dark with it in her hand and did not open it, because she knew what it said, and because a thing you had written to buy a man's absence was not a thing you read on your way to another man's presence.

"And yours?"

"Mine stays." Marcia pulled the cloak round. "I'm fifty-four. I picked a woman with a headache and I've never been back to Nemausus and the letter's the receipt and I'll keep it. You're nineteen and you've been given yours back by the only woman on this hill who never gives a thing back, on the morning she's decided not to know a thing, and I'd not stand on a stair with it, girl. I'd go." She sat back down on the step, in the dark, halfway, where neither end could see. "I'll be here when you come up. I'll not ask. I've decided. It's catching."

She went down. At the postern, the step, the dwarf.

She put the letter in her gown, against the skin, where a paper had been for five years and was not now; and it sat there, light, folded, with the fish on it, the whole way down the hill. She did not think about it, and knew it was there, and that was, she thought, going down the Clivus with a dwarf beside her, exactly the sum: a thing you had paid, given back to you, that you had decided to carry anyway, and not spend.

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Momus was on the step at the postern with his legs out, and got up when she came, and looked at the hair.

"Back and tied."

"Yes."

"And the pin."

"Yes."

"Good. Both. That's the whole column." He fell in beside her, on the short legs, as she went out through the postern past the German who did not look at her because she was the Augusta's hair and the dwarf was a gift; and they went down the covered stair, and out onto the Clivus, and down. The city was the colour the city was at the fourth hour of the night after a triumph, which was no colour, and the noise had gone out of it at last and left the thing under the noise, which was a hundred thousand people asleep where they had fallen and the sweepers. The smell of wine and flowers and cattle and the sea-coal the bakers were lighting, and the dust, which had settled on everything in the night as it had not since the Syrian started cutting, because for one day there had been no baskets.

"I went to the Syrian's hut on the Kalends," said Momus, to the road. "I'd not told you. I asked him which morning. He said this one, the second hour; he's setting a course and wants the shipowner's boy there first with the rod. I said I'd bring the measure." He walked. "He'll have told the boy. He's a Syrian. So the boy knows a dwarf's coming to the pit with something, and he's been at the far end since

the third hour anyway, Chrestê says."

"You've spoken to Chrestê."

"Never in my life. Four wine-shops and a steward's boy. We count the same." He went on down. "She's gone, tonight. Rooms over a fuller's. She sent me that by the baker's wife at the second hour so I'd have it before I walked you. There's nobody on the stair, girl. There's a man at the end of a cut with a stick."

They came down past the foot of the Caelian, where the road to the Sacred Way went under it, and she looked up, once, because the house was there, at the top, on its own ground, with the atrium and the pools and the ancestors and the corridor nobody used and a room with two doors; and it was dark. It was a senator's who was in Tingis counting corn-ships, and Phaedrus was its steward and had thirteen years in it and had declared one thing in all of them, at the second hour of a morning, with his back to a door; and she felt, looking up, the price, where she kept it, and looked at it, and it was there, and it had not moved, and she had not expected it to, and she looked away from the house to the road and found that she could, which was the figure.

"That's the Caelian," said Momus, not looking up. "I know. I sat at the end of it forty years. It's a house. I've decided it's a house." He walked. "Phaedrus sends to me on the Kalends. He says the fountain's stopped again and nobody's started it and he's decided not to, and that he's bricked up a door in a dressing-room, himself, at night, with his own hands, which he's never used for anything but a key, and told the master in Africa it was damp. He wanted you to have it and he'd not write it to the hill."

They came down through the Velabrum. The Forum Boarium, with the flowers in the dung. The Palatine's flank, and the box on its posts with the hangings down and the timber grey in the no-colour light, and she looked up at it once, because she had stood in it nine hours and not looked at the road, and it was a box, on posts, empty,

and she felt nothing, which she kept, and they went on under it onto the Sacred Way.

The Sacred Way had been swept and had not been swept. The sand was still down, from the Arch to the Rostra, churned and rutted where the carts had gone and dark in long stripes where the horses had been, and the sweepers were in it with the brooms of twigs, sixty of them in a line across the road, working toward the Forum, and behind the line a boy of eight or nine was going along bent double with a bag, picking up what the crowd had dropped. He had a system. He did not look at the sand; he looked at the sweepers' feet, and when a foot kicked a thing that was not sand he went for it. Coins. A hairpin. A child's clay horse with a leg off. A knife. He had the knife in his belt already and his face was the face of a boy who had done the sum on the knife and the sandal-maker who would buy it and was moving on to the next figure, and she watched him for the length of ten paces and thought: there, that one, in twenty years. And then: no. He'll be dead or a sweeper. It's one in a thousand that the floor holds, and he doesn't know it, and he's happy.

Against the wall of the Basilica, where the carts had turned, somebody had leaned one of the boards. It had come off its cart in the turning, or been pulled off by the crowd for the timber, and whoever had taken it had got it as far as the wall and left it, because it was heavier than it looked, and it stood there in the grey with the figure on it a hand high in black, the lower half already scored with a knife where someone had started to scrape the paint for the wood. She read it from the road. She did not stop. Eleven numerals, and a weight, and under the weight the small mark the man who had weighed it put on a thing when it had been checked three times and he would stand behind it. She had seen that mark on a sail-maker's bill at ten, in a strong-room, with the lid off. The dwarf, beside her, read it too, and looked up at her face, and said nothing, which was a thing he could do when he decided to, and they went on down toward the Rostra

through the sand with the sweepers' brooms going behind them like a tide coming in over shingle.

"Momus."

"Girl."

"You said you were in a cage. Two years. And then Tertulla's father's, and then hers, and forty years at the end of a corridor." The sand was churned to the colour of the cut and their feet went in it. "You've never said what you'd have been. If there'd been no cage."

The dwarf walked a while.

"Tall," he said. "Not clever; that's in the head and the cage doesn't reach it. Tall, and a baker's boy in Praeneste, and dead of a fever at thirty, and nobody on this hill would ever have heard the name." He looked up. "The hill wants a dwarf to be sorry so it can be kind. I'm not sorry. I'm shaped. The Augusta knows the difference; it's why she's never once been kind to me, and I've loved her for it." He walked. "Walk a bit slower, girl. I'd like it to last."

She stopped at the Rostra.

Not for a reason. The dwarf went on three paces and stopped too, and did not ask, and she stood in the churned sand of the Sacred Way at the foot of the old speakers' platform with the beaks of ships on it that had been taken from somebody's enemies four hundred years ago and were bronze now and green. The Forum round her empty in the grey, and the Capitol above with its gold gone to lead in the no-light, and she did the sum. The whole of it. In order, the way she kept things, because a woman at a loom had told a boy that the gods liked to see a face, and the boy had told nobody, and Chrestê had told the wine-shop, and the dwarf had told her, and she had decided that if he could do it at the end of a cut in the dark she could do it at the foot of the Rostra in the grey, and that she would do it standing, because she had done everything standing.

A common room. A steward saying *she'll be useful*. A strong-room with the lid off and a boy reading a bill aloud with his eyes on the bill

and not on her, so that she had looked at him instead, and had kept it. A mole in March, in the dark, and a kiss with his eyes open, and her hand flat on his chest and the arm held to its length, hers, because it was the only thing on the mole that was. A shutter that would not bar. A Rhodian on a stair, and the sum, *live*, and living. A dying woman and a slate and a basin and a word. A shed with the sea in a glass. A road up a hill with a false paper in a hem and a Thracian's wife's voice, and a widow's house with a corridor nobody used and a fountain that stopped, and a boy at a dinner she did not look at so that he would know exactly how far up the room she was. A room with one window and eleven women and a comb. A year of her tongue. A pin with gold on a break. A panelling door. A letter in her own hand asking for Tingis. A sail, told to a comb, with no *I*, and a boy left off the sheet on purpose, and her not knowing, on leaf three, whether that had been the cruellest thing or the kindest. A terrace by a sea with no manifest. A floor with a slate on it and a woman who had thrown her children in a basin saying *it comes out*. A letter to a dying man in a hand only his son could read. A receipt burned over a brazier for Germans' hands. A book with nothing in it. A box with forty boards going by and her lips still on the twenty-second. A woman in an emperor's chair saying *I don't know what it costs*.

It did not come out. She had known it would not. There was a thing left over, and it was the size of a girl on a mole saying *not for nothing* with her arm out straight and a boy saying *all right* and meaning it. She had been carrying it in the place where she kept the Rhodian's eleven for six years and had called it the arm, and the price, and the fifth door, and leaf three, and it had been, all along, the same thing a dying woman had meant with one word, which was *next*.

"Girl," said Momus, three paces on, not turning.

"I'm counting."

"I know. I can see it from here; you've gone still the way he does. Chrestê says he did it at the end of the cut yesterday in the dark and

said a thing out loud to the hole." The dwarf looked at the Capitol. "You'll not say yours out loud. You're your mother's; you say one word and go. But I'd like you to know I've counted the two of you doing the same sum at the two ends of the same road a day apart, and that in forty years at the end of a corridor I've never once seen that, and that I've decided it's the thing I'll remember when I'm dying, and not the cage."

She stood a moment longer at the foot of the Rostra. The Forum was empty. The sweepers were somewhere behind. Above, on the Palatine, a window was lit on the south side where the old library was, and a man was in it with the door shut and four scrolls, deciding not to know, and she looked at the window, once, and looked away, and the price was where she kept it and had not moved, and she found that she could.

"And?" she said. Out loud. Her mother's. To the Forum. Not telling.

Nothing answered, because it was a question, and the answer was at the end of a cut with a stick in his belt and no rod yet, and she had an hour.

"Walk me," she said to the dwarf.

"I'm walking," said Momus. "You're the one stopped."

◆

The Curia. The Guard, two of them, at the corner where the Sacred Way went past into the Argiletum and the new road went right toward the cut. They looked at a tall girl with her hair tied back and a pin and a dwarf and did not stop them, because the Syrian had said *a dwarf will come with the measure* and this was clearly the dwarf and whatever he had with him was clearly the measure; and the new road went up a little, and round, and the cut was there.

She had seen it from the west terrace for a year, every morning, as a square of red with the dust over it and a dark square in the red at the far end. She had stood at its edge once, for the length of a count, at the

third hour of a morning the Augusta had chosen because it was the one hour he was not at it, and had said a thing to a Syrian to be carried. She had not seen it like this, with the light coming and nobody in it. From its edge it was not a square. It was a hill gone. A hundred paces across and more than that long and a hundred and twenty feet down to the floor the Syrian had made, with the Quirinal's shoulder standing sheer on the far side where it had been sliced, as raw as a thing cut yesterday though it had been cut a year, because tufa did not heal; and the floor of it bare and swept, because the gangs had not come yesterday and would come today, with the lines of the basilica's footings laid out in string and pegs. The libraries, and the market's curve going up the Quirinal's side in brick already to its second storey; and at the far end, at the foot of the sheer shoulder, where a column was going to stand a hill's height so that nobody would forget, the pit. Square. Deep. Full of the first grey of the light, which had come over the Esquiline behind her while she walked and was coming down the shoulder now and had not yet reached the bottom of anything.

And at the pit's edge, on the near side, with his back to her, standing, a man.

He was not holding a rod. He had not been given one yet; the hut was dark and Blaesus was asleep in it. He had his hands at his sides and a stick in his belt and the plain tunic and the stripe, and he was tall, and had been since fourteen. He was standing the way he had sat on a mole at fourteen with the whole of the sea in front of him, which was still, with his weight on both feet, looking at a thing to see what it weighed. He did not turn round. He could not have heard them; the sand on the new road was deep and the dwarf walked quietly and she had been taught by a consul's widow to make no sound on a floor. He did not turn round because he was on a mole, and nobody on a mole turned round, and because a Corinthian had told the wine-shop he had stood at the far end since November and never once seen a litter,

and he was not looking for a litter. He was looking at the hole.

Momus stopped at the edge. There was a chest there, the Syrian's, with the rods in it and a plumb-line coiled on the lid, and he climbed onto it, with the short legs, and sat, and put his legs out, and did not look at her.

"There," he said, very low. "I've walked you. The Syrian's at the second hour. You've an hour." He looked at the pit. "I'll count. I'll not hear."

She stood at the edge of the cut with the hill gone in front of her and the light coming down the sliced shoulder and the man at the far end with his back to her and his hands at his sides. Her feet were under her. The floor was there, and it was not paper.

She walked along the edge. Not fast; the way a woman walked who had been taught to make no sound on a floor and had decided, this once, to make some. The sand went under her feet. The light came down the shoulder. The pit filled. And he heard her — she saw him hear her; the shoulders changed and did not turn — and she came the length of the cut's edge with the ivory in her hair and her hair tied back like a girl with a slate, and stopped, beside him, a pace to his left, where she had sat at twelve with her hand flat on his chest, and did not put her hand on him, and looked at the hole.

They stood side by side and looked at the same thing. The light reached the bottom of the pit.

"It's a hundred and twenty feet," he said, after a while, in the house's shorthand, to the hole, in the voice he had used at eleven in a strong-room to read a sail-maker's bill aloud to show a girl what he could see. "He's going to put a column there exactly that high so nobody forgets there was a hill."

"I know," she said, in the same hand, in the eggs voice, to the hole. "I've watched it from a terrace for a year. I didn't know it was that deep. From up there it's a square."

"Most things are."

"Yes."

Behind them, on the Syrian's chest, a dwarf with his legs out counted, and did not hear, and the dust that had settled in the night on everything in Rome lay on the cut's floor undisturbed, because the gangs had not come yet, and would.

30

A Hundred and Twenty Feet

The cut, the second hour, 107

He had been in the hut since the end of the fourth hour of the night, because the alternative was his own room, with the slate on the table and the lamp in the stair-window that he had not lit and had not been able to stop looking at.

Blaesus was asleep across the door on a sack, as he slept, with his mouth open and no sound coming out of it, since he could not hear himself snore and so, Apollodorus said, had never learned to. Celer stepped over him. The hut smelled of lime and tallow and the Syrian's wine. He lit the one lamp from the banked brazier and sat on the rod-chest and opened the day's sheet and did not write on it. The figure for the footing was already in his head and had been for a week; what the Syrian wanted was the figure on a sheet in the hand the Senate could read, and the hand the Senate could read needed a flat surface and a steady lamp and a man whose attention was on it, and he had the first two.

He got up and did what he did when a figure would not sit. He checked the plumb-lines. There were eleven, coiled on their pegs along the back wall, each with a lead weight the size of a hen's egg and the Syrian's mark cut into the lead, and he took each one down and ran it through his fingers from the peg to the weight for a kink or a fray, the way his father had run a ship's cable through his hands on the mole at Puteoli with his eyes shut, and hung each one back. None was frayed. He had checked them the morning before. He checked the rods: the twelve-foot, the six, the three, the bronze pins tight in the seasoned oak, the oak itself for a warp against the lamp. None was warped. He put the lid on the chest and sat on it again.

Through the hut's one window the sky over the Esquiline had begun to be a colour. Not light; the thing before light. The cut was below him in it, a hill's height of nothing with the string-lines across the floor, square after square, pale in the dark where the lime had dried on them. At the far end, by the shoulder, the ladder stood against the face where he had left it.

He went down.

The engineers' stair first, cut in the tufa, forty-one steps, which he had counted the first morning in November and not since; and then along the floor of the cut in the near-dark with the string-lines under his feet, stepping over each where it crossed, because you did not walk on a Syrian's line; and the walls going up on either side of him a hundred and twenty feet to a sky that was now, when he looked, grey. The tufa breathed cold. There was the smell it had, which he had not been able to name in seven months and which Blaesus, who could not smell it, said was the smell of the inside of a hill that had never been outside before. His boots were loud. At the far end the shoulder of the Quirinal came down sliced like a cheese, the strata in it showing, brown on grey on brown, and the ladder against it, and he put his back to the ladder and his face to the length of the cut and stood, with the stick in his belt and his hands at his sides. The light came down the face behind him a foot at a time, and he waited, as he had waited every morning for seven months for a thing he had told himself he was not waiting for.

He heard her before he saw anything. Sand, on the edge above, where there had been no sand yesterday.

He did not turn round, and she stood a pace to his left where she had sat at twelve, and the light was in the bottom of the pit, and he found that the thing he had been told to have after the question was not a thing he had, and that he was going to have to make it, out loud, on the edge of a hole, in a hand only one other person could read, with that person beside him.

"You left me off the sheet," he said. To the pit.

"Yes."

"Why."

She did not answer at once. Below them the Syrian's string-lines ran across the floor of the cut in the grey, square after square, where a basilica would be.

"A man in the prefect's office would have asked whether the boy knew," she said. "And when. And what the vines were bought with."

"That's the figure. I asked why."

"You've a freedwoman who kept a merchant's books. She'll have told you."

"She told me you took the lower figure and looked at the woman while you did it. She said she couldn't tell if it was the cruellest thing or the kindest."

"No," said Fausta. "Nor can I." And then, after a moment, as if it were a smaller thing: "I've a book now. I've written it both ways, on facing leaves. I read them. It doesn't help."

He stood. He had come with a list and the list was going, item by item, into the pit, the way the dust went in the evening.

"I wrote the finding," he said. "Four hundred and eighty. My name under it, and the ring."

"I know."

"He said it was just. In a letter. He said *that's the and*." He stopped. "He had the stroke doing the sum of what was left, and he wrote *F* on a tablet, and I said *the stone*, and he let me."

She turned her head then — not round; a degree, toward the shoulder of the Quirinal, where the light was. "Vibia wrote me. She drew the letter. She couldn't read it."

"You wrote to him. In the hand. After. Knowing."

"Knowing you'd find it." The ivory at the side of her head took the light and he did not look at it. "There's nobody else alive can read that hand."

"*The same reason you've not called the villa.*"

"Yes."

"I don't know what that is."

"Yes you do."

The dwarf on the chest did not move. Somewhere behind them in the hut a deaf clerk was waking, and would not hear, and the pit filled by degrees to the floor.

"My mother said *and?*," she said. "I took it for a reckoning. It wasn't. She was asking." She let the shorthand carry it; she had never been able to say a thing in Latin that she could say in the hand. "So. I'm asking. You said once you'd nothing after it, and burned the sheet. Chrestê told the wine-shop. The wine-shop told a dwarf." A breath. "Have something this time."

He had been told, by a woman over a slate, to stop being good at nothing for one morning. He had been told by a man at a table with the sky on it that there was always a next. He had not been told what to say, and he found, on the edge of a hole a hill's height with the morning in it, that he had no column for it and was going to have to do it the way he had done a bill at eleven, with his eyes on the thing and not on her.

"Not for nothing," he said. "You said it. I said *all right*, and put it in the column, and I've been six years doing the other thing because I thought *all right* was the sum." The light had reached the floor. "I'll go to Hadrian when Lucius is dead. You'll be in the room. He'll look at you and you'll say your sentence and he'll laugh, and ask again. That's the hill's sum and it's right; I've done it a hundred times on a stool." He breathed. "I'd like, once, to turn round. I know nobody on a mole does. I'm asking what it costs."

She was quiet so long that he thought the hour had gone. Then, in the shorthand, very level:

"The hill."

"Say the figure."

"The day either of us is the other's, we're priced. She keeps us because she can't price us. She's said so, in her way; she's given me back a letter this morning to see what stays true without it." She did not look at him. "By noon they'd all know — she'd know, he'd know, Sabina would see my back. And then you're Sura's clerk who went to the cut with the Augusta's hair, and I'm the hair, and he's a man who learns." A pause. "That's the figure. I've paid worse. I'd not pay it for *once*."

He had known the sum before she said it. He had asked anyway, which was new, and she had answered as a manifest, with no *I* in it, and under the manifest, where he could read because he had been taught by her mother's slate and his father's margin, was a thing that was not *no*.

"Then when."

"When the column's up." She said it the way the Syrian said the time. "A hundred and twenty feet. He says six years. Then it's a column and not a hole, and she's sixty-two, and he's whatever he is by then, and we're a thing the hill's tried to price for six years and couldn't, and that's the only kind of thing up there that's ever let be its own." Her voice did not move. "That's not *no*. You can read it."

"Six years."

"I counted five for a man in Africa. I can count six for a column."

Six years. He would be twenty-six. He had been taught the long game in a strong-room with the lid off and had never once played it for anything that was not a figure.

"Then I'll measure the column," he said. "Every course. I'll be at the far end before the gangs. It's where the man stands who did the figure."

"I know. I've a terrace."

The light lay on the pit's floor, flat and grey and whole.

"Chrestê's gone to a fuller's," he said.

"I heard." A pause. "I liked her over a slate when I was fourteen. I'd not have said so." She did not move. "There's a thing I'll give you. Not the arm. A paper." Her hand went to her gown and came out and held it between them, at the height of the pit's edge, without turning: a folded sheet, soft at the folds, a brass fish in the wax. "Tingis. In my hand. Asking. She gave it back this morning." The shorthand, level. "You've a shelf. Don't read it. You know what it says."

He took it. It weighed nothing. He put it inside the tunic against the skin, and his hand touched hers on the paper for the length of a breath and then did not, because the paper was given and the arm was not; and it was the arm, he understood, and the length of it, and it was shorter than it had been.

And then he turned round.

Not to her. Away from the pit, toward the near end of the cut, because there was a sound there, which was a Syrian with lime on his arms coming along the edge with four engineers and a deaf clerk carrying a rod, shouting, in the Greek, "There. The weigher. And — ha. The dwarf's measure." He arrived. He looked at the two of them a pace apart on the edge of the pit with the morning on them, and whatever he thought about it stayed under the lime. "One at each end. I'll not set a thing a hill's height on one pair of hands. Then she goes up and you come to the hut and I've seen a rod." He held it out. "Take it."

◆

She took the rod.

That was what she would keep of it, in the book, that night, on the cold floor, with Sabina asleep and her hair wrong: not what had been said, which was in the hand and would stay there; the rod. Twelve feet of seasoned oak with the Syrian's marks on it in bronze pins, that Blaesus put into her hands at one end as if she were an engineer, because he was deaf and had not been told she was anything else, and that the shipowner's son took at the other. They went down

into the pit by the ladder the gangs used — she went first; he did not offer the hand and she did not look for it — and stood on the floor of the Syrian's footing a hundred and twenty feet below the city with the morning coming down the sliced shoulder onto them and the rod between them, and measured.

Apollodorus called it from the edge. The side; the diagonal; the depth from the string to the floor; the offset from the shoulder's foot. She held her end to the mark and he held his and the Syrian read the bronze pins through the glass he had and Blaesus wrote in the loud flat hand of a man who could not hear what he was writing. The figures were right, each one, because the Syrian had dug the pit to them and was measuring only to be told so by two pairs of hands that had kept a book; and between the calls, on the floor of the pit, twelve feet apart, with the rod level between them, they did not speak. The morning came down the sliced shoulder onto the two of them a hill's depth below the city, and a man above read what it weighed.

"Level," the Syrian called. "Good. Hold it. Last one." And then, lower, to the engineers, in the Greek he thought the pit would not carry, and the pit carried everything: "Look at that. Neither of them's moved. I've had legionaries on that rod who couldn't hold it for a plumb-line."

"Level," said Blaesus, loud, writing.

"Then that's the course." Apollodorus straightened. "Bring it up. The gangs are at the Curia; I can hear them. Up, both. You" — to her — "to your hill, by the new road; the Guard will not have seen you. You" — to him — "to the hut, with Blaesus; I want the footing's figure on a sheet by the third hour and the first course set by the sixth, and the emperor will come at the ninth to see a stone where a hill was."

She went up the ladder. He held the foot of it, because that was what was done with a ladder, and she did not look down, and at the top the dwarf was on the chest with his legs out and the seamed face

doing nothing, and he said, as she came over the edge, in the voice that was for the end of a corridor, "I counted. I didn't hear." He got down. "Come on. Sabina's hair."

She went along the edge. She did not look back at the pit. She had held one end of a rod level for a quarter of an hour and the other end had not moved, and she was going up a hill now to a room with one window and a woman with a cloth who had decided not to know, and would know, and would say nothing.

At the near end, where the new road went down past the Curia, the gangs were coming up. Three hundred men with baskets and mattocks in a column, with the overseers, going to take a hill away a basket at a time as they had every morning for a year but one; and she stood aside with the dwarf to let them by. They went past her into the cut without looking, because she was a tall girl with her hair tied back and a pin and a dwarf and the Syrian had people at the pit every morning; and they went down the ramps onto the floor and the first basket went into the first barrow and the first mattock went into the red, and the dust came up.

It came up as it did, all at once, as a thing breathed out, from three hundred men and a year's practice, and stood over the cut in the still June air the way it had stood every morning she had watched from the west terrace, and went up, and spread, and began to settle on everything, on the Forum and the Curia and the Capitol's steps and the Palatine and the Augusta's one window, which would have to be shut, and on the far end, where a man was climbing out of a pit with a rod over his shoulder and a deaf clerk behind him and a folded paper with a brass fish on it against his skin, and did not look up at the near end; the Syrian had said *the hut by the third hour*. He had six years, and she could see from the set of the shoulders, even through the dust, what he had decided to spend them doing.

"Girl," said Momus, beside her.

"Yes."

"You've a face on you like a slate that's come out."

"It hasn't." She turned up the new road toward the hill. "There's a thing left over."

"There always is," said the dwarf, and fell in beside her on the short legs, and they went up through the dust, which was the colour of the cut, and of the sand on the Sacred Way the morning after a triumph, and of the ash a mole was built on.

◆

Marcia was on the covered stair, halfway, where neither end could see, and stood up, and did not ask, and looked at the girl's face in the light that was light now, and at the hair tied back, and at the dust on the hem of the gown, which was the colour of the cut and had not been there when she went down.

"You've been in it," the freedwoman said. "Not at it. In it. There's tufa on you to the knee."

"I held a rod."

"Did you." Marcia looked at the hem a moment longer and then at the face, and the round brown face came unarranged, as it had once in a steward's room with Germans in the atrium, which was not be arranged. "I'll not ask. I said. But I'll tell you one thing, for nothing, which is the first for-nothing in forty years and I'd like it marked: the Augusta woke at the first hour and lay with her eyes open and did not call for the cloth, and at the half she said to the ceiling, *Marcia, is it dusty*, and I said *not yet, Augusta, the gangs aren't in*. She said *tell me when it is*, and turned over." The freedwoman sat back down on the step. "So I'll go up now and tell her it's dusty. That's all she's asked. It's the only question she's got left that she's allowed herself, and I think it's the one she means, and I think you know what it means, and I'd not have you go into that room without knowing she's asked it."

She went up. The courts. The fountain that worked. The north rooms, where Sabina was at the glass with her hair down and the beautiful disappointed face turned to the door before it opened, and

looked at the girl who came through it, and at the hem, and at the hair tied back, and at the face that did nothing, perfectly; and said nothing; and turned back to the glass; and said, to it, in the low quick voice, after a while: "Your back's different. I said I'd know. I do." A pause. "Don't tell me. The new way. The pins on the left; he's coming from the library at the third hour and I want him to not know me, and then to know me, and then to look past me at the corner, and I want to see what his face does when the corner's got tufa on its hem."

She did Sabina's hair. The new way. And at the third hour the Spaniard came from the library in the Greek cloak with no dust on it, because he had been in a room with the door shut, and stood in the door of the cold rooms and looked at his wife in the glass and did not know her for a moment, and then did, and then looked past her to the corner; and the grey eyes found a tall girl with a box of pins and her own hair tied back and the Syrian's hill on her hem to the knee, and rested; and the face did not do the thing. It did the other, the one from the library, across four scrolls: it simply looked, as a man looked at a column that he had decided not to know the figure for and had been handed the figure anyway, by a hem.

"Puteoli," he said, in the Greek. "You've been to see the Syrian's hole."

"Yes, Hadrian."

"Was it as deep as he says?"

"A hundred and twenty feet. I held one end of the rod. The Syrian read it. It was right."

"One end." The grey eyes did not move. "And the other?"

She stood in the corner with her feet under her and the floor there, and it was not paper, and she had decided on a terrace to stop pretending about what was true, only about what it cost. She knew what this cost, because she had said the figure to a hole an hour ago with no *I* in it, and she said it anyway, because the doors on this hill were labelled and this one said *Hadrian* and she would not begin six

years by lying to the one man who would spend them learning.

"The boy who weighed the gold. The Syrian wanted two pairs of hands. He said he'd not set a thing a hill's height on a figure made by one."

The Spaniard stood in the door. Behind him, at the glass, Sabina had gone very still with a pin in her hand. And the face did, at last, the thing — interesting, and a little short of what it might have been — and then, under it, where she had learned in a low chair to read, the other thing, the one that was not quite patience and was what patience was made of.

"Two pairs of hands," he said. "Yes. He'd say that. He's a Syrian; he counts in pairs." He turned from the door, and stopped, and said to the corridor, not to the room, in the Greek: "I was in the library. From the first hour. The door was shut. I'd like that known. I read Sappho; the bad copy; the apple on the topmost bough that the pickers couldn't reach. I've read it a hundred times and this morning I noticed, for the first time, that she never says whether anyone got a ladder." He went. "Sabina. Plotina's room. Bring the girl. The window's being shut; it's dusty; she's asked for her hair done again because the first was for a box and this is for a receiving day, and she says she wants it done by someone who's been down the hill this morning and can tell her what it weighs."

The Augusta had the cloth on. The window was shut, and the room with one window was close already in June with eleven women on the benches outside the door and the dust standing beyond the glass in the light like a thing breathed out; and Marcia was at the shoulder with the comb and said *the old way*, as she did, and Fausta put the box down and began. The woman on the couch under the cloth said nothing for the whole of it, which was the thing, and when the last pin was in and she had turned her head once to the left and once to the right and said *that's it, that's my mother's*, she said one more thing, to the ceiling, in the voice that was not for metre and that

Fausta had heard perhaps five times and would hear, she understood now, once a year for as long as they both lived, on the morning after whatever the year's sum had been.

"Is it dusty, girl?"

"Yes, Augusta. The gangs went in at the second hour. Three hundred. It'll be on everything by noon."

"Good." The cloth did not move. "Then the hill's being taken away and I've decided not to know by whom, and I'll have the window shut for six years, and Marcia will tell me each morning that it's dusty, and that's the whole of what I'll ask. Six years. The Syrian says. Then it's a column." A silence under the cloth that was the silence of a woman who had, for the first time in thirty years, a thing in a column she could not price and had decided to keep it there. "Go and sit with Sabina. The room may come in. And girl. The hem. Have it brushed before the benches see it, not because I mind — I've decided not to mind; it's new — but because Tertulla's son's letters from Tingis are getting longer and I'd not have the fourth bench write to Africa that the Augusta's hair came in from the cut with the Syrian's hill on it. He's patient. Let him be patient about nothing."

She went down the long wall behind the comb. The benches rose.

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He did not go back to the hut until the figure was on the sheet.

He did it at the Syrian's table with Blaesus at his elbow reading each line as it went down and nodding, loud, as he nodded, and when it was done he signed it with his name in the hand the Senate could read, and Apollodorus took it and looked at it and put it inside his tunic against the lime without a word. That was the base of a column seen to. He went up the engineers' stair. Forty-one. He went out past the Curia, where the Guard who had let him through at the first hour of yesterday looked at the stick and not at the face, and up the Sacred Way through the sweepers, and the Velabrum, and the long climb of the Aventine, and the stair.

The room was as he had left it. That was the first thing, and he stood in the door and had it: the table, the slate on the table with the Kalends figure in her hand and the line under it and nothing after, the stool, the second stool, the bed, the shelf. The lamp in the stair-window, unlit. And the things that were not there, which he counted, standing, because counting was what he had: the comb that had been on the shelf, the red cloak on the peg, the Corinthian pot she had kept her pins in. The sandals under the bed. The second cup. She had taken what was hers and nothing that was his, down to a knife she had bought with her own money and used on his bread, and the shelf where the comb had been had a clean place on it the length of a comb, and the rest of the shelf had dust.

He fed the gods. Hermes's two, and the one of his own that he had bought on the Aventine in the first month, from the boxes under them: barley, a little oil, a splash of the wine from the jar which was two days old and had not been poured since the feast. The small bronze faces took it as they took everything. He stood a moment with the dish in his hand and looked at the boxes under the shelf, the eleven boxes, with Hermes's figures in them in the hand he had been taught, and the twelfth box, which was empty and had a lid, and had been empty since April. He did not open any of them.

Then he sat down at the table and took up the stylus and turned the slate over to the clean side and wrote, in the Latin hand, for nobody, *VIII Id. Iun. — footing figure to the Syrian; course set; measure level,* and under it, after a while, in the other hand, the one only one other person could read, a thing that was four strokes long and that he looked at for the time it took the light to move from the table's edge to the slate, and then rubbed out with the ball of his thumb; and he turned the slate back over to the side with her figure on it, and the line, and nothing after, and left it so, and went down the stair with the lamp unlit to find a cook-shop that was open and eat something, because he had not since the feast and a man who was

going to walk into Sura's house in the morning and be told what was next needed to have eaten.

On the stair, at the turn, where the window was, he stopped and looked out at the city with the dust standing over the Forum in the middle of it, and the hill beyond the dust, and the terrace on the hill, which was too far to show a figure on it, and was not too far to know there was one. Nobody looked at her hem, because nobody on that hill looked at a hair-girl's hem, and that was the hill, and she had decided it was a house.

On the west terrace, that evening, she opened the book on her knees at the leaf after the triumph and sat with the ink and did not write. Momus, on the parapet, watched her not write for the time it took the light to go off the Capitol, and said nothing, and when she closed it with the leaf blank he said, "Good. Some things you keep by not putting them down. I've a whole corridor of them."

And on the west terrace, that evening, with the dwarf on the parapet and the city below going about its noise and the cut beyond the Forum with the first course of a column's base set in it on a figure two pairs of hands had held level, the dust that had gone up at the second hour was coming down, slowly, in the long June light, on everything, on the Forum and the Capitol's steps and the Augusta's shut window and the box on its posts and the sand of the Sacred Way and a hut where a man was writing a footing's figure on a sheet with a deaf clerk and a folded paper with a brass fish on it against his skin; and it was the colour it was; and it would come down every evening for six years on everything in Rome; and when the column stood. The dust stopped, people looked up at it and said *a hundred and twenty feet* and did not ask who had measured, because nobody on that hill thought a rod had two ends.